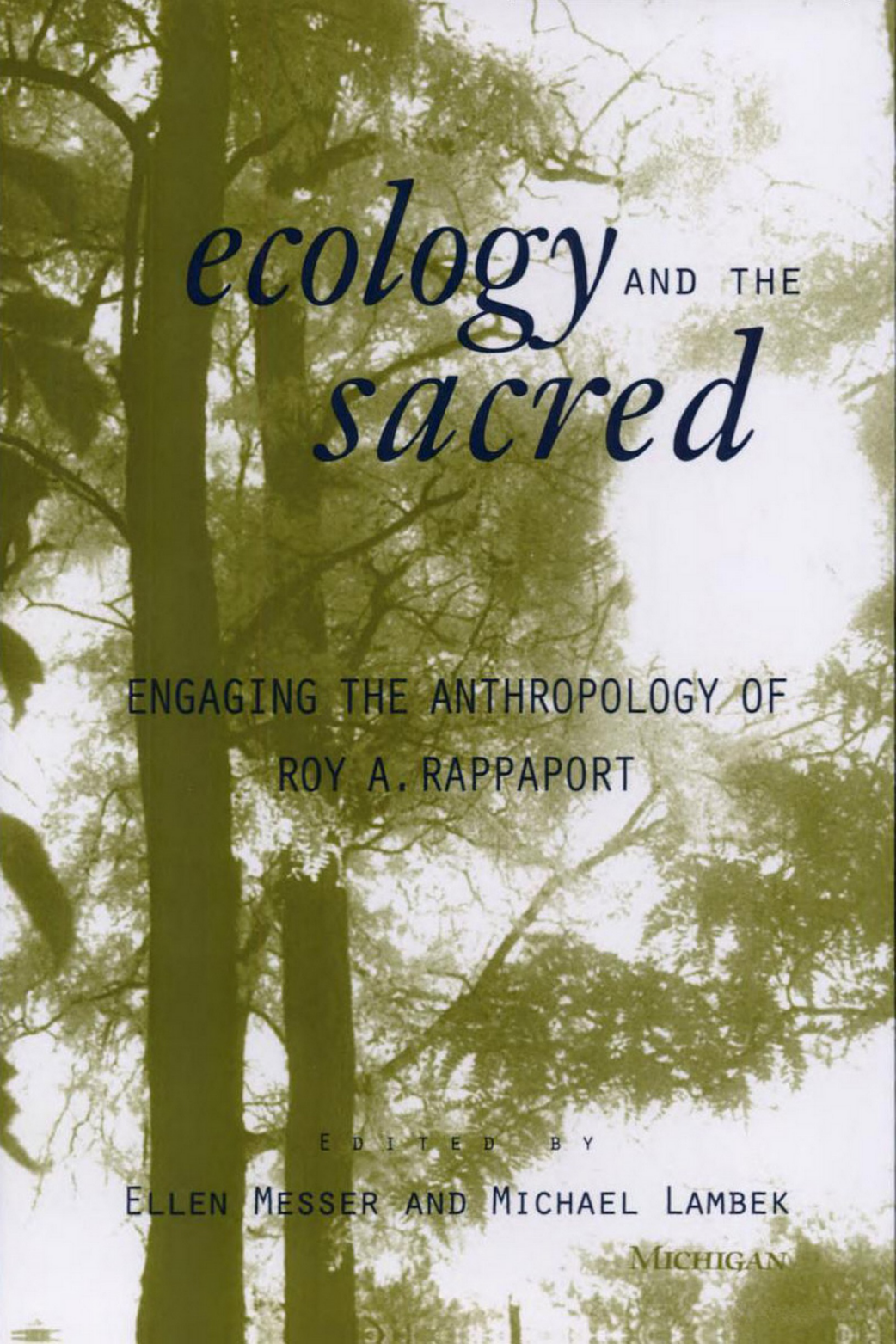


ecology AND THE sacred

ENGAGING THE ANTHROPOLOGY OF ROY A. RAPPAPORT

EDITED BY

ELLEN MESSER AND MICHAEL LAMBEK

MICHIGAN

Ecology and the Sacred

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Engaging the Anthropology of Roy A. Rappaport

Edited by
Ellen Messer *and*
Michael Lambek

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For Skip

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Thinking and Engaging the Whole: The Anthropology of Roy A. Rappaport

Ellen Messer

In a 1994 essay succinctly entitled "Humanity's Evolution and Anthropology's Future," Roy A. Rappaport assessed the discipline's theoretical and moral foundations and its mission for human survival. He highlighted its comparative advantage over the narrower concerns of other social sciences and the humanities and praised both its "scientific" and its "cultural" directions, which together create the holistic discipline whose subject matter is humanity. This is vintage Rappaport at his inspirational best: theoretically innovative, comprehensive, and committed to solving humanity's problems.

Inside and outside anthropology, Rappaport will be remembered as one of its great original thinkers, whose work had a lasting impact on its orientation and organization. Starting with his 1960s essays on human ecology (1963a, 1963b, 1968a, 1969b) and his pathbreaking "systems" ethnography, *Pigs for the Ancestors: Ritual in the Ecology of a New Guinea People* (1968; 2d ed., 1984, hereafter, *Pigs*)—reprinted several times and in multiple languages—his ideas on human ecology and ritual regulation of environmental relations drew a wide following.[1] Thereafter, he devoted the better part of his life to understanding *why* ritual should order ecosystems and human life and drew connections linking adaptation, the structure of human communication, and ritual life in *Ecology, Meaning, and Religion* (1979) and finally *Ritual and Religion in the Making of Humanity* (1999).

Along with these theoretical inquiries, Rappaport grappled with the disorders and troubles of American society, especially the impact of national and global environmental resource management schemes on local peoples (1993a, 1994b). Significantly, he never lost sight of what he

considered to be the obligatory public role of the anthropologist—to address the large, serious issues of human survival. More professional public servant than popularizer, Rappaport's own public policy engagements involved mainly environmental issues, specifically energy use and its human impact, but they also included follow-up fieldwork in Papua New Guinea (PNG) in 1981–82 and consultations on social welfare concerns in Michigan, where he spent his entire professional life as an anthropologist. As president of the American Anthropological Association (AAA) from 1987 to 1989, he was able to encourage similarly engaged research by convening and nurturing AAA panels on anthropology and public policy (1988–90) and by supporting AAA task forces that used anthropological theory and methodology to address social problems, again with an emphasis on the contemporary United States as well as the developing world, anthropology's more typical domain.

Such wide-ranging activities were possible because Rappaport maintained a unified theory of humanity evolving in global ecosystems that infused his anthropological research, teaching, policy networking, and professional service. In the rest of this introductory overview, I briefly review this holistic perspective in Rappaport the professor, in his evolution as a professional anthropologist, and more extensively in the ideas and activities of Rappaport the scholar-activist over his professional lifetime from the 1960s through the 1990s.

Professor Rappaport

Like several of the other contributors to this volume, I first met Professor Rappaport ("Skip") as a graduate student in anthropology at the University of Michigan (in 1970), where he directed the mandatory graduate "core" course in ethnology, team taught Ecological Anthropology with ethnologist Kottak and archaeologists Ford and Flannery, and offered Anthropological Approaches to Religion as a window onto his emergent ideas about the role of the sacred in human evolution. Elsewhere at the time American anthropology was in ferment; cognitive anthropologists wrangled with phenomenologists, behaviorists, and cultural materialists, and ethnographers and linguists sought separation from archaeologists and physical anthropologists housed in the same departments (Hymes 1969). Accompanying these schisms were considerable posturings over "new" methods and frameworks of analysis, notably the "new ethnography" by linguistic anthropologists and the "new ar-

chaeology" by prehistorians seeking greater scientific rigor in data collection and interpretation (although both new and old criticized functionalism as tautological). In the human ecology track at Michigan, however, we saw no need to "reinvent anthropology" (Hymes 1969) because the organic four-field unity in its American anthropological approach maintained cohesion. Moreover, the breadth of Rappaport's courses and vision assured students that anthropology was a universal discipline that studied not only small-scale societies but the structure of the social problems, institutions, and bureaucracies of large-scale complex societies such as that of the United States.

Memorable qualities in Rappaport's teaching were his brilliance and his scientific and philosophical rigor, which occasionally were mixed with flashes of self-effacement. (If I could discover a systemic logic linking ritual to ecology in highland New Guinea, he humbly informed his students, then any schm__k could!) He also communicated a deep, earthy identification with fellow human creatures, especially when drawing on his experiences among the Maring. Although students had come to expect his lectures to contain huge concepts and an erudite vocabulary, he usually devoted one session to descriptions of ritual subincision that were deliberately designed to make students squirm, to force them to feel as well as think about the situations of fellow human beings as part of an analysis of the nondiscursive dimensions and bodily truths communicated in ritual. Rappaport was a persuasive intellectual leader also because he exuded charisma; he had the special gift that allowed him to focus intently on and listen seriously to whoever was on the other end of a communication. Dashing across campus, his long black cape flying around him, his visual image was part Count Dracula, but his demeanor was always more that of a zaddik, a traditional wise person–rabbi, a term of address that, with all his ambivalence toward his ancestral Jewish religion, still held a certain attraction.

Consistent with this latter image, two additional characteristics stood out in Rappaport's relationships with students and colleagues. He eschewed the common academic game of ferreting out weaknesses in others' positions for the purpose of using such insights to publicly humiliate them. Instead, he was willing to admit in certain cases that he might have been wrong—or at the very least misunderstood—and constantly moved his own argument forward, clarifying it while taking into account any criticism. Second, he was willing to mentor and support students who had chosen serious social issues (later termed "engaged anthropology") as

their principal area of research, even projects that some of his colleagues deemed peripheral to anthropology.

Outside of classes and the seminar room, Skip was a person who sincerely enjoyed the pleasures of good food and drink and generously helped his colleagues (especially his students) do the same. He loved poetry and art, and in his own life approached nature and cosmology as a poet as well as an ecologist. He was also a serious correspondent who in a nontrivial way reflected on the complexities of life and worked into these personal missives his latest professional understandings of "meaning." In retrospect, Rappaport was, as we say in the United States, "an original," but above all he was an anthropologist whose outlook was flavored by his historical experience as an American, his professional identity as an academic citizen of the world, and his prophetic and mystical Jewish heritage. From all these fonts he drew strength as a human being, someone deeply committed to social justice and saving the world. The wide range of topics and scholarship presented here is eloquent testimony to the breadth and depth of his insights and his abilities to inspire and nourish disparate and often conflicting interests within anthropology.

Professional Background

Already close to forty after having been a soldier in World War II, an alumnus of Cornell's School of Hotel Administration, and then an innkeeper, Rappaport embarked on graduate study, in his own words (1994c: 166), in order to understand his own alienation. He chose anthropology after probing discussions with Kai and Erik Erikson, who fortuitously were close friends who frequented his inn. Significantly, he entered Columbia University (not because he desired to study with anyone in particular but because it had a School of General Studies, which accepted him) in the throes of the turbulent 1960s, as the currents of ecology, civil rights, the Vietnam War, and the threat of nuclear war heightened public debate on politics and ecology. With "Think local, act global" the reigning paradigm, the time was ripe for anthropologists, especially of an antimodernist bent (Dove 1997), to learn more about the ways so-called primitives managed local environments and how such knowledge could improve their chances for global survival.

In Columbia's anthropology courses, Rappaport encountered the exciting and often competing ideas of Harris's cultural materialism,

Conklin's ethnoscience, Mead's understandings of fieldwork, Arensberg's political anthropology, and Vayda's, Barth's, and Conklin's interpretations of anthropological ecology. Exposed to Leslie White's "general evolution," as it was presented by Fried, he developed his own ideas of ordered general systems, a lawful and unified order underlying the apparent multiplicity of human structures and events. Presented with Conklin's ideas on ethnoscience and ethnoecology, he developed his own comparative units of "cognized" and "operational" environments, which incorporated aspects of Harris's materialism. He moved Arensberg's focus on the formal characteristics of political hierarchies and their operations toward ideas about structure in adaptive systems. Drawing on all of the above plus readings in biological ecology, with Vayda he moved beyond Steward's cultural ecology to a human ecology that removed the conceptual separation between the subsistence culture core and secondary peripheral features.[2]

His Polynesian fieldwork commenced with four months of archaeology in the Society Islands, which provided firsthand knowledge of Polynesian landscapes and suggested the explanatory potential of general ecology (1967a). Fieldwork helped him formulate a comprehensive synthesis of the relations between human populations, social and cultural structures, and the environment (1963a, 1963b), in which he critiqued previous functionalist and materialist interpretations, including that of Sahlins (1958). There followed fourteen months of ethnological-ecological fieldwork in Papua New Guinea, as close to a pristine environment as he could find. Working closely with his wife, Ann Rappaport, and with nearby colleagues Vayda and Lowman-Vayda, he developed ideas about the role of pig rituals in regulating human-environmental relations, which became the subject of his dissertation (1966a) and *Pigs*. Although he had embarked on a study of a PNG population with the aim of treating the human population in the same terms that biological ecologists studied animal populations in ecosystems, he found he could not avoid focusing attention on the ritual cycle, and this piqued his interest in ritual and the sacred more generally. These topics continued to occupy him for the rest of his life.

In 1965, Rappaport joined the Department of Anthropology at the University of Michigan in Ann Arbor, where he established roots, served as chair (1975–80), was elected a senior fellow of the Society of Fellows (1975), and became director of the university's Program on Studies in Religion (1991). His most important early influences at Michigan, by his

own account (1994c), were Meggitt, Sahlins, and Wolf, although the archaeologists (Flannery, Ford, and Wright) also figured importantly in the development of his adaptative systems argument and Kottak, and later Fricke, carried on and updated ecological studies and courses. The most profound influence over the course of his lifetime, however, was Gregory Bateson, whom he met in 1968 and whose ideas on adaptation and evolution as informational processes infused his work thereafter.

The details of Rappaport's intellectual biography are best recounted in a history of his own ideas, which moved seamlessly from ecological theory and method to ritual, the sacred, and adaptation; then maladaptation, trouble, and engaged anthropology; and finally religion, science, and humanity's future. The following account, organized according to these overlapping themes, concludes with Rappaport's professional and institutional commitment to unifying in a single discipline self-identified scientists and humanists and to training theoreticians who were also activists and fieldworkers who were also philosophers.

Ecological Theory and Method

Rappaport's key conceptual and methodological insights, the ideas he used to explore the basic "contradiction between naturally constituted physical law and culturally constructed meanings" (1968: 241) by comparing and then contrasting the overlap and structure of "operational" and "cognized" environments, were already well developed in his earliest writings (1963a, 1963b; 1979). The operational, or law-governed, environment was based on Marston Bates's citation of Mason and Langenheim: "the sum of those [physical-environmental] phenomena that enter a reaction system of the organism or otherwise directly impinge upon it to affect its mode of life at any time throughout his life cycle" (1960). The cognized environment was defined as "the sum of the phenomena ordered into meaningful categories by a population" (Rappaport 1979: 6). For ecology as a whole, Rappaport emphasized: "The relationship of these culturally constructed meanings and values to organic well-being and ecosystemic integrity is the central problem for ecological anthropology" (1967: 241). For his landmark study (*Pigs*) in particular, the central organizing question was: "*What is the relationship between the reference value or ranges of values of the cognized model and the goal ranges of the operational model?*" (1968/1984: 241), emphasis in the original). The conceptual framework, methods, and findings were summarized in "Ritual Regula-

tion of Environmental Relations among a New Guinea People" (1967b) and presented in their entirety in *Pigs for the Ancestors* (1968). Rappaport further detailed the specific advantages of this human ecological method in five articles (1968a, 1969b, 1971b, 1971a, 1972a), which were reprinted in different locations and widely circulated and cited. Collectively, these works became benchmarks for teaching ecology and environmental anthropology (see, e.g., Moran 1990; and Milton 1993, 1996), for finding the roots of environmental degradation in "ecological imperialism" (1971a), and later for exploring the linkages between global ideologies and local ecological practice (see Hornborg, this volume; Escobar 1999; and Brosius 1999a, 1999b). Together they established Rappaport as an innovative thinker whose work sought to integrate the findings of a rigorous inquiry based on ecological methods drawn from the biological and physical sciences with careful social and cultural analysis based on anthropological methods.

Rappaport's work was groundbreaking both for its ethnographically based "systems analysis" and for its focus on ritual, which by the early 1970s he was analyzing as the cybernetics of the sacred. Drawing on general systems theory (von Bertalanffy 1968) and applying known principles of biological ecology to a human population (Odum 1959/1963), he clearly specified his units of analysis (the "human population" not the "culture"), gave goal ranges and reference values objective measures, and backed up all assertions about the human and environmental impact of human activities with objective calculations (1984: 363). Like a good scientist, he used quantitative procedures (censuses, weighing, counts, surveys) to determine the current state of each of the variables in units that corresponded to those of accepted biological ecological theory and methods. He published all the operational data in ten appendixes, which allowed other scientists to view the data and critique the interpretation (see, e.g., nutritionist McArthur's 1974 and 1977 critiques, to which Rappaport responded in his addendum to the 1984 edition of *Pigs*). All of these scientific procedures were intentionally introduced to get beyond the vague social structural-functional formulations and simple functionalist or materialist arguments (which were tautological) that characterized most ecological anthropology. The goal was to study not ritual's function but its adaptive value in maintaining empirical ("reference") values in ecological terms: carrying capacity, persistence of biological species population in the environment, human nutritional well-being, and frequency of warfare.

Beyond the rigor of the scientific analysis, the treatment of ritual as unifying human social and environmental relations set *Pigs* apart from all the other ethnographies published up to that time. The identification of ritual as an important mechanism regulating peace and warfare, distribution of the regional population, and humans' sustainable use of domesticated (pig, sweet potato) and nondomesticated (eels, marsupials) food resources was innovative. Another innovation was that the analysis did not try to specify whether local models of the natural world were "true" but only whether they were appropriate to maintain the ecosystem. Indeed, the whole focus on ritual was something of a surprise given that the original intention of the fieldwork had been to demonstrate, contra Steward's cultural ecology (1955), that a purely ecological study of a human population was possible!

Also a departure was Rappaport's conceptualization of culture as a "cognized environment," which included not only people's mundane technical understandings of their surroundings (e.g., useful plant classifications), those necessary for subsistence and survival, but the entire range of relations people recognized and characterized in their particular ecosystems. His decision to compare cognized and operational environments, with its explicit rejection of an approach restricting analysis to terms provided by the cultural respondents, also departed from the popular cognitive and linguistic anthropological approaches to folk classification and indigenous knowledge (ethnoscience, including ethnoecology, ethnobiology, and ethnomedicine). Rappaport judged the cognized environment approach to be superior because it was holistic, it facilitated cross-cultural and scientific evaluation and comparison, and it paid attention to the multiple ways in which people conceptualized their environments. Although ethnobiology constituted an essential part of the cognized environment described in *Pigs,* Rappaport emphasized the symbolic and ritual significance of certain plants (e.g., *Cordyline* sp.) and animals (pigs), as well as Maring understandings of species dynamics and interrelationships in the ecosystem, more than their position in mundane biological taxonomies (see the essays by Strathern and Stewart, Wiessner and Tumu, and Gillison in this volume).[3]

Above all, Rappaport intended that his ecological approach should circumvent the trap of finding that "culture comes from culture" and ensure that anthropologists would address large serious issues of human survival: "Cultures may induce people to polish their fingernails, but food supplies do not limit them, disease does not debilitate them, nor do

predators feed on them" (1969b: 185). Instead, his key "culture" questions concerning human adaptation and evolution were whether cultural knowledge proves adequate to produce adaptive rather than maladaptive responses or, stated more philosophically, whether culture, by developing needs of its own and establishing goals, values, and purposes for humans, "is a symbolic means to organic ends or organisms' living means to cultural ends, for humans come to serve and preserve their cultures as much as, or even more than, their cultures serve and preserve them" (1984: 385). Notwithstanding his later critics, who charged that Rappaport cared more about energy and material flows than about social and cultural systems, specifying the relationships between the culturally encoded "reference values" that guide human cultural actions regarding the environment and specifying the relationships of these values with the scientifically conceived "goal ranges" that protect ecosystem stability allowed Rappaport to analyze human activity holistically rather than simply measuring physical impacts. From beginning to end, the principal virtue of his ecological approach was its holism.

Ritual, the Sacred, and Adaptation

Although Rappaport found that ritual and religion were central to the ecology of the Tsembaga Maring, in *Pigs* the large questions of nonecological interpretation and meaning were relegated to footnotes. His ecological analysis could not reveal why regulatory functions attributed to the Maring ritual cycle were embedded in ritual. Moreover the *kaiko* ceremonial pig slaughter suggested considerable communicative structure and symbolism that could not be dealt with adequately in purely quantitative terms. Despite his personal ambivalence (or, worse, his negative attitude) toward religion, he devoted much of his subsequent anthropological research to understanding ritual's internal structure, the principles of sanctity that governed it, and how these principles connected individuals, societies, and ecosystems. Thereafter, what was a footnote on the symbolism of the *kaiko* in *Pigs* became a life project that led to Rappaport's second major theoretical contribution, the joining of religion to ecological studies in the analysis of the sacred in human evolution.

Beginning in the early 1970s he published a series of articles proposing the evolutionary significance of religion for human ecology: "Sanctity and Adaptation" (1970b); "Ritual, Sanctity, and Cybernetics" (1971c); and "The Sacred in Human Evolution" (1971d). During this period, while

he was strongly influenced by Bateson, who also studied ritual communication as a cybernetic process intrinsic to adaptation and evolution (and whose collected essays, *Steps to an Ecology of Mind,* were published in 1972), Rappaport also read widely in philosophy, religious studies, and linguistics.

During a two-year sabbatical in Cambridge, England, he incorporated elements of Peirce's (1960) semiotics and Austin's (1962) performative theory and used these to analyze "The Obvious Aspects of Ritual" (1974b) and the relationships between "Liturgies and Lies" (1976b). Language, according to his argument, is essential to human adaptation ("the processes through which living systems maintain themselves in the face of continuous disturbance and occasional threat") because the ability to communicate through lexicons made up of symbols (signs related only "by law" or convention to that which they signify) and grammars (sets of rules for combining symbols into semantically unbounded discourse) enables humans to report upon the past and the distant and to order, plan, and coordinate actions. Language, consequently, allows human beings to imagine, create, and explore alternative worlds and propose what should or might be, the realms of desirable, moral, possible, and imaginary existence. But language complicates evolution (what is being maintained unchanged) by introducing new content and flexibility to humans' understanding of, and responses to, the world around them. Such reflections pushed Rappaport beyond his earlier studies of self-regulating local and regional human populations, which followed the holistic ecological thinking of scientists such as Odum (1963), to an analysis of the "fully human condition," which required "meaning." Still immersed in general systems theory, Rappaport launched a long-term search for the etiology, structure, and attributes of logos—transcendent or higher truths—that binds human beings into a meaningful and enduring order and enables the trustworthy communication necessary for a shared social and cultural life (1979).

In these post-*Pigs* writings, Rappaport showed that ritual points in many directions to establish social relations and not merely to regulate human-environmental relations. Paradoxically, these moves did little to dampen the criticism of those who branded his work "vulgar materialism" or simple-minded functionalism (see, e.g., Friedman 1974 and Sahlins 1976, to which Rappaport responded in 1975a, 1977a [enlarged in 1979], and his 1984 epilogue to the second edition of *Pigs*). These critics dismissed Rappaport's attempts to break down the dichotomy between

functional or materialist and interpretative or symbolic understandings; objected to his partition of the materialist part of the argument into the operational environment, which has its place as long as the analyst does not ignore, paraphrasing Geertz, the "other things going on here" (see also Wolf 1999); and ignored his subsequent work on ritual altogether. Rappaport responded to these and all other known critics in a 180-page epilogue to the second edition of *Pigs* (1984b), which was almost as long as the original ethnography. This epilogue clarified his subsequent arguments on adaptation and revealed both his capacity to engage in self-criticism and his willingness to embrace points of correction received from colleagues (such as Flannery). But it demonstrated as well an almost obsessive defensiveness against Friedman. Freeman, who attacked Mead, was also a critical target in a series of "replies" (1986, 1987a, 1987c, 1987d).

Such responses notwithstanding, the analysis in *Pigs* continues to raise questions inside and outside its own framework. First, if the goal in any general purpose system is to maintain reference values within a set range, in the Maring (or any other) human-dominated "system," then which values are being maintained, those of the social organization or key components of the ecosystem, and over what time and spatial frame? Rappaport responded to these fundamental questions by examining inappropriate reference values as system pathologies, in particular: the inversion, in the course of evolution, of the relationship between regional socioeconomic-demographic systems and local ecosystems (i.e., which takes priority in structuring and governing human behavior). His more comprehensive consideration of "maladaptation, disorder, and the anthropology of trouble" analyzed "maladaptation as structural deformation." Specifically, "violation of contingency relations" and "hierarchical maldistribution of organization" describe cases in which an "increasingly complex world system sucks organization out of local systems" and produces "hypercoherence," such that a change in one element, for example, a drop in world coffee prices, causes a drop in the birth rate in the PNG highlands because young men then earn less and so lack the wealth needed to marry (1979: 160–64; 1984b; 1993a: 300–301; 1994a). These are important structural formulations, but they do not resolve problems of scale or elaborate on the significance of the degree of embeddedness of cultural symbols, issues that are taken up by Moran and Brondizio, Hornborg, and Wiessner and Tumu in this volume.

In an alternative formulation, anthropologists such as Ellen (1982:

195–99) and later Friedman (1994), drawing on their own long-term field observations or contemplation of the rise and fall of empires in history, presented more dynamic, medium- or long-term historical models of human-environmental dynamics, which admit social transformation and cultural change and describe local-regional or periphery-center structural relationships. In a theoretical (not historical) vein, Rappaport, too, in the 1970s, probed and conceptualized the structural characteristics of systems feedback and adaptiveness. Following Bateson, he explored theoretical possibilities of errors in logical typing, hypercoherence, and "inversions" for systems dynamics and in this context accepted Flannery's (1972) explication of positive feedback in the evolution of states. But his argument was framed more in negative terms, in order to understand maladaptation, than in positive terms of "deviation-amplifying (positive) feedback" in dynamic systems.

Put another way, a logical problem with Rappaport's Maring systems formulation is that it takes ecological goal ranges (to ensure survival) to be identical or equivalent to homeostasis and so does not allow for change. Indeed, a major challenge for Rappaport's adoption and usage of von Bertalanffy's (1968) general systems theory was the insistence on homeostasis and negative feedback when human populations in ecosystems appeared to be undergoing constant change, accepting more and more energy, information, and materials from outside, and experiencing profound internal social transformation (see Wiessner and Tumu and Strathern and Stewart in this volume). Although defining the boundaries of human populations that engage in social and material exchange well beyond the local or regional system is a challenge Rappaport acknowledged and tried to deal with in the epilogue to the second edition of *Pigs* (1984b), he was less willing to accept criticisms that he underestimated, missed, or may have mistaken the social logic triggering PNG pig festivals. This was because such criticisms threatened the fundamental premises of his reasoning: they undermined his radical separation of (individual) economic versus ecosystemic logic and also seriously challenged his equilibrium model of Maring society. Despite all of his subsequent writings on structural transformation, maladaptation, and trouble, he did not alter the original interpretation in *Pigs*. To the end, he rejected alternative interpretations that wished to understand his 1960s observations as one point in the development of a dynamic system that had relatively recently experienced the introduction of a major new staple food, the sweet potato, which allowed human

penetration and expansion into the PNG highlands, where human populations were already experiencing the perturbing influences of colonial governance, Christian missionaries, and, as LiPuma (in this volume) points out, "exchange" with anthropologists.

Rappaport's "systems" thinking also blocked any theoretical accommodation with those who observed and thought about the practical impact of human purpose or individual decision making on systems dynamics. In writing "On Cognized Models" (1979), Rappaport acknowledged that different members of local human populations clearly hold different notions or pieces of the "cognized environment."[4] Citing territorially based differences in Australian aboriginal sacred stories, he went so far as to speculate that individual or systematic intragroup differences in the domain of sacred knowledge might foster social solidarity and contribute to social wholeness.[5] He accepted the additional point that in Latin American communities individuals might differ in the specifics but share the cosmological axioms or classifications that divide all things into "hot" and "cold" categories (Messer 1978); he related this idea to the ways in which information is structured and judgments of "what is being maintained unchanged" (1979: 117) as humans in ecosystems respond to perturbations in the material and informational environment. But he did not explore further what implications differences in mundane agricultural or medical knowledge might hold for "self-regulatory" ecosystemic processes or cultural integrity and persistence. This was because the division of knowledge raised the great problems of human agency, human strategies, and praxis and Rappaport never took these to be his principal areas of interest. He rejected their significance as focusing inappropriately on the individual instead of the system (Vayda and McCay 1975; Rappaport 1979: 54). Simply stated, the interpretation that ecosystems are self-organizing and self-regulating was incompatible with the idea that they should be understood as consequences of the individual pursuit of power. His holistic human ecology framework directly opposed frameworks based on praxis, "practical reason," or individual political-economic behavior, all of which understood human beings to pursue private advantage, to maximize their individual positions vis-à-vis others, and "to think and act against the world" rather than thinking and acting as "part of the world" (1984b: 312).

Finally, there remained the issue of why ritual should regulate the environment. Rappaport responded by asserting that ritual regulation was a mode of production comparable to those of feudalism or capitalism (1979:

73). In a partial response to claims that ritual is a very complex and expensive mechanism with which to solve ecological or economic problems, Rappaport asserted that ritual is multipurpose and fundamental to human experience and has existed as long as humanity. He also acknowledged that ecological methods cannot answer questions of the origin of any particular ritual. But such disclaimers, as Gillison points out in this volume, leave the regulatory framework somewhere in the realm of the mystical.

In sum, Rappaport hardly remained stymied in a limited explanatory framework of functionalism or materialism. But his initial equilibrium framework did postulate "no change" when social and ecological parameters were likely to be in flux (see Wiessner and Tumu, LiPuma in this volume). He never solved the problems of how to conceptualize, measure, and map units undergoing change, their possible "resilience" rather than "homeostasis," or orderly change around a moving target, although in his more general theoretical writings on wholeness and holiness he was concerned with accounting for continuities and change in both cognized environments, operational environments, and their linkages. Such concerns also were central to his structural analysis of maladaptation and disordering as a dynamic process in modern complex societies—concerns that led him to theorize the anthropology of trouble and respond with an engaged anthropology.

Maladaptation, Trouble, and Engaged Anthropology

At the end of the 1980s, Rappaport increasingly sought ways to institutionalize and widen applications of his adaptation-maladaptation framework and engage anthropologists more directly in formulating, not just implementing, public policies. As AAA president in 1987–89, with sponsorship by the Wenner-Gren Foundation, he convened public policy panels that were designed to diagnose the "troubles" afflicting modern American society and culture (1994b) as well as those of the developing (the panel preferred the term, "transforming") world. The resulting U.S. volume, *Diagnosing America* (Forman 1994), sought to understand the structural roots of intolerance, inequality, and resistance to the American values of pluralism and cultural diversity. The other panel, which resulted in a book titled *Transforming Societies, Transforming Anthropology* (Moran 1996), embraced the shift that had taken place in anthropology from local to global perspectives. With Rappaport's encouragement, it focused anthropological attention on huge global troubles such as disor-

dered states and the uneven impact of global ideologies (e.g., human rights) on national and local cultures. Beyond "local impacts," the authors also explored linkages among social levels (Colson and Kottak 1996) in the arenas of health, hunger, the media, and environmental management and drew connections linking the actions of large-scale social or political-economic institutions such as transnational corporations, nongovernmental organizations (NGOs), and U.N. organizations and conventions to communities (Rappaport 1994a; Forman 1994; Moran 1996). Encouraging such transformations in subject matter and focus, Rappaport recognized, had the potential to transform anthropology into a no less theoretical but more engaged discipline. With reference to the panels, Peacock (in this volume) describes the kind of conversion process by which Rappaport, the "prophetic activist — a charismatic inspirational yet earthy and human leader who envisioned anthropology as a calling," reoriented him and other anthropologists toward social action and away from strictly academic humanism.

In his "engaged anthropology," which he dubbed "the anthropology of trouble" in his AAA Distinguished Lecture (1993a), Rappaport continued to draw heavily on his systems theory of maladaptation. He looked forward to anthropologists putting theory to work to identify the structural deformations causing social problems and contributing to more adequate theory and policies of correction. No longer would anthropologists serve as handmaidens, applying their insights to the problems framed by other disciplines; anthropologists would frame the problems and explicitly add a values dimension to public policy.

Practicing what he preached, Rappaport contributed his own anthropological wisdom, in chronological order, to the interpretation of energy and forestry use (1971a, 1972a) and an assessment of community-level solar energy technology for the U.S. Department of Energy (in 1976). He served on U.S. government and National Research Council panels investigating the proposed siting of a nuclear waste disposal repository in Yucca Mountain, Nevada (1986–96) and the human (social and environmental) impacts of proposed oil drilling on the Pacific Outer Continental Shelf (1988–92). As early as 1977, Rappaport had been involved in a National Science Foundation research project on Consideration of Non-Quantifiable Variables in Impact Assessment[6] and these later projects provided the chance to apply his ideas to specific cases (1989t, 1990t, 1991t, 1992t/1, 1992t/2). Addressing more general issues of environmental planning, Rappaport also served on the U.S. Government

Advisory Board (1991) and then the Executive Working Group (1993) of the Committee for a National Institute of the Environment and within anthropology on the AAA Environmental Task Force and the Society for Applied Anthropology Committee on Human Rights and the Environment. In all these settings, he was able to convince economists and geographers, as well as other anthropologists, that it is sensible, even mandatory, to ask wider and more holistic questions about the social and environmental impact of planned change, even though anthropologists' questions are seldom simple to answer. He also successfully prevented the implementation of some potentially damaging projects (see Johnston in this volume).

The common thread connecting all of Rappaport's policy writings is a continuing argument against economists' and other experts' thinking. Economists, he argued, base their actions on the erroneous belief that ecosystems can be "valued" by estimating and summing the total monetary worth of the economic resources contained within them. As a corollary, they measure social impact by means of estimates of lost streams of income—when in fact priceless societies with irreplaceable traditions are being uprooted! He proposed that, instead of the usual economic indicators, assessments of "human environmental impact" would make nonquantifiable dimensions of human systems central to policy decision making and would consider the whole human system.

Rappaport's program for holistic assessment includes conceptions

> of morality, equity, justice, honor . . . property, rights, and duties; [religious and] aesthetic values and conceptions of what constitutes high life quality; distinctive understandings concerning the nature of nature, or the place of humans in it, of proper behavior with respect to it, and of equitable distribution of its fruits, its costs, and its dangers . . . assumptions about the nature of reality: what is given, what requires demonstration, what comprises evidence, how knowledge is gained (1994a: 159)

He attacked the notion that the most important social impacts could be quantitatively measured stating that,

> the term *value* . . . refers to conceptions like "truth," "honor," . . . "integrity," [and] . . . trustworthiness," [but] . . . there is a radical incompatibility between some of these values and metrics

> of any sort [and] . . . "fundamental" or "basic" values tend, in their nature, to be very low in specificity. What is it, after all, that constitutes "liberty" or "happiness" or, for that matter, "life"? (1994a: 168)

As a specific example,

> plausible significant effects of offshore oil development . . . might be anger at and alienation from government for what is perceived to be inequitable treatment, increased conflict within affected localities and regions among organizations, individuals, and agencies taking different positions on development, psychic and social tension arising out of the increasing scope of uncertainty concerning the particulars of development and fear of disaster, decreases in the pleasure of the shorefront recreational public as a consequence of nearby oil and gas facilities, and the endangerment of the way of life of native peoples and other quality of life issues. . . . The aesthetic considerations of affected populations, or violations of their religious beliefs, or of their conceptions of equity, or even their vague conceptualizations of the good life, cannot be ruled inadmissible because they resist serious monetary representation, or even quantitative representation of any sort, for they may well be—are even likely to be—the most significant factors for those populations in developing attitudes and taking action. (1994a: 160–61)

Existing systems of analysis, he cautioned, do not deal adequately with the scale or distribution of impacts over space (local to global), time (this generation to future generations), or susceptibility to mitigation (167–69).

Intrinsic to Rappaport's holistic assessment of values were corrections to at least three elements of economists' reductionist thinking: their failure to take into account the multiple structural levels at which humans respond to environmental and political perturbations, their tendency to take culture as given, and their assumption that individuals act to maximize individual advantage or inclusive fitness. The environment, Rappaport insisted, is more variable than the variables economists or environmental experts choose to model for simplified decision making. Therefore, cost-benefit analysis is inappropriate for understanding the range of cultural concerns that should form a part of any "environmental

impact" assessment. Adaptive processes, he argued, are not necessarily maximizing or optimizing, as would be a profit-oriented firm's, but self-corrective and self-organizing processes that aim at solutions that are "good enough" for survival (1979: 70). Economic (rational) man is not the natural and logical motivational state of individuals; rather, individuals often operate in ways that appear to contradict maximization and their immediate interests. Reductionist economic logic at any level (individual, firm, social group, or global business) misses the logic of the ecosystem and by such lapses threatens and disorders the earth and its inhabitants. Taken together, he argued, these mistakes lead policymakers to dissolve the distinctiveness of different classes of things into a common unit of analysis or measure — usually money, although, depending on the problem, sometimes (food) energy or other nutrients, food production (calculated in weight, volume, calories, income per unit area, labor, or other "output" per unit "input") — and to substitute quantitative for qualitative difference. By forcing nonmetrical distinctions into a metric, Rappaport argued, decision makers render the world less meaningful even as they degrade it ecologically (1984: 328).

A shortened version of this statement, published as "Considering the Meaning of Human Environment and the Nature of Impact" (1994a), in *Who Pays the Price? The Sociocultural Context of Environmental Crisis* (Johnston 1994), became central to the conceptual arguments of environmental anthropologists advocating the human right to a sustainable environment (see Johnston in this volume). Rappaport's criticism of nonholistic thinkers was aimed mainly at professional economists, engineers, environmental or biological scientists, and other technical "experts." But other anthropologists (e.g., Ingold 1996; Dove and Kammen 1997) took on anthropological colleagues who overemphasized quantitative measures.[7] Paradoxically, although his life's work was directed at unmasking "ecological imperialism" masquerading under the euphemisms "progress" and "development" (1971a), some of Rappaport's own criticisms of economic approaches within anthropology focused on political economists who privileged explanations of power or economic thinking over adaptive processes. Again, this was because he considered ritual regulation to be a distinctive mode of production. Widely criticized, this early gap or oversight was bridged by those of his students who practiced political, historical, or other, "newer" ecologies (Greenberg and Park 1994; Biersack 1999; Wolf 1999; Lees, this volume).

Rappaport's refusal to deal with individual issues of power and ex-

ploitation in Marxist or popular leftist terms may help explain why he never became the kind of public intellectual that some of his colleagues envisioned he would (or was). More importantly, his ideas were complex, and as a scholar he was unwilling or unable to simplify sufficiently to make them more available to a general audience. Notwithstanding the criticism leveled at his early work, he never was a reductionist, a single-minded cultural materialist, or particularly easy or fun to read.[8] Apart from Rappaport's critique of the statement by a General Motors executive that "what is good for General Motors is good for the country" as an example of maladaptive "usurpation" (misplaced special purpose systems assuming the goals of the general system), he offered few cute or catchy sound bites likely to appeal to a general audience. Although he confronted all the big issues surrounding population and environment, his arguments were never simply political but always complexly cybernetic and characterized by the liberal use of systems and anthropological jargon. In sum, Rappaport was an author of scholarly articles and volumes, not op ed pieces or trade books.

Equally, Rappaport's dedication to systems thinking made him less partisan politically than the ecological writers who carved out popular niches. Although his early, more popular writings on energy flow (e.g., 1971a) and ecosystem feedback and regulation were widely circulated and cited, he never achieved the popular name recognition of many contemporary ecologists, systems theorists, and populists who wrote for large audiences and tended to cover fields outside their immediate area of expertise.[9] It was not that Rappaport was less successful; rather, he never chose this route. Finally, anthropology had undergone transformations; whereas ecology and systems thinking were popular in the 1960s and 1970s, these approaches were at least partially eclipsed by sociobiology, Marxist "critical" perspectives, structuralism and semiotics, the anthropology of experience, and postmodernism, which came to dominate the discipline in the following decades (see Lambek, this volume). From within anthropology, Rappaport devoted considerable energy to accommodating these changing fashions and trends.

Religion, Science and Humanity's Future

Alongside engaged anthropology, Rappaport continued to hone arguments for his magnum opus on religion. He refined ideas on "the construction of time and eternity in ritual" (1987d, 1992) and ritual

communication, truth, morality, and evolution (1988b, 1993b, 1994d, 1995a). Finally, on his deathbed, he completed *Ritual and Religion in the Making of Humanity* (1999), which has been greeted as the most significant treatment of its subject since that of Durkheim (Hart 1999; Lambek, this volume). This final work found ritual to be universal, the basis of all human community, communication, and trust. It argued that the combination of the discursive (liturgical order) and nondiscursive (religious experience) dimensions of holiness is all that allows human beings to commit themselves to the orderly rules of social life that organize their collective lives and to cultural conventions that allow them to maintain their populations in some kind of balance with their ecology. Human beings need certainty and wholeness, Rappaport argued, which only ritual and religion can provide. In sum, ritual is the basic mechanism of human adaptation.

To reach these conclusions Rappaport continued to ground his abstract theory in Maring ethnography and his ideas of ultimate sacred postulates, logos, and resilience in his understanding of the history of Jewish religion. More specific illustrations of his argument on ritual and communication he left to future readers (some of whom take up the challenge in this volume; see the essays by Gluck, Wagner, Levy, Csordas, and Lambek). Although he acknowledged possible maladaptations and pathologies in the structure of ritual communication, he did not let historical instances of religious killing, plunder, or other "pathologies" disturb his notion of religion's formative role in the "making of humanity" (Wolf 1999; Gillison, this volume; Lambek, this volume). Nor did he wrestle with critical historical and psychological questions of religious competition, conversion, and choice where there exist multiple competing orders—all claiming truth—that are part of religious, social, and cultural history. To the end, his "metanarrative" was "adaptation" and "adaptive structure" through which he again attempted to reconcile scientific and humanistic understandings.

Science, like religion, plays a crucial role in Rappaport's understanding of human survival. Its role is to analyze the operational environment, but in the modern world, where science seeks to usurp the place of religion (in Rappaport's terms, "the holy"), it presents a prime example of systemic "inversion." Questioning the value of ritual acts but offering nothing to replace them and allowing calculations based on facts organized under theories that open up new realms of thought but under which knowledge can be questioned, science by its very method fragments and

precludes certainty. Humanity, however, needs certainty and wholeness in order to survive. It requires participation in "acts of observing and analyzing the world in accordance with natural law [which] are very different from participation in ritual acts constructing and maintaining the world in accordance with *Logos*" (1994c: 162). Only our capacities to simultaneously pursue science (law) and construct logos (meaning) can assure humanity's future. This reconciliation of the laws of nature with cultural constructions of it is ultimately and principally the mission of anthropologists, who recognize that no science is entirely objective and detached and already incorporate into their analyses a theory of praxis (a point LiPuma grapples with in his contribution to this volume).

Rappaport's insistence that science must involve subjective as well as objective understandings was a practical and methodological but also a moral stance. Following Bateson (1972) and Toulmin (1982), he emphasized anthropology's qualitative concerns for holism and context-based assessment, its methodology of participant observation, and its humanistic focus. He hailed anthropology as the preeminent postmodern science, one that will further understandings of cosmology, world unity, and global integrity as its practitioners pursue research leading to action. It will be based on ecology, but an ecology that is identified with *logos,* a term used here to describe both a realization of the world's law-based unity and a commitment to its cultural construction. To the end, it was Rappaport's view that anthropology's future lies in understanding and formulating humanity's place in the world and the action-oriented programs needed to achieve it (1994c: 160). In his words: "Humanity, in this view, is not only a species among species, it is the only way the world has to think about itself" (1984b: 310; 1994c: 166).

Holism within the Discipline

This somewhat mystical formulation of anthropology's role in human survival—without tangible referents and with overall ambiguity—encompassed and at an abstract level bridged the enormous divides that it experienced in the final decades of Rappaport's life. He envisioned the objective of anthropology to be nothing short of an understanding of humanity's evolution and an active engagement with social problems to ensure human survival.

Although Rappaport recognized that "our colleagues will do whatever they take to be interesting or important" (1994c: 153), his vision was

anthropology as science—the only science, although not only science—dedicated to understanding humanity. Coming full circle from his roots in human ecology and systems theory, in the 1990s he looked forward to anthropology enduring as a distinct science of humanity but one in which poetry, performance, and passion also had their place. Addressing the major theoretical divide of the 1990s, he cautioned that a radical separation of science and culture is a profound error:

> Two traditions have proceeded in anthropology since its inception. One, objective in its aspirations and inspired by the biological sciences, seeks explanation and is concerned to discover causes, or even, in the view of the ambitious, laws. The other, influenced by philosophy, linguistics, and the humanities, and open to more subjectively derived knowledge, attempts interpretation and seeks to elucidate meanings. Our ancestry, thus, lies in both the enlightenment and in what Isaiah Berlin (1980) calls the "Counter Enlightenment." . . . Radical separation of the two is misguided . . . because meanings are often causal and causes are often meaningful." (154)

Anthropology, he reflected, still seeks, uneasily, to unite "simple-minded" and "muddleheaded" styles of thinking, with the muddleheaded tending to dominate because "we (anthropologists) have never been very trustful of simplicity, and we have always taken the world to be messier and more complicated than any method or combination of methods could account for" (153–54). The muddleheaded prevail also because anthropology holds an "ambivalent epistemology" that "expresses the condition of a species that lives, and can only live, in terms of meanings it itself must construct in a world devoid of intrinsic meaning but subject to natural law" (154). In Rappaport's thinking, however, this very ambiguity, characteristic of the species and reflected in anthropology's epistemology, holds important advantages: only anthropologists study both the operations of nature and human attempts to manipulate it. They therefore are well placed to identify the places where human models of and actions toward nature do not map adequately onto the operational environment and to correct world-destroying errors. But the discipline at large only partially shares this vision.

During the late 1980s and 1990s, Rappaport reached out to those inside and outside the discipline who were working on issues such as human rights and the environment (see Johnston, this volume) and who

shared his particular concerns.[10] As president of the AAA (1987–89) he tried to bridge the growing divisions between anthropologists at the extremes, between those who defined themselves as reflexive humanists versus sociobiologists and those in between who identified themselves to varying degrees as philosophers or scientists. He was, as Hornborg so eloquently states it in this volume, one of those rare individuals who could both count potatoes and write philosophy. But he also had to maintain a spirited defense of holism in the face of critics who insisted that all cultural "wholes" (including ecological consciousness within cultures) are imagined because the world is in constant transition (e.g., Friedman 1994, 1997) and because minimal environmental impacts have much more to do with small-scale activities than with any purported "primitive" environmental ethic or mentality (e.g., Ellen 1986).

Others, however, more closely approximate Rappaport's quest for holism. Descola and Pálsson (1996) seek holism in the accounts of human-environmental relations of different peoples, and Pálsson (1997) tries to move beyond dualism in his call for a new public environmental discourse that, like Rappaport's, can remove disciplinary boundaries and inject humanity into models of and solutions for natural resource problems. In keeping with Rappaport's systemic analysis of maladaption, comparative analysis of (environmental) discourse has a place (Brosius 1999a, 1999b). Similarly, Hornborg (this volume) suggests that anthropologists can use methods of cultural interpretation—including deconstruction—to analyze the cultural background of degradation and the labeling of ecological crisis and has begun a historical project to relate (cultural) concepts of personhood to the ways in which humans treat nature. Kottak (1999) has tried to expand (and summarize) the methods and contexts through which anthropologists can contribute to ecological research, leading to action in interdisciplinary, especially development policy, contexts. And Vayda's call for a more rigorous, event-specific, or "evenemental," or event ecology (Vayda 1997; Vayda and Walters 1999) tries to take into account the correct mix of both political and natural forces in the explanation of particular cases.[11] There are also renewed calls for holism among the humanists, who pursue the anthropology of experience from symbolic and cognitive perspectives and seek inspiration in Rappaport's writings (e.g., Fernandez 1986).

In addition, outside the discipline we see some return to a quest for holism—or "unity of knowledge"—based on reactions to the fragmentation of university disciplines and the perceived need for a unified theory

to address complex environmental and social problems. E. O. Wilson's *Consilience* (1998), which represents one such attempt, searches for underlying ordering principles available in interdisciplinary discourses such as neurobiology and cognitive psychology and also new interdisciplinary fields such as the environmental sciences. This recognition of the need for holism and more unified theories of knowledge were always Rappaport's strength and, following his teacher Bateson (1972), his unique contribution. There are also increasing concerns about human values in science, the relationship between science and religion, and the spiritual dimensions of cosmology. Many seek also an intrinsic, if not always positive, role for ritual and religion in social transformation.

Conclusion

In sum, in both his very recent contributions to studies of religion (1999) and his emphasis on the role of anthropology as a postmodern science (1994c) Rappaport appears to be an emergent, if not a visionary, figure who will become more not less significant in the twenty-first century. Whereas at the beginning of his career he, with Vayda (Rappaport 1968a), suggested that human ecological analysis ultimately might involve sacrificing the notion of an autonomous science of culture, in his subsequent and certainly in his final writings (1994c, 1999) Rappaport sought to understand the sacred and all that sets humanity apart. In these final works, he also argues that anthropology is an autonomous science but also a field in the humanities with a distinct and essential contribution to make to our understanding of humankind and global ecology. This final viewpoint is shared by the volume's contributors, whose associations with Skip and his work span his lifetime and are ample testimony to the breadth and depth of his scholarship and influence.

Plan of the Volume

In keeping with his self-critical and holistic sense of his work, Rappaport had his own ideas about how a festschrift in his honor might be structured and organized. He hoped that it would contain critical essays that would engage and advance his ideas, possibly organized according to his own sense of his professional development, with obvious cross-linkages among sections. In keeping with this plan, our contributors build on Rappaport's ethnographic insights, explore implications of his ecosystem

analysis that lead into the anthropology of trouble, and contextualize his ideas on religion and evolution in a variety of political settings. A final section offers findings in PNG ethnography that appear to crosscut all of Rappaport's categories. Consistent with his later essays, which inject a human, subjective element into their scientific analysis, most contributors begin with some personal reflection on Rappaport's significance in their professional lives.[12]

Ecology and the Anthropology of Trouble

Rappaport's ecological anthropology is reworked here to incorporate into the analyses historical-political processes and interest group or individual perspectives that highlight the mechanisms that keep ecosystems in disequilibrium, particularly in modern, complex societies.

Lees, who was Rappaport's first Ph.D. and a founding editor of *Human Ecology,* demonstrates how far anthropology has moved in the direction of "political ecology" in her essay "Kicking Off the *Kaiko:* Instability, Opportunism, and Crisis in Ecological Anthropology." Updating human ecology, she succinctly reviews the relevant Marxist, feminist, and sociobiologist literatures, which move human ecology away from "equilibrium" to focus on inequalities within households and communities, the co-optation and manipulation of communities by individuals, and the significance of different perceptions of environmental resources as they affect their management. Her brief analysis of the etiology of an Israeli water "crisis" convincingly demonstrates how powerful groups in this state society are able to declare a crisis for their own political and economic advantage. In this case, the function of ritual (here the public declaration and management of an alleged crisis) is to keep society in a disequilibrium state that favors opportunists, although the longer term implications of state-level intervention in what should be local water management and judgments of crisis illustrate the structural features of Rappaport's notions of maladaptations and trouble.

Rappaport influenced the way anthropologists engage such political-ecological linkages by participating in policy dialogues that explore the methods and values involved in environmental decision making. This is the theme in the next three essays, which utilize a range of not always compatible approaches and follow Rappaport's turn in attention from local to global environmental awareness and action.

The first two essays engage processes of environmental change from the opposite (and often opposed) methods of scientists (quantitative material and information data analysis) and humanists (semiotics). In the first, Moran and Brondizio demonstrate how large-scale satellite remote sensing (Geographic Information System, or GIS) techniques can be combined with local and regional ecological (including ethnographic) reporting to model deforestation, agroecology, and ecosystem restoration in the Amazon Basin. In this careful, data-based essay, the authors carry Rappaport's original approach—to study and compare operational and cognized environments—into new arenas. They quite literally map cognized environments, reported by anthropologists, onto operational environments, reported in satellite imagery. In the process, they show how anthropological methods developed for small-scale social analysis can contribute to our understanding of regional ecosystem dynamics, global economic and environmental processes, and transnational technical-diagnostic procedures designed to ascertain information on ecosystem function or malfunction.

Hornborg, by contrast, approaches the global environmental crisis from an anthropological humanist, semiotic, and phenomenological perspective. He ponders a possible historical relationship between conservationist human ecology and premodern notions of personhood and analyzes, as "the ecology of cultural diffusion," the semiotic and selective process by means of which components of global discourse and currency such as transnational MacDonald's fast food, Coca-Cola, and "money" are disembedded from an original context so that they can be adopted and used in the discourse and ecology of another culture. In asking "what kind of conditions could be imagined that would select for *specificity:* for embeddedness, local economies, local knowledge, and local identity" he returns to an issue that was central to Rappaport's concerns: if environmentally protective notions of and actions with regard to "the sacred" are tied to specific (local) conditions, can local awareness address global environmental issues and universal ideologies, world religions, and global environmental movements become more grounded in and protective of specific environments?

Johnston, who spearheads anthropologists' activities on human rights and the environment within the Society for Applied Anthropology and the American Anthropological Association, provides case studies that show the many venues in which anthropologists engage environmental policy, the multiple social levels (local to global) of anthropological analysis, and the institutional and technical aids to action, including NGO

networking, the media, and especially the Internet and electronic mail. Her contribution exemplifies how anthropologists have moved from ecological anthropology to environmental management and policy issues. In the process, she demonstrates how important it is that anthropologists follow in Rappaport's footsteps, combating exclusively economic formulations of environmental and social impacts and at the very least making national and international decision makers aware of the close linkages between human rights achievements and environmental quality. Whereas Lees focuses on the effects of state politics on ecological issues, Johnston emphasizes the destructiveness inherent in the privatization of large development projects, especially as they fall outside the corrective purview and possible corrective action of global moral actors.

Such policy approaches aim to remove or reform disorders emanating "from the top," where the systemic goal of survival for the general purpose system is often distorted, or in Rappaport's term "usurped," by special purpose (political-economic or private industrial) systems, which may also exhibit other dysfunctions, maladaptations, and structural disorders. But how does systemic analysis incorporate ordinary individuals at the "bottom", who must somehow relate to a political system's message? This is the topic taken up in Markowitz's essay, which closes this section. It examines Russian teenagers' understandings of the world, Russian politics, and modern culture. In interviews these teenagers indicate their disillusionment with both the old Communist order and the opportunistic new post-Communist order (or disorder). They have lost the apparent solidarity generated by the old Communist rituals but are equally disillusioned by the new order of greed, which offers nothing of value to replace it. Russian teenagers, Markowitz concludes, "neither trust nor advocate quick, ideological solutions to deep structural problems." If anything, they look for vague "natural" or "ecological" alternatives to ideological movements because the latter — nationalist romanticism, communism, monetarism — are spurious responses to problems opportunistically framed by the powerful, who subordinate "the fundamental and ultimate to the contingent and instrumental" (Rappaport 1993a) and, instead of solving them, multiply and magnify the country's troubles.

Ritual Structure and Religious Practice

More meaningful ritual and sacred practices are addressed in the second section, where Levy, picking up on Rappaport's concept of ritual as a universal category, draws on his ethnographic observations in Tahiti and

Nepal, and historical readings on Buddhism and Christianity, to investigate how these and other cases fit Rappaport's concepts of ritual. Ritual in each case must be more than form; it must be bolstered by interpretation and belief to sustain social order. It must also be supported by ethical acts, socially constructed and accepted obligations, that stand in some relationship to ritual and belief. All can be analyzed as dimensions or levels of Rappaport's concept of the sacred, which, Levy affirms in closing, is the heuristic strength of Rappaport's insights for purposes of comparative research.

Gluck, an American Reform rabbi and one of Rappaport's last students, adopts Rappaport's five levels of the sacred as a framework within which to analyze changes or adaptive flexibility in Jewish grieving rituals. The antiphonal mourner's kaddish prayer, he notes, focuses on the Jewish ultimate sacred proposition — "God is [the unknowable name]" — not on death and mourning. It says nothing, moreover, about the emotional state and grief of the mourner. In the 1960s, when giving voice to such sentiments seemed important, American Reform Jewish liturgies added "introductory" prayers to cover such sensibilities. After tracing the history of Jewish mourning ritual, Gluck analyzes the contents of a number of these additional prayers to demonstrate how they accommodate change with unchangingness: the ultimate sacred postulate remains at the core of the kaddish.

In what contexts do people accept the new while retaining the old, with or without conflict? In what contexts or at what levels are they willing to entertain plurality in religious or everyday behavioral practice? These are questions addressed by Wagner and Peacock, both of whom carried out ethnographic research with fundamentalist Christians in the southeastern United States. Wagner, like Gluck, refers to Rappaport's concepts of five levels of sanctity in her analysis of sources of unity in Christian schools. She illustrates simply but cogently that such Christian schools are able to accommodate a variety of fundamentalist beliefs and practices because they are able to agree on six fundamental articles of faith and have agreed to disagree on "lower order" axioms. Agreement on fundamentals, which Wagner takes to be ultimate sacred postulates, allows diversity and flexibility on all other issues of doctrine and conduct.

Peacock, by contrast, is also interested in the emotional side of fundamentalism, the conversion experience. In a study of fundamentalists in two world religions, he compares the contexts, concepts, and language of

conversion experiences among Christian fundamentalists in the southeastern United States and Indonesian Muslim sectarians. He constructs a kind of double image of insiders-outsiders, beginning with the anthropologist, who is recording and sometimes participant observing in the actual conversion context without being converted himself. The convert, who has known prior states, comments as an insider–former outsider. Peacock's comparison sets up a multidimensional contrast between the two forms of conversion along the lines of emotional state, gender, and aims (e.g., to overcome sin) and finds that for Christian converts emotions are high, people seek or discover a visionary experience of being saved, and they aim to overcome sin and reform their unholy lives. Muslim converts, by contrast, are trying to achieve peace of mind through consistent conformity to Islamic law. Peacock provides the kind of cross-cultural, ethnic and gender-sensitive analysis, grounded in world religions, that Lambek suggests might be a fruitful outcome of Rappaport's framework. But, given the political significance of the individual leaders and groups with whom he worked, Peacock also views his contribution as engaged anthropology, which is the topic of his introductory remarks.

Csordas then engages what he construes to be a theoretical cognitive lacuna in Rappaport's work, the domain of subjective experience. The explicit goal of his research, which was carried out among North American Catholic Charismatics and Navajo individuals from three different religious sects, is to demonstrate the convergence of the sacred (numinous, ideal) and the environmental (material) in embodied images experienced in dreams or waking states. Traditional Navajo and members of the Native American Church, he finds, perceive "indications" (of the holy) from images in nature such as clouds, which can look like lizards and thereby become an omen of illness. Such omens are based on a "real" perception of nature, yet they are "imaged" and function in similar ways to omens perceived in dreams, visions, and so on. They comprise a culturally conditioned way of perceiving nature; mountains and plains are also imaged as in a sacred mountain that looks like an eagle. Csordas focuses on such "indeterminacy" as a way of knowing that brings the environment (material landscape) and the sacred (the ideal) together in spontaneous "numinous" experiences analogous to ritual acts. This essay evokes Rappaport's focus on ecosystems as wholes, which brings the discussion back to a cybernetics of the holy that unites mind and body, the numinous and the environment, which is also Lambek's concluding point.

In his long, thoughtful conclusion to this section, Lambek critically compares Rappaport's evolutionary, ordering, adaptive systems approach with those of other anthropologists. Rappaport's notion of religion—especially ritual—as establishing moral categories and actions most closely resembles Durkheim's. But Rappaport enjoyed historical and intellectual advantages over Durkheim: he had access to an additional half century of ethnographic studies, which allowed him to further reflect on the "elementary forms of the religious life" and to draw on cybernetic communications and linguistic theories in his inquiry into the formal and discursive properties of liturgical orders and their significance in human evolution. He also grounded his understandings of religion in his personal experiences of Maring ritual and the Jewish liturgical order. On the basis of these and other examples, Rappaport theorized five levels of sacred communication, from the least to the most materially grounded, and a model of religious (numinous) experience that incorporated discursive and nondiscursive elements. As Lambek notes, however, Rappaport left it to others to illuminate specific historical circumstances (see the essays by Levy, Gluck, and Wagner), to explicate historical specifics of ordinary versus sanctified cognition (see Csordas), and to analyze cases of conversion, especially in pluralistic situations (see Peacock). Moreover, whatever the historical findings, acceptance of Rappaport's ideas, Lambek suggests, ultimately will depend on "whether one believes that order or disorder is, or has been, more characteristic of the human condition."

The Papua New Guinea Context: Following Skip's Ethnographic Footsteps

The final section, in which contemporary ethnographers update Rappaport's ethnographic insights, examines diversity and change in highland PNG. As a set, the essays encourage readers to view variation across geographical space (Strathern and Stewart, Gillison, Wiessner and Tumu) and time (LiPuma, Wiessner and Tumu) and also suggest where the Maring appear to have differed from their neighbors either at that time of early contact with Europeans or later. For example, the Maring may have been unusual in their absence of "big men" who manipulated pig production and prestation for their own ends.

Paying homage to Rappaport's "superb set of ethnographic field data" (Strathern and Stewart) the essays begin by revisiting Rappa-

port's detailed analysis of the Maring's *kaiko* (pig) festival and its fundamental tie to "uprooting the rumbin" (a *Cordyline* shrub), which in Rappaport's interpretation signaled a cosmic shift from peaceful production to prestations that re-ally, and realign, local groups ultimately through warfare. They then compare religious beliefs, ritual practices, and ecosystem consequences for additional PNG societies variously defined and bounded as local or regional populations at one or more periods in time.

Strathern and Stewart, working among the nearby Melpa, find that the Melpa demonstrate the economic logic and individual competition and manipulation of power that Rappaport, in his interpretations of the Maring, took pains to dismiss. But this competitive exchange occurs in the historical context of pacification, in which competitive exchange replaces actual fighting and Christians battle satanic forces for control over ground and fertility. Alongside these latter forces, traditional symbols of fertility, such as *Cordyline* shrubs and a female fertility cult also appear to endure. From these multiple perspectives, the authors add to Rappaport's original interpretation the idea of a political-economic (power) dimension to ritual management of the ecology, while further developing his later idea of enduring ultimate sacred postulates amid change. The other authors also take up these themes.

Gillison, who worked among the Gimi, continues the first theme. She concurs with the interpretation that big men, in pursuit of political-economic power, manage pig husbandry, sacrifice, ritual, and women. Her economic account scrutinizes the dynamics of local pig raising with reference to the conscious roles of individuals in group processes and decision making. These observations then serve as a foil for opening up Rappaport's method and theory to alternative Freudian viewpoints on consciousness and religion. Gillison credits Rappaport with "having achieved for ecology what Douglas did for the body by expanding into new terrain Durkheim's ideas about the hidden social logic of religion" but then criticizes him for "driving higher reason and communal interests into the unconscious," where an almost mystical unconscious is the seat of social or ecological reasoning.

In their historical study, Wiessner and Tumu take up both themes, as they survey ritual activity associated with the Ain Cult of the 1940s. In association with other post–sweet potato the cults, human population, pig production, and long-distance social ties expanded and the ritual exchange of pigs accelerated, "like a bush fire," and grew out of

control. At their height, forty thousand people were involved in the exchange of tens of thousands of pigs. This was hardly "ritual regulation" of the environment in Rappaport's terms because environmental deterioration and infertility (especially high child mortality) characterized these (Tee) cultic developments. But this was not the end of the story. Weissner and Tumu describe how there arose a competing (Ain) cult, which, couched in language of world deterioration and entropy, sought to avert environmental collapse by returning to ancient sacred postulates and symbols such as the planting of a *Cordyline* shrub to symbolize conversion and rejection of ritual pig exchange. Its goal of social transformation, to limit environmental damage and preserve world harmony, describes a conscious program, analogous to Christianity, which eventually competed with and largely replaced it.

Such consciously directed social transformations are in contrast to LiPuma's essay, which describes the unintentional historical (mythic, founding) role of the ethnographer (Skip) in indigenous PNG exchange and reflects on how external (Western) contacts, be they missionaries, government administrators, or anthropologists, distort or enter into existing value systems. LiPuma sheds light on the controversy over whether these highland groups were primitive conservationists or capitalists and whether the adaptation Rappaport described in the 1960s represented stability or a period of decline (see Hornborg). The essay expands on Mauss's insights in *The Gift* and explores the multiple social dimensions of the ethnographer's gift giving and reciprocal exchange with local people, transactions that forge the ethnographer's social identity and position relative to others. LiPuma generously describes Skip's formative role in PNG cosmology and cosmography; a tall, big-footed outsider who came bearing gifts and was also a harbinger of social transformation.

As a set, these essays attest to the enduring value of the fieldwork of Rappaport, the ethnographer and theoretician, and Skip, the ethnographic ancestor depicted in the discourses of both PNG anthropologists (Strathern and Stewart) and natives (LiPuma). All affirm the proposition that there exists some ritual regulation of environmental resources, but particularly Wiessner and Tumu, through historical interpretation, present evidence that feedback can be deviation amplifying, not just negative, and can lead to dynamic changes in local and regional social systems and ecosystems, not homeostasis. Moreover anthropologists by their very presence constitute perturbations and contribute to flux. These ethnographers also demonstrate how difficult it is to overcome

what were critical limitations of the original argument framed in *Pigs,* namely, whether it is possible, and if so how, to define and set boundaries for local and regional populations in ecosystems that are never pristine but always influenced and involved in exchange acts with those beyond their problematic borders.

Summary

Contributors to this volume address Rappaport's entire lifetime of works in a single volume because his ideas on humanity, ecosystems, and the sacred form a logical whole. His continuing interests in ecology, as against political economy, and in wholes, as against cultural parts, perspectives, or individual or historical practice, mark him as one of the great original thinkers in anthropology and religion, although, as Lambek notes, they also to some degree marginalized him as a central figure in the 1970s, 1980s, and 1990s in American anthropology. Notwithstanding, the breadth and depth of this festschrift and other essays (e.g., the special section [winter 1999] of the *American Anthropologist*) suggest that Rappaport's impact has been and will continue to be far reaching and will influence generations of anthropologists to come.

Rappaport's legacy will endure because the search for sustainable human and environmental futures is never ending. In addition, resurgent interest in ecology, religions, and holistic analysis, both inside and outside of anthropology, should encourage further scrutiny and explication of his ideas. Historical testing of his notions of the sacred and the structure of communication will substantiate or modify his concepts, but they will continue to be useful. Fulfillment of his moral aspirations for the discipline will depend on whether anthropologists are willing to accept and act on obligations to use anthropological theory to discern the etiologies and epistemologies of social problems and construct appropriate theories of correction. The contributors here have taken the first steps.

NOTES

1. Biersack (1999) wrote that *Pigs for the Ancestors* may be the most widely distributed ethnography of all time.

2. It demonstrated that the religious aspect of culture is not a mere epiphenomenon but central to human-environmental relations. Although Steward amended his cultural ecology model to include interrelations between culture

core and secondary features at about this time (1968), the unit of analysis remained the cultural group not the human population.

3. Rappaport criticized ethnoscientists who failed to consider the whole (cognitive environment or cognitive together with operational environment) and instead selected for analysis small, insignificant domains such as firewood categories. Although D'Andrade (1995) belittles such criticism as ethnocentric (firewood categories are extremely important to those who rely on firewood as fuel), his criticism does not demolish Rappaport's general point; in fact, the ascendancy of the "new ethnography" in the discipline as a whole was relatively short-lived. Ironically, like ecological approaches, it was marginalized in the face of the new postmodern and poststructuralist interpretative anthropology and the anthropology of experience. Paradoxically, the 1980s found now "old" new ethnographers such as Brent Berlin denying that any anthropological approach should have an exclusive claim to truth and proposing a new "scientific anthropology" unit for the American Anthropological Association to counter the anti-science, literary-humanistic trend. In his later work, Rappaport sometimes referred to certain of the data and findings of ethnoscience. He was interested in universals, particularly in how they might be conventionally established in ritual, and so he drew on Berlin and Kay's (1969) study of universals in the evolution of color terminologies. In retrospect, Frake's (1964) ethnoscientific description of the religious domain among the Subanun treats some of the same points, such as ritual performance's on/off informational role, as Rappaport's "Obvious Aspects of Ritual." Ford and Flannery, team teaching a human ecology course with Rappaport in 1970, encouraged greater complementarity between ethnobiology and human ecology, but reconciling the approaches was left to graduate students such as myself (Messer 1978).

4. "It must not be imagined . . . that the understandings of all members of any tribal society are uniform. That some variation within common frameworks is usual, even among people of similar age and sex, is demonstrated by variations in the folk taxonomies commonly provided by different informants in the same community" (1979: 133).

5. "Among Australian aborigines sacred knowledge is typically distributed among men according to their section, subsection, moiety, and totemic affiliations and sometimes by locality as well [among the Walbiri]. No one knows the [*Gadjari* cycle] myth in its entirety, let alone all of the *Gadjari* songs and rituals, but in each of the four major Walbiri countries there are men who know the portion of the cycle pertaining to their own region. The *Gadjari* thus creates a set of understandings that no individual fully possesses but in which many individuals participate. Interdependence is intrinsic to the ways in which sacred knowledge is distributed among Australian aborigines, and it may be that the dependence of local groups upon each other for the performance of the rituals understood to be necessary to maintain the world counteracts the social fragmentation likely to attend hunting and gathering in vast deserts" (1979: 133–34).

6. R. Andrews, principal investigator, 1977.

7. Anthropologists who adopted quantitative methods such as the new computer modeling techniques, which challenged analysts to quantify prestige or

evaluate the rationality of food strategies in terms of energy or particular nutrients, received criticism from other sources: from ecology-minded colleagues such as Ingold (1996), who exposed the fallacies and paradoxes of the assumptions underlying "optimal foraging theory"; and from those modeling and documenting the social impact of modern agricultural strategies such as the Green Revolution (Dove and Kammen 1997), which alters not only grain yields (the economists' indicator of value) but relations to people to land, the quality of human relations, concepts of time and space, and what constitutes acceptable risk. Like Rappaport, the latter tried to make more complex the reductionist human development models and paradigms that are dominated by economists but are sometimes embraced by anthropologists.

8. The intended contrast here is to his Columbia teacher, Marvin Harris, a very successful author who is widely read both inside and outside of anthropology.

9. Such figures include ecologist Barry Commoner (1967, 1971), limits to growth modeler Dana Meadows (1972), state of the world activist Lester Brown, and scientists David Pimentel and Paul Ehrlich. Although Rappaport meant to call attention to the destructiveness of large corporations and misdirected political power, popularizers such as Frances Moore Lappé, in her *Diet for a Small Planet* and Black Elk, the Sioux Indian author, probably reached more people.

10. Rappaport himself at the end of his life had only a half-time appointment in anthropology, as he headed the University of Michigan's program on religion. Moreover, in the Department of Anthropology, where he had been chairman from 1975 to 1980, ecological interests in the 1980s and 1990s were taken up by Tom Fricke, an anthropological demographer who held a joint appointment at the Institute for Social Research; Steve Lansing, with a joint appointment in Natural Resources; and Barbara Smuts, a primatologist with her principal appointment in Psychology. They were insiders-outsiders who had multiple department, interdisciplinary institute, or specialized center identities, allegiances, and affiliations as well as patrons and clients. As a class, they might have found themselves marginalized within the discipline, as they looked outside of anthropology for collegial and administrative support, and also within interdisciplinary task forces, which often look to economics or "harder science" disciplines for models, evidence, and interpretations.

11. Vayda would also insist that cognitive or phenomenological anthropologists not just claim but explore whether certain mental (culture) constructs lead to concrete human actions, which then impact the environment, and that postmodernists such as Hornborg, must frame historical hunches as testable hypotheses and then evaluate them, that is, test whether premodern cultures were ecologically conservative and in what contexts (1997). In many cases of multilevel descriptions of environmental perceptions (e.g., those of Brosius and Escobar) it remains to be seen whether studies, published in full, will replicate Rappaport's analytical ordering of individuals, social groups, and ecosystems and include a full analysis of material as well as ideological orders.

12. References to the person and personal relationships use the personal name, Skip, while references to the scholar and his works use the surname, Rappaport.

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PART I

Ecology and the Anthropology of Trouble

Kicking Off the Kaiko: *Instability, Opportunism, and Crisis in Ecological Anthropology*

Susan H. Lees

Roy Rappaport's "Anthropology of Trouble" (1993a) included concerns about both environmental crises and political processes. What follows is an attempt to show how his early work can be reinterpreted in light of more recent theory to illustrate the connections between political processes and environmental crises. In particular, I look at applications of this theory to *water crises,* using an illustration from my own research in Israel as well as other cases in the ecological literature.

After introducing some theory about politics and the environment, I try to show a connection between the equilibrium models that dominated ecological anthropology when Rappaport published *Pigs for the Ancestors* and today's political ecology. The connection lies in Rappaport's own ethnography, his documentation of the step-by-step process during which a "crisis" is declared, and subsequently resolved, in a small community. This process, I argue, has its analogues in large-scale societies as well. The transformation of ecological anthropology in which sociopolitical differences are highlighted alters our interpretation of this process.

In the next section, I discuss the application of this perspective to the understanding of social responses to turbulent environmental situations. Analyzing the social dynamics of ecological "crises" helps us, I argue, to understand more about the nature and timing of water crises such as the one I observed in Israel in the early 1980s. The final portion of this essay discusses crises within this perspective and the Israeli water crisis as a case in point.

Crisis and Turbulence

How are environmental crises related to sociopolitical inequality? This is a central theme of what has come to be called political ecology. A number of contemporary political ecologists have suggested that gross social inequalities of the sort observed in modern complex societies such as the United States (Gould, Schnaiberg, and Weinberg 1996) and India (Gadgil and Guha 1995), give rise to ecological instability and environmental degradation. The argument is generally that the unchecked greed of the dominant classes proceeds at the expense of the less powerful, depleting their resources and/or polluting their living and working spaces. The field of environmental justice has highlighted environmental racism to point to the disproportionate burden of pollution and resource depletion on people of color, whether within complex societies like our own or across international boundaries in global economic interconnections (Di Chiro 1995; Johnston 1997). Applications of these perspectives to water problems also occur in the literature (see, e.g., Donahue and Johnston 1998), and some examples are given below.

While these arguments from political ecology are often convincing, even compelling, they are incomplete in that they appear unidirectional and they seldom address the role of the constant changes that take place in nature. Environmental turbulence (such as flood or drought) provides an important opportunity for a shift in the balance of power. This, then, is the theory to be expanded upon in this essay: as new groups emerge to positions of influence and form coalitions with others with intersecting interests (see Gould, Schnaiberg, and Weinberg 1996), they are able to declare certain environmental situations, such as changes in water availability, to be "crises" and to shape the larger social response to the particular crisis. Among the most elegant of the examples in the contemporary literature is Jacqueline Solway's exploration of the transformative consequences of a drought in Botswana: its treatment as a crisis by the government permitted extraordinary interventions in traditional social relationships (1994).

This perspective rests on an awareness of the social diversity of experience and interest. The importance of seeing *difference* within societies, from the largest and most complex to the smallest (like the Tsembaga Maring), was not brought home to ecological anthropology until about a decade after Rappaport's *Pigs for the Ancestors* was published (1968). Critiques by the Marxist, feminist, and sociobiological

schools of research led anthropologists to disaggregate their data on populations, and even households, to see the different impacts of environmental and social changes on individuals and groups of individuals. Thus, Godelier (1986) and others came to criticize Rappaport's work and focus more on sociopolitical differences in even small-scale, nonindustrial societies.

Rappaport's ethnography anticipates this perspective by providing the details that a later generation could use to reinterpret his evidence of the way the Tsembaga manage their environmental relationships. We can draw up an alternative interpretation, using this material, which reflects our current preoccupation with the importance of political inequality and its environmental consequences. First, let us examine Rappaport's analysis of the situation of the Tsembaga.

Kicking Off the *Kaiko*

The *kaiko,* a ceremonial feast in which the Tsembaga Maring honor their ancestors by slaughtering a large number of pigs to present to their neighbors, was adopted into the anthropological literature, shortly after Roy Rappaport described it, as a model (or paradigm) of ritual regulation of an ecosystem. Rappaport says:

> The *Kaiko* thus provides, among a group in which the slaughter of pigs is in large measure advantageously restricted by ritual to stress situations, a ritual means for disposing of a parasitic surplus of animals. In somewhat different terms it may also be said that the kaiko provides a means for limiting the amount of calories expended in acquiring animal protein. (1968: 159)

Rappaport credits Vayda, Leeds, and Smith (1961) with yet another interpretation of the function of pig festivals in the New Guinea Highlands: "In addition to preserving the people from further parasitism by the pigs, the *kaiko* in some instances may be a response to and a protective reaction against their destruction of gardens" (1968: 160).

Yet, while these functions may well be served by the *kaiko,* they do not explain its ultimate, or even proximate, causes. By examining Rappaport's account of its proximate causes, we may in turn learn something about its functions, both in the sense of its consequences and in the sense of the way in which it worked in Tsembaga society at the time

of Rappaport's observation. Thanks to the excellence of his ethnography and the thoroughness of his published description in *Pigs for the Ancestors,* we are able to examine a causal chain of events to identify what, precisely, are the triggers for kicking off the *kaiko.*

Rappaport tells us that the *kaiko* ceremony he observed,

> started with far fewer animals, and it is probable that pig populations never approach the maximum number that can be supported by all the women in a local population. Since pigs are individually owned, some women find themselves burdened with several pigs before others have any at all. It is with the husbands of women already burdened with pigs that public agitation to uproot the *rumbim* and stage the *kaiko* apparently starts (1968: 158).

What happens when a number of men who are subjected to insupportable complaints from their wives (and in one case a daughter) about having too many pigs to take care of is, to me, the most interesting and most neglected point.

> *Men with few or no pigs responded to the talk of an approaching kaiko by attempting to acquire animals* (1968: 159, emphasis added)

Rappaport then concludes that

> Agitation for a *kaiko* starts when the relationship of some pigs to their owners changes from one of support . . . to one of parasitism. . . . There are sufficient pigs to uproot the *rumbim* when this unfavorable change in relationship occurs in enough cases to produce a consensus within the population. (159)

This observation leads me to an interpretation that I will seek to generalize to other analogous situations. The communal event in this case, that is, the ceremonial pig slaughter that serves the function of relieving an environmental crisis (for some), is precipitated by stress on the more affluent and persuasive members of the community. They seek to ameliorate their personal household crises through cultural means that involve other members of the community. This means that the resolution of a crisis for the successful and fortunate has to be paid for by the poorer

and weaker. In this instance, the latter have to hustle to get their own pigs in order to be able to participate in the ceremonial slaughter.

Disequilibrium and Inequality

The ceremonial cycle of which the *kaiko* is a culmination has been represented in the anthropology textbooks (such as Kottak 1979) as a model of homeostatic equilibrium. Yet, analyzed into a sequence of causal stages, we can interpret it as a disequilibrating process as well, one in which the community as a whole is brought into two uncomfortable relationships with their pigs—first too many, then too few—because *some* members of the community have a problem and are able to use a cultural device involving the *whole* community to solve it. Other widespread cultural institutions, such as (classically) the "cargo" system of rituals associated with the civil/religious hierarchy governing peasant communities in the highlands of Latin America (Wolf 1955), were similarly characterized in the anthropological literature as equilibrating devices. These cultural institutions, and probably many others like them, provide an opportunity to be used by successful members of society to solve certain problems of their own in socially acceptable ways. The acceptable solutions, however, also cause problems for others by shifting the stress, so to speak, onto the poorer and weaker members of the community. They result in intensification of the use of environmental resources, at least for certain periods, resulting not necessarily in equilibrium but in disequilibrium. Certainly no ethnographer has more effectively illustrated the differences among community members in their stress and motivations than did Rappaport, with his henpecked husband initiators of the *kaiko* and their hapless neighbors hustling to keep up by borrowing pigs from others in order to make a respectable showing at the feast. In case we get carried away by impressions, he gives us the figures to back up his argument: exactly how many people, exactly how many pigs.

My own work on ecological crises has involved societies in which inequality and inequity are far more conspicuous than they are among the Maring of the New Guinea Highlands. In these societies, a great many environmental problems might be experienced by many different people, yet what is declared to be an official crisis, to which a response must be made, depends on which groups, or coalitions of groups, are sufficiently powerful to make *their* problem the problem of *everyone* in

the society. In Rappaport's case study, we have a clear instance of the co-optation of society as a whole by a more fortunate few through a cultural institution. The process of co-optation, however, was in the past much neglected by ecological anthropologists, who ignored differences among members of a society or group in their interests and motivations and in the impacts of societywide events.

It may be the inadvertent consequence of ceremonial occasions such as the *kaiko,* and the *mayordomia* in the Latin American cargo system, to keep societies in a state of imbalance, of disequilibrium. This disequilibrium starts with unequal luck or skill (or, in complex societies, status), which confers advantages on some members of the group, who then favor engaging in rituals that cost them little and solve certain problems for them. Their luck and talent (or social status) may also be factors in their ability to convince others to participate in such rituals, which cost these others more than they do the initiators.

Disequilibrium favors opportunists. This dictum I derive from the theoretical formulations of C. S. Holling, whose recent work in ecosystem management theory focuses on turbulence, instability, and change. Holling (1995) suggests that turbulent, unstable ecosystems are quite normal in nature and that a failure to return to a previous state after the disruptive effects of a perturbation—such as a storm or a fire or an earthquake—is also quite normal, thanks to the potentials created by disruption for opportunistic species.

Water, Power, and Ecological Crises

It has long been recognized that instability in the natural environment can be magnified or accelerated in unexpected ways by a human intervention that was intended precisely to reduce unpredictability. This has become abundantly clear in irrigation studies; irrigation exists to provide a stable and predictable as well as an augmented supply of water. The problems arising from increased dependence upon this supply are well documented, including salinization of soils, pest and weed problems, dropping or rising water tables, and on and on.

As the relationship between political power and water management has been a matter of speculation probably more than any other resource management issue considered in the anthropological literature, it is also abundantly clear that there is a connection between the technology and organization of management and the structure of power in a society that

uses irrigation. The regulatory policies and practices put into place in any one instance are the product of decisions about what the problem is by those who have the power to articulate such problems and execute policy. They are also the product of accumulated knowledge by those designated to study and implement knowledge in the service of their employers. In a recent study, for example, Tom Waller (1995) attempted to show that expertise in the Imperial Valley irrigation district in Southern California is put to the service of large growers in the valley and is not scientifically neutral; the options that are studied and promoted are those that serve the interests of the powerful.

Accumulated knowledge in one direction, then, places barriers in the way of the search for knowledge in other directions. Ignorance is as inevitable as are the unexpected events that will occur in unstable systems. Nevertheless, *crises* are special, often politicized variants of untoward surprises. Crises strike in part because surprises are inevitable. They are politicized because new groups emerging to power assign blame to and *contest* the existing policies, practices, and institutions that fail to serve them and shut them out of the decision-making process.

Crises, such as water shortages apparently caused by drought, provide an opportunity for contending groups to assert their interests. Note that the power to declare a crisis is itself contingent upon power—having a voice and a constituency to hear and support it. Resolutions of crises reflect the coming into power—or failure to achieve it—of contending groups. These might be competing families, geographically defined groups competing for resources, and groups differentiated by class, ethnicity, wealth, occupational interests, and so forth. In water control situations, the most common competitions today are between rural irrigators and urban domestic and industrial water users and a third, highly vocal group, largely urban- and suburban-based conservationists whose interest is in preserving natural recreation areas. These are the big players; locally, the configurations vary and overlap with other distinctions.

Thus, for example, C. S. Holling and his colleagues Light and Gunderson (Light, Gunderson, and Holling 1995) document several stages in the history of ecological crises in the Everglades region of southern Florida. Here, different socioeconomic groups, each with their own agendas, respond to what they see as problems in the management of water in ways they believe will favor their interests. In successive periods, various groups come to power and regard the water "crises" differently, with consequent differences in what they deem to be appropriate

technical solutions. Some groups in each era are left out of consideration—that is, they can neither declare a crisis nor deny that one is taking place, as they do not have an effective public voice. Today, for example, such groups might include Latin American migrant laborers or African American sharecroppers. Perhaps more than in the past, still other groups, such as local Native Americans, nonlocal conservationists, and urban entrepreneurs, do have a say in whether something should happen and what that should be. These groups become more visible to one another as they form their coalitions in response to an environmental crisis and may, if they are on the winning side, be able to consolidate their new influence still further.

Such shifts were evident in my own work in Israel as time went on, incorporating different contending groups in different ways and each time brought to a head during the frequent episodes of water scarcity (Amiran 1995).

The Israeli Water Crisis

The case I studied (Lees 1998, 1995, 1993), the water crisis of 1984–86 in Israel, contrasts in a number of ways with the one Tom Waller (1995) describes for the Imperial Valley of Southern California. For one thing, Israel's Jewish farmers almost never hold private property in land; virtually all their land is leased to them by the state. For another, there is no such thing as large-scale corporation-run agriculture.

In this instance, the water supply system was designed to promote agricultural use by small-scale Jewish-Israeli farmers either on communal farms (kibbutzim) whose size would barely compare with those of middle-sized farms in the United States or in cooperative settlements (moshavim), in which family farms averaged about ten acres. The latter were in the majority. The irrigation network provided water to these farmers by means of a pressure system that farmers used with a combination of sprinklers and drippers to irrigate crops.

The system was carefully monitored, and the aquifers, which provided most of the water, were annually recharged with stored runoff from rainfall. However, it was revealed in the public media some years after the water shortage crisis of 1984–86 that the system of monitoring and recharging had become increasingly ineffectual through time, with changes in political priorities, to which I shall return shortly. The consequences of mismanagement are dire, for invasion of seawater into the

coastal aquifers destroys the resource base. The plan and the technology promised more stability than the implementation was able to deliver.

The system of allocation and control was more or less equitable where the Jewish-Israeli framing community was concerned (Arab-Israeli farmers received considerably less, as the intensely political jockeying for allocations from new sources and disparities grew over time). Ignoring the plight of Arab-Israeli villages in increasingly competitive agricultural development, the designers of the system focused more on the potential inequities between the north and the south than on Jewish-Arab differences. The issue of Palestinian (in contrast with Arab-Israeli) access to water did not concern Israel when the designs were drawn, in the 1940s and 1950s, when Jordan and Egypt governed the West Bank and Gaza, respectively. This was to become, in the 1990s, the most pressing political issue of all.[1]

Allocation and control tended to effect great efficiency in water use, as it motivated farmers to use water conservatively for best profit. Farmers were penalized for overusing their allocation but rewarded for efficiency—they could use what they saved at the same low rates to irrigate more land. As elsewhere, the carrots worked better than the sticks. Water production rose very little after the 1960s, but the areas under irrigation grew steadily (see Lees 1995, 1998).

The national system made both ideological and practical commitments to support small-scale cooperative farming. The provision of water was state subsidized (in the 1980s, some two-thirds of its cost was paid by the state and one-third by farmers), and at the height of agricultural development about 80 percent of the national water capacity was allocated to farming cooperatives of one kind or another. The commitment of the state to agriculture in the first place reflected a certain ideology (labor or socialist Zionism) and, some would argue, a defensive strategy—it could not be argued very convincingly as a purely economically based decision. While it was posited that self-sufficiency in food was a necessity, agriculture produced surpluses within ten years of the establishment of the state; yet it continued to expand and receive subsidies. As for the form of agriculture supported by the state, it was clearly a reflection of a policy to promote a socialist ideal by founders of a certain bent (Lees 1997, 1993). The dominance of the founding generation ended with the national elections of 1977, in which the Labor Party was defeated by the Likud Party, a coalition of more conservative, nationalist, religious, and ethnic underdogs.

While the policy consequences of this shift in the balance of power were to be established gradually over the ensuing years, undermining the privileged place of agriculture in national priorities, a "crisis" did not manifest itself until the early 1980s. At that point, farmers began having serious financial troubles. Government austerity measures brought inflation to a halt, with negative consequences for the farming sector, which was deeply in debt, particularly as a result of investments in high technology. Simultaneously, there were market shifts, with serious international competition for the agricultural sector's best export crops such as cotton (with new competition from China) and citrus (with intensified competition from Spain). The final blow was a rainfall shortage of three seasons' duration—not unusual, not even unusually severe, but damaging and very untimely.

At this critical juncture of historical negatives, the government intervened in water control in a way that it never had in the past. Declaring a water crisis in the spring of 1986, it centralized its control over allocation and shifted from pricing incentives to outright force: when a community had reached its allocated quota for a month's period, water would be shut off until the next period. Simultaneously, while farmers and their cooperative institutions were on the brink of bankruptcy, the government announced its intention not to relieve them of their debts by any means, and these institutions did indeed fail and were never revived. The press carried numerous stories about farmers squandering money and living the high life, and other stories about water wastage and unwise crop choices, even while cities were rationing water for domestic use (Lees 1997).

Conflict between urban and rural, "oriental" and "occidental" Jews, and class conflict, were subtexts in the public criticisms of the farmers' use of water. Even before the crisis of the mid-1980s, water privileges symbolized these rifts in political discourse. The Israeli political analyst Yael Yishai (1982) writes,

> Oriental Jews see the co-operative settlements, and the Labor party to which they are affiliated, as symbols of economic exploitation, of the affluent "first Israel," contrasting with the salaried workers employed in the regional enterprises of the kibbutzim. They therefore did not hesitate to express their frustration and resentment by voting against the Labor alignment and for the Likud. This hostility did not fade after the general election. In September 1981, the Prime

> Minister was reported to have referred in a radio interview to members of kibbutzim as "arrogant millionaires enjoying their swimming pools." This accusation led to a vociferous public debate, which exacerbated the existing friction and estrangement. (237)

The class connotation of "swimming pools" is important here, symbolically a red flag representing conspicuous (wasteful and insensitive) consumption by the privileged.

The outcome of the crisis was, immediately, a reduction in the allocation of water to the entire agricultural sector, from 80 to 60 percent, with promises of consideration of further cuts and subsequently discussions of new ways to govern water allocation for the farming sector. There had always been those who advocated that farmers should pay prices for water that reflect its real worth—reflecting the cost of production and market value. It was argued that this would result in less waste and more economical use of the resource. These proponents now came to prevail.

Overall, the result of the water crisis and other crises in the agricultural sector with which it coincided were:

1. A shift of water allocation from rural to urban sectors
2. A shift of organization from state paternalism in agriculture to competing coalitions of special interest groups
3. A shift of power from the "pioneers" to inheriting businessmen
4. A shift of ideology from socialism to market capitalism

Eventually, these outcomes will result in a contraction of agriculture to fewer growers and less land cultivated by Jewish farmers. This would satisfy Israeli urban middle class conservationists, who want nature conservancies, national parks, and so forth, and the rising class of Israeli capitalists and professionals, who want a reduced subsidy for small farmers and fewer, better farmers. There has already been an elimination of much of the water subsidy, a rise in the price of water for farmers, and a reduction in the use of water for irrigation. Farmers in the 1990s did not always use more than their quotas, at least in some years, and sometimes used less, as the cost of agricultural production would now be unjustified. Thus, a water shortage was a pretext for bringing about a change in an entrenched system.

Other changes, from other quarters, were yet to come. By the early 1990s, many Israeli water experts and academics from economics and

political science had begun to formulate means of revisioning the water system to accommodate anticipated peace agreements with the Palestinians. Water was regarded as an essential issue in the future peace settlement, and its allocation between Israel and the Palestinians continues to be negotiated as of this writing. As the decade progressed, and public interest in peace negotiations was expressed, debates about the role of water in the establishment of peace became a predominant factor in the politics of water control and the perception of crisis. Yet the older issues did not disappear. In the summer of 1999, water allocations to farmers were cut by 40 percent, a measure justified by the water commissioner as the appropriate response to dangerous shortages. Were these cuts made easier by the earlier weakening of the farming community or by its adaptation to its new situation during the past decade? Will these cuts become permanent, and will they facilitate a repartitioning of water as part of the peace process with the Palestinians?

Conclusions

In the Imperial Valley case, the entrenched system was one of dominance by large absentee growers, and the shift, parallel to the Israeli case, moved water from rural interests to urban ones. Waller (1994) argues that "it took a crisis" to bring about the change. I would argue that potential crises lurk everywhere in nature—it is really a matter of some group or coalition of groups acquiring sufficient power to *declare* a crisis, to bring the matter to the table, to seize an opportunity that they themselves have created.

Outcomes of such crises are, nevertheless, unpredictable. In a classic study, George Morren (1980) described the outcomes of a series of historic droughts in England, in each instance an increase in government centralization of control over water and a decrease in the ability of local people to respond on their own to local conditions of water shortage—or abundance, for that matter. What he did not anticipate, however, was the advent of Margaret Thatcher. Under her conservative government, policies and trends not only of decades but in the case of water of centuries were overturned. In particular, water, along with many utilities and services, was privatized. The summer of 1998 brought yet another drought, and local private water companies responded as best they could.

I hope I have shown how political opportunism contributes to the shaping of the perception of ecological crises and their resolutions. This is

not to say that water shortages or other environmental disturbances are not real, but that they are sometimes useful to some groups to bring about changes they feel are necessary. Perhaps for this reason ecologists and ecosystem management theorists like C. S. Holling (1995) have made them the focal point of their recent studies, and we might do the same.

Perhaps Rappaport would have been surprised at this application of his observations on the *kaiko,* but I do not think that it would have displeased him. In fact, the use of his ethnographic work to address a problem in the "anthropology of trouble" would have pleased him very much.

NOTES

1. In recent years, a number of writers (see Hassoun 1998, for example) have attributed the "water crisis" in Israel and in the Middle East in general to the unequal power relations between Israelis and Palestinians, who have been under Israeli authority since 1967. Although I agree that Palestinian farmers and urban dwellers have not been treated equitably by Israeli authorities, I did not find the assignment of this unequal relationship as the primary cause of a *water crisis* (as opposed to a real hardship for many Palestinians, both rural and urban) convincing. This essay explores shifting power relationships among Jewish-Israeli interests but unequal power relations among Palestinians with regard to water remain to be addressed. So does the politics of water allocation and use in other Middle Eastern countries as well as the political uses of claims and assignments of guilt to Israelis with regard to water scarcity in the region as a whole. These are interesting and apt topics for research in political ecology, but unfortunately they are beyond the scope of this essay.

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Human Ecology from Space: Ecological Anthropology Engages the Study of Global Environmental Change

Emilio F. Moran and Eduardo S. Brondizio

Understanding Levels of Analysis

Contemporary concern in the research community and policy circles with the "human dimensions of global environmental change" offers a rare opportunity to anthropologists. For the first time, policymakers and the physical sciences community have acknowledged the central place of humans in environmental modification (Peck 1990) and thus have implicitly accepted what anthropology might have to say about it. This is a battle that Roy Rappaport fought throughout his career and to which he contributed a great deal. He participated in panels regulating nuclear waste disposal, energy usage, and poverty in America. During his presidency of the American Anthropological Association, he spearheaded two public policy panels of anthropologists to seek ways for the discipline to engage the "disorders" of the modern world—in America (Forman 1994) and in Third World societies (Moran 1996). To date, however, it is an opportunity that seems to have been squandered by the discipline. Anthropologists bring a rich experience to these debates (Johnson and Earle 1987) and familiarity with many of the world's populations that have in the past and into the present managed to develop intensive systems of production, in some cases without the environmental destruction that seems to characterize much of contemporary development. This is the very reason Rappaport gave the authors for the popularity over the years of his first book, *Pigs for the Ancestors* (1968). The answers to our environmental dilemmas today are in large part to be

found in the rich diversity of human experiences in interacting with the environment in the past and present.

For participation in the contemporary debates over the human impact on global environments, ecosystem models and ecosystem theory are fundamental (Moran 1990). An ecological anthropology for the twenty-first century must build on the comparative approaches first proposed by Steward (1955) and complement them with more refined approaches, which permit analysis of global environmental changes and their underlying local and regional dynamics.

One of the tools that will need to be used with growing frequency by ecological anthropologists is geographic information systems (GIS) and the techniques of satellite remote sensing. Remote sensing from satellite platforms such as the National Oceanographic and Atmospheric Administration's (NOAA's) AVHRR (Advanced Very High Resolution Radiometer) sensor, NASA's Landsat Thematic Mapper (TM), and the French SPOT (Système Pour L'Observation de la Terre) satellite provides information of considerable environmental richness for local, regional, and global analysis (Liverman et al. 1998; Conant 1978, 1990).

For analysis of global processes or large continental areas such as the entire Amazon Basin, AVHRR is the most appropriate because of its coarser resolution but daily coverage. Although designed primarily for meteorological monitoring, it has been profitably used to monitor vegetation patterns over very large areas. Because of its scale, anthropologists to date have had little use for these data.

Data from Landsat's Multispectral Scanner (MSS) are valuable for the study of relatively dichotomous phenomena, such as forest cover versus nonforest and grassland versus bare ground, and to establish a long historical account of land cover change. They have been used since 1972 by a number of anthropologists, for example, in the pioneering work of Conant (1978) and Reining (1973). It is one of the most cost effective ways to address many environmental changes of interest, but it still is not very powerful for detailed community-level analysis.

The improved resolution of the Landsat Thematic Tapper (TM) sensor after 1984 allowed more detailed studies of land cover changes in the Amazon Basin, the New Guinea Highlands, and the Ituri Forest of Central Africa (Moran et al. 1994a, 1994b; Wilkie 1994), including discrimination between age classes for subtle palm-based agroforestry management and flooded forest in the Amazon estuary (Brondizio and Siqueira 1997; Brondizio et al. 1994a, 1996), erosion in Madagascar

(Sussman et al. 1994), and intensification in indigenous systems (Guyer and Lambin 1993; Behrens et al. 1994). The Enhanced Thematic Mapper (ETM+) sensor in Landsat 7 is a further improved source of information whose data began to be released in late summer 1999. It permits time-series analysis seamlessly with the earlier Landsat TM and MSS sensors.

These recent advances require that careful attention be paid to issues of both temporal and spatial scale. In earlier work, Moran (1984, 1990) pointed out that many debates on Amazonian cultural ecology were, at least in part, a product of sliding between different levels of analysis without fully recognizing the methodological and theoretical consequences. Appreciation for issues of scaling has increased with the growth of global environmental change studies and their challenge of integrating data and models from different disciplines (Wessman 1992: 175).

In this essay, we highlight the value added of remote sensing to anthropological questions, and vice versa, in ongoing studies on the dynamics of land use in eastern Amazonia. The preciseness of regional analysis depends on the quality of the sampling at the local level. Detailed local-level sampling is far from common in traditional remote sensing. Much of what passes as "ground truthing" is visual observation of classes such as dense forest, or cropland, without detailed examination of land use history, vegetation structure, and composition. The long-standing anthropological bias toward understanding local-level processes, when combined with the use of analytical tools capable of scaling up and down, becomes an important contribution to the advancement of land use/land cover research and to issues of articulation between differently scaled processes. One could argue that in the future refined satellite remote sensing will need the fine ground-level expertise of anthropologists to advance the quality of products from the ever more refined sensors being launched to monitor the earth.

The Use of Remote Sensing in Anthropology

Anthropologists bring to the analysis of global change a commitment to understanding landscape differences and revealing the human behavior behind them. When looking at a satellite image, they search for driving forces behind land use differences, and for land use classifications that are meaningful in socioeconomic and cultural terms. Satellite remote sensing is an area of growing interest among ecological anthropologists

studying ethnographic land use patterning and agricultural intensification. Conklin (1980), using aerial photography in his *Ethnographic Atlas of Ifugao,* integrated ethnographic and ecological data to show land use zones from the perspective of the local population. Behrens established a formal basis for using remote sensing and GIS as a means of classifying land use intensification by indigenous Amazonians (Behrens et al. 1994). In Nigeria, Guyer and Lambin (1993) used remote sensing combined with ethnographic research to study agricultural intensification. Their work demonstrates the potential of remote sensing to address site-specific ethnographic issues within a larger land use perspective. A special issue of *Human Ecology* (September 1994) was dedicated to the topic. There was substantial agreement among the articles about the importance of local-level research to inform land use analysis on the regional scale. This conclusion was reinforced in an issue of *Cultural Survival* (1995) dedicated to showing the fruitful connection between local-level knowledge and remote sensing, GIS and mapping tools—and its contribution to indigenous grassroots movements (e.g., demarcating territories).

Contemporary perspectives on the cross-fertilization of remote sensing and social science research are explored in the recent volume *People and Pixels* (Liverman et al. 1998). Examples from anthropology and demography to health and epidemiology applications illustrate the use of remote sensing data from different sensors and applied to different scales.

The challenge posed by complex spatial patterns and problems of scale has opened a new forum for the discussion of theories and methods. It offers an opportunity to the remote sensing analyst to come to the field, measure vegetation, talk to people about land management, and rethink the algorithms used in image analysis. It offers ecological anthropologists the chance to expand the scope of investigation from one or two villages to entire regions; to verify informants' verbally elicited data about land use; and to enrich analyses of spectral patterns, spatial statistics, and the impact of land use on land cover with social content.

Methods of Data Integration

The method of multilevel analysis of land use/land cover change is built upon a structure of four integrated levels of research: The landscape/regional level; vegetation class level; farm/household level; and soil level (fig. 1). The model relies upon a nested sampling procedure that

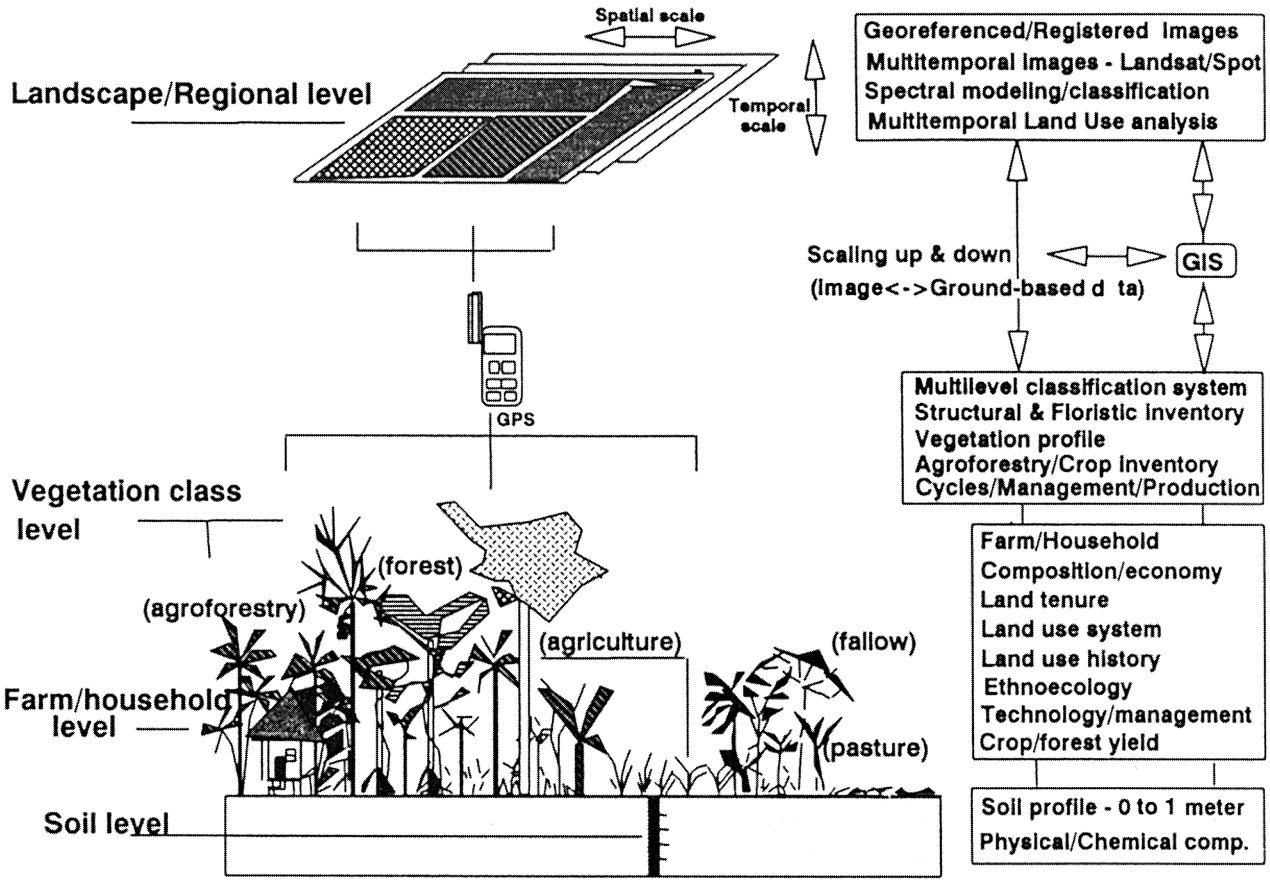


Fig. 1. Methods of multilevel analysis of land use and land cover change. (From Brondizio et al. 1994b and Brondizio 1996.)

produces data that can be scaled upward and downward independently or in an integrated fashion. The integration of multitemporal, high-resolution satellite with local data on economy, management, land use history, and site-specific vegetation/soil inventories aims to make it possible to understand the ecological and social dimensions of land use at the local scale and link them to regional and global scales of land use dynamics. The assessment of land use and land cover change as a function of socioeconomic and ecological factors is a fundamental step toward understanding the sustainability of current forms of land use and the consequences of this action on the region's land cover.

Household/Farm Level

It is important to collect local data so that they can be aggregated with those of larger populations within which households are nested. For instance, demographic data on household composition (including sex and age) can be aggregated at the population level to construct a demographic profile of this population, but this can occur only if the data are collected in such a way that standard intervals of five years are used. Other important data collected at this level are related to subsistence economies and are useful for understanding resource use, economic strategies, market relationships, labor arrangements, and time allocation in productive and "nonproductive" activities. At this level, it is important to cover the basic dimensions of social organization such as settlement patterns, labor distribution, resource use, and kinship (Moran 1995; Netting et al. 1995).

One of the most difficult decisions in land use analysis is about the boundaries of a population. Geographic boundaries are associated with factors such as land tenure, landscape features, and inheritance. An analysis based on local information and maps, images, or aerial photographs can provide more reliable information than either one alone.

Ethnoecological analysis of local resources and management practices may reveal information that most of the time is overlooked by those not delving into "the names that go with things." In the Amazon estuary, local agroforestry management techniques can be discerned but not without familiarizing oneself with local production systems. Data collected at this level can be aggregated to higher levels of analysis in geographical and data base formats. Georeferencing of households, farm boundaries, agriculture, and fallow fields may be achieved through the use of Global Positioning System (GPS) devices. These are small

units that permit the precise location of any point on the planet to within a few meters. Data collected at this level also can provide, for instance, information on the distribution of activities throughout the year, the agricultural calendar, and the production season, which can also help determine the best time for future fieldwork.

Vegetation Class Level

Mapping of vegetation cover has implications not only for understanding the impact of land use practices on land cover but also for predicting the sustainability of management practices at the farm level. Basic vegetation parameters need to be included so that they can inform mapping at the landscape level. In general, vegetation structure, including height, ground cover, basal area, density of individuals, diameter at breast height (DBH), and floristic composition are important data points. These data inform the analysis of satellite images and provide clues to the regrowth rate of vegetation following specific types of disturbance and the spatial arrangement of vegetation cover.

From satellite image analysis, the definition of structural parameters to differentiate vegetation types and environmental characteristics such as temperature and humidity are particularly important. Structural differences provide information that can be linked to the image's spectral data. Environmental factors such as soil humidity and color and topographic variations are strongly associated with spectral responses of vegetation cover; hence, their association with vegetation data is important. At the farm level, vegetation structure is the main parameter for evaluating the impact of management practices. At this level, floristic composition assumes a very important role. Some species are excellent indicators of soil type and are associated with given management practices. Farmers commonly use the presence of given species to choose a site for a given farm practice and to predict the pace of regrowth of a site. For instance, the presence of *Imperata brasiliensis* is taken as a sign of low soil pH and slow regrowth in the Amazon estuary.

Information on land use history is important not only to define sampling areas of anthropogenic vegetation (e.g., fallow and managed forest) but also to verify that natural vegetation has not been affected or used in the past. For instance, it is important to know whether a savanna has been burned and, if so, with what frequency. Or, if a particular forest plot has been logged, we must determine which species were

removed and when the event took place. Land use and management history need to be more detailed in areas directly subjected to management (e.g., agroforestry) since management and technology determine the structure and composition of the site. In these areas, estimates and actual measurements of production are critical if we are to analyze the importance of the activity in a broader land use and economic context.

Soil Level

Ethnoecological interviews can elucidate many soil characteristics. Taxonomic classification of soil types based on color, texture, and fertility, in general, can inform the major soil types and distributions with relative reliability. Folk classification can then be cross-checked and compared with systematic soil analyses. Soil analyses should include both chemical and textural examination and permit the aggregation of data to regional levels (Nicholaides and Moran 1995). Soil analyses and ethnopedological studies have a long tradition in anthropology, from the work of Conklin among Hanunóo (1957) to the work of Moran (1975, 1976, 1977, 1981), Moran et al. (forthcoming), and Behrens (1989). In all these cases, the indigenous population proved to have a very refined understanding of soil quality, particularly compared to migrants and developers. Interestingly, soil differences explain more of the variance in rates of fallow regrowth when comparing our five study areas in toto, whereas land use differences explain more of the variance in fallow regrowth when comparing farms within any one of the five study areas (Moran et al., forthcoming). This again suggests the importance of a rigorous level of analysis control and the high probability that explanations will vary with the scale of analysis.

Landscape Level

The landscape/regional level provides the spatial picture of management practices and the driving forces shaping a particular land use and cover. At this level, long-term environmental problems can be better perceived and predicted than at lower scales. This level integrates information from the vegetation class, soil, and farm/household levels. Landscape-level data also inform important characteristics of local-level phenomena that are not measurable at the site-specific scale.

Satellite data are today the most important sources at this level.

However, sources such as radar images, aerial photography, and thematic and topographic maps are also important. Digital analysis of satellite images involves preprocessing, spectral analysis, classification, and postprocessing. During preprocessing, one needs to define the image subset, georeference it to available maps and a coordinate system, and register it to other images available if multitemporal analysis is desired. Georeference accuracy depends on the quality of the maps, the availability of georeferenced coordinates collected during fieldwork, and the statistical procedure used during georeferencing (Jensen 1996). A georeferenced image has a grid of geographical coordinates. For some applications, atmospheric and radiometric calibrations are required (Hall et al. 1991). When multitemporal analysis is desired, images from different dates need to be registered pixel to pixel. This process creates a composite image that provides a temporal change dimension at the pixel level, thus allowing the analysis of spectral trajectories related to change in land use. For instance, in a two-date image (e.g., two images five years apart) one can see the change during regrowth of secondary vegetation.

It is useful to use a hybrid approach during the image classification process. A hybrid approach allows one to analyze spectral signature patterns present in the image in conjunction with ground information to arrive at a spectral signature pattern that accounts for detailed differentiation of land cover features. For instance, in examining a Landsat TM image one attempts to account for chlorophyll absorption in the visible bands of the spectrum, for mesophyll reflectance in the near-infrared band, and for both plant and soil water absorption in the midinfrared bands (Mausel et al. 1993; Brondizio et al. 1996). The integration of these spectral features with field data on vegetation height, basal area, density, and dominance of species can be used to differentiate stages of secondary regrowth. The analysis of spectral statistics derived from unsupervised clustering and areas of known features and land use history allow the development of representative statistics for supervised classification of land use or land cover.

Classification accuracy analysis requires a close association with fieldwork and may decrease as spatial variability increases. Thus, ground-truth sampling needs to increase in the same proportion. In this case, the use of a GPS device is necessary to provide reliable ground-truth information, whereas in more homogeneous areas visual spot checking may be enough. An accuracy check of the temporal image requires the analysis of vegetation characteristics and interviews about the history of a specific

site so that one can relate past events to present aspects of the land cover (Mausel et al. 1993).

Data Integration

Integration of data at these scales is an interactive process during laboratory analysis of images and field data and during fieldwork (Turner and Meyer 1994). Advanced data integration and analysis is achieved using GIS procedures that integrate layers of spatial information with georeferenced data bases of socioeconomic and ecological information. Georeferencing of the data base to maps and images must be a consideration from the very beginning of the research, so that appropriate integration and site-specific identifications are compatible. Data on household/farm and vegetation/soil inventories need to be associated with specific identification numbers that georeference them to images and maps so that integral associations can be derived. For instance, properties' boundaries may compose a land tenure layer that overlaps a land use or land cover map. These two layers may be overlapped with another layer and contain a distribution of households. Each household has a specific identification that relates it to a data base with socioeconomic, demographic, and other information. In another layer, all the sites used for a vegetation and soil inventory can be associated with a data base containing information on floristic composition, structural characteristics, and soil fertility, which will also relate to land use history.

Land Use and Land Cover Classification

Designing a classification system of land cover types and land use classes is a first step toward a good classification of land cover that allows inference about land use. This can be achieved through the association of bibliographies and data bases of the study area, analysis of satellite images, fieldwork observation, and ethnoecological interviews with local inhabitants. Different levels of organization are required to define the land cover of a region. In general, levels are organized to fit a specific scale of analysis into the phytogeographical arrangement and into land cover representing the land use types present in the area. In other words, one starts with a more aggregated level of major dominant classes (first) adequate to a regional scale and proceeds with increased detail at the next sublevel (second) to inform more detailed scales. For instance, the first

level may include major vegetation covers such as forest, secondary succession, and savanna. At the second, more detailed level, forest is subdivided into open and closed forest, secondary succession into old secondary and young secondary succession, and savanna into grassland and woodland savanna. At the third level of this classification system, still more detailed information needs to be included to account for the variability of vegetation required at this local scale. So a new subdivision of the forest class may include a third structural variation of the former two and/or a floristic variation of them such as a forest with a dominant tree species. The importance of developing a detailed classification key is crucial to informing the land use and cover analysis at the landscape level as well as the sampling distribution at the site-specific level (fig. 2). We now briefly review three examples of the application of these approaches.

Example 1. Studies of Secondary Succession in Amazonia

Our research on secondary succession in Amazonia has taken into account regional and local differences in soil fertility and land use history. By combining the analysis of Landsat TM images and field inventories of secondary vegetation, our research has tried to achieve an understanding of both the landscape distribution of secondary vegetation and the ecological processes of vegetation regrowth at the stand level. This research has found that soil fertility is a significant indicator of differences in forest regrowth between regions. As can be seen in figure 3, during the first five years of regrowth, Altamira fallow regrowth is a meter higher compared to the average fallow of all other regions studied. This difference increases twofold in fifteen-year fallows.

We have been able to distinguish three structural stages of forest regrowth that characterize the initial (SS1), intermediate (SS2), and advanced (SS3) phases of forest regeneration (e.g., Mausel et al. 1993; Moran et al. 1994b; Brondizio et al. 1994a). Mapping the amount of each of these classes of forest regrowth helps to characterize the landscape and land use strategies. Figure 4 shows the distributions of land cover classes in four of our study sites (Altamira, Marajó, Igarapé-Açu and Yapú). At a glance, one can see the effects of long-term settlement in the Igarapé-Açu region, where mature forest has virtually disappeared and the landscape is dominated by secondary vegetation in different stages of development. In contrast, the Yapú area, with a low population density and a long fallow swidden form of land use, shows little impact on the forest cover (DeCastro et al., forthcoming). The more

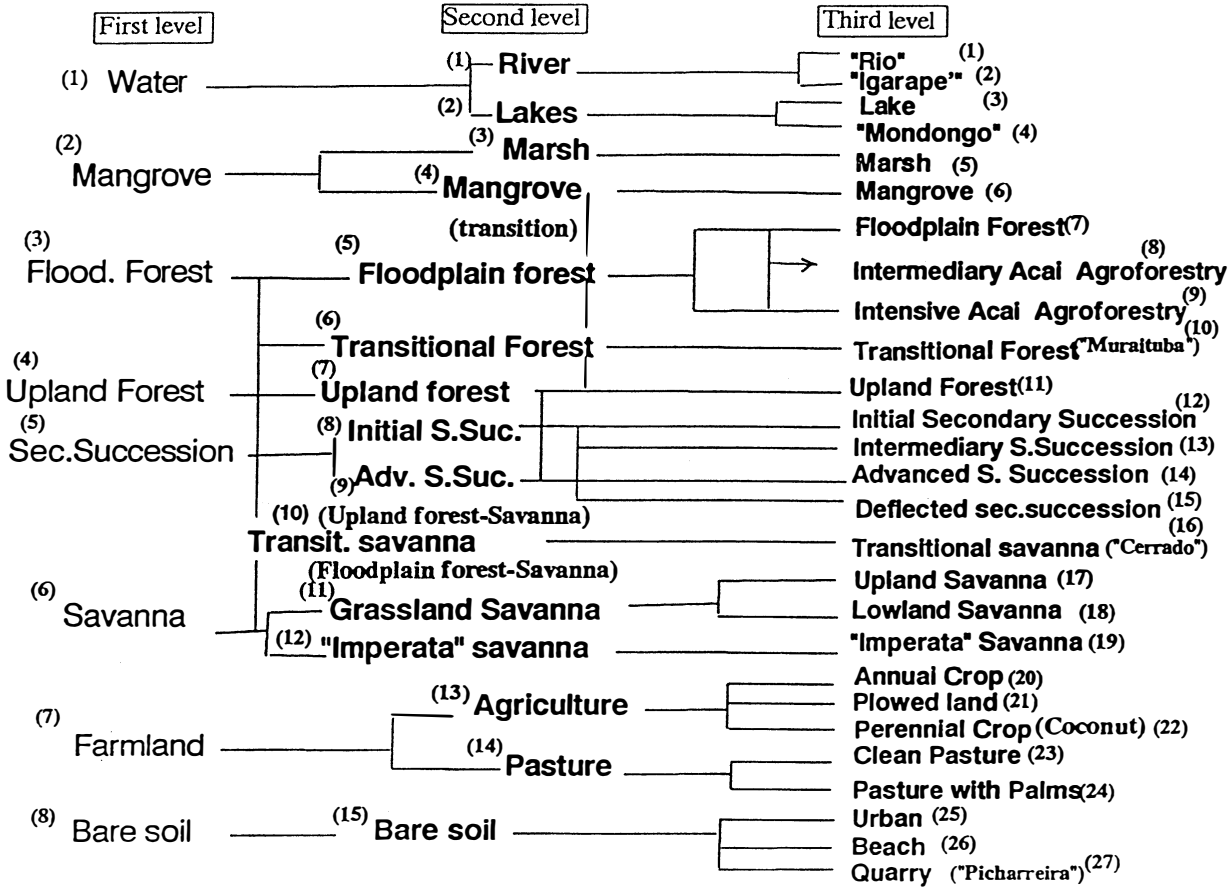


Fig. 2. A multilevel land use and land cover classification system including local discrimination of vegetation types. (From Brondizio 1996.)

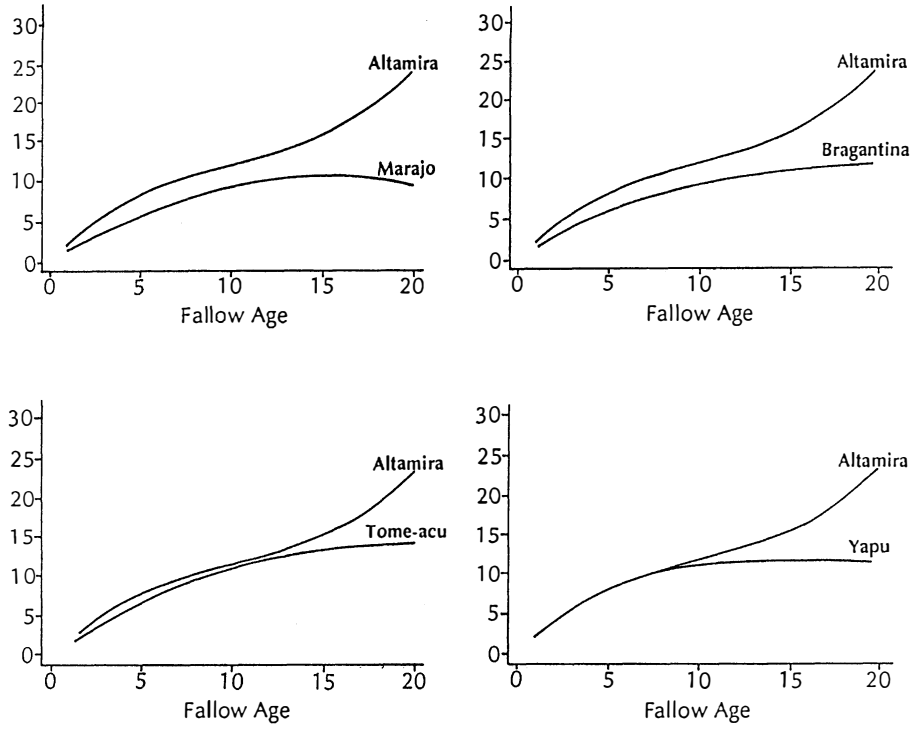


Fig. 3. Height increment in secondary succession. (From Moran and Brondizio 1998.)

recently colonized Altamira area, although largely forested, shows signs of sizable areas occupied by secondary vegetation due to overclearing by inexperienced settlers and the stimulus of bank credit.

Understanding the patterns of forest regrowth in these areas provides clues that could help us to improve the management of shifting cultivation cycles, to increase the economic use of fallow areas (e.g., with medicinal, ornamental, and fruit species), and to develop techniques of enrichment with hardwood species that could lead to less pressure on areas of mature forest to produce economic gain.

Example 2. Population-Level Land Use Patterns in the Amazon Estuary

This example shows the application of Landsat images to distinguish between settlement and land use patterns of Caboclo populations in the

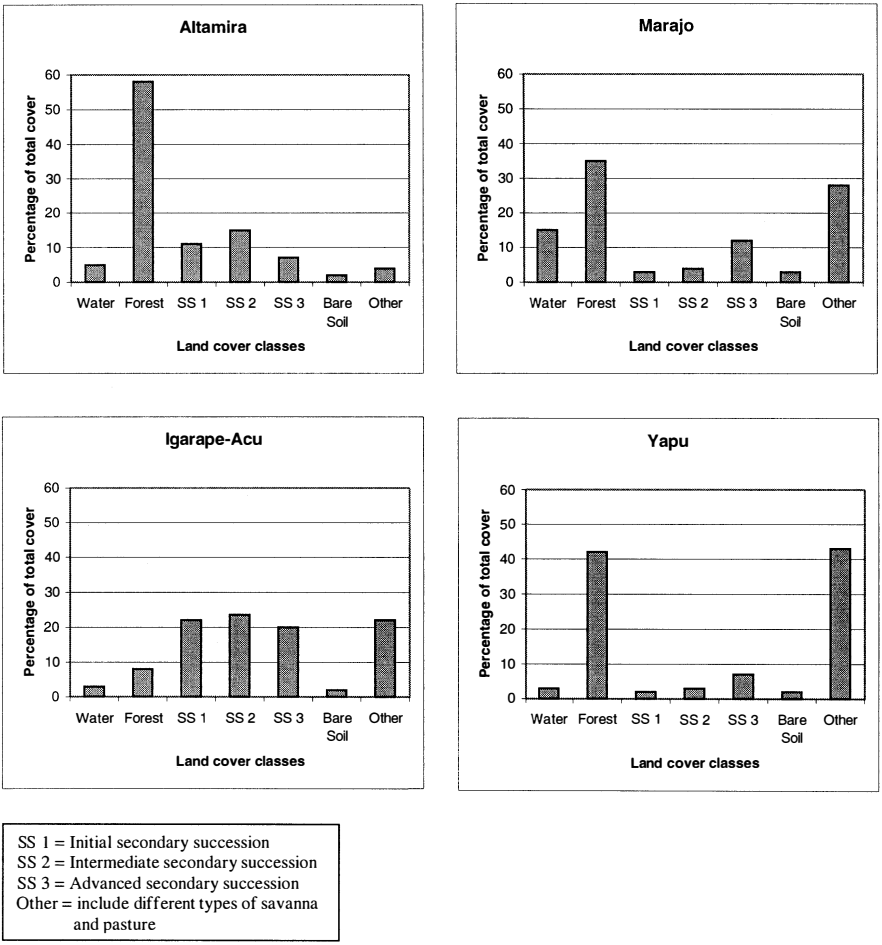


Fig. 4. Contrast in land cover classes at four study areas

Amazon estuary (fig. 5). The region is located around the town of Ponta de Pedras on Marajó Island. It is a transitional area characterized by a rich array of vegetation types such as floodplain and upland forests, mangrove, different types of savanna, and secondary vegetation. Land use types include swidden and mechanized agriculture, floodplain agro-forestry, extractivism, and cattle ranching. The complex matrix of land use and land cover types occurring over short distances has provided us with an opportunity to test and develop new approaches to integrating

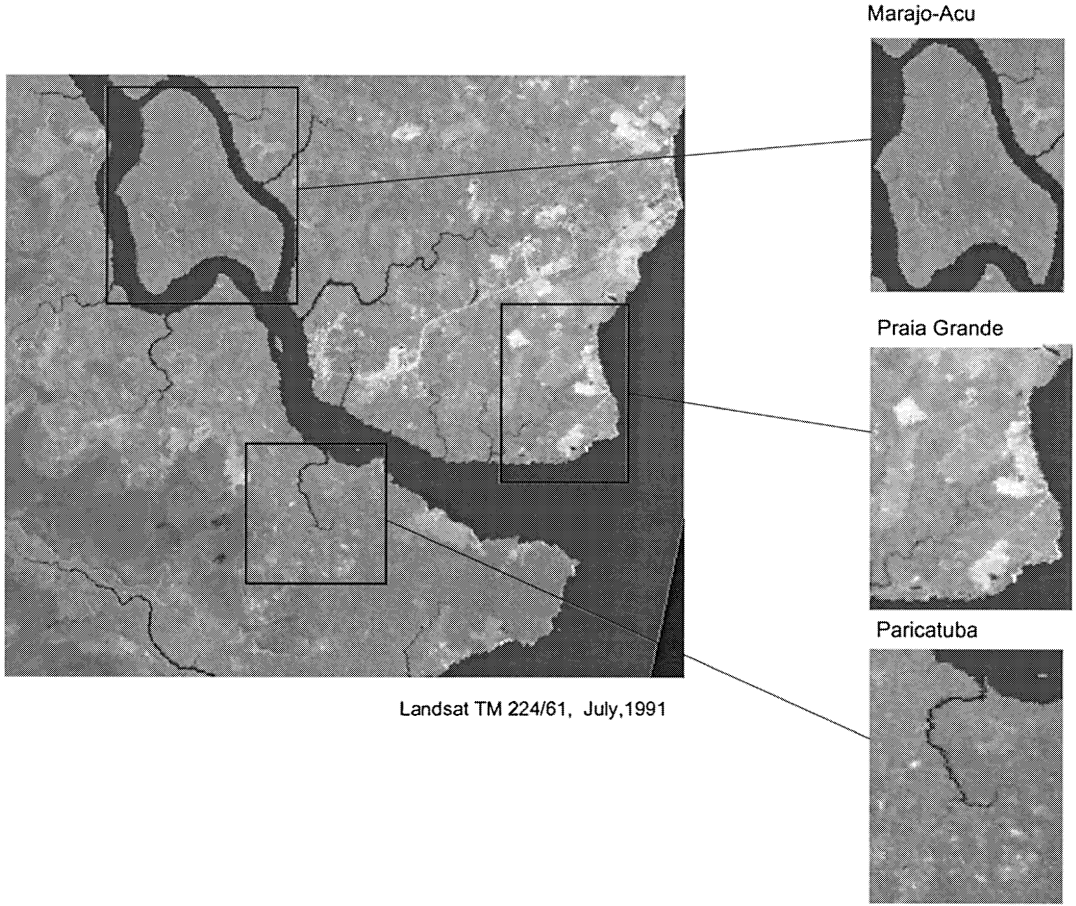


Fig. 5. Satellite images of Ponta de Pedras, Marajó Island, PA, Brazil.

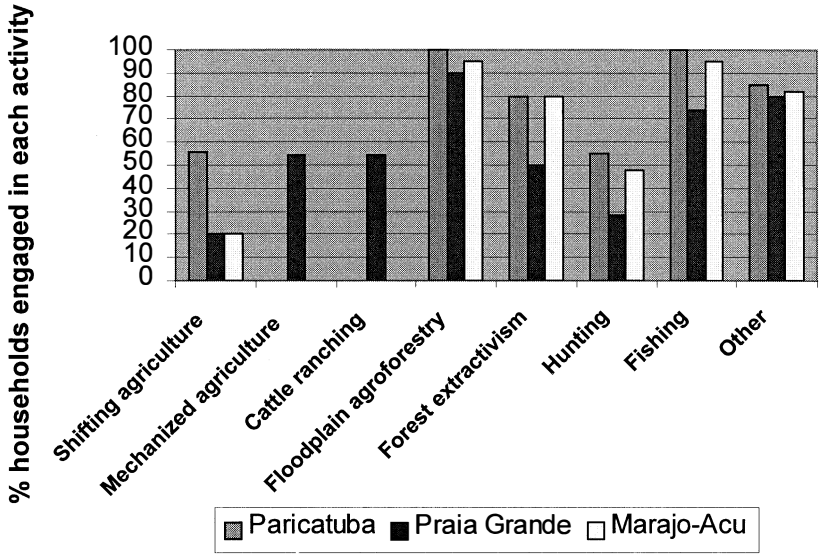


Fig. 6. Differences in activities in three communities of the Amazon estuary. (From Brondizio et al. 1994a.)

remote sensing data with local-level information on land use strategies carried out by local populations.

In this example we used remote sensing and socioeconomic data (collected through household interviews) in analyses of land use and cover patterns. Whereas figure 5 is a TM composite image illustrating the spatial configuration of land-use and cover for three estuarine populations, figure 6 describes the percentage of households in each population engaged in differently patterned economic activities. The use of TM data to discriminate land use and cover classes at the scale of small populations poses a number of challenges to image classification. It requires linking the spatial resolution of TM images with the spatial resolution of small-scale land use practices such as swidden agriculture and açaí agroforestry (Brondizio et al. 1994b; Brondizio and Siqueira 1997). Açaí (*Euterpe oleracea mart*) is the vernacular name given to a multistem palm that occurs naturally in floodplain areas of Eastern Amazon. The abundance of açaí palm in floodplain forest, together with its multistem regeneration capacity, makes it a species highly suitable for management. Açaí fruit, after being processed into a thick juice, is a highly appreciated regional staple food in rural and urban areas alike. In

rural and peri-urban areas, açaí juice is the second most important caloric source, behind manioc flour, and during the past twenty years it has become one of the most important economic resources for a large number of municipalities in the Amazon estuary.

A notable association between the continuity of forest cover and the types of land use strategies carried out by each population can be observed. Two examples can be highlighted. In the Praia Grande subregion, the landscape is characterized by a mosaic of open areas and secondary vegetation. This reflects the fact that over 50 percent of the households are involved in cattle ranching and mechanized agriculture. The presence of a continuous floodplain forest (cutting diagonally from the southwestern part of the image to its center) illustrates the impact of different land uses on land cover. Despite large-scale deforestation in the area, floodplain forest has been maintained as a result of the engagement of this population in *açaí* agroforestry. In contrast, in examining the Paricatuba subregion one can see the importance of swidden agriculture in the areas of upland forest surrounding the floodplain forest adjacent to the local river. A mosaic of small opened areas and secondary successional vegetation surrounding the river headwaters in a circular fashion can be seen. Finally, by looking at the Marajó-Açu subregion and the socioeconomic data, one can begin to understand the shifts this population has experienced during the past twenty years. Newly opened areas are virtually absent (the dark gray areas surrounding the forest are natural grassland) since most of it is now under some stage of secondary succession. This is due to the virtual abandonment of swidden agriculture in favor of *açaí* agroforestry.

Example 3. Household-Level Land Use Change in the Transamazon Highway

This project examines differential land use as it relates to household age and gender composition, growth, and change using a combination of household-level field surveys to scale up to the regional level using GIS techniques. The project hypothesizes that while many other factors noted in the literature, such as credit policy and migration flows, are important, the overall pattern of deforestation is shaped to a much greater extent by the household composition of labor over the course of the domestic life cycle. In this project, we are surveying over four hundred households from a total of more than three thousand properties (McCracken et al. 1999). Figure 7 illustrates the process of GIS development and the use of

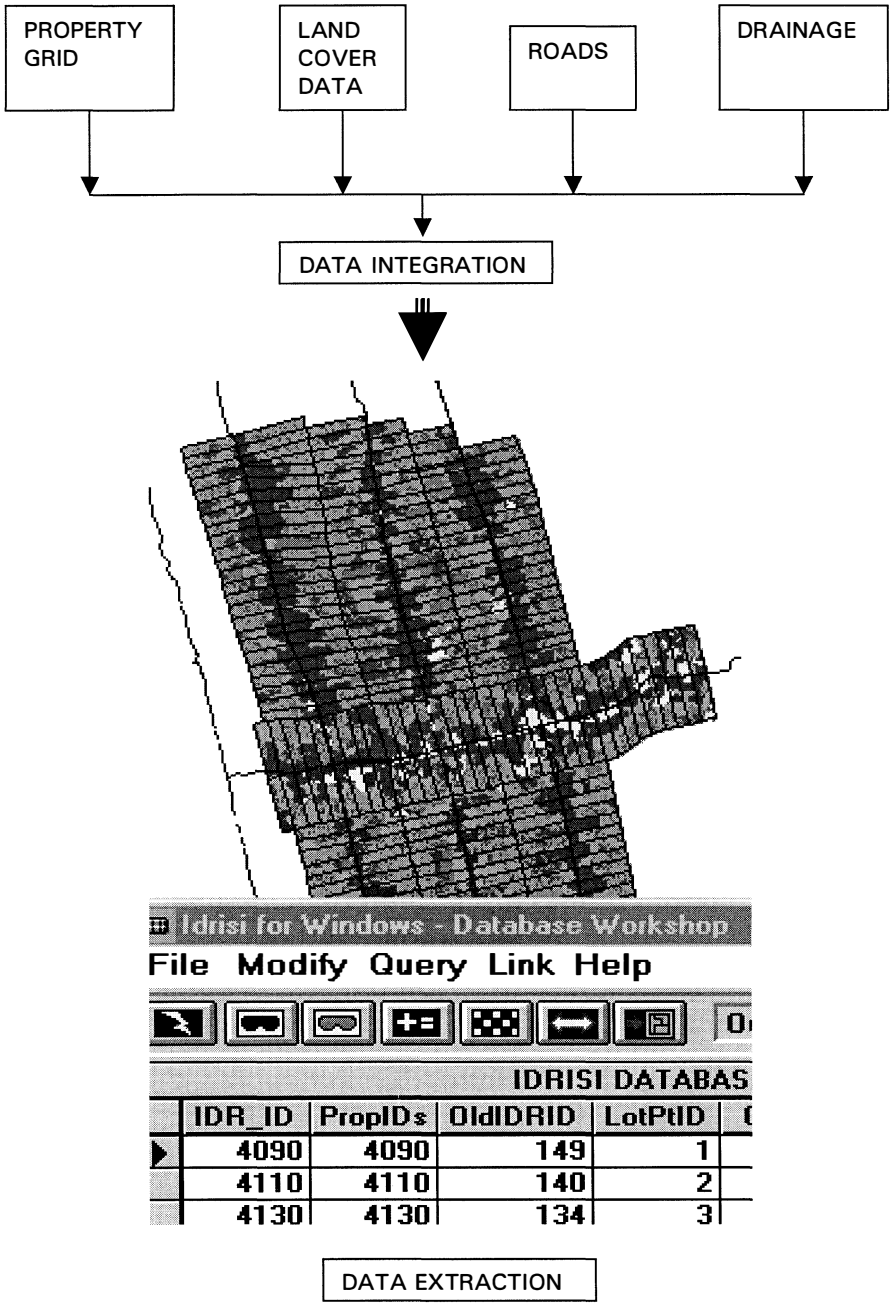


Fig. 7. Data integration and extraction in a GIS

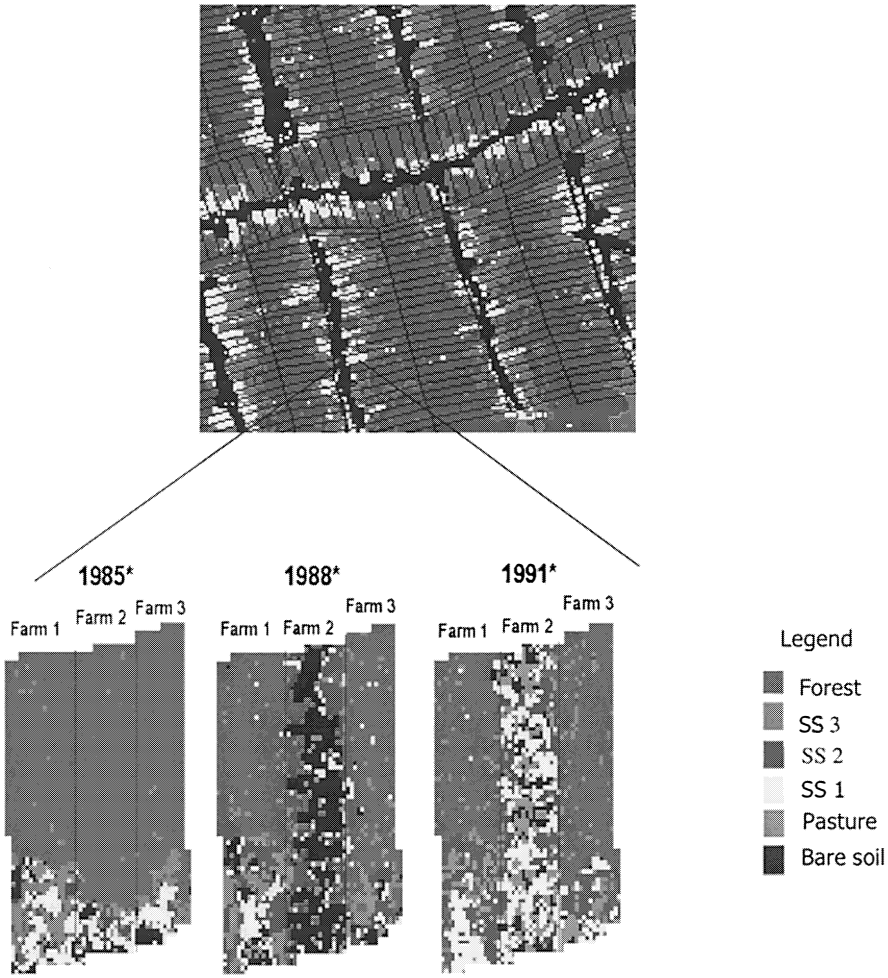


Fig. 8. Contrasting land cover in three farm properties over time. (Classification derived from Landsat TM images, 1985, 1988, 1991.)

a property grid (farm definition) to extract multitemporal land cover data (Brondizio et al., forthcoming).

The examples shown in figure 8 help to illustrate the differences in farm-level land use investigated by the project. By comparing the three neighboring farms presented in the sample, one can see considerable variations in land use strategies. Farm 1 which started with higher defor-

estation, put in annual crops and pasture between 1985 and 1988 but largely abandoned most of them by 1991. In contrast, farm 2, which presented little deforestation in 1985, by 1988 had completely deforested the property and switched to annual crops. This farm shifted from annual crops in 1988 to large areas of pasture by 1991, including degraded pasture. Dissimilarly, farm 3 maintained a small deforested area between 1985 and 1991, which was also initially dedicated to crops followed by pasture. In all three cases, it is important to note that areas in intermediate secondary succession may represent agroforestry areas of cacao due to the similarity in height and basal area between SS2 and cacao agroforestry.

Conclusions

Rappaport personally, and through his writings, inspired the authors' interests in issues of scales of analysis. His comment in the final pages of *Pigs for the Ancestors* to the effect that local populations are highly ephemeral and anthropologists would do well to begin to study local populations as they exist within a regional system led us over time to explore how landscape ecology, and other regional approaches might enrich anthropological and environmental studies. With the development of global change studies, this has added another wrinkle to this type of work: engagement with disorders of the contemporary world such as global deforestation, poverty, devaluation of local environmental knowledge, and finding local solutions to environmental problems rather than imposing outside solutions. Anthropology is capable of contributing to these analyses, with its forte remaining at the local to regional scales. Wessman (1992: 180) has called for studies that link ground observations to regional and global scales if we are to take full advantage of the detailed data available at different scales. A number of these research efforts are currently under way, but they have paid scant attention to the human dimensions of these processes. Extrapolation of ecosystem research to the regional and global scales has been hindered in the past by difficulties in observing large-scale spatial heterogeneity and long-term patterns of successional dynamics.

Remote sensing linked to ground-based studies provides the most promising of tools for understanding ecosystem structure, function, and change, with an explicit link to human activities (Liverman et al. 1998). The capacity to detect long-term change in ecosystems can be enhanced

by analysis of image texture combined with spatial statistics that permit analysis of stand structure from satellite data (Wessman 1992: 189), just as ethnoecology gives us access to the ways in which people perceive resources and their uses. In this essay, we have provided a summary of a multilevel research strategy that links traditional anthropological field methods to regional scale approaches based on satellite digital data from high-resolution sensors. It is one step toward a growing capability to complement our traditional methods of field study with space age techniques to capture landscape heterogeneity and a truly regional approach to human ecology. This strategy is not a purely programmatic statement but, rather, a well-tested research strategy used by a multidisciplinary team at the Anthropological Center for Training and Research on Global Environmental Change since 1992 and more recently by the Center for the Study of Institutions, Population, and Environmental Change (CIPEC), both at Indiana University. Results of this work may be found in the references cited throughout the paper or, as of May 2000, at the team's home page: www.indiana.edu/~act/.

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Ecological Embeddedness and Personhood: Have We Always Been Capitalists?

Alf Hornborg

I believe that most people working in ecological anthropology have come to the conclusion that the global environmental crisis is real: it will not allow itself to be deconstructed, and it does require very serious attention. But anthropology proves to be a house divided. Anthropologists not only study cultures, but they create them within the profession. At the 1996 American Anthropological Association (AAA) meeting in San Francisco, in a workshop discussion of an agenda for political ecology, Emilio Moran (see his essay, this volume) reminded those present to "count their potatoes." My suggestion to look also at the relationship between ecology and personhood elicited an alienating response. There are humanists and there are scientists in ecological anthropology (cf. Ingerson 1994) who unfortunately don't spend much time talking to each other.

A chief reason why Rappaport's work continues to be a source of inspiration for so many anthropologists is that he bridged these two traditions. He was one of those very rare anthropologists who could both "count potatoes" and engage in profound humanistic reflection. His focus was on the very interaction of constructed meanings and natural law. Perhaps because of this particular vantage point, he remained committed to understanding the causes of environmental destruction, even as the academic climate of the 1980s turned many into cynics.

Rappaport's original point about "cognized" (participants') models and their ecological adequacy in *Pigs for the Ancestors* (1968) had more profound implications than was suggested by the debate about whether it was a functionalist argument (e.g., Friedman 1974, 1979; Rappaport 1979). The question of whether ritual pig slaughter among the Tsembaga

Maring of New Guinea served as a ritual regulation of their ecosystem pointed to larger issues of local versus hegemonic knowledge systems. Although *Pigs for the Ancestors* was published in the 1960s, in a sense it foreshadowed postmodernism by hinting that the Tsembaga narrative could be as valid as a scientific one. Even if they were originally couched in the jargon of cybernetics, Rappaport's intuitions had a phenomenological dimension that grew more explicit in his later writings. Had it been presented today, the argument in *Pigs for the Ancestors* could have been buttressed with a variety of perspectives from poststructuralism, practice theory, cognitive science, metaphor theory, and semiotics (Hornborg 1996). It could have emphasized, with the poststructuralists, how language orders the world and how people, discourse, and environment form an inseparable, contextual whole. Or it might have argued, like Tim Ingold (1992), that what matters is experience and ecological practice and that cultural codifications are secondary. It might have leaned on the cognitive scientists Maturana and Varela ([1987] 1992), who show that knowledge is never a question of "internalizing" or "representing" the environment but of a relationship between subject and object that recursively constitutes both the knower and the known. It might also have expanded on the role of metaphor in positioning the human subject and providing frameworks for moral considerations in dealing with the environment (Bird-David 1993). Finally, and in the most general sense, it could have pursued the old argument of Jakob von Uexküll ([1940] 1982), the zoologist who is today recognized as the father of ecosemiotics (Nöth 1990; Sebeok 1994; Hoffmeyer 1996), that ecological relationships are semiotic, that they involve signs, perceptions, and interpretations. All living things live in — and act through — their own subjective worlds (what von Uexküll called their *Umwelts*). Ecosystems are not only material flows. They are constituted of communicative relationships and contingent on a plurality of subjective, species-specific perspectives. Human language and culture are in fact only the most recent additions to the semiotics of ecosystems. Meanings are not "outside" nature but have always been integral to its constitution.

All this is important because it allows us to argue, as Rappaport did, that the destruction of traditional systems of meaning and the destruction of ecosystems can be seen as two aspects of the same process. If, over and against Cartesian dualism, there is a recursive relationship between the subject and the object, then the person should be at the center of attention, even for ecological anthropology. If persons and

landscapes are mutually constitutive, if they coevolve, it should be highly relevant to ask how modern versus premodern personhood is associated with different ways of engaging nature.

Rappaport's *Pigs for the Ancestors* became a reference point for the once widespread anthropological notion of the "ecological native." It is ironic that this notion, although widely disseminated by earlier generations of anthropologists, is now being systematically dismissed as romanticism by anthropology precisely when (or is it because?) it is gaining a popular foothold (cf. Brosius 1999). In their eagerness to rid themselves of romanticism, anthropologists may have become overly reluctant to identify attractive features in traditional, non-Western societies. Richard Lee (1988: 253) has observed that there is now "a considerable industry in anthropology . . . to show the primitive as a Hobbesian being—with a life that is 'nasty, brutish and short.' " In the current climate of opinion, he notes, "no one is going to go broke" by appealing to cynicism.

The current fashion in anthropology is to dissolve any distinction between the modern and the premodern as a modern fabrication. Gemeinschaft is now nothing but a fabrication of Gesellschaft and the ecologically sensitive native merely a projection of industrial society. The rather remarkable implication is that, in the course of the emergence of urban-industrial civilization, no significant changes have been taking place in terms of social relations, knowledge construction, or human-environmental relations. The closely knit kinship group, locally contextualized ecological knowledge, attachment to place, reciprocity, animism: all of it is suddenly dismissed as myth. With the displacement of the old narrative, represented most forcefully by Karl Polanyi (1944), there emerges the new but implicit message that we have always been capitalists.

This is, in fact, what my colleague Jonathan Friedman (1997) argues. Accumulation is our natural state. Ecological sensibility is tantamount to decline or the failure of accumulation. The ideological dimension of this argument is more than usually evident in Friedman's attempt to draw parallels between the Tsembaga Maring and the modern environmental movement:

> The Tsembaga had a much less intensive system [than other Maring, closer to the Highlands], less hierarchy and earlier cut-off points for the accumulation process. It . . . also seems to be the case

> that the Tsembaga are of shorter stature than their higher altitude relatives and that they suffer from what seems to be a much lower level of protein intake. . . . I think one can suggest that there is an interesting historical distributional relation here in which representations of stability and control become increasingly dominant when the going gets rough. It might also be the case that ecological consciousness in our own civilization is also a product of crises that severely effect the conditions of existence and functioning of society. . . . Ecological consciousness is a reaction based on fear . . . that resonates with fear of bodily disintegration. It is an imaginary attempt to re-integrate the self into a larger whole that is threatened with disintegration. We must, as such, take Bramwell's [1989] suggestions concerning the brown-green conundrum very seriously. (5)

This argument is remarkable in several respects. First, quite contrary to Friedman's own, earlier argument (1979: 256) that the Tsembaga ritual cycle had no more than a coincidental connection with ecological balance, the Tsembaga are now accredited with "ecological consciousness" and explicit concerns with "stability." Second, this ecological consciousness is comparable to that of our own civilization, presumably including everything from Greenpeace to [former U.S. Vice President] Al Gore. Third, such ecological consciousness is to be understood as symptomatic of social breakdown, a psychotic fear of disintegration, and brown (fascist) political inclinations. There is no attempt whatsoever to distinguish between different varieties of ecological consciousness such as practical versus discursive, local versus global, or embedded versus disembedded (cf. Ingold 1993; Hornborg 1993, 1994). Even Bramwell's (1989) argument on the partial coincidence of early brown and green reactions to modernization, to which Friedman refers, is considerably more nuanced. I find it very hard to believe that the ecocosmology of the allegedly malnourished Tsembaga and the ecology movement of the still quite affluent, industrialized West are both reducible to the same kind of crisis. But these are the kinds of arguments that anthropologists seem to be getting away with these days.

In the context of a much more sophisticated argument, Ellen (1993: 126) expresses the currently fashionable opinion in his assertion that the "myth of primitive environmental wisdom" does not make sense "except in relation to the recognition that such an illusion serves an important ideological purpose in modern or post-modern society." But cynicism,

too, has its ideological purposes. And dwelling on examples of unwise natural resource management among indigenous peoples today is not a very good argument because it rests on essentialist premises. The opposite argument is not that indigenous peoples are somehow inherently (genetically?) prone to deal wisely with their environment but that the social condition and mind frame of premodern existence contains elements that may be more conducive to wise management than the modern mind frame (Bateson 1972; Rappaport 1979; Anderson 1996). The examples investigated today are rarely "premodern" in the sense that their resource management is informed by traditional metaphors of human-nature reciprocity (cf. Bird-David 1993) or pre-Cartesian notions about the intervention of human meanings in the material world. Such cultural dimensions of human-environmental relations have proven highly volatile as the commoditization of natural resources has expanded (cf. Martin 1978). It would thus be invalid to draw inferences from studies of contemporary, indigenous peoples about the environmental ethos of their premodern ancestors.

A "premodern" condition is very much a matter of experimental immersion or embeddedness in a local, socioecological context (Hornborg 1996). Even if, for the moment, they have lost sight of any way of curbing the ongoing commoditization of the planet, anthropologists have no reason to terminate their long-standing project of investigating the role of the capitalist world market in dissolving such conditions. Even less should they have reason to adopt a cynical posture vis-à-vis people—indigenous or not—who refuse to lose sight of the real changes that have been taking place in human-environmental relations worldwide. The world system may have begun emerging five thousand years ago (Gills and Frank 1993), but that doesn't mean that we have always been capitalists.

In this debate, some of us find ourselves trying to find ways of saying things that we believe to be true but that are systematically screened out by the various filters that act to keep our discourse harmlessly academic and disengaged. In order to go beyond both romanticism and cynicism, we need to ground notions of premodern "environmental wisdom" in a structural, rather than an essentialist, account. We need to focus on the disembedding, decontextualizing forces that are inherent in modernity and that are the common denominator of markets, universalizing science, and the ecologically alienated individual. There is a fundamental, "modern" tendency toward abstraction in the economy, discourse, and per-

sonhood that encourages environmental destruction. Benjamin Whorf explored the connection between market capitalism and objectification more than forty years ago (cf. Ingerson 1994: 62). As Rappaport argued, the subjective and the objective dimensions of environmental crisis are inseparable.

As anthropologists, we are well acquainted with the concept of disembedding through the work of Karl Polanyi. More recently, the term has been much used by Anthony Giddens (1990) and his followers in sociology. The phenomena that it tries to capture, of course, have been central concerns of sociology for more than a century. We know much about what disembedding means in terms of identities and social relationships, but the concept has a lot of analytical potential still to be explored in relation to problems of ecology and sustainability. The challenge for a monistic, post-Cartesian human ecology is to develop perspectives that humanize nature and naturalize society in the same move. The concept of ecological embeddedness suggests a promising avenue in that direction.

There is another way of expressing the process of disembedding, which might make more sense to those who prefer stories closer to natural science. It would have to begin with a critique of what has been referred to as universal selection theory, that is, the argument of Richard Dawkins (1976) and others suggesting that cultural ideas and artifacts are subject to selective processes formally similar to those operating in nature. In anthropology, the closest may be Dan Sperber's (1985: 30–31) notion of an epidemiology of ideas. The problem with universal selection theory is that it seems to assume that the meanings of words or artifacts are embodied in those words or artifacts. We all know, however, that meanings emerge in contexts. We need only go back to C. S. Peirce's triadic definition of the sign, which always includes the interpretant (Sebeok 1994). Selection theory has no way of handling these interpretive contexts, and yet they must be crucial for the process of selection itself. Semiotics is a necessary corrective to selection theory.[1]

Jointly, selection theory and semiotics provide another way of understanding modernity. From the point of view of universal selection theory, the specifics of local contexts of interpretation can be seen as constraints on reproductive success. Logically, the ideas, artifacts, and human persons that should be selected for are those that are least dependent on context. Abstract language, universalizing knowledge, general purpose money, globalized commodities, and cosmopolitan personalities all share

one fundamental feature: they are free to transcend specific, local contexts. They are not committed to place. There appears to be an inverse relationship between experiential groundedness and spatial expansion. McDonald's is testimony to this ecology of cultural diffusion.

Selection thus tends to increase the arbitrariness of the signifiers, suggesting a continuous movement along Peirce's well-known scale from index to icon to symbol. Inevitably, we have to scrutinize the paramount artifact of modernity, money itself. It is a code with only one sign, like a language with one phoneme, an alphabet with one letter, or a DNA molecule with only one kind of nucleotide. As such, it is a sign with a completely arbitrary referent, lacking even a conventional relationship (as in Peirce's definition of *symbol*) to any specific thing that it signifies. Nothing meaningful can be expressed with it, because meaning emerges in contrasts or in differences between what something stands for and what it doesn't. In fact, if there were two kinds of money instead of one, it would make all the difference in the world. The multicentric economy of the Nigerian Tiv described by Paul Bohannan fifty years ago in theory recognized three distinct kinds of values. It could be argued that an economic transaction among the Tiv in the 1940s embodied more meaning — in a formal, semiotic sense — than ordinary market exchanges. Widening the reach of general purpose money has divested the possibility of investing the economy with meaning (cf. Kopytoff 1986).[2]

Viewed from outer space, money is an "ecosemiotic" phenomenon that has very tangible effects on ecosystems and the biosphere as a whole (Hornborg 1992, 1997, 1999). Without the abstract semiotics of general purpose money, no one could trade tracts of rain forest for Coca-Cola. In the terms of Bateson and Rappaport, it brings about communicative disorder. Natural systems tend to show a kind of correspondence between temporal and spatial scales, so that the more inclusive a system is the longer its time span. A forest is thus more permanent than a tree, a tree more permanent than a leaf, and so on (Holling and Sanderson 1996). To trade rain forests for carbonated beverages obviously does not agree with this pattern. It exemplifies how short-term needs of less inclusive systems gain priority over the long-term survival of the more inclusive. By translating into material practice the notion that everything is interchangeable, irrespective of scale, general purpose money paves the way for such destruction.

I would like to conclude by suggesting that there is a peculiar relationship between money and the sacred, two ideas — or "memes" in

Dawkins's (1976) words—that both signify encompassment, abstraction, and the transcendence of context. It is not a coincidence that the nature of both of these phenomena preoccupied Rappaport. In a complex sense, money is a transmutation—and an inversion—of the sacred, as in the biblical Mammon or Marx's concept of money fetishism. Money partakes of the same capacity for abstraction as the sacred, the ultimate, the irreducible. But in terms of money nothing is sacred and everything is reducible. The sacred is an abstraction rooted or embedded in local resonance; money—like science—is disembedded abstraction (Hornborg 1994). Universal selection theorists could no doubt observe that human history has selected for money and science at the expense of the sacred. This is what we have come to know as modernity.

Modern, objectivist rationality claims a monopoly on legitimate knowledge construction, suggesting a confusion of map and territory. But, to the extent that there is such a thing as an absolute truth, it will not allow itself to be encapsulated in any specific set of words. There will always be more than one way of drawing a map. Cognitive scientists are concerned not with truth but with the adequacy of representations, and the only measure of adequacy we will ever have is survival (Maturana and Varela [1987] 1992). Foucault (1972) locates in classical Greece the point at which what words said started to become more important than what they did. Spiritual and "deep ecology" approaches to environmental issues suggest a renewed concern with the performative dimension of our narratives. It could be argued that they represent a logical next step beyond the paralysis of constructivism. If the constructivists are right in suggesting that there is a sense in which we ourselves are the authors of our world, the discovery that this is the case should ultimately inspire responsibility rather than nihilism. If we have to recover a metaphorical idiom capable of sustainably relating us to the rest of the world, the reflexive experience of modernity now leaves us no other choice than to learn how to handle the awareness that this is what we should be doing.

With all these things in mind, we might ask what kind of conditions could be imagined that would select for specificity: for embeddedness, local economies, local knowledge, and local identity? Friedman (1994, 1997) would call such conditions decline. But then the world system historian Braudel (1979) found that periods of decline are in fact golden ages in the daily life of the masses. Are the dark ages of the historians experienced by the majority as periods of tax reduction? In the light of the unity that we have posited between them, such a cyclical recuperation

of local communities may go hand in hand with the recuperation of nature. And, just maybe, the social condition that some prefer to think of as decline could give us some ideas on how to redesign money and market institutions so as to select for ecological embeddedness.

NOTES

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1. I am indebted to Henrik Bruun (1997), a graduate student in human ecology in Gothenburg, for putting this in a nutshell.

2. Although more or less exotic exceptions can certainly be found (Parry and Bloch 1989), they do little to invalidate the long-standing sociological conclusion that, by and large, modern money has had a tendency to render social relations increasingly abstract (Giddens 1990).

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Considering the Power and Potential of the Anthropology of Trouble

Barbara Rose Johnston

In this essay, I take as my starting point one of Roy Rappaport's later works, "Human Environment and the Notion of Impact" (1994a), an essay abstracted from a longer report, which was prepared as part of a National Academy of Science study on the impacts of offshore oil drilling in the continental United States. This essay represents an example of Rappaport's effort to apply anthropology in the policy arena. His experiences refined and sharpened his notions on the power and potential of a problem-focused public interest anthropology, ideas that are reflected in later works, especially those pertaining to the "anthropology of trouble."

In the National Academy of Science study, Rappaport was responsible for assessing the adequacy of existing science to predict, mitigate, and thus protect human systems from the adverse impacts of offshore oil drilling. To complete this study, he traveled around the United States for over a year, attending public hearings and interviewing affected peoples in areas where offshore drilling was proposed. The resulting report confronted the legal definition of *human environment* as it is contained in the United States Outer Continental Shelf Lands Act as Amended (1978) and expanded the notion of human environment from a definable set of physical, demographic, and economic characteristics to include considerations of the social, symbolic, and conceptual elements of human systems.

In "Human Environment and the Notion of Impact," Rappaport argues that human systems are living systems—they respond to impacts and their responses may be difficult or impossible to predict. Development activities and events create primary impacts, which stimulate secondary impacts, and these in turn operate synergistically in ways that

intensify existing effects and produce new ones. Impacts and responses to impacts are always culturally and even subculturally relative (1994a: 165–66). Rappaport observed that this dynamic, holistic notion of human environment is not reflected in the frameworks that structure environmental analysis and decision making (frameworks established through legislative mandates such as the National Environmental Protection Act of 1969). Rather, existing models of human environment defined populations and social concerns in quantifiable terms that are readily inserted into cost-benefit analyses and used to make rational decisions. These conceptual frameworks lack a good deal. Rappaport writes that "the understandings upon which conventional rules and practices are founded include not only those narrowly focused upon specific aspects of human affairs, but also more general, and from the point of view of the actors, more fundamental conceptions, conceptions of morality, equity, justice, honor; religious doctrines; ideas concerning sovereignty, property, rights, and duties; aesthetic values and conceptions of what constitutes high life quality; distinctive understandings concerning the nature of nature, of the place of humans in it, of proper behavior with respect to it, and of equitable distribution of its fruits, its costs, and its dangers" (1994a: 159).

Rappaport demonstrated the impoverishment of then existing definitions of *human environment* and the consequences of these conceptual shortcomings. When incomplete and inadequate constructs are used to define the critical categories of concern in human environmental analysis, experiences are trivialized, problems are overlooked, and efforts to mitigate the adverse consequences and thus protect humans and their environment are doomed to fail. Furthermore, Rappaport showed how these failures can produce over time a sense of abuse of community "rights" and how this in turn may stimulate sociopolitical unrest or escalate existing tensions to the point of violent conflict:

> It may be in the nature of human systems generally, that violations of a community's conceptions of its rights in its local surroundings, or of its conceptions of justice and equity, or perceived threats to its "general way of life," or to its basic canons of reality, will frequently take precedence over material considerations in the conduct of affairs. . . . [W]hen a community's concerns are ignored by analysts and decision makers . . . the dominant issues become matters of "high Principle" . . . [and] self sacrifice may be more highly valued than material benefit. . . . [F]ailures to give full and respectful treat-

> ment to local conceptions, perceptions and apprehensions have in the past, led to widespread citizen alienation and anger, political and legal action, and even threats of violence. (1994a: 164)
>
> For a community to have its understandings of reality disregarded by a powerful authority is profoundly alienating, for it leaves no common ground upon which the community and the authority can stand. For some there is nothing left to do but fight. For others, feelings of powerlessness and alienation contribute to such social pathologies as drug abuse and domestic violence. For most, there may be a general loss of confidence in the agencies of the government or even the legitimacy of government itself. (165)

As an effort to influence national policy, Rappaport's work was hugely successful. In highlighting fundamental flaws in the methods and procedures used to define and evaluate potential social impact, he demonstrated to his fellow members of the National Academy of Science research committee and to the policymakers who received the committee's report and recommendations that existing assessment procedures and decision-making structures could not possibly achieve an adequate assessment of the social impacts of offshore oil drilling and thus could not meet legislated mandate to protect humans and their environment. Timing, the content of his contribution, his position in the discipline, and perhaps the broader politics of his engagement all influenced whether people listened to what Rappaport had to say. His points were acknowledged and played a supporting role in the National Academy of Science recommendations to ban oil drilling on the U.S. outer Continental Shelf. This ban was implemented, and Rappaport achieved his desired advocacy goal.

From a disciplinary praxis perspective, "Human Environment and the Notion of Impact" reflects Rappaport's vision of an anthropology in which research, analysis, and reports are conducted and shaped with the goal of informing and influencing national policy. In conversations discussing this work, Rappaport acknowledged that the process of engagement—the year spent traveling around the country attending public meetings, listening to testimonies, asking questions, gathering citizen views, and sharing his views, opinions, and research findings with other members of the interdisciplinary committee—was as important in influencing the outcome as the end product of engagement (his written report). This experience as a scholar-advocate reinforced Rappaport's

vision of an engaged anthropology and the need for disciplinary structures that support and sustain efforts to influence policy and action. His commitment to strengthen disciplinary praxis in the public policy arena is reflected in his reorganization work within the American Anthropological Association during his term as AAA president, and later as a member of its Environmental Task Force, and is articulated in his 1993 essay "The Anthropology of Trouble" (1993a).

Rappaport believed that substantive transformations can occur when anthropologists act as citizens, when they apply their analytical skills to troubles at home as well as abroad, and when they consciously use these engagements to encourage broader awareness and acceptance of responsibility. These beliefs represent the ideal that many of us strive for—to use anthropological skills and experiences as a way to analyze, assess, and hopefully transform decision-making systems and the public policies they generate. Some of the "troubles" that draw anthropological attention and intervention involve the biodegenerative conditions and social inequities of industrialism and globalization; the sociocultural context of "disasters" such as oil spills, floods, and earthquakes; the human rights problems of war and postwar reconstruction; the environmental quality and social justice aspects of conservation and natural resource management; and the human costs of economic development (including ethnocide, ecocide, and at times genocide). Being drawn into the anthropology of trouble is often the result of an urgent need to help in any way possible those informants, friends, and families whose lives we touch, whose experiences are reflected in the many intellectual articulations that shape and sustain our professional careers, and whose health and viability are threatened by human and environmental crises of one sort or another. How effective, and how risky, is this work? What can we learn from the successes and failures of anthropological engagements in troublesome terrain?

To explore these questions, I turn to the case of the Pehuenche and hydroelectric dam development on the Biobío River in Chile. The case provides an opportunity to illustrate Rappaport's observations concerning the linkages between flawed analytical models, inept decision making, adverse human and environmental impacts, and subsequent social crises. As will be seen, the case also provides an example of the difficulties of individual and disciplinary engagement with the anthropology of trouble.

The Pehuenche and Biobío River Hydroelectric Dam Development

The Pehuenche are culturally and linguistically Mapuche and are the last remaining indigenous group in Chile that lives according to cultural tradition on ancestral lands. They are a small group of five thousand or so loosely organized members living in kin-based groups in the lowland valleys of the Biobío River watershed. The Pehuenche have been adversely affected by deforestation and land loss associated with Pangue and Ralco Hydroelectric Dam developments on the Biobío River, a project initially funded by the International Finance Corporation (IFC, a member of the World Bank Group) in partnership with ENDESA (Empresa Nacional de Electricidad S.A., a privately owned Chilean corporation). As of September 1999, an estimated one-fifth of the Pehuenche population faced involuntary relocation to make way for the Ralco Dam, the second in a planned series of six dams.[1]

In 1990, the newly elected Chilean government approved plans for hydrodevelopment of the Biobío River by ENDESA. Implementing this project would require invoking the Electrical Services Law (decreed in 1982 during President Pinochet's regime) to privatize Pehuenche reservation land. Pehuenche land rights are guaranteed by the Chilean Constitution and were reaffirmed by the 1993 Indigenous Peoples Law and the 1994 Environment Law. Under the Indigenous Peoples Law, the Pehuenche control their lands and have the right to refuse any deal offered them by ENDESA. ENDESA dismissed the relevance of this law, arguing that under the 1982 Energy Law the nation's need for energy supersedes indigenous rights.

ENDESA asked the IFC to provide private development funding for the Pangue Dam, the first of a series of six hydroelectric dams planned for the Biobío River. In 1990, the IFC began appraising the Pangue Dam proposal, and while it was considering the funding, national and international advocacy campaigns were organized and demonstrations, press releases, and independent investigations called into question the social and environmental impacts of the project.

This hydroelectric dam project was the first major development initiative approved by the new democratic government in Chile. The political struggle to challenge the Pangue Dam and halt further hydrodevelopment on the Biobío began with the first public announcement of

the proposal in 1988 and expanded to the international environmental advocacy arena in 1990, when the Chilean Government issued project approval and the IFC agreed to consider providing funding for the project. It intensified in 1992, when IFC funding was authorized. The struggle involved a wide range of actors, including Chilean anthropologists and sociologists, indigenous groups, and national and international environmental organizations. Public response to the project was fierce, as it would require massive deforestation, tame a wild river, cause significant downstream damage, and generate energy for people whose needs were already being met from other sources. Much of the initial protest centered around environmental concerns, involved national and international environmental organizations, and attacked the proposed development on its assumptions of demand for energy and inadequate consideration of environmental costs (especially that of deforestation).

Despite Chilean and international efforts to halt the project, in December 1992 the IFC Board of Directors approved the decision to invest in the Pangue Dam, with conditions that included greater attention to social and environmental concerns. In October 1993, the IFC and ENDESA signed an investment agreement providing a U.S.$170 million loan to ENDESA to build the dam and $4.7 million in equity for the Pangue project—giving the IFC a 2.5 percent equity interest in Pangue S.A., the ENDESA subsidiary that built and operates Pangue and plans to construct a second dam (Ralco) on the Biobío. The investment agreement was negotiated by the IFC and ENDESA—without Pehuenche awareness or involvement—and remains a privately held document. Contained in this agreement were plans to mitigate the social impact of the dam—including reinvestment of a portion of the profits in the Pehuen Foundation, a nonprofit organization created via the initial funding agreement covenant between IFC and ENDESA to improve the social welfare of surrounding Pehuenche communities (the foundation is managed by Pangue S.A.).

The Pehuenche were not considered "affected people" in initial feasibility studies and impact mitigation plans. While social impact assessments were conducted to determine the impact of the dam on local landowners, residents were not identified as Pehuenche—members of an indigenous community with ancestral ties and rights to the watershed. According to the IFC, "eight non-indigenous families (53 people) had to be resettled because of the building of the Pangue project" (IFC 1997: 3). However, according to the November 22, 1997, testimony provided

to the American Anthropological Association Committee for Human Rights (CfHR) by Theodore Downing and Chilean anthropologist Claudio Gonzalez Parra, three of the families that accepted resettlement packages were indigenous and another two were misclassified as non-Indian because interviewers spoke with male heads of households and overlooked the presence of Pehuenche wives. A ninth family, which refused resettlement, was forcibly evicted.

Furthermore, feasibility studies did not consider or plan for the "downstream" effects of hydrodevelopment. Staff depicted the project to the IFC Board as a single, "stand-alone" dam, rather than a series, and only those who were literally knee-deep in the water from the Pangue Dam were considered affected people. Thus, as noted by Downing and Gonzalez Parra, an additional twelve to fourteen Pehuenche families with homes on the Pangue Dam shoreline were not considered "impacted" and not included in resettlement plans. Altogether, of the hundred or so people directly affected by the Pangue Dam, Downing and Gonzalez estimated that approximately 77 percent were indigenous. By defining Pangue as a stand-alone dam rather than a construction designed to work in conjunction with a large reservoir-dam upstream (Ralco), IFC employees were able to avoid consideration of (and later culpability for) the cumulative impacts of Pangue and direct impacts of Ralco. These impacts included the involuntary displacement of more than a thousand people, including six hundred Pehuenche (an estimated one-fifth of the total population).

In September 1996, despite long and intense protest in Chile and abroad, the Pangue Dam was built. While advocacy efforts did not achieve success as measured in the demise of the Biobío Dam development project, the process of organizing, educating, and lobbying contributed to substantive political change in Chilean governance, including the passage of the October 1993 Indigenous Law. This law protects the land and rights of indigenous people and grants native groups special rights to be consulted on decisions pertaining to their land. It established a commission composed of indigenous group leaders (CONADI, National Indigenous Development Commission) to review and approve all decisions affecting indigenous peoples. And in March 1994 Chile's first ever environmental law was passed, establishing a similar commission (CONAMA, Chilean National Environmental Agency) to review and approve all development-related decisions affecting the natural environment.

Anthropological Efforts to Analyze "Trouble" and Influence Policy and Action

Advocacy efforts intensified in the last year before water filled the Pangue Dam. In an effort to demonstrate that adequate social impact mitigation measures were being employed, the World Bank authorized an independent "social impact" audit. In May 1995, Theodore Downing, a past president of the Society for Applied Anthropology, was contacted by the bank and asked to do an independent evaluation of the Pehuen Foundation. After negotiating a participatory and transparent approach, Downing traveled to Chile, where he worked from June through December 1995.

While Downing was conducting field research, in November 1995 Grupo de Accion por el Biobío (GABB), the primary Chilean environmental advocacy group, filed an inspection panel claim with the World Bank, asserting gross violations of environmental laws and calling for an investigation of IFC's role in funding the Biobío dam development project (the Pangue and Ralco dams). This claim was supported by forty-seven nongovernmental organizations (NGOs) but was rejected by the World Bank inspection panel on grounds that the IFC, as the private financing arm of the bank, is not covered by its mandate. Shortly thereafter, GABB commissioned a critique of the environmental impact statement prepared for the proposed Ralco Dam, and this critique prompted CONAMA to declare the Ralco environmental impact statement unsatisfactory.

In May 1996, Downing's social impact audit of the Pehuen Foundation was completed and the report was submitted to the IFC. Downing had used participatory ethnographic methods to study the social, cultural, and political characteristics of the Pehuenche. He traveled from village to village, involving Chilean colleagues and Pehuenche community members in an ethnographic study of Pehuenche community identity and seeking their perceptions of the positive and negative consequences of dam development and the efficacy of social and environmental mitigation measures. Downing also worked with Pangue Dam officials and Pehuen Foundation staff, examining their initial plans, reviewing mitigation-related activities, and evaluating the degree to which Pehuenche people received and were involved in (or even aware of) mitigation-related projects, activities, and benefits. Downing's research identified significant culpability gaps in planning, decision making, and mitigation-related processes. Hu-

man and environmental conditions had significantly worsened, and the foundation had become a vehicle for Ralco resettlement rather than meaningful and sustainable redevelopment. These failures stemmed partly from the IFC's failure to provide for the Pehuenche's informed participation and the lack of structural opportunity for such participation.

Specifically, Downing's report noted that, through the year 2001, Pangue S.A. agreed to provide the Pehuen Foundation the greater of (1) an annual amount equal to 0.30 percent of the company's net income or (2) the equivalent of 5,780 Chilean unidades de fomento. After 2001, the company will provide the foundation with an annual amount equal to 0.30 percent of the company's net income. As of 1996, the company had not registered profits from electrical generation and did not include profits from timber harvesting in their accounts. Thus, Pangue S.A. was obligated to provide the foundation with about U.S.$130,000 per year, an amount determined through IFC/Pangue S.A. negotiations without informing or consulting with the Pehuenche and without conducting a technical study to determine whether this amount would sustain impact mitigation and social reconstruction objectives. Downing estimated that profits from timber harvesting associated with Pangue dam development (1988–94) netted timber profits between $3 million and $18 million.[2]

In reviewing the foundation accounts and other records, Downing found that between 1992 and 1996 residents of Callaqui and Quepuca-Ralco received $250,000 in direct foundation program benefits and more than $575,000 in project-related wages. The Chilean government spent another $1.6 million on the region. Despite this influx of dollars, Downing's data suggested no substantial trend toward poverty alleviation in the dam-affected communities (Callaqui, Pitril, and Quepuca-Ralco). Furthermore, the company failed to incorporate four of the five critical elements of the IFC/Pangue agreement into the foundation's statutes and operational agenda. Specifically, it failed to realize its commitments to make the foundation a vehicle for sustainable development that would provide long-term benefits to the Pehuenche by promoting their socioeconomic development, prepare to mitigate the effects of construction activities (with construction scheduled to end in 1997), preserve and reinforce cultural identity, or make its best effort to arrange for the supply of electric power to the communities.

In short, Downing found that the small, poverty-stricken band of Pehuenche Indians was in essence, subsidizing Chilean hydropower development at the cost of their economy, resources, and culture.

In his report and statements, Downing noted that the Pehuen Foundation was an innovative creation with laudable goals and objectives, and his review found some evidence of its positive effects on some families in some Pehuenche communities. However, alienation of the Pehuenche from all meaningful levels of the development-planning and decision-making process played a key role in the failure of the foundation to meet its expressed objectives. Although Pangue S.A. hired some Pehuenche and three Pehuenche served on the Pehuen Foundation board, no Pehuenche was involved in efforts to set up the foundation and establish a plan for effective and sustainable development. Nor were the Pehuenche involved in the April 1997 agreement between the IFC and ENDESA to use the foundation to resettle the much higher number of families affected by construction of Ralco Dam.

Both the developer and the lender interpreted "informed participation" by the Pehuenche to mean simply ensuring the presence of Pangue area *lonkos* (leaders) at some foundation board meetings. The *lonkos,* however, do not have authority formally recognized by the Pehuenche to make decisions binding on their groups. Downing's ethnographic work found a fluid and dispersed leadership pattern that makes it difficult to determine who speaks for the entire group. Political organization is based on kinship, and the Pehuenche community consists of highly individualistic groups of families and lineages (Downing 1996: 13). Efforts by the IFC, ENDESA, Pangue S.A., and the Pehuen Foundation to secure the Pehuenche's "informed participation" were fatally flawed from the start. The flaws were compounded due to the fact that the foundation staff was "culturally untrained, inexperienced in indigenous and rural development and included only Spanish speaking, non-Mapuche staff" (43).

In addition, Downing's ethnographic work on the Pehuenche sociopolitical structure suggests that the IFC, ENDESA, and the Pehuen Foundation made fundamentally erroneous assumptions concerning the Pehuenche political structure. Though elected by their communities, Pehuenche representatives on the foundation board can be replaced by Pangue company appointees if they do not appear at a meeting. They can be removed from the board if its voice vote decides that they are an impediment (1996: 16–17). However, as Downing noted, elected representatives lack reporting and feedback mechanisms to dispense information in their communities and seek communitywide input. From the Pehuenche perspective, representatives do not have the authority to

speak on behalf of the community. Downing's report identified these problems and noted that only a general assembly of the entire tribe would provide the culturally appropriate forum and result in authoritative decisions reflecting the tribe's will in reference to Ralco resettlement, the Pehuen Foundation structure and activities, and related decision-making processes.

Downing's evaluation report contained recommendations for improving development-community relations by broadening compensatory efforts to include all affected people and restructuring social mitigation efforts to include meaningful Pehuenche involvement. The report included a plan for a number of meetings in Chile (a reporting requirement included in his original contract) bringing together affected peoples, project stakeholders, and representatives from the different government agencies and interest groups to examine the social impact audit of the Pehuen Foundation in culturally appropriate language and form and to develop appropriate next-step strategies. The IFC accepted Downing's report, but soon after, in response to a request from ENDESA and in the interests of protecting their client-shareholder relationship, it refused to disseminate the report, canceled plans for previously approved stakeholder meetings, and threatened Downing with legal action if he tried on his own to divulge information contained within the social impact audit.[3] Several days after receiving the audit, ENDESA announced that the Pehuen Foundation would be the primary mechanism used to resettle people displaced by the Ralco Dam.

By May 1996, environmental advocacy had generated sufficient pressure to push World Bank president James Wolfensohn to authorize another inquiry, and Jay Hair (past president of the U.S. National Wildlife Federation) was appointed to head a team of scientists contracted to conduct an environmental performance audit of the Pangue Dam. At the same time, in Chile, CONAMA was persuaded by ENDESA and Chilean government officials to retract its rejection of the Ralco environmental impact statement. CONADI then released its report, stating that the Ralco project was illegal based on Chile's 1993 Indigenous Law. Chilean President Frei responded to the CONADI report by firing its director, Mauricio Henchuiaf, a strong supporter of Pehuenche rights.

By February 1997, documentation of the social and environmental problems that had resulted from inept planning of the Pangue Dam were too extensive to ignore and the ecopolitics surrounding plans for the Ralco Dam were too intense to dismiss. The IFC threatened to

declare ENDESA in default of its loan for failing to meet the environmental conditions outlined in their contract for Pangue. Shortly after receiving the IFC statement of concern, ENDESA refinanced its IFC loan. Dresdner Bank of Germany bought all of the loan obligation, leaving the IFC with a financial involvement limited to the 2.5 percent equity interest in Pangue, S.A. Advocacy efforts directed toward the World Bank were immediately rendered ineffective, as the World Bank had no other projects financed in Chile and thus no political leverage.

In April 1997, Jay Hair's independent review was completed. It provided evidence of the failure of environmental safeguard measures and confirmed Downing's documentation of massive deforestation. In June 1997, CONAMA approved the Ralco project's environmental impact assessment and established a public comment period that ended in December 1997. In July 1997, the IFC released a heavily censored version of the Hair report, with excerpts totaling one-third of the document. Almost all of the excerpted material pertained to the failure of the Pehuen Foundation and the social impacts documented by Downing.

In September 1997, CONADI questioned the legitimacy of individual Pehuenche-ENDESA resettlement agreements, noting that ENDESA had omitted key information about where people would be moved when gathering signatures. Pehuenche leaders reiterated previous declarations indicating their opposition to Ralco and their refusal to move. In October 1997, six of seven Pehuenche *caciques* (tribal leaders) met to review the Ralco environmental impact statement and voted to reject the dam proposals. In November 1997, CONADI met with each of the households that had made Ralco resettlement deals with ENDESA and reported evidence that questioned whether the agreements were signed with free will. Also in November 1997, the AAA CfHR began inquiries into human rights violations associated with the IFC funding of hydrodam development, and testimony was given by Chilean anthropologist Claudio Gonzalez Parra, Theodore Downing, Carol Lee (vice president and general counsel of the IFC), and other members of the World Bank staff.

For some twenty months (May 7, 1996, through December 26, 1997), the IFC refused to release the Downing report to those who requested copies, including the Pehuenche, other project stakeholders, the Chilean government, and the broader international community. During this time, Downing filed a number of protests at the World Bank, including demands for compensatory action on behalf of Pehuenche

displaced by the Pangue Dam and a human rights abuse complaint. An internal investigation of human rights violations by IFC staff found, not surprisingly, flaws in some of its decisions and actions but no legally actionable behavior.

On December 26, 1997, the IFC notified Downing that he could release copies of his report without fear of lawsuit, provided that he include a disclaimer indicating that the report is not a formal IFC report. Permission to disseminate the information was received after the expiration of the public review and comment period on the Ralco Dam proposal. As a result, the Ralco Dam impact statements, mitigation measures, and relocation plans were shaped around the functional involvement of the Pehuen Foundation and in ignorance of the institutional flaws that were contributing to the human rights abuses and environmental degradation documented in the Downing audit. In January 1998, the Chilean government announced that Ralco Dam construction had been approved and would commence later that spring. This approval was given without CONADI endorsement.

Disciplinary Efforts Analyze "Trouble" and Influence Policy and Action

As an example of the "anthropology of trouble," Downing's effort to analyze and assess the social impacts of Pangue development with the goal of developing problem-solving strategies that involve all actors in meaningful, equitable ways was abruptly curtailed when the IFC censored his work. When he did not succeed in his formal role as independent auditor and consultant to the IFC, he continued to push for acknowledgments of its culpability and meaningful redress of the abuses suffered by the Pehuenche by filing formal complaints in the policy committees of his professional associations. His efforts prompted the involvement of the AAA's CfHR, the Society for Applied Anthropology, and the American Academy for the Advancement of Science's Committee on Professional Responsibility and Scientific Freedom. Advocacy on the part of professional organizations resulted in investigations and published reports, meetings, and letters of concern sent to the IFC, the World Bank, ENDESA, the U.S. State Department, and the Chilean government.

Letters from professional organizations protesting the treatment of the Pehuenche and the censorship of the scientific research did not

produce immediate or clear results. They did, however, create another source of political pressure on the World Bank and kept the Pehuenche issue alive long after the IFC's major fiscal involvement had ceased. In testimony to the CfHR and in public statements, the IFC has acknowledged that it should have taken a more systematic approach to analyzing environmental and social impacts in the Pangue project before funding and should have examined the indigenous peoples' issues more thoroughly, especially the project's indirect impacts on indigenous people. It admitted that lack of informed participation by indigenous people has been a weakness of the project (IFC 1997: 2). Carol Lee said that problems associated with the project should be understood as part of the IFC's "learning curve." Shortcomings, while unfortunate, were "consistent with the environmental procedures in place at the time" (Lee 1997 and IFC 1997: 4). According to Lee, these controversies and the whole experience have prompted a number of changes at IFC, including adding staff, creating an environmental review unit, and drafting proposed human and environmental policies and procedures.

However, while the IFC asserts that "lessons have been learned" and changes made in project review, development, and implementation, there is some evidence that past mistakes are being repeated. Focus International, the primary architect of the Pangue and Ralco resettlement plans, was recently hired to develop the social impact mitigation measures for the Chad Cameroon pipeline project, funded by the World Bank and the IFC and involving the involuntary displacement of the Bakola Pygmies. Focus International is a joint Canadian-Chilean organization. The Chilean owner is also the president of the Pehuen Foundation.[4]

For the Pehuenche, thanks to the after the fact release of Downing's work and subsequent investigations by NGOs and other groups, their story is now well known. Their condition, however, remains largely unremedied. Some families have been relocated and others struggle with the involuntary relocation associated with the building of a second dam. While preliminary construction on the Ralco Dam has been initiated, advocacy efforts by Chilean and international organizations continue—targeting national political arenas (especially Chilean government agencies), the developer (protests and blockades on the access road leading to the second dam at Ralco), and the new project funders (attempting, through public information and shareholder campaigns, to get European funders to recall their loan or use their power to lobby for changes in the development project).[5]

Policy and Praxis Lessons from the Pehuenche Case

What's to be learned from this "anthropology of trouble" case of individual and disciplinary efforts to substantively transform the social realities of hydrodevelopment in Chile? Rappaport's analysis of the impact of flawed conceptual models in the development planning process, discussed at the beginning of this essay, are clearly illustrated here: incomplete and inadequate constructs were used to define the critical categories of concern in the initial social impact assessments for the Pangue Dam, experiences were trivialized, problems were overlooked, and efforts to mitigate the adverse consequences and thus protect humans and their environment failed.

The narrow conceptualization of "affected people" meant that the World Bank Operational Directive 4.20, which establishes bank policies and procedures for projects that affect indigenous peoples, was not implemented. As defined by the directive, indigenous peoples have a close attachment to ancestral territories and the natural resources in them, self-identification and identification by others as members of a distinct cultural group, an indigenous language, customary social and political institutions, and primarily subsistence-oriented production. The primary objectives of this directive are to ensure that indigenous peoples do not suffer adverse effects during the development process, particularly from bank-financed projects, and that they receive culturally compatible social and economic benefits. Implementing these objectives requires the development of plans in which indigenous peoples have full awareness and involvement, a framework that acknowledges the legal status of the group as reflected in the country's constitution, legislation, and subsidiary legislation (regulations and administrative orders), and acknowledgment of the ability of such groups to obtain access to and effectively use their legal system to defend their rights. Particular attention is paid to indigenous peoples' rights to use and develop the lands they occupy, to be protected against illegal intruders, and to have access to natural resources (such as forests, wildlife, and water) vital to their subsistence and reproduction.

The IFC's failure to recognized affected people as indigenous meant that safeguard mechanisms such as Operational Directive 4.20 were not utilized; the impoverished definition of *human environment* produced conceptually flawed plans, decisions, and "compensatory" actions; and, as detailed below, these shortcomings produced abusive conditions and

sociopolitical conflict.[6] These failures produced what Rappaport termed "a sense of abuse of community rights," and this in turn generated a decade (and more, as the conflict continues) of national and international sociopolitical conflict that has at times escalated to the point of violence.

The sociopolitical response to abusive conditions described in this case illustrates some of the ways in which human environmental rights groups (and the anthropologists working to support them) respond to the relative inability of the state to act, for reasons of political will or authority, to insure that development occurs in a rights-protective context. Advocacy campaigns and other actions target project funders (banks, multinational corporations, and shareholders) and developers (multinational and national corporations) and generate political pressure at a variety of local, national, and international levels. Their intent is to persuade state governments to sanction, censor, or use their relative political leverage to negotiate more equitable terms and conditions for local communities (i.e., to redress abuses, renegotiate terms with project developers to minimize social and environmental impacts, deny project funding proposals, or halt project funding).

On the one hand, success for human and environmental rights activism directed toward the World Bank and other development funding institutions is achieved when project funders and developers acknowledge that problems exist, hold meetings to discuss them, and renegotiate terms in an effort to redress or minimize them (as evidenced by the Society for Applied Anthropology Public Policy consultative meeting with World Bank officials). These actions generated pressure on the bank and prompted action to improve accountability (as evidenced by their internal human rights investigation) and external transparency (as evidenced by the social and environmental audits). On the other hand, as anthropologist Laura Nader reminds us, reliance on problem solving through negotiation is particularly vulnerable to failure because "in the arena of international power-brokers, the purpose of negotiation may not be problem solving, but control" (1995: 61).

Thus, while the World Bank and the IFC have by some measures improved transparency (posting, e.g., proposed social and environmental policy changes on a web site for public comment) as of this writing, there has not been a significant compensatory response to the problems created by funding the poorly planned Pangue Dam. Nor have internal human rights complaints procedures been established within the bank. No bank-

wide human rights policies have been adopted. The IFC still argues that public participation and transparency mechanisms required in other bank assessment, planning, and decision-making structures are recommended policy and not requirements that apply to it. And rights-protective operational directives for projects involving indigenous peoples and involuntary resettlement were reworked in 1998. The current draft of the World Bank's social and environmental procedures frames the previous directives as "policies" employed when appropriate (not mandated in all instances) and with a compensatory commitment to restore damaged conditions rather than the previous commitment to restore and improve the quality of life of affected peoples.

In short, this case also illustrates some of the limitations of advocacy aimed at influencing policy. Policies are not legally binding obligations. Policies are guidelines employed within a political context in which interests are recognized, evaluated, and prioritized. Negotiating rights in an increasingly privatized world means that obligations to clients and shareholders supersede, or even render irrelevant, rights-protective social and environmental policies. Protecting business interests means restricting public access to plans, project development data, and the day to day operations of the resulting enterprise. Multinational corporations are not signatories to international treaties and conventions, and, while they do have the obligation to comply with the laws of the countries where they do business, it is that state's responsibility to ensure compliance. Monitoring and enforcement of state laws in a private, multilateral development process is particularly difficult given the peripheral location of many development projects, the lack of funds that would allow regular and intensive scrutiny, and the peripheral or nonexistent role of the state in negotiations between private corporations and multilateral financing institutions. Culpability for ensuing social and environmental crises is difficult to assign, and, given the availability of private investment capital, when the state or multilateral funders attempt to apply leverage and renegotiate agreements or actions private corporations can simply refinance their loans. When projects are completely funded with private capital (investment banks, hedge funds, and so forth), contractual relationships between the private funder and the corporation are confined to a specific set of obligations. While developers have the legal duty to meet the terms of those contracted obligations, they are very rarely obligated to ensure that goals are actually met.

The Pehuenche case represents a significant wake-up call for

anthropologists whose work involves peoples in the path of economic development. Increasingly, international development projects are being funded through private-public partnerships such as that of the IFC and ENDESA. When compliance with human and environmental rights-protective mandates is linked to loan negotiations, agreements between funders and developers over "sensitive issues" are crafted in closed-door settings where deals can be made without the involvement or even the awareness of affected people. The ability of these negotiated solutions to actually achieve their intended goals can be compromised by the lack of public involvement and authority (i.e., the rights of and opportunities for governments, interest-specific groups, and affected peoples to define problems and design and implement response strategies). The privatization of development reorders the priority of "significant concerns" and reduces or eliminates accountability mechanisms, including the use of rights-protective policies. As development activity is increasingly privatized, the culpability gap will widen considerably. It is my expectation that with globalization and the privatization of development activities we will see more and more cases of rights-abusive troubles.

Conclusion

The struggle to analyze, mediate, and substantively transform the conditions that produce and reproduce the "trouble" described here represents anthropological responses to dysfunctional governance. Through formal and informal political means, those engaged in the "anthropology of trouble" seek transformations in local, national, and international decision-making systems that: (1) allow people living with the problem to gain greater control in defining the nature of the crisis, devising equitable responses, and prohibiting its recurrence; and (2) encourage the institutions and organizations that played a significant role in creating the problem to acknowledge their culpability and (through their efforts to respond) carry a greater share of the burden in resolving it.

Life-threatening situations prompt people to act, organize, and transform the conditions of their lives. The common experience and urgent need to respond blurs previous lines of cleavage, and the cultural notions and historical relationships that divide groups in society are temporarily pushed aside as people struggle to survive a common threat.

New leaders emerge, new networks and coalitions are formed, and community identity is reshaped. Given that many human environmental crises emerge from situations in which local people are excluded from the decision-making process, efforts to transform decisions or conditions often hinge on information flows and communications tools. The anthropological response to urgent and life-threatening troubles typically involves facilitating the flow of critical information—using skills, experiences, and resources to document conditions, analyze inequities, assess culpability, and suggest reconstructive actions.

One consequence of this problem-focused, advocacy-oriented anthropology has been a growing involvement with systems of power and the painful awareness that critical analysis, advocacy, and action carry substantial personal and professional risk. As anthropologists increasingly embrace the scholarly advocacy approach called for by Rappaport and immerse themselves in the "anthropology of trouble," some find success a painful or dangerous experience, as those who benefit from the status quo often lash out against those who document abusive conditions and the processes through which they emerged. Efforts that threaten the status quo inevitably stimulate a backlash. Others find themselves entangled in their engagements, struggling to understand the nuances of power, and overwhelmed by relative power relations. They may be marginalized or dismissed by policymakers as subjective and nonscientific, as lobbyists for a special interest group or agenda. For many anthropologists, having policymakers listen to their findings, agree, and make effective and meaningful changes on the level experienced by Rappaport is an experience all too rare. It is their social relationships, obligations, commitments, and the periodic small victories that sustain continued involvement in the "anthropology of trouble."

As a case of disciplinary praxis in the anthropology of trouble, the Pehuenche case illustrates what may well be the usual experience of struggle rather than the unusual experience of overwhelming success. The Pehuenche case illustrates how anthropologists and others attempted to secure an acknowledgment from the World Bank that mistakes were made, to reaffirm the bank's responsibility to act as an institution in the interests of the public (creating a human rights policy and complaints and postproject review procedures within the bank and extending rights-protective operational directives and procedures to include all actions funded by the IFC), and to stimulate meaningful contemporary actions to redress the environmental degradation and human

rights abuses that resulted from initial failures of the IFC and the bank to follow their own rules.

In highlighting fundamental flaws in the methods and procedures used to define and evaluate potential social impacts, and in documenting the social, economic, and environmental consequences of these flaws, Theodore Downing demonstrated to the IFC and ENDESA that their assessment procedures, decision-making structures, and mitigation measures had failed to achieve an adequate assessment and mitigation of the social impacts of hydrodevelopment on the Biobó River. Timing, the content of his contribution, and certainly the broader politics of this engagement (with plans for a second dam at a crucial point in the Chilean decision-making process), all influenced the IFC's decision to make sure that people could not listen to what Downing had to say. Downing continued his advocacy efforts despite the threat of a lawsuit and professional blacklisting. Small victories sustained his continued involvement, and, while the Pehuenche situation remains contentious, some measure of success may be found in his efforts to encourage professional organizational advocacy. Disciplinary engagement required the use (or formation) of structural mechanisms to assess, advocate, and attempt to influence policy and action, and this effort will hopefully strengthen the discipline's ability to act in other cases and other places.

Endnote

I wish to conclude this essay on a personal note. When I began my efforts to draft an essay for the Rappaport festschrift, I had just returned from an anthropology conference where I had been a panelist in a political ecology session. During the discussion period, one member of the audience offered the comment that anthropology needs to move away from the staid approaches of our intellectual ancestors, such as Roy Rappaport, and move toward an anthropology of advocacy, activism, and action. I was taken aback to hear Rappaport's work cast in such apolitical, passive terms.

In my experience, Rappaport's writing, disciplinary praxis, and efforts to structure and shape human environmental policy illustrate a true commitment to anthropological praxis that influences policy and action. I used his essay "Human Environment and the Notion of Impact" as a starting point because it suggests more than conceptual analysis; it is a product of his advocacy. His work demonstrated huge gaps in environ-

mental decision-making systems, and his analysis suggested that adequately addressing social concerns within them requires understanding and coming to terms with culture, values, beliefs, and the qualitative as well as quantitative aspects of a material and immaterial reality that is rarely confined to the assigned boundaries of time and space. The implications of these observations are profound. His advocacy supported the substantive transformation of national policy and resulted in a ban on oil drilling off the shores of the continental United States. The implications of his success are to be celebrated and savored, as they represent the power and potential of an anthropology of trouble.

NOTES

The Center for Political Ecology is located at the University of California, Santa Cruz, and publishes the journal *Capitalism, Nature, Socialism.* Comments and criticisms can be sent to <bjohnston@igc.org> or the Center for Political Ecology, P.O. Box 8467, Santa Cruz, California 95061. Some of the ideas in this essay were developed from earlier works, and portions have appeared in Johnston 1997 and Johnston and Turner 1998.

1. My familiarity with this case is based on research conducted as part of the American Anthropological Association's Committee for Human Rights (CfHR) investigation and report on human rights abuse associated with World Bank funding of a hydroelectric dam development on the Biobío River (Johnston and Turner 1998) and supporting personal communications, documents, and other materials provided by Ted Downing. Ethnographic information is derived from Downing 1996.

2. Downing based this estimate on the value of timber on Pehuenche lands cut and sold in connection with the construction of the Pangue Dam. Deforestation in the Pangue Dam region (and thus, profits by Pangue S.A. and ENDESA) and deforestation in the broader area occurred because roads were built and independent timber harvesters were attracted to the area. These operators typically gave Pehuenche land owners small sums of money, harvested their trees and left, leaving the Pehuenche landowner unwittingly responsible for the violation of Chilean forestry laws which require permits and reforestation) (Downing 1996: 67).

3. In testimony to the CfHR (November 22, 1997) Downing described legal actions threatened by IFC as including loss of any future consulting work with the IFC or World Bank Group, suits for damages that would result in the loss of all current (including his home) and future assets (including future employment income, pensions, and social security).

4. September 1999, personal communication from Ted Downing. See also his commentary on human rights concerns associated with the Cameroon pipeline

project in Bakola Pygmy/Chad-Cameroon pipeline posted at <www.azstarnet .com/~downing/bakola.html> (Oct. 1999).

5. For continued coverage of the Pehuenche and the hydroelectric dam development controversy, see the Consejo Inter-regional Mapuche (Mapuche Interregional Council) web site (http://www.bounce.t/cim); the International Rivers Network web site (http://www.irn.org), and the Rehue Foundation, Netherlands, web site covering Mapuche and Pehuenche issues in the Alto Biobío (http://www.xs4all.nl/~rehue).

6. It is important to emphasize that, while the IFC is a member of the World Bank Group, it sees its primary responsibility as defined by the contractual relationship with its private sector client and has interpreted the human and environmental aspects of World Bank operational directives as policy rather than operational mandate. Thus, even if the IFC did recognize the Pehuenche as indigenous, there is some doubt as to whether all aspects of the directive would have been utilized, especially those conditions requiring transparency and public participation which have the potential to conflict with their private partners interest in making a profit. Furthermore, even when World Bank operational directives are employed, their ability to protect the rights of indigenous peoples has in many cases been seriously compromised by the political economic interests driving project development. Information on World Bank policies and procedures is derived from personal communications and discussions with Thayer Scudder, Robert Hitchcock, Ted Downing, and Suzanne Hanchette; from documents and meetings with IFC and other World Bank representatives as part of the CfHR investigation into human rights abuses; and from published sources, including Cernea and Guggenheim 1994/1996, Cernea 1995, and Cernea 1988.

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Teens and Troubles in the New World Order

Fran Markowitz

> We have identified here a common form of disorder: the subordination of the fundamental and ultimate to the contingent and instrumental.
>
> —R. A. Rappaport, "Disorders of Our Own"

During my 1995–96 fieldwork in Russia, I was pleasantly surprised to find teenagers calmly optimistic about their country and their personal futures. This optimism, expressed in the hope that "all will be peaceful, all will be fine" (vsyo budet spokoino, vsyo budet khorosho), seemed to fly in the face of Russia's still contentious political arena and shaky economy as well as the frequent complaints heard on the street that things have not changed for the better since the *raspad* (disintegration [of the USSR]). Further, the teenagers' optimistic predictions about life in the twenty-first century came as an unanticipated conclusion to autobiographical narratives of tedious, unchanging lives rather than dynamic tales of growth from Soviet children to teenagers in the Russian Federation (cf. Blos 1962; Elkind 1967).[1]

Upon closer examination, what seem like inconsistencies between Russian teenagers' dire reflections and optimistic projections are the logical outcomes of a folk ecological understanding of how and why their country got into trouble in the first place. As a riddle popular in the 1980s expressed it:

Q: How do we know for sure that Marxism-Leninism is not a science?
A: Because scientists would have tried it out on monkeys first.

The unnatural experiment in communism that was foisted untested upon millions of innocent people accounts for Russia's present disorders and begs to be remedied.

Teenagers in the mid-1990s, like many in the adult generations, described Russia as a naturally huge, wealthy landmass filled with priceless physical and human resources. They attributed the problems their country confronts to the Bolshevik Revolution, which artificially diverted Russia off its "natural" course. Russia in 1905, they told me, was already on the way to a form of democratic capitalism uniquely suited to the nation's particular needs. The imposition of a nonindigenous political system and then seventy years of communist dictates upset this natural progress. Now Russia needs time to recover from the damage in order to return to its original, bounteous state.

The irony here, of course, is that almost a century earlier Lenin and his followers had devoted themselves to the justified liberation of the same rich territory from the unjust grasp of its greedy, exploitative ruling elite. The Communists' goal in 1905 and thereafter was to redirect Russia's development so that all persons and peoples could thrive via a revolutionary social program of progress and justice. But the disclosures of glasnost and the economic events of the 1990s revealed that seventy years after the revolution communism had failed miserably in achieving its original goals. Rather than empowering the people, the Soviet state-party merger used campaigns of terror to produce compliance, and instead of equality an exclusionary hierarchy of powerful and powerless had become entrenched. Following the "tanks for butter" policy of its command economy, government planners had run roughshod over lakes, rivers, mountains, and plains, causing ecological devastation and ignoring popular desires for adequate consumer goods. In the 1990s, the Russian Federation's economy was far from stable, and citizens' earlier shock at empty store shelves and rationing coupons had been followed by an equally shocking profusion of food, clothing, and electronic goods priced beyond their means. Politicians promised *stabilizatsiia* (stabilization), but inflation rates and prices fluctuated every day, and New Russian capitalists employed get-rich-quick importation schemes to stock shops while ignoring the mandate for a slower but surer resurrection of Russia's industries.

As they narrated their autobiographies, intertwining progression through school with discussions of "new for us" goods and media, it became clear that, although Russian children grew up bombarded by a

rhetoric of change, they experienced these so-called changes more as a knobby fabric of constancy than as a series of events with concrete results. "Change" in their lifetimes had become the unchanging status quo. Because they felt these loudly proclaimed transformations as ambiguous flux, Russian teenagers have become wary of ideological definitions, distrustful of politicians, and skeptical of ready solutions to the troubles that were brought about by political, unnatural forces in the first place.

Nonetheless, they are neither alienated nor pessimistic. As Russia reemerged from the Soviet Union, several cultural analysts indicated that Russian youth simply wished to withdraw from the chaotic real world into the *kaif* (fun) of musical happenings and alternative social realities (Cushman 1995; Easton 1989; Pilkington 1994; Rabodzeenko 1998; Traver 1989). By the time I came to Russia in 1995, however, sixteen year olds were pondering the problems of their country and thinking about ways to right the wrongs of the past while taking steps to plan their future. They resembled the perestroika-*raspad* era cohort in their profound repugnance at the artificiality created by Communist politicians and the damage done by its planners to Russia's physical and human environments. As a result, they are convinced that to achieve the peaceful future that they envision post-Soviet Russia must be left undisturbed in flux to readjust priorities, shape an authentic culture, find equilibrium, and thereby reclaim its rightful place in the new world order. And for this to happen young people advocate abandonment of empty group rituals and the spuriousness of politics.

This essay is an analytical description of how Russia's teenagers arrived at the ecological solutions they propose for dealing with and resolving the troubles in their country. In the first part, it explores the ways in which, as growing children, they experienced life in the Soviet Union (and during its downfall) and then developed an understanding of their country's problems and prospects through the knowledge gained from these experiences. The second part presents teenagers' discussions of their disgust with politicians and the gratuitous solutions they propose to Russians problems. These discussions are set against an overview of social-psychological theories of adolescent development in order to grasp the particular character of post-Soviet teenagers' apolitical positions. Finally, young people's antipolitics is presented as the practical side of an emergent knowledge scheme that inverts and reworks the notion of "progress," a key symbol of communism, to champion a "natu-

ral" or ecological course for solving Russia's internal problems while also strengthening its shaky position in the global community.

Coming of Age in the Soviet Union

Russia's teenagers in the mid-1990s had been born in and spent their childhoods as wards of the Soviet state. Some began attending state nurseries and kindergartens as early as six months of age, although most embarked on this collectivist life course at age three (Bronfenbrenner 1972). Their first major transition occurred when they entered school as seven year olds, and the fun and games of earlier years turned into formal education. In first grade, they learned the fundamentals of arithmetic, were taught to read and write in Russian, and were introduced to the life and works of Lenin and the events of the 1917 Revolution. Throughout their school years, they learned that the USSR was the most powerful, just, and forward-looking nation in the world.

Not one of the 123 sixteen year olds I interviewed had any doubts during primary school (grades 1–3) about the status of their nation or its collective aspirations. Nadya explains, "Oh yes, everything was very good! Everyone was striving toward building communism as soon as possible. We had these goals and hoped that as soon as possible we would be taken into the Octobrists, and then into Pioneers."

Just as the state and party converged in the USSR's government, communist children's organizations merged with the education program in the schools. During second grade, all pupils were urged to earn good grades and behave well in order to merit inclusion in the Octobrists. Sometime during the year, to reinforce the knowledge that they were absorbing, second graders were ceremoniously presented with emblematic badges and dubbed the "grandchildren of Lenin." A year or two later, when they were deemed responsible enough, they then took the oath and ritualistically received the coveted red tie that marked them as Pioneers, the "constructors of communism."

In most schools throughout the former USSR, all the children in a class became Octobrists together at the same time, but each child was judged individually before entering the Pioneers. The homeroom teacher, sometimes with, sometimes without, the assistance of an advisory board, selected pupils with the highest grades and the best, most conforming behavior for the first round of inductions. Dubbed the *otlichniki* (excellent ones), their ceremonies were the most elaborate

and impressive and were often held in museums away from the humdrum school territory. Aleksei from Moscow and Kira from St. Petersburg describe these events:

> *Aleksei:* We were taken to the Museum of Weaponry. And in this museum, there's a hall on the second floor. We had to recite some verses, which I don't remember now at all. We had learned them. Then we walked around the hall, and then we went to Red Square and to Lenin's Tomb. See, about Pioneers, we all wanted to be accepted. Because from first grade they were always telling us about Lenin, Lenin. How Lenin made the Revolution, how all of this started with him, and how we must carry it on.
>
> *Kira:* They inducted us into the Pioneers in the Lenin Museum. It was all so festively solemn. "Always be prepared!" "On with Lenin's struggle!" We recited the oath together. It was really wonderful. There was such pride!

A few months later, the rest of the class would be brought into the Pioneers with a similar, but smaller scale ritual. Sometimes there were three or four rounds, and pupils with the worst grades and rowdiest behavior were hesitantly accepted at the end.

Along with the satisfaction that came from linking oneself to a nationwide network of children and a universal vision of progress, the initiation ceremony transmitted yet another, albeit negative, message: behave! The selection process for the Pioneers was the first time that children experienced the consequences of nonconforming behavior on a large scale. Now not only would certain actions elicit warnings and public shaming from the teacher but these could also result in exclusion from membership in the one and only organization that conferred honor and identity to children. Rejection from the Pioneers was tantamount to rejection from collectivist life. Everyone wanted to be accepted, and they rejoiced in the pride that accompanied their initiation. Of all the teenagers I met during 1995–96, only one, a diffident boy from a workers' family, had not "made it" into the Pioneers.

Acceptance into the Pioneers was the significant rite of passage that turned little, naive children into responsible, future citizens of the Soviet Union. The induction ceremony, in which youngsters collectively recited an oath, gave a salute, and received the red tie that then became part of

their daily school uniform, publicly conferred upon them a new persona. The ritual's structure, messages, and results were designed to fuse the canons of communism with the personal identity and goals of each its participants (cf. Rappaport 1979: 192–94).

In further confirmation of the ritual's messages, Soviet children were reminded with each school accomplishment that they had come one step closer to the "bright future" of communism. Elementary school pupils had every reason to internalize these messages, especially those that focused on progress and how the USSR, through its scientific advances, was contributing to the betterment of all humanity. Each child received encouragement and praise for making the grade in mathematics, chemistry, and physics. Lyonya recalled that in his school the names of the best students were posted on a rocket to show one and all that they were advancing onward and upward along with their country.[2] Youngsters' personal achievements, their mastery of science and control of nature, were linked to, indeed necessary for, the achievement of communism's collective goals.

Although in the late 1980s the Soviet Union was in the throes of perestroika and glasnost, most of the teenagers recalled that these policies had very little if any impact on their schools. As elementary school pupils, they were impervious to the undercurrent of discontent that flowed across the Soviet Union in the form of anecdotes and popular riddles (cf. Yurchak 1997). In the invariance of its induction ritual, the red tie, and daily recitations of the oath, the Pioneers organization was "not only enunciated, accepted, invested with morality and naturalized, but also sanctified" (Rappaport 1979: 211). This nationwide youth group, like the Communist Party and other pieces of the Soviet state apparatus, appeared as a given, time-honored certainty. These children had become part of it, linked to Lenin, just as their parents and grandparents had been decades ago.

Yet, after discussing the anticipation that surrounded their induction and describing the pageantry of the ceremony, the teenagers had little to say about the workings of the Pioneers or their participation in its activities. Upon reaching the narrative climax of ritual transformation into constructors of communism, their stories descended into a bitter assessment of its results. They portrayed the ceremony as brief and illusory and their so-called transition as disconnected from the established conventions of everyday life. The idealistic revolutionary messages of the ritual confronted and conflicted with the practices mandated in its aftermath.

Instead of the social project that they had promised to carry forth, the schoolchildren experienced being Pioneers as a disciplinary regime of dress codes and daily lineups. Not long after the ceremony, most came to feel as Oksana describes it, that the Pioneers amounted to little more than "the [empty] ritual of ironing my tie every day—and the name."

The teenagers' experiences of becoming Pioneers challenges Rappaport's (1979: 193) contention that people "are often free not to participate in rituals if they do not care to . . . [for] participation always rests in some degree upon choice." Of course, Rappaport was writing of adults, who in every society are able to exercise at least some agency in the course of daily life. Children, who are dependent on parents and state (or other adult) institutions, are much more limited in their options. "When did you become a Pioneer?" I asked as I began talking with teenagers about their life experiences. Invariably their answers began, "We were taken into Pioneers in the third grade." As I mulled over their replies in the plural and the passive voice to the active mode question I had posed in the singular, I realized that the teenagers were telling me that becoming a Pioneer was a passive and collective process. In reviewing this period of their lives, the teenagers scornfully assessed their induction as an ultimately meaningless process, for "everyone became a Pioneer in the end anyway."

Somewhere along the line a rupture had occurred between the ritual's messages and their intended results. In Rappaport's (1979: 127) terms, the information transmitted in the ceremony failed to ramify meaningfully in individuals' lives. Yet by going through the rituals they confirmed the certainty of state-party institutions. Everyone was reminded again and again that the Pioneers, the Komsomol (the youth wing of the Communist Party), the Communist Party, and the Soviet state were eternal institutions that could never falter. What could, and did, disappear was sanctity, as the lofty goals of Lenin's social project were everywhere translated into conformity, obedience, and *chusto stada,* the "herd mentality."

During the late 1980s, although they had no choice but to become Pioneers, Oksana and many others chose not to participate in afterschool hobby groups in Pioneer palaces. At first, I found these reports very puzzling because virtually every Soviet and Western book about education in the USSR lauded the Pioneers for providing stimulating activities, under the guidance of committed and talented group leaders,

to masses of young people (see Kon 1975; Makhov 1982; Morton 1972; and Weaver 1981). The teens helped me to decode this contradiction by explaining that they always looked forward to returning home at the end of the day. There they would be free of the "collective," their school uniform, and the red tie. They would have something to eat, get together with a friend or two, do their homework, talk to their parents and grandparents, watch the news on television, and go to sleep.

But at the same time as they rejected participation in after-school Pioneers projects, kids-as-Pioneers continued to go through the rote movements of ironing and displaying their red ties, taking part in daily lineups, and singing patriotic songs. Like their parents, they had learned to act the part of communist collectivists while doubting the authenticity of their actions as well as the messages encoded in them. They recalled in 1995–96 that this contradiction did not strike them as odd at the time; it was simply a fact of life with which they and all other Soviet schoolchildren had to contend.

The identificational messages that Pioneers rituals were intended to inspire were too far removed from the practices of daily life to be taken seriously, and so the children—and, so it seems, more often than not their teachers—ignored them (see Yurchak 1997). This decoupling of ideal and practice was further strengthened by the then preteens' increasing interest in the new music, consumer items, literature, and films that were entering Soviet Russia as glasnost changed from a new reform program to the state's underlying policy. Often reinforced by their parents' well-developed split between public and private life (Shlapentokh 1989) and its transmission along with other values from the parental generation to the children's (Rabodzeenko 1998: 440), the Pioneers ceased to have symbolic or identificational meaning for these children several months, if not years, before the organization was disbanded. In fact, many of the teenagers stressed that when they returned to school in September 1991 without their school uniforms and Pioneer ties they had hardly noticed the difference: "A school's a school, a place of knowledge. So it was, so it is, so it will be." By contrast, others derided the old days, when they had been part of a "herd" and looked like "we had all been hatched in the same incubator."

Out on the streets, away from the protected environment of the school, things *were* changing, and the teenagers as school kids were at least somewhat aware of them. They noticed ebbs and flows in the length

of lines outside shops and alterations in the urban landscape as petty traders erected *palatki* (tents) to peddle their wares and colorful billboards appeared, breaking the gray gloom of winter. They witnessed a startling growth in the amount and assortment of goods in stores, heard new kinds of music on the radio and in the streets, and enjoyed a wide assortment of foreign and domestic films at theaters and on television. Some paid attention first to the attempted 1991 coup against Mikhail S. Gorbachev and then to the creation of a new, post-Communist government. Unlike their own (false) change from naive little children into Pioneers, the Soviet Union's transformation into fifteen new states was not accompanied by grandiose ritual. Quite the contrary. Nonetheless, teenagers also discuss this transmutation with ambivalence, uncertainty, and caution.

With just about every positive statement comes a negative qualifier, and with almost every negative the teenagers back up and present a positive contradiction. While stressing the benefits that accompanied abandonment of communism's centrally planned command economy, the teenagers also note that the pleasures of the free market are offset by an unwelcome rise in crime and corruption and a growing gap between rich and poor. They point to the creation of new social groups, with the BOMZhy, or homeless underclass, at one extreme and the economic elite of New Russian (after Smith 1990) and/or mafia businessmen at the other. Many young people echo the laments of their elders in mourning the passing of what they remember as a communal spirit, a concern with the *narod* (nation, people), and a general sense of helpfulness. They attribute the recent and despised current of greed to new government measures that were implemented too rapidly, too disjointedly, and without enough compassion or thought. Such complaints about a program gone awry parallel their narratives about the failure of communism in their transition into Pioneers.

Yet, unlike the older generations, not one teenager expressed a desire to return to communism, nor is anyone eager to embrace a fascist solution that would restore order to the land. They are using the flux of the present to be left alone to enjoy the pleasures of youth, to relax to the beat of their musical tastes, to prepare for university entrance exams, to dream about travel beyond Russia's borders, and to gather with friends. The last thing they want is to be manipulated by politics, to put their faith in programs that have no chance of success, or to participate in more rituals that lead nowhere but to disillusionment.

Adolescence and Politics

In the latter part of the twentieth century, social analysts have reported mixed findings on adolescents' political orientations. Several American and British observers have noted that teenagers everywhere tend to be cynical about politics and politicians (Furlong and Cartmel 1997) if not apathetic (Torney-Purta 1990). At midcentury, however, others—most notably Erik Erikson (1963, 1968)—delineated the teen years as the age of identity, during which time the desire to resolve ambiguity is central. Pointing to examples from recent history, including the spectacular rise of the Komsomol in the early years of the USSR, the almost mystical attraction of the Hitler Youth for German teenagers during the interwar period, and the power of China's youthful Red Guard, Erikson buttressed his contention that adolescents seek absolute and often radical answers to life's major questions as they solidify their identities. Richard Braumgart (1975: 255) emphasized practice over ideology, claiming that, "It is during the socialization period, somewhere between adolescence and early adulthood, that youth are drawn into radical social movements" (see also Esman 1990). These ideas, along with a prevalent "youth as a social problem" discourse (see especially Riordan, Williams, and Ilynsky 1995; and Kon 1975 for an earlier Soviet version) and horrific examples of ethnic violence in nearby Eastern Europe, prepared observers of Russia for a right-wing backlash, particularly among the youth (see Dunlop 1993: 279). Reviewing their country's history from the vantage point of the disorderly present has led many Russians, old and young alike, to an idealized image of prerevolutionary Russia. While teenagers usually emphasized nascent strands of democracy and capitalist development when they described the early years of the twentieth century, other, older Russians—from the creators of Pamyat, a stridently nationalist, overtly anti-Semitic organization, to several prominent intellectuals in the Russian Writers' Union and even in the Institute of Anthropology and Ethnology—tended to attribute Russia's problems to the excessive influence of non-Slavic peoples and their foreign political programs (e.g., communism), which were not suited to the particular character or ecology of the country (see Kozlov 1995 for the most cogent expression of this view).[3] These views have found political expression in the slogan of Vladimir Zhirinovsky's right-wing Liberal Democratic Party (LDPR), "Russia for the Russians" (*rossiya dlia russkikh*). The emotional pull of Slavic nationalism resulted in the LDPR winning the

largest bloc of votes in the Duma (lower house of Parliament) elections of 1993 and second place to the Communist Party in 1995.

Of all the teenagers I interviewed and the several dozen more with whom I had informal conversations, only one expressed an affinity for the LDPR. Most spoke of Zhirinovsky, his dictatorial manner, and his platform of ethnic exclusiveness and posturings of hate with shame or outrage:

> *Sasha K.:* I might go to vote, but I don't know who to vote for. For Yeltsin, no. Not for Zhirinovsky either. His party, the way he made it, he's considered like a second Hitler. They took interviews with young people on television. Practically no young people are going to vote. Well, they don't believe in anyone because everything has fallen apart.

Sasha attributes post-Soviet disorder not to its multiethnic population but to the unscrupulous (Russian) politicians who first built an untenable system and then conspired to let it crumble, damaging millions of people and Russia's ecosystem in the process. Most of his agemates agree wholeheartedly. While professing disinterest in politics, it matters greatly to them that a militaristic hatemonger not lead Russia to repeat past mistakes.

> *Olesia:* I would definitely go to vote against Zhirinovsky. Because I don't want to live under a totalitarian regime. I couldn't handle someone else telling me what to do.
>
> *Maksim Ch.:* I'm not interested in politics. I don't know who I'd vote for, but I'd vote against Zhirinovsky. I don't really know his politics, but I relate negatively to him as a person. I saw him on TV, and even in his interviews he [physically] fought with others. And the way he talks about himself. He thinks he is so great. That's not someone I want in power. But generally I don't follow politics.

In contrast to the teens, for adult Russian citizens, especially the elderly, whose status in society and monthly pensions have crashed downward with the end of the old regime, a comparison of Russia's present with the Soviet past can result in nostalgia for communism. Disregarding or trivializing the repressions, the wars, the push for progress that spoiled so many

forests and waterways, and the prioritization of military needs over consumerism, they claim that a communist government would mean a return to greater equality, the reestablishment of basic social values, and a badly needed moral order, or homeostasis. Anticommunist adults and young people reply that under communism "equality" was merely a slogan and old age pensions provided a bare minimum of support. But since everyone got the same amount and that bare minimum was enough to buy the few consumer items the stores offered, no one seemed to mind—or could mind. It was only when Mercedes Benz automobiles hit the streets, apartments were privatized, up-to-date fashions filled the stores, and food products for every taste overflowed the markets that old people, and others whose economic status precluded enjoyment of these wares, protested that their government pensions or paychecks were not enough to live on (see Humphrey 1995; Ries 1997). In December 1995, for these among other reasons, Russia's voters gave to the Communist Party (KPRF) the largest plurality of Duma seats. Only one girl, Nadya, from among all the teenagers I met, expressed support for the KPRF. Tanya explains, "To tell you honestly, that majority that voted for the Communists, they were mainly grandmothers. Young people are not very active politically. Those of middle age spread out their votes, and those who mainly go to the elections are the elderly."

While Tanya may be right in her analysis of election results, neither she nor her peers is apathetic about who comes to power. Like their disparaging remarks about Zhirinovsky's right-wing LDPR, they had much to say about why they deplore and discredit the KPRF. In addition to its totalitarian tendencies, they point out that since the Communists did not deliver on their promises during the seventy years of the Soviet Union their party ought to be relegated to the past.

Anton: I'm against the Communists, that's for sure. Because I believe that this isn't the right political direction—it brings nothing. We already know this from experience. It's meaningless to elect them again.

Sergei: Certainly against the Communists, that's for sure. I've already seen what this has brought. We've seen what was here in 1917 when the Revolution took place and then what they did.

Yulia: I'd vote against the Communists—no doubt of that. Because to return to that old model that we already had seems to me ridiculous.

Just about all of Russia's teenagers are solidly opposed to the imposition of any ideologically based government on either the right or the left. While agreeing with their elders that Russia is in trouble, young people usually do not concur with them as to the source of these woes or which one of Russia's "traditions"—Slavophile, communist, democratic—can provide a way out (see Tolz 1998). Convinced that strident doctrines will only result in more disasters, teenagers oppose ritualistic cover-ups of everyday problems, hasty solutions to crises, and especially the ideologues who promulgate them.

But this opposition is just about imperceptible because it is not manifested in social movements or political activism. Indeed, after the summer of 1991, when droves of young people came to stand on the barricades with Boris Yeltsin and blocked the attempt of hard-line Communists to depose Mikhail Gorbachev and reimpose the old regime, Russia's youth virtually disappeared from their country's political scene. Instead, they have turned inward toward personal goals and explorations, relationships, and hobbies, rejecting all the slogans and collective action that, as they see it, got their country into trouble in the first place. Natasha offers an explanation:

> I don't believe that anyone is speaking the truth. First one, and then the other, and they all say that everything will be fine (*vsyo budet khorosho*). Everything will be fine—and everything goes into their own pockets! They all talk about their love for the *narod.* Yeltsin talked about how much he loved the people. "We're all for Yeltsin!" Perestroika under Gorbachev, "Perestroika! Perestroika!" And instead of rebuilding, we got—unraveling!

As noted previously, this avoidance of politics by Russia's young people and their repugnance at Manichaean ideologies, contradicts most social-psychological analyses of teenagers' cognitive development. Many prominent theorists point to a shift that occurs "during the adolescent years, from a lack of political thought to, in many cases, an intense involvement in this area of life" (Coleman and Hendry 1990: 41). Braumgart and Braumgart's (1990) cross-cultural sample, while indicating that teenagers in the 1980s and 1990s are not attracted to change-oriented politics with the same fervor as earlier in the century, does show that youthful participation in political causes has not decreased since the

1960s. Certainly the *intifada* staged by Palestinian youths and the student demonstrations in Beijing's Tienanmen Square are the most dramatic recent examples of political involvement. Even North America's supposedly apathetic "Generation X" gets involved in environmental movements and demonstrations against nuclear power. What, then, accounts for the retreat of Russian youth from the political scene?

As their own narratives show, movement through group rituals that failed to produce what they promised followed by the public downfall of a massive, ideologically based governmental system caused Russian youth to retreat from the political scene. Raised within a rhetoric of change that promised more social benefits and personal satisfaction with each policy shift and governmental reorganization—from Gorbachev's first announcement of perestroika in 1985 to the many incarnations of Yeltsin's presidency—young people, along with their parents and grandparents, anticipated changes for the better. But as each year passed a kind of ambiguous, directionless flux became the status quo. This contradiction quickly became part of public knowledge and shaped lived-in experiences. In Olga's words: "I wouldn't go vote. Because it seems to me useless. I have this feeling that everything is already figured out, just like that. It's just that there are all these elections and elections, and things change and nothing changes."

Others of Olga's agemates were less prone to lament this state of affairs and just noted matter of factly that *nestabil'nost,* or "instability," has been the hallmark of these times. To paraphrase Kroeber (1963: 212), they are disillusioned with government and resigned to what they perceive to be a kind of social staleness or cultural fatigue. They express weariness at seeing "old wine poured into new bottles" but do not anticipate a dramatic change for the better and oppose the superficial solutions that they perceive will bring about changes for the worse.

A second, related reason for teenagers' eschewal of political participation is their monumental suspicion of group actions, especially those that are ideologically inspired. Referring to their experiences in the Pioneers, they expressed disgust for the ritualized behavior that mandated being "one of the herd," led about by distant leaders who cared not a whit for their well-being. Rappaport (1979: 142) sadly noted that "degradation of ritual, widespread in the contemporary world, is contributing significantly to social and environmental problems, as well as to failures of meaning." But what these Russian teenagers are saying is that

when rituals fail to respond to the material or moral order or to offer solutions to problems within it they must be reexamined, reconstituted, or discarded.

A short-lived euphoria accompanied the toppling of communist regimes throughout Russia and Eastern Europe (see, e.g., Hosking 1990; Taubman and Taubman 1989; and Zaslavskaya 1990), but soon after cynicism regarding politics and politicians returned. It is common knowledge that bribery in post-Soviet Russia remains rampant, skimming off the top is normal, and politicians who promise to improve the situation of the *narod* while campaigning for office usually disregard these promises once they are elected. Teenagers, like everyone else, know this and consider politics and politicians immoral. They think about this and talk about it a lot but feel powerless to influence the political agenda.

> *Veronika:* I don't really follow politics. I think it's dirty business. I have no respect for politics or politicians even for the president. I don't feel any respect.
>
> *Dmitry T.:* It's gotten to the point where it's impossible to believe in any of them. Not any of them is any good. All they do is promise.
>
> *Maksim A.:* I definitely would not go to vote. Everyone promises a lot and delivers nothing. It's all the same what will be. What must be will be.

Rather than organize yet another pointless demonstration and shout slogans that fall on heedless ears, Russian teenagers' method of protest is to sit on the sidelines, turn their backs, and withhold support from all phases of politics. With this strategy, they are not opting out of thinking about their country's political course but displaying opposition to political movements, which they believe are behind Russia's troubles.

Andy Furlong and Fred Cartmel's recent study of British youth (1997) resonates well with the situation I have described for Russian teens. They found that "Young people can express an interest in politics without being active in the formal institutions of party politics; they may be involved in political action while not voting or expressing a strong party affiliation, or may be knowledgeable about political issues while remaining cynical about their ability to influence the political agenda" (97). Russian and British teenagers' lack of political participation, which seems on the surface to be indifference, is not indifference at all; it is a rejection of the way that politicians pander to the people and a refusal to

play this game. Their behavior, though counter to prevalent theories about adolescents as active change agents and seekers of absolute answers to life's big questions, is consistent with the ways in which teenagers view their lives, the recent history of their countries, and the problems that individuals in mass society confront at the beginning of the twenty-first century. Russian teenagers are against any and all radical plans for their country; they want an even, steady, and authentic course that will safeguard the ideological and consumer-based freedoms they have obtained of late, and they dread the thought of a sharp shift in either direction. As children in the Soviet Union, they had no choice but to participate in the pomp and pageantry that were massive cover-ups for decay and deceit. As teenagers in the Russian Federation, they do have a choice, and they opt out of participation.

Antipolitics and Righting Disorder

Russian youths spent their childhood and adolescence in a nation in a constant state of nondirectional flux and are weary of hearing about great changes that ultimately lead nowhere. Instead, they look forward to *stabilizatsiia,* some sort of equilibrium, a predictable future with a working economy, a rational political system, no war, and no radical shifts. And most believe that this is a distinct possibility—if politicians refrain from injecting Russia with crazy, extremist schemes like shock therapy economics, communism, and nationalistic right-wing brands of totalitarianism. Positive change must be slow, steady, and natural. Fast changes are spurious; they disrupt, and disorder grows deeper, blocking all possible ways out.

In a 1994 article, Russian sociologist V. N. Shubkin found that young people are distrustful of the government's promises of economic and social aid. He explained this distrust as a result of their desire for "fast solutions inherited from Bolshevism." Although my findings regarding teens' skepticism at government assurances are similar to Shubkin's, my conclusions do not at all concur with his, for it is clear from their narratives that Russia's young people do not find credible, nor do they advocate, quick ideological solutions to deep structural problems. Their own words demonstrate that they have disengaged from the fast solutions of bolshevism and believe that these are the very artifices that led to their troubles. Wary of easy answers to difficult questions, Russian teenagers are cautiously optimistic that stability is on its way and

"*vsyo budet khorosho.*" But this scenario can only come about with time, as Russia returns to its own course, and the country's culture, social life, and economic and political systems work out their kinks.

For young people, "democratic Russia" means more than anything else the opportunity to turn inward and think of, enjoy, and improve themselves, to seek new experiences and openly discuss ideas that were precluded in the days of mandatory participation in the Octobrists and Pioneers. Liberated from school uniforms that included meaningless emblems and free from performing in rituals that did not deliver on their promises, young people experience democracy as relief. Their focus on exploration and self-reliance may turn out to be the best hope for Russia's "transition to democracy" as the country attempts to remedy its troubles. What seems like indifference to politics is not indifference at all ("It's not all the same to me"); teenagers' noninvolvement reflects precisely the path that they believe is most appropriate for Russia's stabilization and development. Reflecting Rappaport's (1994a) adage that "relief is one thing and correction is another," the last thing these young people wish is to put their faith in a fast and easy short-term remedy that results in perpetuating the old problems.

Russian teenagers do not want to change the world. It's already been changed, arguably for the worse, by the Communists in their drive for progress, and in the last decade of the twentieth century Russia's "democrats" have been experimenting with a wide variety of ways and means to set their country back on course. Young people simply want to live in this more colorful, more authentic world and make it a fait accompli. Rational, tentative, small-scale planning, rather than ideological movements that often produce disasters along with their catchy slogans, is the only way to avoid "subordination of the fundamental and ultimate to the contingent and instrumental" (Rappaport 1994a). By sitting on the sidelines and refusing to go along with any self-appointed strident leader, they assure themselves, and their country, of this course.

Communist "progress," teenagers tend to believe, brought about disorder through an economic system that disregarded the consumer, spoiled the environment, and took away the pleasures of the individual. Having experienced these results on their bodies and witnessed them in the landscape, Russia's young people have abandoned the beliefs, social rituals, and everyday behaviors that undergirded Soviet collectivist life and have refused to provide support for the rise of another totalistic ideology. But they are not floating unanchored in a "moral vacuum"

(Ilynsky 1995), nor are they stuck in a vortex of "social inertia" (Kon 1989). Instead, they are continuing with their schooling, trying out a range of styles, exploring different kinds of music and ways of being in the world. Cautiously optimistic, they tentatively plan for the future, hopeful that the naturally evolving tendency toward stabilization in post-communist, democratic Russia will give them and everyone else in the country the possibility to *zhit' spokoino, zhit' khorosho.*

NOTES

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1. Research conducted with American adolescents earlier in the century indicates that they are likely to tell "personal fables," exciting stories of transformation and transition.

2. By the same token, the names of *dvoishniki* (D students) were publicly displayed on the back of a turtle.

3. Viktor Kozlov is a senior ethnologist at the Russian Academy of Sciences' Institute of Anthropology and Ethnology.

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PART II

Ritual Structure and Religious Practice

The Life and Death of Ritual: Reflections on Some Ethnographic and Historical Phenomena in the Light of Roy Rappaport's Analysis of Ritual

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I. Introduction

Roy Rappaport makes claims about ritual that will exercise radical relativists and those impatient with claims about "universally shared" and "basic" sociocultural structures. These claims were presented in a preliminary version in his influential essay "The Obvious Aspects of Ritual" (1979) and then developed at length in his posthumous book *Ritual and Religion in the Making of Humanity* (1999).

I will, for my present purposes, outline his claims about the nature and significance of religious ritual without attempting to review his arguments and justifications for those claims. Rappaport asserts that ritual is *"the social act basic to humanity"* (Rappaport's italics) and that "no society is devoid of . . . ritual" (1999: 31). Ritual is recognizable through its *form,* which is to say that it is a clear-cut *genre* or *structure,* distinguishable to outside observers everywhere, as is, we might say, "song," or "humor." He is centrally concerned with the social implications of that generic form.

Ritual, he argues, is—indeed must be—"as old as language, which is to say precisely as old as humanity itself" (1999: 16).[1] Human communities always and everywhere have had to develop ritual (and/or maintain it) because the implications of ritual form (irrespective of its highly

variable contents), the "logical entailments" of that form, are—or, at least, have been—essential to community life.

Rappaport begins with a terse definition of what he will take ritual to be: "the performance of more or less invariant sequences of formal acts and utterances not entirely encoded by the performers" (1999: 24). This definition, as he notes, encompasses much more than "religious ritual." He distinguishes religious rituals from other kinds of enactments to which this definition would point (such as drama) by taking note of contrasting features (e.g., religious rituals have participating *congregations,* dramas have passive *audiences*). He does not define religious ritual directly but delineates its nature through his discussion of its contrasts with nonreligious forms and, indirectly throughout the book, by means of his discussion of its various forms and entailments.[2]

Thus not all phenomena characterized by "more or less invariant sequences of formal acts and utterances not entirely encoded by the performers" are religious ritual, and conversely "not all religious acts are ritual" (1999: 25). But, given these qualifications, his strong claim is that "ritual is the ground from which religion [and concomitantly social order] grows" (26). This is because the performance of ritual "logically entails the establishment of convention, the sealing of social contract, the construction of . . . integrated social conventional order, the generation of theories of the occult, the evocation of numinous experience, the awareness of the divine, the grasp of the holy, and the construction of orders of meaning transcending the semantic" (27). The first twelve chapters of his book are devoted to the elaboration of these claims. This unique set of entailments is why ritual is a sort of elemental religious act, and, as well, "the social act basic to humanity," and why it is ubiquitous.

The implications of ritual enactments that Rappaport discusses are of two sorts—(relatively) *external,* at the sociocultural level, and (relatively) *internal,* affecting the "inner world" of the individual. The *external* sociocultural entailments include most centrally the "sealing of social contract" and the establishment of morality and convention. But aspects of ritual action often have "cognitive and affective as well as social consequences, producing a state of mind as well as society" (1999: 226). Participation in ritual has the potential to generate, he claims, an *experience* that provides a ground for a *belief* in the doctrines of the encompassing religious system—a vivid sense of eternity and immortality, a sense of the numinous and of deity (27), and a sense of the interrelated integra-

tion of all things in a mode of understanding that Rappaport—following William James and Gregory Bateson—calls a state of grace (382ff.).

Rappaport's enterprise, although it was stimulated by and illustrated with empirical materials (beginning with his analysis of the New Guinea Tsembagas' ritual cycle [1968]), uses ethnographic and historical materials primarily in illustration of various theoretical points. His book is essentially a coherent theoretical work, the logical working out of inferences about the "necessary," and thus "universal," implications of ritual forms in a critical interaction with other scholars' proposals. His arguments will be, for many readers, strongly plausible in illuminating their own intuitions and/or stimulating for productive disagreements. The test of the value and endurance of such general schemas is in their usefulness in tying together in some new and strong way miscellaneous observations in one or more arenas of investigation and in their heuristic force—the inquiries they generate, as well as in the generative provocativeness of their limitations and errors.[3] For complex and innovative proposals such as Rappaport's, this testing will take time.

I wish here to sketch some rather miscellaneous comparative and historical phenomena where I find Rappaport's claims illuminating or provocative. His analysis and assertions provoke such questions for comparative social analysis as—is ritual recognizable to outside observers and what does the "recognizability" imply; is the *prevalence* of ritual in a particular community and its relation to other religious phenomena sociologically interesting: what are the relations of ritual to the numinous in different kinds of communities; what are the conditions affecting the relations of ritual to belief; and, of particular interest in the contemporary world, what light do Rappaport's formal arguments throw on struggles to weaken or dispense with ritual.

II. Tahiti: The Recognition of Ritual and the Question of Its Prevalence in a Particular Community

The first Europeans who encountered Tahiti and its neighboring islands noted practices that they recognized immediately as religious and as rituals or rites. These were events usually conducted on massive stone platforms, "shrines," that were loci of dangerous and "more than natural"

power (*mana,* a kind of power distinguished from "ordinary" force in the Tahitian and Polynesian vocabulary), clearly bounded and isolated from ordinary space by various boundary markers, inhabited by powerful and dangerous anthropomorphic images of "gods," and sites of performance by specialized officiants. The performances of these officiants, recognizable as "priests," had a canonical, invariable form: "The slightest mistake or hesitation necessitated recommencement of the prayer or even abandonment of the whole ceremony. . . . Errors in prayer delivery were considered a 'mortal sin'" (Oliver 1974: 86). The language used by those priests was not ordinary conversational Tahitian: "Some accounts state that the language of prayer was esoteric, incomprehensible to all but the priests" (87).

These formal features of setting and procedure signaled, as Rappaport's schema predicts, that the procedure was of a different order than ordinary human undertaking. The setting, the hieratic language, the rigid formality and resistance to merely human improvisation, with their implication of messages transmitted, like the voice of God from the burning bush, from some transcendental and more than human place were the kinds of forms for generating the idea and experience of the sacred[4] that Rappaport delineated. The Polynesians, like everyone else, had apparently independently invented religious ritual or—probably more accurately—had maintained and developed it in the course of their innumerable voyages and migrations and long isolation in the Pacific.

Recognizable rituals existed and were associated with supernatural agencies, a familiar set of human purposes, bounded sacred and "magically" powerful arenas, and doctrines about gods and the afterlife. But how *extensive* was the use of such ritual? Rappaport's arguments about the communal functions of ritual, its contribution to the "construction of integrated conventional orders," give this question comparative relevance—does the prevalence of ritual and its implications for social (and personal) integration vary in socially significant ways in different kinds of communities?

At the time of the first European contacts (judging from the extensive reports of European voyagers) and during my own village studies, although there were extensive doctrines about the supernatural and in the pre-Christian days an extensive repertory of ritual practices (Oliver 1974: chap. 3), the *extent*[5] of religious and available ritual practice seemed to be quite limited in comparison with many other premodern places,[6] the difference being particularly striking to me retrospectively in comparison

with Bhaktapur, a Hindu city I subsequently studied in Nepal. Ritual and the sacred (in forms adapted from a missionary-introduced British "low-church" Protestantism, itself suspicious of ritual) were confined in large part to gestures in a few essential status-changing rites of passage and in weekly status-maintaining church services. The only enduring pre-Christian rite of passage, a penile "supercision" operation on adolescent boys, was done without any supernatural reference or ritual form at all.

In its marked contrast to the situation in the Kathmandu Valley city, communal life in the Tahitian village was organized in such a way that, on the one hand, the *need* for the social uses of ritual as portrayed by Rappaport was relatively modest and, on the other hand, the numinous and other uncanny implications of ritual were more disturbing than useful.

III. Tahiti: The Meanings of the Numinous

Whatever their very spare use of ritual might imply, Tahitian villagers frequently experienced, in spite of themselves, one of the important entailments of Rappaportian ritual—encounters with the numinous. But in the village it was certainly not an elevating, welcomed encounter—and its major locus was not ritual. People experienced the numinous as a particular kind of unpleasant and frightening feeling. They felt that their "heads were swelling," that they had gooseflesh, that the hair on their head was "standing up" (this piloerection was easily visible to others) and that they were in the presence of something strange. This set of feelings was verbally and categorically distinguished from "ordinary fear" generated or associated with familiar dangers such as sharks. It was usually experienced in isolated places in response to strange noises and sights. These were strange in that they were uncanny—they were experiences that seemed to dissolve the categories that make the classification of the everyday world possible (Levy 1973: 152ff.), and which signaled that one was at the edge of a radically different kind of world and in the presence of one of its denizens. Uncanny feelings arose in certain settings, encounters, and conditions of light—areas of wilderness outside of the village, sights of phosphorescent glimmerings, foggy periods when it was hard to see clearly, and while walking alone in the dark village path at night. People who were alone, who could not anchor themselves cognitively in interaction with another human, were particularly vulnerable. These feelings were interpreted as being the perception

(as a feeling of warmth is the perception of heat) of the presence of a sentient, motivated, probably malevolent (but frightening whether malevolent or not), vaguely humanlike denizen of another kind of world—in short, a ghost or spirit. Villagers were in the presence of "a numen," a (as the dictionary tells us) "divine or supernatural power or presence, especially as associated with a particular place or object." For Tahitian villagers the impulse was to get away from the place or object as quickly as possible. The forms generating such experiences clearly evoke the experience of the supernatural, but this is not the realm of the sacred.

Rappaport derives his idea of the "numinous" (attributes of or feelings generated by numens) from Rudolph Otto ([1923] 1950) and William James ([1902] 1990) where "numinous" has acquired a strangely (to Tahitians at least) positive tone, pointing to God[s] rather than spirits.[7] He quotes Otto's description of the numinous as "the emotion of a creature, submerged and overwhelmed by its own nothingness in contrast to that which is supreme above all creatures" (1999: 378), a phrasing clearly pointing to an exalted divine. Rappaport takes James's characterization of "religious experience" as also describing the experience of the numinous. This experience is variously characterized by James as solemn, serious, grave, tender, rapturous, and wonderful (1999: 376). Rappaport notes that in James's own examples these experiences are hardly as gentle as some of these terms imply. Making use of other comments of James, Rappaport writes that "those moved by religious experience do not merely submit to the divine. They 'abound in agreement' and embrace it. And they do not merely accept the order sanctified by the divine. They participate in it zealously, ardently and even joyously" (377). These numinous feelings and modes are qualities of the divine as they are grasped in immediate experience. Rappaport takes this kind of numinousness as being the essential "non-logical, affective component, [the] ineffable" (371) constituent of the holy. He argues that the numinous, while not confined to ritual, has ritual as its most usual locus (373). The experience of the numinous generated by ritual's form is essential to ritual's meaning and to its persistence throughout historical time. The numinous, he argues (1999: 508), is the experiential basis for belief, and without such belief, among at least some members of congregations, the ritual has the danger of losing its vitality and falling into desuetude.

But Otto has room for the kind of numinousness characteristic of Tahitian villages, which he significantly perceives as "primitive."

For Otto, there has been an evolution of the numinous: "'Numinous dread' . . . is the mark which really characterizes the so-called 'religion of primitive man,' there it appears as 'daemonic dread'. . . . This crudely naive and primordial emotional disturbance . . . [is] later overborne and ousted by more highly developed forms of the numinous emotion" ([1923] 1950: 15ff.).

In view of the larger field of numens, the euphoric numinous experience generated by ritual that points to the divine is a special case, both within a society or as more or less salient among different societies. It is the "perception" produced and shaped not by adventurous encounters of a certain sort at the edge of social and intellectual space but by special kinds of human procedures—rituals and presumably other religious and aesthetic enactments—and is thus, in large part, subject to human craft and control and set against the anxious numinous experience of the randomly encountered nondivine (or at least problematically divine) supernatural.[8] Ritual in this comparative sense helps transform the sense of the uncanny into awe, spirits into gods, the supernatural into the divine.

As Rappaport puts it (1999: 399): "Ritual is . . . the furnace within which the image of God is forged out of the gifts of language and the powers of human emotion." But other supernaturals are forged without the help of ritual, although rituals (such as exorcism) may be used to evoke and control them for human purposes and then (hopefully) to get rid of them. That is, ritual both controls the preexisting free-floating numinous and generates a relatively comfortable and socially useful transformation of it. In those historical and local conditions under which the free-floating numinous and its spirit-numens begin to disappear from the world—banished by electric street lights, clearing of the wilderness, and education (Levy, Mageo, and Howard 1996)—the numinous experience of ritual, now its privileged locus, operates in a transformed context where it presumably has new implications and tasks.

IV. Bhaktapur: The Extent and Work of the Religious Sphere

The question of the sociocultural implications of comparative differences in the extent of different communities' uses of ritual and religion became salient for me during a later study (1990) of a vastly different kind of community, that of Bhaktapur, a traditional and ancient Hindu

city of some forty thousand people in Nepal's Kathmandu Valley, whose civic life was, in stark contrast to the life of the Tahitian village, extensively and minutely organized by "religious" forms and enactments. The main religious forms relevant to the city as a whole (in contrast to its component elements such as families, castes and individuals) were frequent and often prolonged calendrically determined festivals. The significant elements and references of those festivals—all tied together, differentiated and defined through the festivals' actions—included the city's sacralized spatial divisions, its systematically differentiated pantheon of deities, units of the city's elaborate caste system, the solar and lunar calendars, and legends and esoteric doctrines explaining the connections among these elements. In Bhaktapur, the sacred was mobilized as a major force for the city's social, cultural, and psychological organization (Levy 1990, 1997). I have argued that the large size and enormous social complexity of Bhaktapur (and those particular sorts of ancient cites that resembled it)[9] *required* such resources for social coherence, whereas they were superfluous and disvalued in the tiny Tahitian village (Levy 1990: chap. 2).[10]

In Bhaktapur, this mobilization of the sacred in the service of the integration and organization of the community as a whole was through "festival," and not through what we would ordinarily think of as "ritual." Ritual, in Rappaport's strong sense, was recognizable as such at the edges and often was embedded in the course of festivals. Festivals were, as Rappaport would predict, *enabled* by ritual enactments, and many—but not all—of their focal and climactic moments were marked by them. Conducted by one or another of a large variety of priests and initiates, these rituals were performed, often in secret and confined to a group of initiates (the noninitiate public taking for granted that these secret rituals had been properly performed), for the essential public purpose of sacralizing the elements of the festivals—performers, masks, images of deities, and other paraphernalia—as well as some of the critical transformations occurring in their course.

V. Bhaktapur: What Exactly Is a Ritual?

In Bhaktapur, festival—conducted at times fixed by the annual lunar and solar calendars, involving formally designated sets of human and divine participants systematically moving through and focusing on traditionally designated and semantically significant city spaces, responding

to these places and their deities with often elaborate conventionalized actions "not entirely coded by the performers" — is within the domain of gods and the holy. But festival is not ritual. Rappaport realizes that there is a problem here. "Ritual is one member of an extended family of performance forms [he cites as examples dramas, 'some political conventions,' ceremonies, festivals, carnivals, and demonstrations] to some of which it seems . . . to be more closely related than to others" (1999: 38). The features definitive of ritual are variously and partially shared among them.

In Hindu Bhaktapur, rituals that sanctify the components of festival, that, say, transform a stone carving or mask into an incarnation of a god, are members of a larger set of enactments — acts of worship — that seem to be unproblematically glossable as rituals. These are *pujas,* whose intended purpose is to induce the gods to do humanly useful things or at least to refrain from harm. These *pujas* are terminologically and conceptually distinguished from festivals and a variety of other religious enactments. Although *pujas* in contrast to these other enactments are clearly "rituals," on closer study they turn out to be a formally designated sequence of worship some of whose phases are more like Rappaportian ritual than others. The *puja* consists of a conventional series of "symbolic" acts that vary greatly in formality and seriousness and transcendent force. In ordinary terms, they are "ceremonies" whose various segments have varying degrees of ritual form and force. Thus, we sense in the Western marriage ceremony, as Rappaport himself notes, that some parts of it — the homily, the kissing of bride and groom, the throwing of the bridal bouquet — are not quite ritual in Rappaport's strong sense — at least they do not necessarily point to nor generate the sacred or divine in their form. Local Brahmans in Bhaktapur recognize focal enactments — usually one — in the long ceremonial sequence of the *puja* as *the puja* within a *puja.* Such segments are introduced by means of dramatic sounds (the blowing of horns, the rattling of a drum, or the ringing of a bell), a climax of special offerings, and a heightening of attention among the participants at the point when the god, having been properly welcomed and feted at some length, and perhaps offered a blood sacrifice, does the focal transformative work of the ceremony. We perceive this focal ritual sequence within, for example, the Western marriage ceremony in the solemn subsequence leading up to the transformative "I now pronounce you man and wife." Yet the other parts of the larger *puja* or marriage ceremony have some or much of the generic criteria of ritual while not

seeming fully ritual in Rappaport's treatment. Rappaport realizes the problem, although somewhat hesitantly. He is cautious about distinctions between "ceremony" and "ritual" (1999: 39) such as Raymond Firth's suggestion (1967) that "ceremony" should be used to emphasize symbolic acknowledgment and demonstration of a social situation and "ritual" for procedures believed to have effective power of their own. Rappaport finds the distinction of "dubious value." But without some such distinctions Rappaport is left with a problem. When is a ritual not a ritual and why do some parts of a "ritual" (used in a loose sense) seem more like a "ritual" (used in a strict Rappaportian sense) than others? In response to this difficulty, Rappaport makes a parenthetical proposal, which is, however, not developed in his later arguments.

> It may be useful to make a distinction between ritual, the formal, stereotyped aspect of events in general and rituals, relatively invariant events dominated by their formal components. . . . It is not necessary to distinguish ritual radically by imposing an arbitrary discontinuity upon the continuum of formality at any point. . . . The phenomena with which the study is concerned lie toward the more formal, less variant end of the continuum (35.)

This would suggest the possibility of a mobile interplay of "ceremoniousness" and "rituality" in various performances. When ritual is treated as having a quantitative dimension, questions about the implications of different degrees of rituality (as characterizing religious events within a society or comparatively among societies) arise.

VI. Immanence and Transcendence, Monotheism and Polytheism, Sources of Faith and Belief

Rappaport argues that participation in a ritual tends to generate through its "internal, psychological" effects a *sense* of the holy and thus provides an experiential basis for belief, a kind of perceptually based intuitive knowledge. Without this experientially anchored belief, he argues, any particular ritual, and indeed the family of rituals, would wither and die. One may ask under what conditions is this ritual induced support for "faith" more or less critical.

Bhaktapur's festivals are major experiential generators of belief and

of intuitive social understanding and thus of social ordering (Levy 1990, 1997), as all of its citizens witness and participate in the complex dramatic enactments of aesthetically powerful figures (crafted images and specially dressed and often masked living humans) who are generally taken to be (at the proper times) incarnations of the gods and thus the god itself. The city is full of incarnate divinities whose locations, movements, and actions are profoundly meaningful and emotionally moving. Most people I interviewed "believed" in them—albeit granting them a special, extraordinary kind of reality. These immanent gods did much of the work of sustaining belief that Rappaport ascribes to ritual.

In a letter to Denis Diderot in the late eighteenth century, Johann Kasper Lavater, a prominent Swiss Protestant pastor and theologian, wrote that he envied the heroic figures of the Old Testament who had direct sensuous contact with God and His divine messengers and who therefore did not have to face the problem of faith—they only had to "believe" in the reality of what they saw and heard. When the deity became transcendent, when God(s) stop walking the earth, as is the case in the monotheistic religions, faith becomes a special problem and the role of ritual becomes especially important in recapturing the divine presence in the ways Rappaport portrays. The Last Supper of the incarnate and living Jesus is only transformed into a ritual, the Eucharist, seeking to recapture his presence, after his Ascension.

Monotheism seems to be specially associated with transcendence, and its transcendent God, with his diffuse representational responsibilities, is necessarily general, abstract, contradictory, and ultimately ineffable. When deity functions on the ground as a way of variously and concretely representing a whole domain of differentiated and integrated ideas, social elements, and psychological states, it is likely to be polytheistic and thus divisible into a system of discrete and semantically appropriate signs.

The traditional segment of Bhaktapur's people (which in 1973 included almost all of them), like the early biblical elect, do not have the same kind of problem of faith that latter-day monotheists have. Some few of them may doubt the sacred reality of what they see (which did not necessarily make the performances less effective), but the performances are so powerful, so densely embedded in the contexts of their lives and experience, that such doubt at the time of my study seemed extremely limited.[11] Belief was anchored in a dense and deeply felt sensory experience of the sacred in action and not limited to the experience of ritual.

The problem of faith, seems attenuated, and is, at the least, altered in such settings. Rappaport's argument that ritual is of primary importance in the generation of religious belief is perhaps biased or at least weighted by his focal concern with monotheism. In the context of a transcendent monotheistic God, the power Rappaport claims for ritual's ability to generate a sense of the divine presence has a special importance, and so does the subtle interplay of those elusive and shifting terms, "faith" and "belief."

As Rappaport notes (1999: 120) faith is different from belief in that (quoting Fehean O'Doherty) "faith is neither subjective conviction nor experienced certitude, but may be at its best when doubt exists" and (quoting Paul Tillich) "faith *necessarily* includes an element of uncertainty or doubt." But, Rappaport argues (in one of his most important suggestions) that participation in ritual has the power (as a sort of speech act) to produce certain obligations and thus social order even when the participant lacks faith and/or belief. One who goes through a marriage ceremony and its component rituals is socially married even if he or she doesn't have faith in those rituals.

It is useful to add to Rappaport's account a parenthetical suggestion that the "experiential reality" generated by the form of ritual experience, as well as that generated by other enactments of divine immanence such as festival, may well (almost necessarily) be held by believers as being of a different sort than the reality of the objects and events of ordinary experience.[12] The objects of religiously generated belief insofar as they are experienced as real have a special, extraordinary, and, as we shall see, fragile reality.[13] Their special sort of reality is similar to the special ontological status given to the kind of reality inferred from the feelings of the numinous, a reality that entails a shift in cognitive mode from everyday logic and perception to a more dreamlike and emotion-driven logic,[14] two modes that are probably everywhere usually more or less distinguished in "sane" minds, or at least "sane" states of mind, in the service of what Freud called "reality testing." To deny that members of a community make this distinction (except under special and extraordinary situations of, say, mystical enlightenment or other ecstatic states) is to entertain Lévy-Bruhlian conceptions of primitive mentalities conflating, collapsing, and confusing the natural and the supernatural.

I shall return below to the shifting status of faith and belief in relation to historical struggles against ritual.

VII. When Are Rituals and Religion More or Less Useful for Communal Integration? Sociocultural Complexity as a Variable

Rappaport argues that one of ritual's essential and immemorial functions is the enabling of social order. Participation in ritual signals assent to the community and its rules, to the effect that participants acquire or reinforce a sort of contractual relation to that order, thus becoming vulnerable to new and particularly powerful sanctions if they violate the rules of the now sacralized components of the order to which a particular ritual is relevant. A familiar example is the transformation produced by the ritual of oath taking. What were only ordinary lies prior to taking the oath become much more serious—perjury and its equivalents—after the oath, and the mild sanctions against the liar now become severe, in some societies exile or death, in the case of the oath violator. Ritual here is a powerful force for "trustworthy" social order. This use of ritual was in the long perspective of cultural evolution, according to Rappaport a way of ameliorating the augmented ability to lie enabled by the development of language (1999: 15) and to protect against the subversive dangers of the language-enabled ability to imagine, reason about, and construct alternate and conflicting orders (17).

If ritual is such a resource, then we can ask a comparative question. Under which sociocultural conditions is this trust-ensuring function more or less called for? Such functional propositions imply that the social-ordering aspects of religion and ritual would tend to effloresce, to increase in quantity (frequency, duration, costliness, seriousness) when other forces for order are relatively problematic.

Rappaport notes that there is a source of dependable social integration within a community based on shared local common sense ("deutero-truths"),[15] and, one should add, shared moral convictions, generated from the shared and pervasive *forms* in which various learning experiences are locally mediated as well as (and in many ways more important and less obvious than) congruence among community members in the *content* of that learning (cf. Bateson 1972; Levy 1973, 1976, 1996). "To the extent that the experiences of the members of any society are similar they will learn [the same] deutero-truths" (Rappaport 1999: 305). These shared forms of learning might be assumed, he writes, to generate shared orientations that would be sufficient to ground orderly social life. He rejects this assumption because, he argues, as every member of any

society has different experiences, then "each person's deutero-truths may be expected to differ in some degree from those of others" (307). Thus, ritual and religion are still necessary for generating assent and commitment. He notes, in passing, my suggestion that "different societies, probably differ in the degree to which they can depend upon deutero-truths to establish the public understandings that underlie social life," but he goes on with his central task of the generality of ritual structures and their implications.

For a comparative inquiry, the historical and cultural variations in the social uses and usefulness of ritual and religion and the theoretical problems these differences pose should not be glossed over in a quest for universal structures. Thus, the great difference in religiosity between Tahiti and Bhaktapur is influenced, I have proposed, by the fact that it is possible in an isolated, tiny Tahitian village to base much social order on shared integrative assumptions and psychological forms (i.e., on deutero-truths), something that is not possible in the large, enormously complex but highly integrated society of Bhaktapur. The principal device Bhaktapur uses for the social ordering of its diverse population is an enormous efflorescence of religion. It is in such complex but still premodern places, much more so than in a certain subset, at least, of "simple," small, face-to-face communities,[16] that the work of ritual and other religious resources becomes especially useful and elaborate.[17]

VIII. The Struggle Against Ritual

If ritual is or has historically been a (or, as Rappaport claims, *the*) fundamental social resource, if it performs so many "humanity-making" social and psychological tasks, then the various historical struggles against it and the social and cultural dynamics of its attrition become freshly framed.

In the book's final chapter, entitled "The Breaking of the Holy and Its Salvation," Rappaport considers the problematic status of religion and ritual in their relation to the social and ecological realities of our contemporary situation. He takes the problems of religion to be, in part, internally generated: "Every evolutionary advance is likely to set new problems as it ameliorates those already prevailing. . . . The emergence of the concept of the sacred made the human way of life possible by ameliorating the subversive possibilities intrinsic to certain aspects of language. . . . [But] sanctity and other of religion's conceptions might . . . have prob-

lems of their own" (1999: 438). He considers a variety of these internally generated problematic features. These include the threat imposed by — and thus the antagonism of — one sacralized community to another as well as problems generated by religious rigidity, oversanctification and overspecification — that is, of attempts to sacralize, control, and rigidify practices whose mobility in response to shifting ecological and social conditions are essential to human well being. Such overspecification, perceived as onerous and erroneous constraints generate critical reforms within a faith (and fundamentalist counter-reactions), and open the way to secular challenges.

Rappaport also deals with "external" problems generated by changes and developments in the sociocultural context in which forms of religion are embedded. He considers such factors as change in scale, development of new loci of power, technological changes, and the developments that have come to privilege one of the aspects of human interest, the economic sphere, over the interests of "the system as a whole." Such elements, rather than the whole, have become sacralized in a "disastrous inversion."

Such considerations are Rappaport's move toward a historicizing of his schema of the holy, largely in a sort of dichotomy of religion's essential usefulness in the (distant) past versus its contemporary pathology — and the pathology of its ambient society. His analysis of the attenuation of ritual is based, as is his analysis in general, on structural considerations. I wish, in accordance with this essay's emphasis on historical and comparative events, to consider some earlier challenges to the social and psychological power of ritual, attempts to dispense with and disable its "universal" resources. What were the consequences of these radical moves? In our first example they did not prevail; in the second, they heralded a profound change in the nature of religion.

The Struggle against Ritual: Early Buddhism

It is generally held that early Buddhism — arising in India in a period of great social, cultural, and economic change in the sixth century B.C. in opposition to the traditional priestly Brahmanical religion — was profoundly skeptical of ritual. As a popular text puts it, speaking of Theravada, or "early," Buddhism: "The disciple must free himself, first from the general delusion that correct outward action will insure a man's

salvation, and then from the particular delusion that religious rites and ceremonies have intrinsic value to the attendant devotee" (Holmes 1911, quoted in Humphreys 1962: 120).

Early Indian Buddhism was anti-Brahmanical (ritual tends to be associated with priesthood) and denied, at least in some of its philosophical writings, the reality of the power of the priests; the existence, or at the least the power, of the gods to whom ritual was addressed; and the transformative power of ritual itself.[18] Individuals' fates were held to depend not on ritual or loving attachment to a deity—these were "delusions"—but on the automatic consequences of people's actions in the world, their karma. Those consequential actions, producing good or bad karma according to their various moral implications, depended ultimately on the truth or error of an individual's understanding of the true nature of the world and the states of mind and actions that should properly follow from this understanding. Salvation, an escape from delusion, was brought about through the laborious quest for proper understanding.[19] This austere and difficult individually centered path to salvation did not prove sufficient for most devotees. In practice, apparently, karma-transcending and rectifying gods and rituals continued to operate usefully at the periphery of early Indian Buddhism (which quickly died out in its Indian homeland) and were to return in more and more elaborate forms in the course of Buddhism's later development elsewhere in Asia.

It turned out not to be easy (at least in this Asian case), as Rappaport's analysis centrally implies it would not be, for a religion to jettison ritual and survive. It is noteworthy that in these early Buddhistic assertions and practices, and surely among some of the more adept of its followers, the attempt to escape ritual and its associated doctrines was through trying to transcend it in a move to a conception of a totally moralized everyday world, the world of karma, which was where the veiled and hidden sacred became manifest to the enlightened. In its strongest anti-ritual conception the operation of karma did not require, did not logically permit, the mediation of freely acting gods, priests, or rituals, for there was no separated god who stood apart and needed to be addressed, petitioned, and made believable through the devices of ritual and prayer, no separate realm of the sacred standing against the profane, no space between the individual and the transcendent that needed to be bridged—that space being an illusion of the unenlightened. This antipriestly, antiritual vision of a moral universe giving a central meaning to human fate and behavior, and, indeed, to the fate and behavior of

all sentient beings, is a vision of a thoroughly sacred world in which the adept perceives himself to be, in which all beings, albeit unaware, are. In this move, dispensing with ritual involves an augmented sacralization of the world.

The Struggle against Ritual: Disenchanting the World

The early Buddhist ideal was to weaken formal religion through a sort of superenchantment of the world. Our own modern struggle with ritual has famously eventuated in (or at least threatened) what Max Weber called the "Entzauberung der Welt," the disenchanting of—the removal of magic from—the world. An intermediate stage in this modern enterprise was the attempt to weaken what Rappaport claims to be one of the central implications of ritual—the experientially based "knowledge" generated automatically by the numinous experience of ritual participation. Let us review this familiar story, with Rappaport's analysis of ritual as orientation.

Christian reformers' dissatisfaction with belief based on the experience induced by ritual form is perhaps most clearly and paradigmatically illustrated in Ulrich Zwingli's radical sixteenth-century assertion about the focal Christian rite of the Eucharist, that Christ's blood and body did not *exist* in the rite's transubstantiated wine and wafer, as Christianity had traditionally claimed, but that they, and thus their consummation, were *only symbolic.*

Zwingli's position in the Reformation debate on the Eucharist reiterated an ancient Christian theoretical proposal, at a moment when it had profound social, political and institutional relevance.[20] In place of *est* (the Eucharist *is* the body and blood of Christ), he argued, *significat* should be understood (the Eucharist *represents* the body and blood of Christ). As Zwingli put it, "we say the words are figurative," and then he adds, maintaining priestly authority, "we explain the figure" (Hastings 1928: 5:567). When such claims prevail, a fateful wedge is driven into the power of ritual—a doctrinal challenge to the experienced reality that Rappaport argues is generated by the form of ritual and that, he argues, is critical for the support of belief in a religion's particular doctrines.

Zwingli also held that, although the Eucharist was only a "memorial" of Christ's sacrifice on the part of any particular recipient, it was "as a public declaration of faith . . . more significan[t] for the members of the

congregation who saw him take his stand than for his own spiritual life" (Bainton 1974: 552). Using Rappaport's perspective this appears as an interesting attempt to suppress the inner—and what now is beginning to be taken pejoratively as magical or superstitious—reality of the ritual-in-itself while maintaining its external force as an act of public commitment.

Zwingli assumes that his act of interpretation, his intellectual argument, will remove or attenuate the experienced-based belief. Insofar as ritually generated experiential reality can be effectively challenged by an intellectual and doctrinal claim, at least at moments in history as diverse as sixth century B.C. India and sixteenth-century Europe, it suggests that ritual has to be supported by a structure of interpretations, as well as by other enabling features of historical and cultural context, to survive and serve its Rappaportian functions. Such attacks on the ontological status of the reality of the experience-warranted belief generated by ritual are, as we have noted, anything but trivial. Rappaport puts this clearly: "If a liturgical order . . . is not supported by the conviction [i.e., the experientially based belief] of at least some of the members of the congregation . . . it is in danger of gradually falling into desuetude, of sooner or later becoming . . . 'mere ritual'" and of eventually dying away (1999: 396).

IX. Belief, Faith, and the Dying of Ritual

To cast doctrinal doubt on the experienced supernatural reality of a centrally important ritual like the Eucharist (and thus on the supernatural reality of all Christian rituals), to call it "*only* symbolic," is to struggle against what Rappaport holds to be part of ritual's essential force. Why this move was at least partially effective at this particular place and historical moment and what its motives were are not relevant here. But what becomes now of post-Rappaportian ritual?

When the ritual lost its direct and impersonal power in itself, a power that could henceforth be seen as magic and illusory, and thus as superstitious, concern turned from the ritual itself to the quality of a given participant's personal engagement with the ritual. As the autonomous power of the ritual in itself becomes attenuated "faith" becomes a question not of the *validity* of a numinous experience joined to a special doctrine and action, but of the soteriologic efficacy of enacting an "only symbolic" memorial. This faith must now be achieved by means of individual effort. An individual's state of mind as he or she performs the

ritual (now not the state of mind produced by the ritual but the state of mind brought to the ritual) takes on a critical importance—and the modern question of the sincerity, the inner state, of the participant arises. The meaning of belief and faith and the contrast between them sharpens and shifts. As John Locke paradigmatically put it in 1689, more than a century after Zwingli, in a passage in which believing becomes the strenuous responsibility of the participant:

> All the life and power of true religion consists in the inward and full perusion of the mind; and faith is not faith without believing. Whatever profession we make, to whatever outward worship we conform, if we are not fully satisfied in our own mind that the one is true, and the other well-pleasing unto God, such profession and such practice . . . are indeed great obstacles to our salvation. (quoted in Horton and Mendus 1991: 18)

"Belief" is essential, Locke wrote, and "such is the nature of understanding that it cannot be compelled to the belief of anything by outward forces" (Horton and Mendus: 18). Belief comes not through the experience of the ritual but through "reason," and the "light and evidence" that accompanies it.[21] This reasoned belief is not that generated by the numinous experience of ritual and its special kind of reality, but is based on "reason and evidence." It would seem to be an extension of the epistemology of science and its methods of acquiring knowledge of nature and, thus, of studying God's works.[22] And to know now only that somebody partakes in the "outward worship" of church rituals is not to know very much about his or her social reliability. Participants may just be going through the motions of acquiescence, and these motions, if not sincere, are now taken to have dubious force. Locke's statement would seem to imply that without belief the social validity of the ritual itself may be in doubt. Even the external social contractual implication of participating in ritual, Zwingli's emphasis on the power of a "public declaration of faith," would seem to be being progressively weakened.

Now ritual becomes not the locus for the experience of deity but the locus of an absconded God who has to be submitted to through an act of faith in something not imminently present, an act of will, of character, of careful reasoning, and of new sorts of social virtues. For this Lockean (and radical Protestant) move to take place, ritual has to be divested of its direct, impersonal claims to transcendent powers.

Faith is now, in one way, more important (for there is less autonomous power and experiential truth in the ritual in itself), but it needs to be sustained by an intellectual achievement (Locke's "belief") engaging the "full perusion of the mind" and a wider segment of the self in order to be a true faith.

With ritual made problematic, it becomes progressively less important and the arena of significant religious action begins to shift. Now (to quote Charles Taylor's remarks on the implications of the Reformation) "one no longer belonged to the saved, to the people of God, by one's connection to a wider order sustaining a sacramental life, but by one's wholehearted personal adhesion" (1989: 217). This Reformation faith "seemed to require an outright rejection of the sacred, and hence also of the church and its mediating role. . . . Along with the Mass went the whole notion . . . that there are special places or times or actions where the power of God is more intensely present and can be approached by humans" (216). Ritual and its implications are being profoundly transformed from Rappaport's generic form.

The natural shift in emphasis for many religious groups was some version of the Puritan notion of *ordinary life* as a holy vocation whose ethical performance is an act, perhaps *the* act, of worship and a basis for (or the sign of) salvation. This is reminiscent of the Buddhist emphasis on karma, but, in a great contrast, God still exists (among all but a few deists) as a free and largely incomprehensible agent with the freedom to forgive and understand, to condemn and punish, to transcend and overcome karma for his own utterly transcendent purposes, and inhabits a separate realm of the fully sacred which the saved will one day inhabit.

In a next step in this long struggle to escape ritual, even the relation of the ethical living of ordinary life to an eschatological realm of God begins to dissolve, and the state of things that Nietzsche recognized as our murder of God was on the horizon. The news that Nietzcshe's Madman brought to the marketplace was not that God is dead. His auditors did not believe in God. The news was that "we have killed him . . . are we not straying as through an infinite nothing. . . . What was holiest and most powerful of all that the world has yet known has bled to death under our knives: who will wipe this blood off us?" The Madman's implicit challenge was *"now what must be done,"* but he realized he had come too early. He threw his lantern on the ground, and it went out (Nietzsche, [1887] 1974:181).

Throughout all these modern centuries, ritual—religious ritual—has

become not only more and more empty but more and more dispensable, and thus the intuition of the holy that ritual helped generate — an intuition that grounded religious practice and an understanding of the world — evaporates. This desacralization of the world, generated and warranted in large part by the pathologies of religion, is, Rappaport argues in his hortatory final chapter, a profound threat to human adaptation to a world for whose survival we, "the part of the world through which the world as a whole can think about itself," are now responsible. We must think "not only about the world, but on behalf of the world . . ." We have a great moral responsibility — and a rediscovery, revitalization, and reformulation of the sacred, informed by what we have learned (and what we have to unlearn) is essential to our task. In that final chapter, for which the extended sociological, linguistic, psychological, ecological and theological analyses of the book were a preparation, Rappaport takes up the Madman's challenge.

NOTES

1. Rappaport cautions that his "suggestions concerning religious origins and importance are meant to provide the most general context possible for the more specific arguments and discussions developed in the course of this work. The validity of these less general arguments and discussions does not, however, depend upon the acceptance of the book's more general theses" (199: 2).

2. In the course of Rappaport's book, the term *ritual* almost always refers to religious ritual.

3. Attempts to submit Rappaport's theses to empirical criticism must bear in mind, as I have tried to do here, an important implication of strong claims about cultural universals, which is often neglected in the criticisms of those claims based on "contradictory evidence." That is that the "universal's" absence in one or all features in a particular place does not necessarily "disprove" the universal in favor of relativism but rather may lead to the unfashionable question of why this form and its "logical entailments" are *not* found in a particular place or time or social segment. If there were a particular community whose members lacked, say, the universal of humor — or (closer to ethnographic reality) reversed the almost ubiquitous forward and backward movement of the head to signify assent and its side to side rotation to signify dissent or refusal — we are entitled to take a cautious "deficit" stance and ask why *don't* they do things as others do? The lack of some highly general human feature, its absence or local modification, may require an explanation in terms of the local conditions that result in the suppression, transformation, or transcendence of a universal.

4. In this essay I use *sacred* in its general dictionary sense and not in Rappaport's technical usage, where *sacred* is taken to mean "the discursive

aspect of religion, that which can be expressed in language" (1999: 23) and is a component of the "holy."

5. A different issue from the frequency of ritual is the various ways in which people in different communities may be *involved* in the rituals they do perform or witness. There is little evidence about this for eighteenth-century Tahiti. The usually careful and perceptive observer William Bligh wrote about Tahitian involvement in the "rites" that he witnessed: "I should have reasoned that people strongly impressed with superstitious notions or ideas would be equally affected at the same rites attending them, but it is powerfully the reverse here; laughing, ridiculous questions and the strongest proofs of inattention in all the ceremonies I have met with, convince me to the contrary, and I do believe that whatever their sacred ceremonies are, they are followed up with very little reverential awe and with no respect" ([1787–88] 1937: 2:14). Bligh was observing Tahitian religiosity from the perspective of British low-church earnestness, and the Tahitians were altered by his presence, and perhaps by a sense of the power of new gods. Nonetheless, the passage is provocative.

6. This relative secularity impressed the early European explorers. Via the account of Bougainville, it was one of the sources of Denis Diderot's eighteenth-century polemic use of Tahiti (ikn his *Supplement to the Voyage of Bougainville*) as a land of noble savages where a wise and natural rationality had replaced the kinds of religious superstition that were, in his opinion, keeping France in darkness.

7. On some of the social and psychological differences between gods and spirits, see Levy, Mageo, and Howard 1996.

8. Bram Stoker's *Dracula* is a paradigmatic modern literary example of Otto's "primitive" form of the numinous. See Levy 1985.

9. These cities were based on the development of preexisting local cultural forms and had considerable cultural unity. They can be contrasted with cities that were mixtures of heterogeneous peoples. See Levy 1990: 18ff.

10. In 1962, during the period of my study, the village had 284 people, of whom 140 were sixteen years of age or older.

11. It seemed limited to a few "modernized" people who could read in other languages, and/or had extensive experience in other societies and much of whose life and work had been conducted away from the city.

12. Another strategy—or an at least intellectual argument—for achieving belief in propositions that seem to violate common-sense reality is to collapse the distinction between "knowledge" and "belief" à la Saint Augustine who argued (in the face of Gnostic criticisms that they were a matter of mere belief, rather than knowledge) that it was proper to accept Christian accounts "that could not be demonstrated" insofar as much of what he firmly believed and treated as secular knowledge (the sort of things that if we were not to accept them "we could do nothing at all in this life") had been told to him and were also hearsay and thus also "mere belief" (Augustine [ca. 400 AD] 1991: 94).

13. Rappaport's argument (e.g., 1999: 280 ff.) that the ultimate sacred postulates of a religious community have to be unfalsifiable is related to one of

the social uses of such postulates. Postulates whose acceptance differentiates a community from some other community of believers cannot be of the order "fire burns," which everyone would assent to, but have to be of the nature of an unfalsifiable (and unprovable) assertion that usually appears absurd to outsiders who do not share the faith. This is the only way in which a parochial faith can mark itself off from nonbelievers. But even within a community of believers their particular parochial identity-affirming belief may well (under certain conditions) have to "include an element of uncertainty or doubt" so that its adherence can serve as a test of the commitment of members of the community to the belief's in-group marking ability, even as it serves to mark their differentiation from outsiders, the nonbelievers.

14. For a discussion of the way these two modes of logic are represented by two different classes of deity within the larger sphere of sacred reality, see Levy 1990, chap. 8, esp. 279–86.

15. The term, and the idea in general is based on the conceptions of Gregory Bateson (1972: esp. 279–308).

16. This formulation requires qualification. Although it was probably exaggerated and was obsessively described in early historical descriptions because of European preoccupations with savage religion, many "simple, face-to-face" premodern communities have been reported as having elaborate ritual lives. I would suggest that the essential difference between such places and remote Tahitian villages is not the small scale and lack of internal social differentiation that they both share but the degree of their effective isolation from dissimilar cultures. Insofar as a community is intimately embedded in a system of areal relations with people of culturally different assumptions and practices, as is the case in many parts of Melanesia, the cognitive situation of many of a community's citizens is indeed complex and the conditions would be proper for ritual elaboration. In their Central Pacific isolation, Tahitians were in external contact prior to the late eighteenth century only with people with almost identical cultures and with languages with only minor dialectal differences. This long isolation and *comparative* social homogeneity affected local patterns of thought and enhanced the power of common sense. See Levy 1973: 267ff.

17. This discussion concerns the comparative ordering of a certain set of traditional communities. In other politics of very large scale or great cultural heterogeneity, law and force become more predominant as ordering resources.

18. If gods existed, they were also the result of *karma* and unable to change its laws. They could not alter karma-generated fate.

19. This schema, of course, generates paradoxes about human free agency and responsibility.

20. The terms of the debate about "corporeal presence" versus "only symbolic force" were ancient (Hastings 1928: 5:540ff.). Their "classic expression" dates from the ninth century (McManners 1990: 103).

21. I am indebted for these quotations of Locke to Fish 1997.

22. This is the beginning of a sort of collapse of the spiritual into the material, resulting in the enlightened "single vision" that William Blake ("May

God us keep, from single vision and Newton's sleep") and the Romantics struggled against. It is, ironically, a reversal of the primitivist's image of the collapse of the material into the spiritual among "primitive" people.

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New Ways in Death and Dying: Transformation of Body and Text in Late Modern American Judaism

A Kaddish for Roy "Skip" Rappaport

Peter K. Gluck

In 1998 a remarkable presentation was offered to delegates at the biennial convention of the Union of American Hebrew Congregations, the lay arm of American Reform Judaism, and duly reported in the spring 1998 issue of *Reform Judaism* magazine (Weiss 1998). The talk was about the "afterlife." It was not a scholarly presentation meant for the academy. Instead, the speaker tried to convince the attendees that Reform Jews ought to once again include in the liturgy ideas about an afterlife:

> How unfortunate that we have rejected the awesome, uplifting belief that our souls live on after the death of our bodies. When was the last sermon you heard about life after death? When was the last funeral where the rabbi said "the deceased person's soul has entered the world to come"? . . . And what does this accomplish? We are deprived of a belief in an ultimate judgment of the wicked, thereby wilting our faith in God. (Gelman 1998: 18)

Whether the afterlife does or does not exist, and what it entails, is not at issue in this essay. Rather, the subject is how Jewish statements about death have changed without compromising the enduring sacred core of the faith. Readers of Rappaport's work are familiar with the emphasis he placed on invariance in liturgical orders: "I take ritual to be a form or structure, defining it as the performance of more or less invariant sequences of formal acts and utterances not encoded by the performers" (1979: 175). Rappaport was also concerned with incorpora-

tion of change into ritual systems and how change at the lower levels of ritual communication is able to preserve the ultimate sacred postulate and thus perpetuate the flow of the sacred into human affairs. In this essay, I use the mourner's kaddish and its preparatory prayers in the Reform Jewish canon to illustrate this concept of hierarchical levels of ritual communication, persistence ("perdurance"), and change in Rappaport's work on religious ritual.

The Paradox of Invariance

In his essay "On Cognized Models" (1979), Rappaport outlines a five-tiered hierarchy of understandings, the pattern of which is to be found in all religious rituals. At the top of the hierarchy are the "ultimate sacred postulates," through which the sacred flows to the rest of the ritual understandings. They achieve their sacred ("unquestionable") status by virtue of their peculiar semantic characteristic as well as their contextual setting in ritual performance. Semantically, ultimate sacred postulates are unfalsifiable and contain no material referents. In addition: "Sanctity . . . emerges out of canonical invariance and its performance, first investing certain sentences expressed in ritual but flowing from those 'ultimate sacred postulates' to others that are directly implicated in the affairs of society" (1979: 223).

The Jewish prayer, Shema, "Hear O Israel, the Lord our God the Lord is One," is often mentioned by Rappaport as a prime example of an ultimate sacred postulate in that the Hebrew word translated as "Lord" has no known dictionary meaning. More precisely, this ultimate sacred postulate represents "the sacred name which cannot be pronounced," which accords well with Rappaport's definitions because the proper name of the Holy cannot be authored or uttered in Hebrew religious discourse.

The second level is composed of "cosmic axioms." Cosmic axioms "refer to assumptions concerning the fundamental structure of the universe or, to put it differently, they refer to the paradigmatic relationships in accordance with which the cosmos is constructed" (Rappaport 1979: 116). An example of axiomatic understandings in Rabbinic Judaism are the categories of good and evil in the universe, which are paralleled by blessing and curse and lead to either life or death. There is, as well, a separation of the human and the divine, with the divine able to mete out rewards and punishment. Rappaport writes that "ultimate

sacred postulates are typically devoid of material significata, whereas cosmological axioms are concerned with relationships among qualities that may themselves be sensible and that are manifested in physical and social phenomena" (119). The spiritual soul, in contrast to the material body, is another fundamental relationship found in Rabbinic Judaism that illustrates how the cosmos is constructed.

The third level of understandings from which cognized models are constructed is a set of specific rules governing the conduct of relations of those oppositions set out on the second level. In Judaism, for instance, in order for one to be righteous and involved with the good one would need to know and understand the laws of the written and oral Torahs, laws known also as *mitzvot,* for they are described as having been given as commandments by God.

"Liturgical orders also import information from the external world in the form of formal indications of currently prevailing conditions" (1979: 120). On this fourth level, data from the lifestyle of the people are transformed into liturgy. Words, images, ideas, seasonal activities, and clothing are but some of the information taken into rituals from the culture and conditions within which they are immersed. The differing calendars found in the Tanakh (Hebrew Bible), as well as such things as the sacrificial cult of the ancient Temple, are testimony on a grand scale to this importation of information from the cultures in which the rituals arose. These importations, such as the use of the Greek banquet meal for Passover, show how central these borrowings can be.

The fifth and final level is comprised of secular understandings. Although these are harder to distill from the ancient writings, for these writings already displayed all ritual behavior as part of the sacred, we might understand the establishment of judges and the anointing of the first king in the Bible as examples of how secular roles and institutions are made sacred. This suggests that the boundary between sacred and so-called secular culture is not rigid. Even today, witnesses are sworn in using the Bible to certify that they are "telling the truth."

Near the end of his discussion of cognized models, Rappaport gives a hint that the structures are not permanently fixed. He writes:

> We may consider difference in the longevity of the understandings assigned to the several levels of such hierarchies. . . . Differences in the longevity of understandings may or may not be recognized by those entertaining them, but whether or not they are, we can ob-

> serve in the ascent from the understandings of everyday life to those of ultimate sacred postulates a progression from the quick to the eternal. (1979: 124)

In this way, for Rappaport, longevity implies change. That which is seemingly invariant and fixed has another side to it. The paradox of invariance is that it allows for change. "Systematic disparities in the longevity of understandings imply a dynamic beyond the invariant series of transformations effected by rituals and sequences of rituals. The relationship between the quick and the eternal is also a relationship between the ever changing and the never changing" (1979: 125).

Another aspect of the relationship of ritual to ongoing social life is that ritual communicative systems incorporate nuances of emergent social meanings relevant to the work the ritual is accomplishing. In this way, social change is taken into the ritual life of the people. However, ritual structures have internal regulatory controls, or rules, which handle the variation:

> Such variation is, of course, in accordance with highly flexible rules, rules that are maintained unchanged through changes in the magnitudes of the reference values which they set. But, as we have seen, such rules can themselves change while higher-order cosmological understandings remain unchanged, and, similarly, these cosmological understandings can change without affecting ultimate sacred postulates. These, taken to be immutable, can remain unchanged as all understandings of "lower order" change. (1979: 125)

Thus, change enters the picture. It happens in different ways at different levels in the model. In fact, the ability of rituals to accommodate new and different understandings is essential if the rituals are to survive. It is important for Rappaport that rituals survive since it is through them that the sacred is brought into the world.

Rappaport proposes that the ultimate sacred postulate acts as a sort of anchor in the ritual structure. Its invariance allows for the variance in the rest of the ritual composite. It is clear that he sees change as a function of the meanings found in the words of the liturgy. The possibilities in words must include their range of new meanings and yet to be accepted understandings. The adoption of new meanings is not some random event but a form of cultural adaptation to ongoing historical

events. Ritual, and in particular the ultimate sacred postulate, makes it possible for this adaptation to occur in an orderly way. The fixed allows for change. Rappaport writes:

> Continuity can be maintained while allowing change to take place, for association of particular institutions or conventions with ultimate sacred postulates is *a matter of interpretation, and that which must be interpreted can always be reinterpreted without being challenged.* So, gods may remain unchanged while the conventions they sanctify are transformed through *reinterpretation in response to changing conditions.* (1979: 233, emphasis mine)

Thus, continuity is accomplished through reinterpretation. The words and sentences of the liturgy do not exist in a ritual vacuum. They are taken from the lexicon of daily usage and are made sacred by their special usage.

"While sanctity may have its source, so to speak, in "ultimate sacred postulates," it flows to other *sentences,* which, unlike them, do include references to material objects and activities, *sentences* directly concerned with the affairs of society (1979: 228). In order for the sacred to flow, the web of words spun around the sacred postulate must relate to the mind and feelings of the participant and the realities the participant knows to be true. The means for making interpretations in response to events in social history must be present for a ritual order to survive. Modes of interpretation thus play a vital role in preserving the ultimate sacred postulate since they constitute the ways in which the entire ritual system processes new information and events.

Change in the Ancient Context: An Example from History

We turn now to a well-known period in Jewish history, which will serve as a basis for our understanding the significance of the kaddish. In 70 C.E., the Romans destroyed the Second Temple in Jerusalem and with it the sacrificial cult that was central to Jewish ritual. This marked the beginning of what is known in Judaism as the *galut,* or Diaspora, for not only was the Temple destroyed but Jewish authority in the land of Israel ended. Before its destruction, sacrificial rituals "to make atonement" were highly significant, for they signified the attainment of "justice," the "forgiveness" of the deity, and the setting straight of the social order by means of its

correction through involvement of the sacred holy name of God. After the destruction, all services, including the regular morning and evening services, were disallowed by the Romans. The priesthood was disbanded. The Romans intended to destroy the entire ritual structure and replace it with Roman authority and culture.

Most of the significant prayers, aside from the Shema and its associated blessings, found today in the daily ritual were composed during the time after the destruction of the Second Temple and can be understood best as responses to that tragic event. These prayers, and the structure in which they are embedded, known as the Tefillah, represent an interpretation of the historical moment in which they were canonized.

As well, the destruction of the Second Temple brought with it the institutionalization of a new Jewish understanding of death included in the prayers of the Tefillah.[1] Although some notion of the afterlife is present in Tanakh (Brichto 1973), the formal structuring of the belief in the body's separation from the soul at death, the coming of a messiah, the resurrection of the body, and continuation of life in a world to come did not take shape in the liturgy until after the destruction of the Second Temple.[2] The prayers in the daily liturgy referring to these themes were created in post-Temple times. As a result of the destruction of Israelite culture and the expulsion from the land by the Romans, a new structuring of Jewish belief took place. It was then hoped that the ancient God of Israel would one day resurrect the souls of the righteous of the generations, bring them back to the land, rebuild the Temple, and introduce a new era, called in rabbinic tradition "the world to come," when peace would exist between nations.

The dynamics of the change in the beliefs concerning death and dying, which became encoded in the ritual, are summarized in the dispute recorded in the Mishnah between the priests of the destroyed Second Temple, the Sadducees, and a new scholar class, the Pharisees. The Mishnah, a Pharisaic document, reads, "All Israel have a portion of the world to come, as it is said, 'Thy people also shall be all righteous, they shall inherit the land forever; the branch of my planting, the work of my hands, that I may be glorified" (Is. 60:21). But the following have no share in the world to come: "He who says that there is no resurrection of the dead" (Sanhedrin 10:1) Here the text, without naming them, excludes the Sadducees from any future life, for they held to an earlier and different belief system, one that provided little hope for a future life to a conquered people. This non-Pentateuchal dogma of the world to come

and resurrection is a core teaching of the Mishnah. Indeed, this belief is the cornerstone of the entire *halakhah* (Jewish law) system. It was "only because the true believer and true devotee of the twofold Law could hope for the immortality of his soul and the resurrection of his body that he was ready, willing, and able to yoke himself to the twofold Law and abide by its discipline" (Rivkin 1978: 230). The new teaching of the Pharisees, made possible by their interpretive move, which, unlike that of the Sadducees, posited both a written and oral Torah, gave people hope in a future life. In this way, both a final bodily and a cultural death were seemingly averted.

The belief in the resurrection of the dead was, in fact, so central that it was incorporated in the essential blessings of the Tefillah, the prayer par excellence (Rivkin 1978: 231). In Rappaport's terms, the adaptation of the ritual to include new meanings represents change at all but the highest level in the cognized model represented in Jewish worship. And so, in the attempt of ancient Jews to save the ultimate sacred postulate, and thus themselves, from disappearing, they made changes in the information encoded in their ritual, changes that, when taken together, provided a powerful vehicle for the flow of the sacred into their lives to continue. As the people and their culture were under attack and threatened with death and, indeed, ultimate destruction, the invariant postulate of "one God" was maintained by surrounding it with new meanings on the "lower levels." In this way, the people and the culture endured, albeit with a newly inscribed purpose. The key prayer in the liturgy that came to represent this constellation of new understanding of "death" is called the kaddish.

A translation of the important lines in the kaddish is:

> May His great Name be exalted and sanctified
> in the world He created according to His will;
> And may He establish His Kingship
> during your lifetime and
> during your days and
> during the lifetime of the entire people of Israel,
> swiftly and soon.
> And say, Amen.

These lines are read by the reader, with the line "May His great Name be blessed" being the response of the congregation. This response

is considered the nucleus of the kaddish by many scholars (Elbogen 1993: 80). The all important name of God is referenced in such a way as to echo the first blessing in the passages surrounding the Shema itself when it is recited early in the service proper. In this way, the Shema and kaddish are linked. The word *kaddish* means sanctification, and it is, moreover, understood by some that the recitation of the kaddish is taken to be one of only three direct formulas for effecting Kiddush ha-Shem (sanctification of God's name) in the liturgy, the other two being Baraku and Kedushah (Kaddushin 1963: 133 ff.). It became the practice to recite the kaddish at public worship at the end of each section of the liturgy. Public worship as a whole thus came to be considered an occasion for acts of Kiddush ha-Shem, the purest of experiences of God's holiness (142).

Four forms of the kaddish prayer are used in the liturgy: the full kaddish, the half kaddish, the scholars's kaddish, and the mourners' (Orphan's) kaddish. The kaddish is composed mainly in Aramaic, the common language of first-century Jews. It is not known exactly when the *kaddish* first became associated with mourning practices in the general community. It is known that the kaddish was used in post-Temple times by Pharisaic teachers to end their *aggadic* lessons, during which time they presented their interpretations of the laws and stories in Tanach. It was then, most likely, taken over to end parts of the worship service in a similar way.

By the Middle Ages, the practice of reading names of the deceased at the conclusion of the service became widely accepted in European Jewish communities. The general practice of having mourners recite the kaddish seems to have originated during the thirteenth century at the time of severe persecutions in Germany by the Crusaders. The practice of reciting the kaddish by mourners during the eleven months after a death, during the memorial service of the major festivals, and on Yom Kippur (the Day of Atonement), as well as the anniversary of the death (Yahrzeit), mark some of the most solemn moments in the rites. Indeed, the mourner's kaddish continues to be used to this day in a similar fashion to conclude all services. In contemporary American Jewish ritual, those who are in mourning are asked to rise to recite the prayer, while a list of names, including that of their loved ones, is read aloud to the congregation. In Reform congregations, the entire congregation stands with the mourner, or those marking the Yahrzeit, the yearly anniversary of the death, as the names are read aloud.

Change in the Modern Context: The Ethnographic Evidence

The recitation of the mourner's kaddish took on ever greater significance over time as a key symbol (Ortner 1973) that connected the generations of a people disinherited from its land. It became a focal point in the liturgy, representing the entire religious system in the sense that it provided the goal for all religious behavior—resurrection in the time to come and a return to the land where the presence of the deity would go forth and fill the earth. Thus, any new change in the understanding of death surrounding the kaddish would represent a major shift in the understandings the ritual asks its adherents to hold. According to Rappaport, this would also signal a shift in their identity. In other words, if the reward of the righteous is not resurrection, then what? How will the people get to the future time of redemption? If not a world transformed in the future, then when? And if none of the above, then why continue adhering to the faith?

The nineteenth-century modern Jewish European reformers, of whom the American reformers are heirs, altered these centuries-old teachings of Pharisaic, traditional Judaism. In the liturgy of the Reform prayer book they removed the prayers of the Tefillah mentioning bodily resurrection in an attempt to bring the Reform liturgy into consonance with modern enlightenment thinking (Petuchowski 1968). Rather than a prayer to God who "resurrects the dead," the prayer addresses a God who "brings life to all." Rather than a prayer for the world to come, the prayer is for a "time of peace." Nowhere in the official prayer books, nor in the new interpretations I was able to find published by congregations independently of the official prayer books, is the resurrection mentioned. There are few if any references to a messiah or messianic age. The differentiation of the immortal soul from the earthly body, though mentioned, is relegated to a minor theme.

Against this background of deletion and change, an additional practice has gained acceptance, primarily in American Reform Jewish congregations. This is the practice of reading a paragraph in English before the kaddish's traditional words of Aramaic and Hebrew. These English inserts provide the participants with interpretations of the fixed liturgy. The readings attempt to make sense of the ancient words of the kaddish prayer, which is written in a language not understood by the modern congregation.

The insertion, now, of English prayers and interpretations alongside those English translations of the traditional Hebrew and Aramaic adds but one more layer to an already multilayered text. It is a most significant layer, since the English inserts provide the participant with interpretations of the "fixed" liturgy. Although there are additional places in the liturgy where interpretations are added, at the point of the reading of the kaddish, the focus is on the meaning of "death and dying."

Interpretations in the vernacular provide an opportunity for Jews in American culture to weave their understanding of the meaning of kaddish, that is, of death and dying, together with the traditional structure of the service. The incorporation of English interpretations, as distinct from loose or varied translations of the Hebrew and Aramaic in the traditional text, connects the kaddish prayer to the ongoing discourse about the meaning of death and dying in contemporary modern culture. The readings also provide the contemporary Jew with an opportunity to receive a host of interpretations of historical events such as the Holocaust and the establishment of the state of Israel.

Much of the evidence is found in the officially sanctioned prayer books of the Reform movement entitled *The Gates of Prayer* (1975, for daily, sabbath, and festival worship) and *The Gates of Repentance* (1978, for New Year's and Day of Atonement worship). In the *Gates of Prayer,* an entire section of English meditations precedes the kaddish. A reader of the service is given the opportunity to select from among a variety of texts, each offering a different interpretation. We read in the *Gates of Prayer:*

> When cherished ties are broken,
> and the chain of love is shattered,
> only trust and the strength of faith
> can lighten the heaviness of the heart.
> At times, the pain of separation seems
> more than we can bear,
> but if we dwell too long on our loss
> we embitter our hearts
> and harm ourselves and those about us.
> The Psalmist said that in his affliction
> he learned the law of God.
> And in truth,
> grief is a great teacher,

when it sends us back to
serve and bless the living . . .
Thus, even when they are gone,
the departed are with us,
moving us to live as, in their
higher moments,
they themselves wished to live . . . (1975: 623)

Grief and loss are presented as great teachers, not of some future time or life in another world, but of how to bless the living.

The meditation spells out an almost pragmatic program of how not to "dwell too long," and therefore embitter our hearts, but rather how to live in this world as the deceased, in their "higher moments," would have lived. In the next reading, a quasi-scientific, pragmatic perspective is explored.

What can we know of death,
we who cannot understand life?
We study the seed and the cell,
but the power deep within them will always elude us.
Though we cannot understand,
we accept life as the gift of God.
Yet death, life's twin, we face with fear.
But why be afraid?
Death is a haven to the weary . . .
We are safe in death as in life.
There is no pain in death.
There is only the pain of the living
as they recall shared loves,
and as they themselves fear to die.
Calm us, O Lord, when we cry out
in our fear and our grief.
Turn us anew toward life and the world.
Awaken us to the warmth of human love that speaks to us of You.
We shall fear no evil as we affirm Your kingdom of life. (624)

In a third offering, the theme of oneness is used to join the memory of those who have died with our lives and then with the unity of the

"source of life," a different expression for traditional language used to reference the deity.

> It is hard to sing of oneness
> when our world is not complete,
> when those who once brought wholeness to our life have gone,
> and naught but memory can fill the emptiness
> their passing leaves behind.
>
> But memory can tell us only what we were,
> in company with those we loved;
> it cannot help us find what each of us, alone, must now become.
> Yet no one is really alone;
> those who live no more, echo still within our thoughts and words,
> and what they did is part of what we have become . . .
> In affirming the One, we affirm the worth of each one whose life,
> now ended, brought us closer to the Source of life,
> in whose unity no one is alone and every life finds purpose. (625)

Finally, from the *Gates of Prayer* we have a reading that refers to the Holocaust. It starts with a kind of historical account and moves on to describe the Jew's response to such events. This reading connects the individual to the group without resorting to the traditional themes outlined earlier in this essay.

> We have lived in numberless towns and villages;
> and in too many of them we have endured cruel suffering.
> Some we have forgotten; others are sealed into our memory,
> a wound that does not heal.
> A hundred generations of victims and martyrs;
> still their blood cries out from the earth.
> And so many, so many at Dachau, at Buchenwald, at Babi Yar,
> and . . .
>
> What can we say? What can we do? How bear the unbearable,
> or accept what life has brought to our people?
> All who are born must die,
> but how shall we compare the slow passage of our time

with the callous slaughter of the innocent,
cut off before their time? . . .

They have left their lives to us:
let a million prayers rise whenever Jews worship;
let a million candles glow against the darkness of these
unfinished lives. (628)

The following passages are taken from the *Gates of Repentance.* As in many of the readings, we note that the life of the departed is preserved in our memories, a more organic response than a discussion about a spiritual soul. With this reading, we also note how the theme of death is tied into the special service for Rosh Hashanah. The "promise that life shall yet prevail" echoes the holiday theme that the God worshipped does not desire the death of the sinners, but that they should turn from their wayward ways and live a better life.

At this sacred moment
we turn our thoughts to those
who have gone from this life.
We recall the joy of their companionship.
We feel a pang, the echo of that intenser grief
when first their death lay before our stricken eyes.
Now we know that they will never vanish,
so long as heart and thought remain within us.
By love are they remembered,
and in memory they live.

O God, grant that their memory
may bring strength and blessing . . .
May we, carrying on their work,
help to redeem Your promise
that life shall yet prevail. (1978: 45)

Similarly, we read in another meditation:

As we turn from thoughts of death
to tasks of life, may we,

like those who came before us,
be builders of God's kingdom,
a world of justice and joy. (223)

In still another reading, we see a disavowal of an infinite, postlife experience. Here a "cycle" of life and death is mentioned but not an afterlife leading to a resurrection in some future time.

The light of life
is a finite flame.
Like a candle,
life is kindled:
it burns,
it glows,
it is radiant with warmth and beauty.
But soon it fades;
its substance is consumed,
and it is no more . . .
Something of us can never die:
we move in the eternal cycle
of darkness and death,
of light and life. (73)

Other readings were collected from American Reform rabbis and congregations who produced their own prayer books or service pamphlets. Some use traditional theological language. Others express a philosophical perspective. Still others voice a humanistic cry. They all include statements that interweave descriptions of feeling states with traditional symbolic, religious expression. These readings give expression in the words and syntax of modern American culture to the voice of the person who mourns and is experiencing grief; they are meant to be read aloud.

In many of these passages, human life is seen as being finite rather than infinite. There is an acceptance of the feelings of loss, of missing the loved one's company, friendship, and companionship. The harsh reality of death is dealt with by focusing on the love we can feel, which once again can be experienced by the mourner standing together with the community and facing the future. Rather than hoping for some reunion with the dead in a future life, the mourner is encouraged to experience his

or her feelings, maintain the memories, and move back into life. These mourner's prayers prescribe the four tasks of mourning: accept the reality of the loss, experience the feelings of grief, adjust to an environment in which the loved one is missing, find a way or place to locate emotionally that which is lost and move on.

The mourner is encouraged to remember the life of the one who has died and to acknowledge that through memory he or she remains connected to this life. The readings normalize what may disquiet the mourner—vivid memories—and states that by reexperiencing the affection and accepting the death of the loved one one can find a kind of peacefulness that "dispels the darkness" of grief. While it is recognized that each life is finite, somehow the "light" of being is passed on to the next generation in an endless cycle. And the individual life is now seen as part of a historic community, "builders of God's kingdom, a world of justice and joy." This is one way of overcoming "existential loneliness." It is also a way of intertwining the ancient meanings of a people with modern categories of meaning. While an individual's life may be finite, one can find peace in the reality that one is connected with a past as well as a future. But one must choose to participate in this scheme, honoring the past by keeping the memories alive.

Another example, from a memorial service for the Holocaust, seeks to reconcile multiple historical perspectives.

> Jewishness is a badge of eternity.
> The history of our people
> follows the course
> of almost every recorded century
> and finds its memories in a thousand lands.
> We have known the ecstasy of victory.
> We have also felt the pain of defeat.
> Our heroes of wisdom are numberless
> and grace the faith of many cultures.
> Our victims of suffering
> are even greater in number,
> swept up
> by the winds of destruction
> and blown into the fury of human hate.
> Both our successes and failures have been intense.
> We are not a moderate people.

Recent years
have added to the sadness of our martyrdom. Millions
perished in a
holocaust of horror
that defies
the description of prose.
Our people
were used in
a catharsis of cruelty
that few ages can equal.
The murder of our victims was an intolerable evil that reveals
the darker side of human desire.
We pay tribute to their lives by
refusing despair,
and by affirming
the ironic hope of their final song.
In the midst of a war of death,
they sang their dream
of a world of life.

We believe in the triumph
of justice.
Even though it has not yet come,
we still believe.

The author of this piece focuses on the reality of death and grief in relation to the Holocaust. Used during a relatively recently introduced annual ritual, a community service in honor of those slain during the Holocaust, this reading explores some of the themes associated with this tragic event. The author places the Holocaust in a historical setting. This historical account includes not just the retelling of events but a statement of the feelings of the people. The Jews have "known the ecstasy of victory" and the "pain of defeat." There is an acknowledgment that "both our successes and failures have been intense." The Holocaust is an event that "defies description." So how is one to deal with the numbness that results from this kind of trauma? Despair? The writer identifies with the victims in recalling "their final song." This refers to a medieval poem written by Maimonides entitled "Ani Maamin," (I Believe). However, this reading restates the traditional hope for the messianic times, a

"world of life," but not entirely in traditional terms. By idealizing the dead and their "dream," the living can find the energy and in psychological terms erect a defense that will allow them to refuse despair, all in tribute to the dead. In spite of it all, the living still believe in the "triumph of justice," and this enables them to build some kind of committed life as identified Jews. Alternatively, this reading provides for those seeking a more universal outlet:

> We pay tribute
> to the people of all ages.
> In the long saga of human adventure
> men and women of many cultures
> delivered their genius to posterity.
> The roster of their names is too long for recollection.
> They reached out from their parochial setting
> and touched the world with their universal wisdom.
> Philosophers and poets,
> scientists and statesmen,
> went beyond their familiar setting and stirred the hearts
> and minds of those who thought
> them alien.
> Truth is the possession of no national monopoly. It is the
> product of no ethnic passion.
> It is the gift of all people to every person.
>
> We give our homage to human greatness.
> We pay with affection our debt of gratitude. Neither race nor
> tribal custom can obscure the oneness of humanity in the
> pursuit of truth. Neither the lust for war
> nor the cruelty of hate
> can sever the bonds of identity that tie all men and women
> together in the unity of common need and shared dreams.

With this example, we move from particularist to universal concerns. Here there is a recognition of the commonality of death among all people. As well, the writer points out the commonality of feeling within all people: "We pay with affection our debt of gratitude." The reading presents a sort of "ecological" perspective in which all cultures participate in a greater pursuit, the "pursuit of truth." This represents the new social context in which we live. It ties together disparate peoples. The

author describes a vision of one world, where men and women are to acknowledge their unit in "common need and shared dreams." The search for the meaning of death, a shared human concern, becomes an avenue for human unity. As part of a community ritual, this kind of reading instructs those present to look beyond their clannishness. The awareness it represents fits well in a multicultural America and helps to define *community* in a new way.

These examples give us a glimpse into the newly forming religious context of modern American Jewish religious culture. In our current phase, we are focused more on the feelings and psychological state of the mourner than on the purpose of the divine. The language employed in the modern liturgy shows different ways of articulating the mourning processes, sometimes paralleling those described by modern writers on the psychology of loss. Whereas the discourse on death has changed through time, the ritualizing around death, the mourning experience, and the mourner's kaddish are constants, anchoring modern Jews to Jewish traditions. Paradoxically, we see that the experience of death, with its variant as well as invariant prayers, helps to define what life, for the individual and the community, is about.

New understandings and interpretations, replacing those that formerly encoded the order, may signify major social and cultural changes. This seems to be the case with regard to the contemporary Jewish understanding of the afterlife, resurrection, and the messianic times of the world to come. A site of disputation in ancient times, in the modern context it may once again be the location for a pivotal debate whose repercussions are not yet obvious. In other words, the site in the liturgy that for a significant part of the past two thousand years helped to structure the understanding of Judaism about the death of the body and related the life of the individual to the long-term history of the people might once again be a site for change. The outcome of the debate may leave the meaning of the liturgical order altered for the community. We are witnessing, then, a moment in the religious culture of a people wherein the ritual is being adapted to new circumstances. It is a moment to be noted and studied, for the process of change is, so to speak, "on the surface" and available to all who are interested in studying such processes.

Conclusion

Near the end of the "Obvious Aspects of Ritual" Rappaport spells out another part of his ritual theorizing.

> So far I have spoken only of the sacred, which is in language and which faces language and the public orders built upon language. But the sacred is only one component or aspect of a more inclusive phenomenon which I call the Holy. The other aspect of the Holy, which following Rudolph Otto (1923), may be called the "numinous," is its nondiscursive, ineffable, or emotional aspect—what is called "religious experience" (James 1903) in the broadest sense. (1979: 211)

He goes on to suggest, using Erik Erikson's work, that there is a psychological underpinning to the numinous.

> Erikson's ontogenetic suggestion has phylogenetic implications. If ontogeny has a phylogeny and if the mother-child relationship among humans is but a variant of the primate or even mammalian pattern, it may be that the basis of the numinous is archaic, antedating humanity, and it may further be that religion came into being when the emerging, discursive, conventional sacred was lashed to the primordial, non-discursive, mammalian emotional processes that in their later form we call "numinous." (212)

It might not be coincidental, then, that much of the modern inserts into the liturgy expounding the meaning of the kaddish should be centered on the psychological and emotional life of the people. Elsewhere in "The Obvious Aspects of Ritual" he wrote:

> Moreover, given the extent to which in solitary rituals various parts of the psyche may be brought in touch with each other it is reasonable to take ritual to be auto-communicative as well as allo-communicative (Wallace 1966: 237 ff.). Auto-communication is important even in public rituals. In fact, the transmitters of ritual messages are often, if not always, their most significant receivers. (1979: 178)

The discursive descriptions of affective states of those who are mourning, taken together with interpretations of modern events, bring into the ritual structure and confer to the kaddish rubric new meaning; they achieve the goal of helping to re-create the ancient ritual in the modern context while maintaining a connection to the ultimate sacred

postulate. Thus, for these religionists the sacred now flows through the individual feeling states and interpretive moves to which the modern liturgical interpretations of Reform Judaism give voice. The discourse of modernity allows for the articulation of the feelings and meaning of the participants' responses as part of communal process. In some sense, then, the feelings and emotional states of the congregation have been canonized in the liturgy, their psyches made sacred.

Rappaport wrote that "Nature is seen by humans through a screen of beliefs, knowledge, and purposes, and it is in terms of their images of nature, rather than of the actual structure of nature, that they act" (1979: 97). Any religious symbol system that represents the human body and provides an indication of its meaning in relation to the sacred would in Rappaport's thinking be of the utmost significance. This is especially true when one participates in a ritual like the reading of the kaddish, which speaks directly to the subject. As one identifies and merges with the meaning of the ritual, the resulting actions and behaviors a participant is bound to perform might make all the difference in the continuation of the life of the individual as well as the group to which he or she belongs.

If, for instance, the belief in an afterlife wherein the physical bodies of the righteous will be resurrected and reconstituted by an all powerful and supernatural deity was found to be wanting in its truth value or challenged by a rational natural scientific account that the ancients who fabricated the belief did not have at their disposal, then perhaps the motivation to live a righteous life would be diminished or lost. Other understandings and meanings, such as pleasure and material gain, might supplant righteousness. In addition, if righteous action, the *mitzvah,* is the key connector to and purpose of the divinely lived life, as it is in Rabbinic Judaism, then the way to connect oneself with the sacred, if one is Jewish, ostensively would be lost. In Rappaport's terms, once an understanding in the cognized model is found wanting, the entire ritual system, if it does not adjust, may fail the participants by not giving them access to the sacred and thus may lead to maladaptive behavior.[3]

This brings us back to the opening concern of the rabbi and the convention. His remarks were aimed at beliefs, but not beliefs alone. He also objected to the encoding of new understandings in the fixed ritual. This kind of debate represents the conserving dynamic and internal control a system exerts over change, even after changes are introduced. In "Sanctity and Lies in Evolution," Rappaport warns: "Since the conditions and even the rules of play are likely to change, flexibility—the

capacity for orderly self-transformation—is advantageous, rigid commitment to particular modes of play—particular conventions or institutions—is disadvantageous, or even lethal" (1979: 233).

For many creators of liturgy, the core motivating principle is to choose a model for liturgical involvement through which the sacred may flow. It is possible to accomplish this within the theory of Rappaport if the institutionalized forms of religion allow for the importing of interpretations that connect the worshippers to both their common world of everyday life and to the sacred. By disentangling the lower orders of meaning from those that represent the ultimate sacred postulate, the modern Jewish liturgist may be able to reconnect and rebuttress the ritual structure with the necessary new meanings, which represent adaptations to the new historical circumstances of the Jewish people.

This is the significance of the newly composed interpretations of the kaddish. It may be that no singular interpretation may gain hegemony over others. The social moment may call for a diverse group of interpretations to be held in a community in which there are diverse points of view. In fact, allowing for diversity may be an adaptive move for a religion interconnected with a democratic and multicultural society. New understandings in psychology and transformations in our understanding of the body and how it works will probably continue to emerge. It may be useful to see them in the light of what Rappaport taught:

> [W]e see two routes to truth: discovery and fabrication, two routes corresponding to humanity's dual nature. We are a species that lives and can only live in terms of meanings we must fabricate in a world devoid of intrinsic meaning but subject to physical law. I have argued that fundamental to fabricated truths are those established in liturgy. . . .
>
> I will only note at the end that law and meaning, the discovered and the fabricated, do not necessarily live easily together and that, therefore, humanity faces some terrible contradictions. . . .
>
> It seems to me, at the end, that dealing with this fundamental contradiction is central to any and all attempts to reclaim rites. (1993b: 50)

The outcome of the debate over the afterlife, the separation of the soul from the body, and the resurrection of the body in the world to

come will be rooted in such contradictions. The influence of these new interpretations on this world may be more than a simple insert into the liturgy might imply.

NOTES

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1. It is not commonly known, because of the discursive turn in modern Judaism I am discussing, that notions of a personal messiah, resurrection, and a "world to come" where the Temple will be rebuilt in Jerusalem are all present in the traditional Jewish liturgy in the benedictions of the Tefillah, also known as the Amidah or Shmoneh Esreh. Two authoritative translations, with commentary, can be found in Birnbaum 1949: 81–98 and Hertz 1952: 131–57.

2. One of the earliest usages of the idea of resurrection in the literature is found in 2 Macc. 7 and 4 Macc. 8.18. The dates of their composition are uncertain, and no liturgy is mentioned. The prayers in the liturgy would of necessity been composed after the destruction of the Temple and the dispersion of the people since they call for the rebuilding of the Temple and a return to the land.

3. As an example of this, some believe, with tragic hindsight in the case of the Jews of the Holocaust, that the traditional religious system led them to wait upon salvation in life after death rather than reacting in a way that would have saved lives. Others propose, quoting Jewish tradition again, that the Holocaust was a divine punishment. These positions, supported by themes represented in the traditional liturgy, are untenable for many.

The early Zionists, as another example, who boasted of a newfound faith in secular ideas, did not wait for a personal messiah or an ingathering of the exiles and were not counting on a future reward for their righteousness through resurrection. They followed a different model of behavior than that which is presented in the liturgy. They were "proactive" in establishing an army, a school system, banking, and the like. Part of the debate in modern Jewish life is over the beliefs that will survive the tragic events of this century.

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Monolith or the Tower of Babel? Ultimate Sacred Postulates at Work in Conservative Christian Schools

Melinda Bollar Wagner

Are America's conservative Christians a myriad of disparate groups or a coalescing monolith capable of wielding considerable political and social power? It has been said that groups with various agendas are uniting into just two camps — the conservative orthodoxy, characterized by "commitment to an external and transcendent authority," and the liberal progressives, who tend "to resymbolize historic faiths according to the prevailing assumptions of contemporary life" (Hunter 1991: 44–45). This phenomenon, which began in the religious arena, has spilled over into politics, education, and other institutions of American life and has been labeled "culture wars" (Hunter 1991).

Research in Christian schools suggests that a confluence of conservative Christians *is* taking place. How could members of these dissimilar — even discordant — groups fuse? Roy A. Rappaport's theory explaining social system adaptation helps us to understand the conservative Christian union. If Rappaport's suppositions are correct, and if I am right in my application of these concepts to the conservative Christian situation, then the conservative Christians and their coalitions are here to stay.

First, let's explore conservative Christianity, then discuss Rappaport's theory of the adaptability of social systems, and then elucidate the former by means of the latter.

Conservative Christians and Their Schools

I came to understand conservative Christian culture through a study of Christian schools. In recent years, Christian schools — private day schools with a conservative Christian orientation — have experienced tremendous

growth. They have been the fastest-growing sector of American education over the last thirty years. Today some 1.5 million students, representing at least 25 percent of all children enrolled in private schools, attend about eleven thousand Christian schools (National Center for Education Statistics 1995).

I explored the culture within conservative Christian schools through full-time anthropological participant observation for a year and a half. The research area, "Southeastern Valley" (names of places are pseudonyms), included all of the Christian schools in one county located in the southeastern part of the United States, plus two larger schools in the closest city, for a total of nine schools. In addition, primary data were collected from twenty-five Christian schools and from over one hundred national organizations that support Christian schools in a variety of ways. The valley schools' sponsoring churches identified themselves as Independent Baptist, Wesleyan, Full Gospel, Charismatic Renewal, Holiness Pentecostal, Independent Pentecostal, and Holiness (not Pentecostal). Thus, they covered the gamut of the fundamentalist, evangelical, new charismatic, and older Holiness and Pentecostal categories of conservative Christians (Wagner 1990).

I use *conservative Christians* as an umbrella term. It has the ethnographic advantage of incorporating the term they use for themselves—*the Christians*—yet it serves to distinguish these particular Christians from more liberal mainstream ones.

The varying strands of conservative Christianity are sufficiently similar with respect to doctrinal beliefs and social attitudes to cause them to be designated as a religious grouping or family by those who map the American religious scene (Roof and McKinney 1987; Wuthnow 1988). But Marsden (1982: 165) has characterized conservative Christianity as "a complex combination of traditions and beliefs."

To develop a taxonomy of these groups is a process of unpacking a box within a box within a box. All of the conservative Christians believe in the literal truth of the Bible.[1] In general, *evangelicals* are taken to be more conservative than the liberal "mainline" churches and less conservative than *fundamentalists.* Evangelicals are more likely to embrace ecumenism; fundamentalists are viewed as more separatist and exclusive. *Charismatics* believe in the gifts of the spirit, such as speaking in tongues and spiritual healing, as do the older *Pentecostals;* fundamentalists believe that, although these gifts were used in biblical times, they are

not meant for human use today. Some *Holiness* churches are Pentecostal, and some are not.

They all believe that a personal relationship with Jesus Christ is necessary in order to be "saved" and have eternal life in heaven. Their own definition of *Christian* is made clear in this exchange between two teachers: "Is she a Christian?" "Well I know she goes to church, but I don't know if she has a personal relationship with Jesus" (field notes). As another teacher put it, "If a person believes in his heart and confesses with his mouth that Jesus Christ is Lord and that God has raised Him from the dead, that person shall be saved." The alternative is the lake of fire in hell.

In conservative Christian ideology, when God brought Jesus Christ to earth and allowed him to die to atone for the sins of humankind he offered salvation, by his grace, to all who would choose it. This choice, it is thought, is proffered by God's grace, and no amount of good deeds ("works") people might do can make them good enough for heaven. Here the conservative Christians say they differ from mainline liberal Protestantism, which, they say, uses a "balance scale" approach—weighing peoples' good and bad attributes and behavior—to determine their after-death fates.

Holiness churches, which grew out of the Wesleyan Methodist tradition, disagree with Baptists (and the new charismatics), who believe that once you have taken on the personal relationship with Jesus you are saved and nothing you can do will prevent you from going to heaven; this is called security of salvation or eternal salvation. Wesleyan and Holiness churches believe that your behavior can "backslide" to the point where you can again become "lost." The Wesleyan and Holiness beliefs allow for man's fall from grace and also for his perfectibility. The evangelical Presbyterian Church in America (PCA) and some Baptist groups hold to a Calvinist doctrine of the "total depravity" of humans and "unconditional election" by God to a saved state (field notes).

Those are the basics. There are many other more subtle doctrinal differences to be found within the conservative Christian milieu, as just two examples—concerning the beginning and the end of the world—will show. There are several conservative interpretations of Genesis. The Institute for Creation Research uses a "short earth" interpretation, with the earth having been created less than six thousand years ago. But the Dakes Bible, and Jimmy Swaggert, teach a "long earth" interpretation,

with the earth (and dinosaurs) having existed before Adam and Eve were created.

Most of today's conservative Christians are premillennial, believing that this world will end and Jesus will return to reign on earth. But they differ with regard to how much of the devastating "end times" the saved Christians will be called upon to live through. They talk of pretrib, midtrib, and posttrib exegeses, which refer to being "raptured out" to heaven at the beginning, in the middle, or at the end of the tribulation. Some believe that in these times "to the just will go the spoils of the wicked," so that the saved will live in luxury; others vehemently deny the scriptural soundness of this interpretation. These differences do not stay within the evangelical, charismatic, or fundamentalist lines.

How have these disparate groups been able to coalesce into one side in the culture wars? Their ideological differences reach back to the Protestant Reformation; the chasms deepened as the various groups reacted to "modernism"—especially the teaching of evolution, the restructuring of the family, and the kind of scholarship that challenges the inerrant nature of the Bible. The split between fundamentalists and evangelicals hardened in the 1940s. Schisms gave rise to the Pentecostals in the first decade of the 1900s, and the new charismatics sprang up in the 1960s.

Clues to the coalition-building process are found in the fact that these dissimilar believers have been able to send their children to the same private Christian schools. Evidence suggests that Christian schools have transformed themselves from schools that were strongly tied to a particular church, and thus denominationally based, to more generic institutions, serving families of several denominations. Market research undertaken by curriculum purveyors confirms that schools across the nation are in increasing numbers moving in this direction (Mooers 1989). This has widened the audience each school can serve and thus is adaptive for their long-range survival.

Rappaport on Adaptation

Systems that are adaptive, "including social systems, do not have special goals or outputs, their properly adaptive goal being nothing more specific than to persist, which is to say to continue to be able to transform themselves in response to the vicissitudes of history and environment" (Rappaport 1979: 232). According to Rappaport, in order to be adaptive, in the sense of continuing to exist, a social system needs a hierarchi-

cal set of principles. At the top end of this hierarchy are "ultimate sacred postulates." An example Rappaport (117) uses is "the Jewish declaration of faith called the *Shema* ('Hear, O Israel the Lord our God, the Lord is One')". Ultimate sacred postulates "sanctify, which is to say certify, the entire system of understandings in accordance with which people conduct their lives."

To be effective adaptive mechanisms, ultimate sacred postulates must have certain characteristics.

1. They must contain no material referents; this renders them unverifiable but also unfalsifiable. "Yet they are taken to be unquestionable, immutable, and eternal." They are "mystically known" and "ritually accepted" (1979: 121, 129). Rappaport (209, 228) defines *sanctity* itself as "the quality of unquestionableness imputed by [the faithful] to postulates in their nature neither verifiable nor falsifiable."
2. They are not concrete. They must not be conflated with instrumental values, which specify the dos and don'ts of life in a particular society. Those values that specify social arrangements should stay on a lower rung of the hierarchical ladder. This protects ultimate sacred postulates and their sanctity from being challenged by rule modifications that may become necessary to accommodate changing historical and environmental circumstances.

A point I want to make here is that ultimate sacred postulates allow and sanctify not only social *change* but also *diversity.* Although ultimate sacred postulates themselves do not specify particular social arrangements, "they provide the ground, deeper than logic and beyond logic's reach" for these specifics (Rappaport 1979: 119). "Truthfulness, reliability, correctness, naturalness, and legitimacy are vested in conventions and conventional acts by their association with ultimate sacred postulates" (211).

3. They must be invariant, providing continuity and a special, timeless quality. Instrumental values can change; ultimate sacred postulates are "regarded as eternal verities." The unchanging ultimate sacred postulates can provide the underpinnings for changing [or diverse] instrumental values because of the vagueness implicit in the ultimate sacred postulates (155).

"If they are vague the association of the ultimate and eternal with the immediate realities of history requires continual interpretation. Interpretation and reinterpretation do not challenge ultimate sacred postulates, but only previous interpretations of them" (155–56).

Thus, "the adaptive connection of the timeless sacred and the immediate numinous to the continuing here and now" remains unchallenged (Rappaport 1979: 243). Ultimate sacred postulates' vagueness, abstract nature, and lack of material referents (which make them immune to falsification) render them adaptive in the long view of a society's changing history.

Rappaport (1979: 117–21) discovered several levels in an adaptive hierarchical system that he studied. These levels grow increasingly concrete and changeable as we move from top to bottom. The hierarchical ladder's steps are characterized by "sanctity, mutability, concreteness, specificity, and immediacy." A similar hierarchy can be discerned in Christian schools. In these schools, the highest level—Rappaport's ultimate sacred postulates—are represented by the Statement of Faith. The level under this is what the conservative Christians call "church doctrine"—this is denomination specific. A still lower level is each school's handbook, which specifies the rules of the school—"rules and taboos concerning action appropriate or inappropriate in terms of the understandings of the cosmological structure that informs them."

Applying Rappaport's Model of Adaptation to Conservative Christianity

How have the various branches of conservative Christendom—some would say strange bedfellows indeed—managed to coalesce into one side in "the culture wars"? The culture of Christian schools can provide some insight. In order to adapt, which is to say to keep their doors open, Christian schools needed to reach out to an audience wider than the children of one sponsoring church. The schools are at least partially motivated by this "self-interest" when they decide to allow diversity in the student body (see Ortner 1984 on "interest theory").[2]

Diversity is Desired

Certainly, the Christian schools are not as diverse as American society at large. In fact, it might be said that creating a "haven" of homogeneity is

their reason for being. But the schools are not as homogeneous as they *could* be. The most exclusive and homogeneous schools would house only teachers and children who attend the one sponsoring church. Next on the continuum would be schools with pupils from cooperating churches in a single denomination. None of the schools in Southeastern Valley fit these descriptions. Among the myriad administrators and teachers I met at national meetings, only one school (sponsored by a Pentecostal Holiness church) fit this description. The other schools prided themselves on a *degree* of ecumenism; that is, they welcomed students from any conservative Christian background.

In Southeastern Valley and City, no school's student body hailed solely from the sponsoring church. So there is diversity among the families of the students and in some cases, among the teachers. Indeed, increased mixing in the student body is a national trend (Mooers 1989). (Although national organizations that support Christian schools advocate casting the net even further, conceiving of schools as places for both "discipleship" for believers and "evangelization" for nonbelievers, school principals who tried this have abandoned it, saying that "It made for a reform school atmosphere" [field notes].)

The accommodations for diversity in the schools have pushed doctrinal particulars out the schoolhouse windows; ultimate sacred postulates remain. They have managed to open the doors wider (and thus keep them open), it seems to me, by lopping off denominational specifics from the ideologies upon which the schools are founded. In order to maintain their adaptability—specifically, to cast a wider net for potential students—the schools have taken steps to remove the "church doctrine" level of the hierarchical system from their operations. The potential for divisiveness and insularity inherent in these more specific statements would harm the schools' adaptive potential. They must produce a "generic" form of Christian education that is not offensive to any sector of conservative Christianity and leave the more specific aspects of doctrine and behavior rules to the family and the church. "Doctrinal purity" is left at the schoolyard gate.[3]

This serves to retain the vaguest, most abstract, least material portions of their ideological statements, thus rendering these statements more viable ultimate sacred postulates. These ultimate sacred postulates can be agreed upon by conservative Christians of many stripes—who then feel free to send their children to the schools. It is the common core of conservative Christian belief that the schools, trying to appeal to

children of more than one church, present to the world in their statements of faith.

Ultimate Sacred Postulates: A Generic Statement of Faith for Christian Schools

An analysis of the statements of faith of schools with a wide variety of denominational affiliations revealed the ultimate sacred postulates at the highest level of the hierarchy. The analysis included ten schools sponsored by six different denominations, plus twelve national support organizations.[4]

In order to give the reader an idea of the central beliefs under which these schools and their supporting organizations operate, we should note that a "generic" statement of faith includes what all of their statements had in common. No two statements were worded exactly alike, yet the content was much the same and certain wordings did recur. These, then, are their fundamentals, beliefs to which all of the Christian schools I researched and the various supporting organizations would adhere: the inerrancy of the Bible, the Trinity, the virgin birth, the Holy Spirit, salvation attained by the grace of God through the blood of Jesus, and the return of Christ resulting in "the everlasting conscious blessedness of the saved and the everlasting conscious punishment of the lost."

These six articles of faith were agreed upon by all of the schools and organizations, whether charismatic, evangelical, fundamentalist, or Holiness in sponsorship. In the various Christian schools sponsored by many different churches from many different denominations the ultimate sacred postulates are, then, much alike. Indeed, the "commitment to an external and transcendent authority" by which Hunter (1991: 44–45) characterizes the "orthodoxy" side of the culture wars is itself an ultimate sacred proposition.

The next level in the hierarchy is more concrete and less vague. In Christian schools, this is the church doctrine that is denomination specific and has been depreciated.

Church Doctrine Is Minimized

The schools I researched exhibited few of the differences that I had predicted, given their varying denominational histories. These schools, sponsored by seven different conservative Christian denominations,

show that knowing the denominational affiliation of the sponsoring church or parents is not sufficient to predict the schools' characteristics. The schools do, of course, have statements of rules representing the lowest, most specific, concrete, and immediate level of the hierarchy. These, too, are surprisingly alike. There are differences, but they do not seem to be tightly bound with doctrinal differences among the sponsoring churches. (In future writings, I plan to posit that the rule variations are a reflection of cultural style distinctions more closely associated with socioeconomic differences than with ideological principles.)

Why do the schools have this panconservative Christian quality? Why don't they reflect the sponsoring churches' denominational differences (as I predicted they would before entering the field)? The answer lies in the first words the school administrators said when I asked them to name the salient features of their schools. They told me that, since their schools include students from several churches, the doctrinal edges are honed down. Time and again, conservative Christians from a variety of denominations said, "We really all *believe* the same way; . . . we'll all be together in heaven."

- "We don't teach church doctrine here." (field notes, HCA; also field notes, CCCA)
- "At DCS, the kids have different religions; we teach about God and Jesus." (field notes, DCS)
- "We have kids from all backgrounds. . . . And we're not there to specifically make Baptists out of them. We're there to provide a Christian atmosphere." (interview, MR)
- "We're trying to bring several churches together here—so we don't preach on that. . . . Fundamentalists, nondenominational, charismatics, all come to the same point. As long as it's from a biblical standpoint. . . . Because schools are servicing children from more than one church, they cannot afford to mingle into church philosophy. It's like walking down a hallway. There are many doors—like classrooms in a school corridor [that represent the different churches]. . . . As a school, you have to stay in the hallway and teach children in a way that's beneficial to the society as a whole—not to any particular church—and not be negative toward any particular church. . . . No matter what the doorpost says." (field notes, GCA; also field notes, CCCA)
- "We're all doing our best to know what the Christian lifestyle is, to

harm as few as possible, to draw as many as possible unto Christ. It shouldn't be so that your doctrine makes someone else stumble or fall away. . . . As Christians we'll all be in heaven together." (field notes, GCA; also field notes, CCCA)

- "We're all trying to do what God wants us to do, trying to keep Christ at the center." (interview, LT)

To emphasize that they are not denominationally bound, none of the schools is called Faith Baptist Academy or Faith Full Gospel School, or Faith Wesleyan School. All are called simply Faith *Christian* School or Academy. Only two use a name similar to those of their sponsoring churches. One school changed its name from one linked to a church to the name of its hometown to further demonstrate its wide appeal. Aware of the basic similarities, teachers from several of the schools desired an "all Christian" high school in Southeastern Valley, for which the several Christian elementaries would serve as "feeder schools."

We can envision schools in which the ideology of the particular sponsoring denominations are taught and the rituals of these denominations are played out. For example, picture a school run by charismatic parents. On chapel day you would expect to see hands raised high in the familiar "praise" salute used by the charismatics. When a child had been hurt on the playground, you might expect healing of the laying on of hands sort (as well as first aid). If the teachers served as role models for the children's correct ritual behavior, you might expect to hear speaking in tongues during chapel.

In reality, the doctrinal differences among the charismatic, evangelical, and fundamentalist strands of conservative Christendom did not prove to be good predictors of the schools' modes of operation because they have been minimized by administrators.

For example, one (fundamentalist) Bob Jones University graduate, working in campus ministries, asked the administrator of Grace Christian Academy, a school sponsored by charismatic parents, this question about the school: "How does the charismatic figure into it?" She emphatically relied, "It doesn't. No one goes around getting slain in the spirit." This was, in fact, borne out by observation. In one year of observing at this school, I saw not a single behavior that is a "marker" of charismatics, with one exception (once the first and second grade teacher prayed for a hurt little girl while raising one arm in the air). There really was no "getting slain in the spirit," no speaking in tongues, no laying on of hands

healing, although there were prayers for healing, as there were in all the schools.

In every school, doctrinal particulars and lower-level rules for living were rarely mentioned, just as the Christian school administrators told me they would not be. If they were raised by students, they were quickly dealt with by referring the student to his or her home church and family for guidance.

An example occurred on charismatic-sponsored Grace Christian Academy's playground. Two kindergartners had a set-to when Sandra accused Gena of liking rock music because she said she liked Cyndi Lauper. They brought the dispute to the teacher, who had never heard of Cyndi Lauper but quickly realized that she was an alleged rock star. She said, "Sandra, you let Gena's mother tell her what she can listen to, and you let your mother tell you what you can listen to" (field notes, GCA). A high school teacher at Baptist-sponsored Abundant Life Christian Academy took a young girl to task for wearing a boy's class ring (from one of City's public schools). The student objected, "My mom said I could" (field notes, ALCA).

Diversity raised its head at Dells Christian School when three first- and third-grade girls planning a sleepover asked their young hostess to "Get scary (video)tapes." One suggested the movie *Ghostbusters.* Another warned, "No, not *Ghostbusters;* that's kind of dirty." The third little girl had already seen it (field notes, DCS).

A diversity of opinion among parents about whether children should be allowed to believe in fantasy characters such as the tooth fairy, the Easter Bunny, and Santa Claus became apparent around Christmastime at Grace Christian Academy. The controversy started in a van transporting fifth and sixth graders to the public library. They sang "White Christmas" and then "Santa Claus Is Coming to Town," which precipitated an argument over whether there really is a Santa Claus. A sixth-grade boy, the son of a teacher, Mrs. Nichols, was adamant that there was not: "There is no Santa Claus. Well, there is; his name is Raymond Nichols. And there's an Easter Bunny; her name is Frances Nichols" (field notes, GCA).

The argument continued the next time they went to the library. It came to a head around a table where two fifth-grade girls who were "believers" and three sixth-grade girls who were not were reading Christmas books, among them, *The Truth about Santa Claus.* The sixth graders tried to convince the two younger girls that there was no Santa. Fifth grader Tina looked up at me with beseeching eyes. "There is a Santa

Claus, isn't there, Mrs. Wagner?" I stood mute and shrugged. As they argued the fine points of seeing and hearing evidence of Santa Claus, they continued to ask me, and debated whether I would know, anyway. I was fairly successfully skirting the issue when their teacher approached. Fifth grader Denise asked, "Mrs. Nichols, is there really a Santa Claus?" Without a moment's hesitation, the teacher answered, "No. There was, but he died—St. Nicholas." Denise protested, "My mother said there was." The teacher replied "Did your mother tell you that? Well, maybe in your family he's real" (field notes, GCA).

Another instance of eschewing church doctrine happened before my eyes when a school administrator, herself a member of the nondenominational charismatic church that sponsored the school, was hiring a teacher who attended an independent Baptist church. The candidate was filling out paperwork when she came into the principal's office with the required statement of faith in hand. "You know, I can sign that I believe in all of these statements, except the last one." The last statement on the list affirmed the gifts of the spirit (speaking in tongues, healing, etc.) that the charismatic Christian founders of this school practiced. "Oh just mark that part out," the administrator advised without a moment's hesitation. It was not an ultimate sacred postulate.

It is easy to see that a church that opens a school for only its own children can dictate specific behaviors and rituals based on church doctrine. But if this is disallowed, then the ultimate sacred postulates—with which every kind of conservative Christian would agree—are what's left. Diversity in praxis encourages reliance on universal ultimate sacred postulates.

It would seem that the conservative Christians are aware that vague ultimate sacred postulates, allowing for interpretation and reinterpretation of the approved specific social arrangements, are adaptive for the survival of their culture in the long run. Just so, their schools are shaped into panconservative Christian academies based on the ultimate sacred postulates. In the culture found in the Christian schools, the ultimate conservative Christian message—how to be saved to live eternally and what happens if you are not—is steadfast. In the generic statement of faith, which we smelted from many such statements from a variety of Christian schools, this primary message was given voice this way: "Salvation is attained by the grace of God through the blood of Jesus. Whoever believes in Christ and will accept Him as Lord shall receive eternal life."

Although the conservative Christians say that the Bible (the Word)

contains specific rules for living, and although they hold national conferences to ferret out biblical solutions to modern problems (Coalition on Revival, Congress on the Bible, Appalachian Conference to Rebuild America), the fact that a variety of specific concrete behaviors are supported by different schools, which all subscribe to the same ultimate sacred postulates, shows that there is flexibility of interpretation at the instrumental or social arrangements level of building a Christian school culture.

The relationship between universal, broad, unchanging ultimate sacred postulates and diverse, specific, changing social arrangements was captured by one teacher when a jeans-clad student who attended one of the new charismatic churches asked why her classmate from a Holiness church (who happened to be absent that day) always wore skirts. Her teacher admonished, "It's not a salvation issue."

NOTES

1. Hunter (1987) found that a minority of students in a sample of evangelical colleges are softening on this position.

2. Elsewhere I have interpreted these changes as compromises with "the world" outside the conservative Christian milieu (Wagner 1990, 1995; Hrezo and Wagner 1997).

3. Notable exceptions are schools associated with charismatic communities (Huntington 1988; Rose 1988).

4. Five of the ten schools were sponsored by fundamentalist Baptist churches, two by charismatics, one by an evangelical Wesleyan church, one by an evangelical Presbyterian Church in America, and one upheld Holiness-Arminian doctrine. It included twelve support organizations: the American Association of Christian Schools, Acorn (curriculum materials associated with Jerry Falwell's Liberty University), Accelerated Christian Education, the Association of Christian Schools International, the Alpha Omega curriculum, CBN University, Central Wesleyan College, the Coalition on Revival, the American Christian Consortium for Education and Accreditation, Grace Theological Seminary, Oral Roberts University Educational Fellowship, and the Trans-National Association of Christian Schools, which is an organization for colleges (the latter four had simple statements, which did not include the point-by-point recitation of beliefs characteristic of the other statements of faith).

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Belief Beheld—Inside and Outside, Insider and Outsider in the Anthropology of Religion

James Peacock

Two features of this essay may seem at first glance to violate the emphasis of Rappaport's anthropology. On the one hand, I treat the conversion experience—radical transformation and transcendence—while his emphasis in the anthropology of religion is on constancy. The sacred is, for him, defined as carrying little information in the cybernetic sense precisely because it focuses on repetition, and ritual is thus the pivot (Rappaport 1971d, 1980b, 1988b). Associated with Rappaport's emphasis on ritual is an emphasis on public as opposed to private, collective rather than individual, "outside" rather than "inside"; I probe the intersections of these seeming opposites. On the other hand, I deal with the place of reflexivity and interpretative questions, while his anthropology of science has appeared to emphasize positivistic search for law and regularity. But these seeming dissonances conceal a deeper resonance with the work, life, and thought of Rappaport.

To address the positivism, first note that in recent years Rappaport called for a synergy between positivism and interpretivism, lauding the perspective of Steven Toulmin, who sees such a synergy emerging in the new science. Rappaport calls for anthropology to claim its deserved role in leading this synergy (Rappaport 1994c). I believe that the tempered reflexivity espoused and exemplified in this essay is in tune with this call.

On the question of conversion and its relation to the constancies that define the sacred, I note that Rappaport's anthropology of religion is always stretching toward the ineffable, ultimate, and transcendent even as it grounds itself in the objective, immediate, and constant; his perspective is Durkheim infused with Weber and Tillich or perhaps simply Rappaport's own dynamism pressing beyond the steady state

cybernetic homeostasis that his own systems theory/Durkheimian framework imposes. The direction of that pressing beyond is mysterious to me, but certainly it moves past grounding the sacred in visible and communal ritual toward the transcendental ground of being or the sense of meaning that Weber, Tillich, and others evoked. Accordingly, an exploration of the conversion experience, which epitomizes such transcendence, carries forward Rappaport's inquiries, or so I believe.

The word *conversion* also permits me to acknowledge a kind of conversion in my life, in the lives of other anthropologists, and perhaps of anthropology itself that came about because of Roy Rappaport.

When he was president of the American Anthropological Association, he organized a retreat at Dragoon, Arizona, which boldly addressed the issue of disorders in the world and what anthropology could do to solve them. For three years, several of us met and discussed and wrote on this question. The products include a book, *Diagnosing America* (Forman 1994), and a manifesto, an appendix in that book, that set forth prescriptions for anthropology that actually are being pursued today as "public" or "practicing" or "engaged" anthropology (cf. Basch et al., 1999). More importantly, participants have gone on to reach beyond narrow confines of the discipline and try to make a difference, through anthropology, in arenas beyond anthropology. Let me illustrate by noting activities by members of our particular panel at Dragoon. Shepard Forman moved into issues of human rights through his work at the Ford Foundation. Katherine Newman has moved to the Kennedy School at Harvard and is a public advocate. Emilio Moran has founded a center for environmental work. Michael Blakey has been a key spokesman on issues of expatriation. Ellen Messer is a leader in nutrition and human rights. Carlos Ibenez has expanded his work in applied social transformation. Frank Dubinskas, before his tragic and premature death, had become perhaps the first anthropologist to be appointed to a chair in international economics. I carried forward many of the precepts of our "manifesto" while president of the American Anthropological Association (and, in a different sphere, while serving at the same time as chair of the faculty at my university). Now, as director of a Center for International Studies, I seek further ways to reorient anthropology toward public issues. Looking back, I can identify no other equally compelling factor in shifting my focus from academic humanism to a more activist organizational thrust than the influence of Dragoon and the model of Rappaport; no doubt, the others would recognize a similar debt. While I admire and learn from Rappaport's scholarly

work, his great impact on me was as a prophetic activist—a charismatic and inspirational yet earthy and human leader who envisioned anthropology as a calling.

Apart from his activist side, however, Rappaport had an abiding interest in the anthropology of religion; in fact, he was a leader in bringing about the creation of a new section for that field within the American Anthropological Association, thus reviving one of the areas of anthropology that has been central since the late nineteenth century. The following essay takes up an issue of this field.[1]

The issue I address can be stated simply: the relation between inside and outside in religious experience. *Inside* refers to what we often term private, personal, the psyche, or perhaps the soul. *Outside* refers to what we often term public, collective, or the world.

A counterpoint to this inside/outside dialectic within the experience of the believer, the religious actor, is the relation of this actor to the observer: the believer as insider, the observer as outsider. This introduces the issue of reflexivity. These two insider/outsider pairs are not precisely parallel; in fact, their asymmetry leads to my conclusion.

This format may seem abstract. My materials will be concrete. They are ethnographic, drawn from fieldwork done over the past quarter century in Southeast Asia among Muslims and in the Southeast United States among Christians.

Both inside/outside aspects pose an issue in theory and method for the anthropology of religion. This is so at two levels. The first is at the level of the believer/participant. The second is the relation between the outsider observer, the beholder, and the believer/participant. Let us examine the first level first. In the contemporary anthropology of religion, it is still fair to say that the two greatest inspirations are Emile Durkheim and Max Weber.

Out of this Durkheimian/Weberian framework has come the pervasive anthropological perspective on the anthropology of religion: emphasizing its collective, public symbols and beliefs, an outer aspect. (For those who wish names, I am thinking of the British/European social-anthropological tradition extending from Durkheim through Leach, Douglas, Needham, Turner, and Lévi-Strauss and the American cultural anthropological stream extending through Clifford Geertz and Roy Rappaport.)

What are the reasons for this emphasis on the public, the outer

symbols? Most salient are two. First, public symbols make meanings public, hence observable, recordable, and analyzable, while private meanings are unobservable. Second, public and collective phenomena crystallize patterns that are somewhat structured and predictable, while private experiences—insofar as we can know anything about them at all—seem ephemeral, irregular, and unpredictable.

A related and basic reason is this existential condition of our practice: the anthropologist is by definition an outsider (this would be true even of a believer who, for the moment, is acting as an anthropologist—a beholder of beliefs). He or she, in the role of anthropologist, is the beholder of belief but not a believer. Paul Rabinow puts it simplistically and accusingly but cogently: "The anthropologist thus ends up studying what is serious and truthful to others without it being serious and truthful to him" (quoted in Lawrence 1989). Aside from such a cognitive gap, there is an experiential one between the methodologies and technologies of observation and the spiritual experience observed. Montana Locklear, a North Carolina Lumbee Indian Pentecostal preacher, described this situation with admirable pith. As my fellow fieldworker and colleague Ruel Tyson staggered into Locklear's church, laden with audio and video recorders, Montana introduced him: "Here's the brother professor. He's come to record the Holy Ghost."

This dilemma of being outside to the insider, beholder of the believer, is not lost on the anthropologist of religion. Essentially two solutions have been proposed: to get inside or stay outside. The first option is advised by Evans-Pritchard, who, after pessimistically surveying anthropological theories of religion, quotes with approval Wilhelm Schmidt, who says, "If religion is essentially of the inner life, it follows that it can be truly grasped only from within" (1965: 121). So Evans-Pritchard suggests becoming an insider, which he himself did, in a sense, by converting to Catholicism. But he does not consider this option within the scope of anthropology itself, which, for reasons already mentioned, remains essentially focused on the externals of religion. The second option is advised by Clifford Geertz: stay outside. We cannot know other minds, much less, one would assume, other souls. Therefore, concentrate on that which we can know: the external symbolism, the performances. Geertz advises: "Understanding the form and pressure of, to use the dangerous word one more time, natives' inner lives is more like grasping a proverb, catching an allusion, seeing a joke—or, as I have suggested, reading a poem—than it is like achieving a communion" (1983: 70).

Here, then, are wise precedents that advise us, as anthropologists, (1) to be outsiders and (2) to focus on the outside. Outsiders, beholders rather than believers, we treat religion only in its externals, such as its rites and publicly affirmed beliefs. And yet, so much of what our informants' experience tells us, what our own experience tells us, points not only to the significance of the inner, as Schmidt stated, but to the interplay of outside and inside and of outsider and insider. A more porous boundary is implied than by the dominant classic emphasis of our discipline.

Of course, there are subemphases, subtexts, we say, to the dominant formula: be an outsider, focus on the outside. Like psychoanalysis, anthropology also claims that as an outsider you can probe the inside better than the insider can. Objectivity is claimed to penetrate subjectivity in a way the subject himself or herself cannot, at least not without the help of the observer—the analyst, the ethnographer—who may in fact take a psychoanalytical perspective.[2] Even more convoluted dialectics are offered by some of our subjects, the fundamentalist Primitive Baptists. They argue that the apparent outsider may actually be more of an insider than the apparent insider, but neither should make what Calvin termed the "dread presumption" to claim to know the significance of evidence from inner experience.

Permit me to introduce a spokesman whom we'll encounter again, Elder Walter Evans, a recently deceased stonemason from the Blue Ridge Mountains, who was a Primitive Baptist elder. Elder Evans is preaching on pilgrimage. He says:

> If you feel today or ever feel, that you're a stranger or pilgrim in the earth, listen to what's said in the following verse: ". . . they confessed that they were strangers and pilgrims in the earth." I'm not saying this to make you sad. What I'm dealing with this morning, endeavoring to, has given me perhaps more consolation than any one verse or verses in all the Bible, . . . Because so much of the time . . . I'll not go into that, but I've felt so much of my time in my life, like a stranger.

We could devote a lecture to these lines, but three quick points are in order here. First, although words like *felt* are used, Evans' main referent is not psychological but theological. As he explained to me, his feeling a stranger hints that he may be a child of God, a member of the Elect, predestined for salvation. Second, feeling a stranger may also

mean feeling estranged from your own faith, as Evans himself testifies to having felt on occasion: "Observing the baptism, it meant nothing to me." Finally, anybody, including non–church members, unbelievers, even the anthropologist, may be a child of God. Paradoxically, the more you feel outside, the more you may, in fact, be inside, because to feel outside in this world is a sign, ambiguous to be sure, of possible elect status in the next.

So the Primitive Baptists provide a theology and imagery to refute and enrich too stark a distinction between inside and outside and to suggest a dialectical relation between the two. The believer/participant himself oscillates between estrangement and commitment, inside and outside. And between believer and observer the line is porous. Your stance of outsider is no unambiguous sign that you really are outside; in fact, it may be "evidence," as they say, that you are not. The more we would tell the Primitive Baptists that we were just observers, the more they would remind us that they, too, were observers, of us, and would discern small evidences that we were more than observers. Hear Mamie Osborne, another Blue Ridge Primitive Baptist, a beauty parlor operator, speaking to Beverly Patterson, a musicologist who was working with us:

> *Mamie:* This is really fascinating, that you do want to learn about us. I detected the enthusiasm that you had, and even seeing the two men, Mr. Peacock, and what was the other one's name?
>
> *Beverly:* Patterson and Tyson
>
> *Mamie:* Tyson, Tyson. . . . I wasn't thinking that the service was all that good, and here they had their ears just peeled, close you know, and I thought, well, it either had to be that they were wanting to learn for a job, or they were interested in what was being said for themselves. . . . I thought they were interested somewhat for themselves.

"Somewhat for themselves." She is astutely cautious, but hopeful, in integrating our statuses as observers and participants.

My quick survey of the anthropology of religion needs a brief supplement. Anthropology, like other humanistic fields, still grapples with a perspective often termed postmodernist. Postmodernism shifts the emphasis from what is known to the process of knowing and the stance of the knower. Postmodernism appears to assume that nothing can be known by the knower except his or her processes of knowing, hence the

experience of knowing—observing, listening, interacting—becomes our frame and our data. In philosophy, Hans-Georg Gadamer exemplifies this emphasis when he stresses that the truth of the message of a text is relative to the perspective of the interpreter of that text; we cannot know what the text says except by exploring our own perspective or horizon as we encounter the text (1982). In anthropology, Vincent Crapanzano exemplifies this viewpoint, emphasizing how his informants' narrations depend upon, virtually derive from, himself, the interlocutor, the ethnographer (1980). So, as postmodernists we get preoccupied with ourselves as observers and our impact on others, those whom we observe, encounter.

Yet others and their forms display, I find, a power and constancy independent of any influence I as observer may exert; furthermore, I discover that, far from me influencing them, it is they who are working on me. Especially is this true when those we are studying are of a conversionist, evangelical group. These "Others" feel empowered as a voice and vehicle of the all-powerful Other, the numinous supernatural Other, to whom the believer has converted and to whom he invites or exhorts the observer to convert. Just what impact such an invitation may have on the beholder is a further question; the point here is to affirm the empowerment of those beheld: of believer through belief, of narrator through narration. As Erik Erikson wrote concerning his work on Martin Luther, the clinical biographer attempting to deal with a client finds that the client has been dealing with him (1958).

We turn now from this methodological issue of the relation between outsider and converted-converting insider to our substantive focus: the movement from outside to inside, the conversion experience. What follows is a comparison, which I introduce with two epigrams.

> *E. E. Evans-Pritchard:* Social anthropology has but one method; it is the comparative method; it is impossible. (quoted in Needham 1983: 62)

> *Jonathan Z. Smith:* In comparison a magic dwells. (1982: 3)

The conversion experience, is, as we know, central to the history and phenomenology of Christianity. From Saul on the road to Damascus to Martin Luther on the road to Erfurt to John Wesley at Aldersgate to contemporary fundamentalism, testimonies and other accounts tell of

dramatic experiences of conversion. The conversion is from some previous state of sinfulness or unbelief to a categorical and absolute commitment and belief in Christ and Christianity. Such conversion is often dramatic and emotional, entailing some vision or altered state of consciousness. The convert experiences a loss of his or her old self and the rebirth of a new self. Theologically, the experience is interpreted as evidence of being saved or at least renewed or given some hope of eventual salvation. Among the "fundamentalists" I studied, this familiar general pattern was typically narrated by the males, to me at least, and it is men on whom I shall focus. One typical male narrative tells of a misspent wild youth and early manhood, drinking, dancing, chasing women, maybe staying out in the woods to hunt and make liquor. Then the wild man becomes convicted of his sins (i.e., found guilty by God), asks Jesus for forgiveness, accepts Christianity, joins a church, gives up his wild ways, and is now found with his family in the pew, or even, after further struggle to escape the call, in the pulpit or at the stand. More dignified variants resemble Puritan conversion narratives. Here are excerpts from Elder Walter Evans, the Calvinistic stonemason mentioned earlier:

> In the latter part of my twentieth year . . . when I cared nothing for God nor his people, satisfied with my big times attending places of worldly pleasure—my father insisted strongly that I attend a meeting being held by people of the Regular Baptist denomination, of which he and Mother were members. I finally agreed to go; however, my purpose was to walk home with some of the girls from the meeting.
>
> It was on Tuesday night while standing in the back of the house, a strong power arrested my heart and soul to the extent my body trembled under the weight like a leaf on a tree shaken by a mighty wind. A voice from somewhere, a still voice taut with power, said, "You are lost without God or hope in the world."

Walter Evans felt himself a sinner "by nature . . . doomed without God's mercy." He knelt at the altar, or "mourner's bench," and "begged God for mercy and pardon of [his] sins." "I was in desperate need of something to give me relief from this awful feeling of condemnation." He left the meetinghouse and went home, but nothing could bring relief: "Neither prayers of Dad and Mother, preachers, nor no one else could

reach my case." Evans prayed and suffered for two days and three nights, until a still voice said, "Your sins are all forgiven." He was raised to his feet "one happy man" and joined the congregation singing, "Christ will bear the Christian higher. When the last trumpet shall sound," his mountain tenor no doubt ringing out over all the voices, as it could still do in his eighties. "Before the song was ended, a call or strong impression came to me. . . . O, how I desired to tell what the Lord had done for me. I was in a new world." He was baptized on Sunday, November 16, 1930.

As I was working in 1970 among Muslims in Southeast Asia—in Indonesia primarily, but also in Singapore—I was struck by the absence of such conversion narratives. Certainly there were conversions. Objectively considered, some of the conversions to Islam entailed quite a radical change of commitment, for example, from Christianity or communism or syncretism (by *syncretism* I mean a distinctly Southeast Asian mix of Hinduism, Buddhism, and animism) to Islam, which is considered in many cultural, political, and phenomenological respects to be the polar opposite of these other faiths. But, however radical the conversion would seem, the Muslims did not, with one or two interesting exceptions, report a conversion *experience* with the emotional and altered states of consciousness noted in the Christian testimonies.

I turn now to a particular Muslim group, the Muhammadijah of Indonesia. Muhammadijah is a reformist Muslim movement in the basic sense that it strives to return to fundamentals: to return to the Qur'an as the literal word of God and to follow that word in stripping religion of irrelevant syncretic practice in order to re-create the pure Islam of the Prophet. In certain respects, Muhammadijans are militant zealots, in others moderate rationalists, but certainly to join Muhammadijah is a radical step for most Indonesians, especially Javanese, who are reared in the looser Hinduized syncretic setting of the larger Javanese culture.

In this context, consider the following account. Ahmad says that like many of village origins he remembers the day but not the year of his birth (this is owing to the Hinduist-syncretist calendar system), and he confirms that he was from a family of this syncretic persuasion, which did not recite the prayers of Islam. But he learned to pray and, praise be to God, he is now a Muhammadijan. (The group echoes, "Praise be to God.") Ahmad goes on to tell how he helped crush a syncretic mystical movement, which, he says, "threatened the safety of society."

This is one of many similar statements that I noted, rendered as

verbatim as possible. They were made in the Indonesian language by trainees in a Muhammadijah training camp called Darol Arqom. This was a two-week, eighteen hours per day, intensive camp for branch leaders of Muhammadijah. (I went through the training myself as a participant-observer. Among the participants, incidentally, was the current head of Muhammadijah, Amien Rais, now a leader in Indonesian politics.) The trainees were all Javanese, ranging in age from their early twenties to mid-thirties. These statements were made as part of an exercise called "personal introduction," which most trainees (twenty-three of the thirty-eight present) were called on to perform at various points during the training. These statements were the closest approximation I heard to what Christians term testimonies. The testifiers described how they came to be committed to a faith manifested in a sect, Muhammadijah; they did this publicly and elicited a supportive response.

But, although these accounts reported conversion and took a kind of testimonial form, none of them described a Christian-style conversion experience. In none of the twenty-three Darol Arqom accounts is there any mention of an emotional experience or altered state of consciousness. Yet the accounts described a shift in belief, membership, and sociocultural identity.

The absence of emotional language was especially striking given recent history. This was in 1970, five years after Gestapu, the massacre of some half a million Indonesians in a conflict that was, in part, between the purist Muslims and the syncretic Communists. Muhammadijah, including some of the Darol Arqom testifiers, had been involved in the murder of their own neighbors. Yet remembered violence did not translate into emotion and drama even as Muhammadijans narrated their conversion from the cultures of those some had killed.

Struck by the absence of the conversion experience accounts, I discussed the matter with one of the instructors as we strolled beside a rice paddy in one of our habitual walks. He seemed to recognize the sort of experience I described but assured me that he had never heard of any Muhammadijan reporting or having one. However, he mentioned suggestively, he had heard of such among the Chinese. This is suggestive because many of the Indonesian Christians, including fundamentalists, are Chinese.

Away from camp, I did a number of interviews eliciting life histories from Muhammadijans and also other Muslims, including Malays, Pakistanis, Indians, and Arabs from Singapore. None mentioned a conver-

sion experience, with one interesting exception, to be noted shortly. In similar interviews with fundamentalist Christians in the southern United States, the conversion experience was almost always mentioned quickly, without prompting, and served as the cornerstone of the life history narration.

Of all the Muhammadijans, one man seemed the most likely candidate for a conversion experience because his conversion seemed so radical and his new commitment so absolute and obsessive. The man, whom I'll call Sanyoto, was reared and educated a Catholic. He is Javanese, hailing from Pare, the town where our colleagues Clifford and Hildred Geertz did their renowned work on Javanese culture. In fact, Hildred Geertz recorded lengthy narrations from Sanyoto at about the age of twelve in response to Thematic Apperception Test cards; these are on file and show something about his way of thinking during his pre-adolescent, pre-Muslim period. When I knew Sanyoto he was twenty-nine, an unusually tall Javanese—six feet or more, thin, bespectacled. We were jokingly called twins (I was about thirty-three then), and we did feel a kind of kinship, expressed, for example, in our sharing some dirty jokes with each other and some of his comrades during the Darol Arqom sojourn and on some Muhammadijah youth movement expeditions later. And we visited his family at Pare. Sanyoto's father was a schoolmaster of syncretic, Buddhist persuasion; Sanyoto had had a brother who was Communist, killed in Gestapu (the massacre mentioned earlier); his mother was somewhat of the Muslim persuasion; and Sanyoto had been reared and educated as a Catholic. Yet here he was at twenty-nine, a medical student but neglecting his studies to stay on the road relentlessly speaking against Christianity. He was the most vehement of the so-called Christologists of Muhammadijah—one who studies Christianity in order to criticize and oppose it, which he did so vehemently as to be admonished by a more moderate Christologist at the Darol Arqom camp (who later became minister of religion for Indonesia). The day after the camp ended, Sanyoto and I walked together to the main road at dawn, he to catch a bus to get back on the road with his anti-Christian evangelism. Sanyoto was a kind of Haze Motes character (in Flannery O'Connor's novel), a harshly puritanical zealot who, incidentally, had on his shelf a copy of Max Weber's work on the Protestant ethic, which in many ways he exemplified, though as a Muslim Puritan.

In short, Sanyoto's conversion to zealot anti-Christian Muhammadijan involved choices and transformations of values, subculture, and

belief that to me, the observer, seemed wrenching. Also, his personality—his rigid puritanism, released occasionally in his "dirty jokes," focused zealously on relentless preaching against the faith in which he had been reared and educated—suggested strong emotions surrounding his new commitment. I sensed that here was a person for whom conversion had powerful inner meanings. Perhaps he had had a conversion experience. On the train to visit his family, I asked him about his conversion. This is what he said, translated and summarized.

> I had no dreams or vision. I simply began associating with Muslim students at medical school. Through reading books on Islam, I came to see that Islam is a continuation of the tradition begun by Christianity. It was easy to accept the concept of "One God" over that of the Trinity but difficult to replace Jesus with Muhammad. However, after I had accepted the Prophet, I felt as though I had shifted from a difficult to an easy religion, and I felt calm. This occurred during my first year at the university. We "drink" Bismillah (the statement of the oneness of God). Malcolm X said after his pilgrimage that the recipe is simple: if you believe in the unity of God, you believe also in the unity of man. Christianity tells us to search for a black cat in a dark room; Islam is like coming into a light. And with Islam I feel close to my fellow believers; if I meet a fellow Muslim for the first time, I am already a brother.

Sanyoto, then, explained his shift of commitments entirely as the rational choice of a new doctrine and a shift of social affiliation. He reports no emotionally charged, altered state of consciousness as part of the shift, no conversion experience. In fact, his shift was, in a way, from an inward to an outward focus, to a rather legalistic, bureaucratic, militant sect that defended him against introspection, of either a Javanese or Christian type, and employed him as a weapon against the world.

We come, finally, to the one partial exception to my failure to discover a conversion experience among Southeast Asian Muslims. This man, from Singapore, is half Chinese; his father is Chinese, his mother Burmese, and he had taken his father's name, Tan, until his conversion to Islam, when he became Abdul Talib. He was educated in a Christian, Anglican school. His father, who owned a perfume factory, was wealthy. His brothers and sisters were all non-Muslim; they represent Buddhist, Christian, and hedonistic-materialist orientations—a cultural diversity

equal to the family of Sanyoto and indeed to Singapore itself but lacking any affiliation with the Malay-Muslim element. Talib's first wife, a Chinese, left him with six children. He then married an Indian-Malayo-Muslim woman who also had six children. With these twelve as well as a thirteenth they had produced, they lived, when I knew him in 1969, in a two-bedroom apartment provided by the army, in which Talib was a warrant officer on the island then known as Belakang Mati, or "Behind Death" (now, under another name, the site of an amusement park).

Talib is a dedicated Muslim, strictly following the fasting and other rules; when I knew him, he was praying five times a day, reciting extra prayers every evening during the fasting month, and fasting extra days. But he is a deviant Muslim, for he has joined the radical sect, Ahmaddiya, which some Muslims consider outside the fold of Islam. Ahmaddiya proclaims Ahmad, a Pakistani teacher, to be the successor to Muhammad. When I first met Talib, at an Ahmaddiya meeting in 1969, he told me, with no prompting, the story of how he converted to Islam. He was at Sarawak, engaged in a shirt-selling business, when he had a vision in which a figure in white entered the room and told him to go to the mosque. He did so and joined Islam.

That's all he said about that, although later he made it a point to tell and show me many aspects of his life, rather consciously making plain how his conversion to Islam entailed a radical break from the lifestyle of his generally rather materialistic and Westernized family and Chinese milieu. Note his Chinese (rather than Malay-Indonesian) ethnicity and his Christian background.

The final bit of data is to note that if one moves outside the Islamic arena one can hear standard Christian testimonial accounts of the conversion experience among ethnic Malayo-Indonesians. I heard one such account from an ethnic Javanese at a Jakarta meeting of the Full Gospel Businessmen's Association. So ethnicity alone does not preclude the conversion experience, or at least the narration of it.

What is the significance and meaning of the seeming lack of a conversion experience and testimonial in the phenomenology of Southeast Asian Islam, at least so far as I have discovered?

I raised the question on two occasions at study groups of Muhammadijah, one organized by the Young Muslim Intellectuals and the other held at the home of Professor Mukti Ali, a well-known Muhammadijan and Muslim scholar of comparative religion and later the minister of religion for the Republic of Indonesia. These discussions suggested the

following comparison between the fundamentalist Christian and fundamentalist Southeast Asian Muslims, especially the Muhammadijans.

Believing that he is born sinful or has sinned, the fundamentalist Christian feels guilt, which is absolved through the conversion experience when he accepts Jesus. The Muhamadijan does not, in the first place, believe in original sin, and Muhammadijans emphasize that they do not see as an important motivation for their actions the desire to be saved from a state of sin. They emphasize instead that they would always sustain peace of mind, *ichlas,* through consistent conformity to the law set forth in the holy Qur'an.

To generalize this contrast a bit, Muhammadijans and fundamentalist Christians could be characterized as guided by contrasting paradigms of action: the dramatistic and the legalistic. The legalistic Muhammadijan sustains his struggle in order to continuously—some would say relentlessly—conform to the laws of the scripture. His action is dictated and explained as belief codified in law. The dramatistic fundamentalist Christian derives from his beliefs a torment that is resolved only through the conversion; his action stems from tension and guilt generated by inner belief rather than from conformity to belief instituted as outer law.

This contrast is an instance of the general contrast often made between Islam and Christianity: the one a religion of law, the other of a life. The drama of Christ's birth, life, and death assumes mystical meaning in the life and experience of Christians; this narrative archetype transcends any legal code. So the contrast gets at fundamental differences between two world religions. But many other questions and implications are suggested as well.

What is the role of ethnicity and culture? Not only Islam but also the Javanese culture of the Muhammadijans with whom I dealt would seem to dispose toward reticence, constraint, calmness, and other values that oppose the dramatic emotional abreaction of the conversion experience. And non-Javanese (i.e., the Chinese) reputedly have such experiences. Yet at least one Javanese did, in a Christian context, testify to such an experience. Visions, transformed states of consciousness, as in trance, occur in other Javanese situations. An interaction of religious and ethnic background is suggested in the contrast between Talib and Sanyoto.

Social-psychological differences doubtless contribute. For example, the Muhammadijan congregation is essentially male, while that of the Christian fundamentalist is of mixed gender. The wild one, a reprobate, a man's man, becomes, through Christian conversion, domesticated.

Ceasing to run around with the boys, he begins to stay home with his wife and children and becomes part of a partially female congregation. Joining the all-male congregation of the mosque and the Muslim community, the Muhammadijan male is not domesticated or effeminized; in fact, his joining affirms his identity as a male, at least in terms of the machismo model of Islam. Because the Muhammadijan can join the congregation without sacrificing his masculinity, he can do so without undergoing the drastic (and in some ways emasculating) conversion experience of the male Christian fundamentalist. This explanation, however, does not consider why females convert, either in Christianity or in Islam.

Rhetorical genres differ. The conversion account is grounded in a language and literature that is biblical but also Western, including a general emphasis on introspection, psychological development, and climax in contrast to a literary tradition in Java and Malayo-Indonesia, which is generally more cyclical than climactic, more conventional then introspective, and more classificatory than developmental. Transformation of identity does occur but often by means of magic or simply a change in status rather than through psychological development.

These observations lead toward an assessment of the phenomenology and psychology of change of identity, especially from outside to inside, in these two cultures, in their lives, in our lives. To remind ourselves of a few points about our own culture, though some may claim that in the postmodernist West identities are changed as easily as underwear, much cultural apparatus still defines the self as continuous. For example, we do not normally change names after an illness or a promotion, as Javanese do, nor do we normally say some of the things some Javanese do (e.g., Haryo was a murderer yesterday, but today the spirit has gone out of him, so he is not a murderer today). We still tend to assume continuity of self such that transformation of it entails struggle, introspection about one's past self in relation to the present self, inner growth, and, finally, choice. If for liberal intellectuals the conversion experience is not the normal vehicle, processes like psychoanalysis resemble the conversion experience in that the old self is broken down while transferring attachment to an authority figure in relation to which the new self is built.

What of the cultural background of the Muhammadijan? A clue is given by a comment made to me by a prostitute of pious Islamic rearing. She said: "When I am practicing my profession I don't pray; when I'm not practicing, I pray." In other words, ritual purity is an issue for her;

she doesn't imagine that a conversion has to transform the sinful self into a new self before she can resume her pious ritual, but she does imagine that a polluting action has to cease before she can be ritually pure. This is akin to various Muslim concerns with menstruation, copulation, and the like that pollute the pure body, if not the self, that should be present in a prayer ritual.

This ritual emphasis in Muslim identity is reflected in the various kinds of rites of passage that lead to being Muslim. At the daily prayers, one has to wash before entering the mosque, for example. But most important, though as custom not creed, is circumcision. This is the great ritual act for males, which moves them, through trauma and pain and comradeship, from being essentially female — a child in a female-oriented household — to a member of the male Muslim community. In Southeast Asia, the greater the Muslim identity the sooner circumcision is performed, as though it becomes more urgent to complete this rite of passage the more one values the Muslim self.

Yet, paradoxically, Muhammadijans never mentioned their circumcision in their autobiographical recollections, unless, as in one instance among the narrations in the training camp, there was a problem with it. For the Muslims, this rite is a given, setting a framework that need not be mentioned. For Christians, the conversion experience is not a given but a gift. However culturally stereotyped narrations of the experience may be, it is perceived as unique to the individual — a gift of God (grace) that the recipient has chosen to accept in his or her own way. It is this fact of choice, of personal decision, that gives impetus to narration.

Becoming Muslim, then, occurs through a collectively dictated ritual; so, to a great degree, is becoming Muhammadijan, for example, through the training camps and schools that indoctrinate. The process is not necessarily mechanical and unreflective; there may be pain, as in circumcision, and reflection and even psychologizing (a tendency that prompted participants in the Darol Arqom to propose to substitute certain psychological terms for theological ones). But these processes are group-controlled rituals that indoctrinate and solidify rather than calling for either the experiences or the narratives of conversion: inner struggles and agonizing lonely, individual decisions.

In the broad cultural background of Javanese Muhammadijans is another kind of transformation that transcends both the conversion experience and the ritual mode of joining. This is identified by the term *kebatinan,* which means "inside" and refers to mysticism. In *kebatinan,*

through meditation and other exercises one unites with a cosmic ground of being. Through such unions, the self can be transformed without the emotional upheavals of conversion. Self is within totality so that self-transformations are absorbed into this unity and hence rendered relatively insignificant and benign. One can be cured of hallucinations or fever, and one grows and deepens while remaining part of this constant unity. Outside and inside, outsider and insider cease to oppose each other since the unity encompasses both. The deeper one goes within, the wider becomes one's resonance with the cosmos without. Inner order automatically yields outer order. And *kebatinan* membership and belief are not exclusivist, so one can theoretically become an insider without giving up outsider statuses, all of which are encompassed by the greater unity anyway.

This transcendental, mystical alternative to both the conversionist and ritualist modes of moving from outside to inside is on the edge and underneath the culture of the Muhammadijans just as the more passionate Catholic mysticism of Eckhart, Suso, Tauler, Teresa, and others lies obliquely behind the Christian fundamentalist conversion experience. Occasionally, the mystical mode seeps into the ritualist, as when an orientation session for a Muhammadijah recruitment camp entitled "Giving Love" makes an analogy between stages of mystical attraction and affection and the process of being drawn into the Muhammadijah. Yet cosmic mysticism is resisted by both kinds of Muslim and Christian fundamentalists, the one reducing recruitment to ritualization, the other to an individualistic decision to accept a gift and make a commitment.

Our inquiry has been couched as an effort to explain an absence of the conversion experience in the Muslim case, as though the Christian one is the norm. We could just as well have taken the other viewpoint—that the Muslim way of experiencing and narrating movement from outside to inside is more normal and the Christian one the aberration that needs explaining. In fact, this is the way it seems from the position of reason and common sense (this is the stance of the Muhammadijans). We may see the radical dissociation and transformation entailed in conversion as pathological (this is how psychiatry tends to view it) or maybe we see it as miraculous. Believers speak of it this way, and so it is in that it is not explicable in terms of worldly processes such as the social, psychological, and cultural factors I or anyone else has adduced. Such explanations never fully account for the transformation from being one creature to being another, from inhabiting one phenomenological world

to inhabiting another. Such a movement in this sense really is miraculous. But so is any radical transformation, whether in the human or the natural worlds, and no analytical explanation, necessarily reductive, will suffice. The best we can do is what Max Weber termed *verstehen,* which means to try to grasp the viewpoint of the other, not by becoming the other nor even by total empathy with the other, but by some kind of intellectual construction of guiding cultural values and social context of the experience of the other. For Weber as for us, comparison can be useful, though not of course perfect, as Evans-Pritchard reminds us.

This allusion to *verstehen* forces a brief return to the nagging issue, which becomes for some more a shout than a nag, and a shout that deafens them to all else. This is the issue of reflexivity: the relationship of insider to outsider, the beholder to the believer. This dialogue is tense when it is conversion that is beheld, for conversion is itself an experience of engagement, hence the study of it is engaging. Further, the convert often wishes to convert someone. Pentecostal informants recount their own conversion experiences, which they tell me I can understand only if I myself convert; they not only tell but embrace and exhort. And Muslims apply pressures, too (they would joke that I "am hit by their da' wa" [evangelism] and one of their newspaper headlines forecast that I was about to convert to Islam). Beholders' feelings of being drawn to believers and their beliefs would seem unavoidable and perhaps necessary for *verstehen,* as was probably true for Weber himself. Studying conversion, then, has, as my computer disk tells me, a "double-sided double density." The subject itself, like Frankenstein, comes to life and invades the life of the investigator, challenging the barrier between beholder and believer. The scholarly stance one takes, even if it is resistance, detachment, or categorical assertion of one's stance as an outsider, is a kind of engagement. So there is some slight resonance between the research experience and the experience researched. This is the lesson of the postmodernist who detects reflexivity. Against this emphasis, however, I assert the point of the believer, and, I suspect, of the anthropology of religion. The experience researched (i.e., "natural religion") is incomparably more interesting and significant from the standpoint of constructing a theory of religious experience than is the research experience, which can only be, from this standpoint, a weak, secondary vision of the religious experience.

To conclude, we have explored two relationships: that between inside

and outside in the experience of the religious actor, as he or she moves from outside to inside through conversion; and that between outsider and insider, as observer encounters actor, beholder believer. The two relationships are themselves related, inasmuch as the outer to inner movement of the believer is replayed by the outer to inner movement of the observer as he engages the engagement of the believer. Engagement with engagement, which is the fate of the student of religious experience as of other human experiences, is one of the fascinations of postmodernism. This fascination has the advantage of focusing on what the researcher knows best, namely, the researcher's own research experience, but it has the disadvantage of diverting us from what is least known but perhaps more profound, namely, the religious experience.

Returning to the concerns of Rappaport, this exploration suggests some of the issues one encounters in striving for the union of a positivist objectivism. The issue is illustrated by the combination of approaches. On the one hand, we search for general factors, elucidated by the comparative method, to explain the presence and absence of the conversion experience. On the other hand, we pursue an interpretivist postmodernism, here illustrated by awareness of the place of the interpreter's subjectivity in the inquiry. Given Rappaport's own work, I suspect that he would have arrived at a position similar to that of this essay, namely, that the experience researched is of higher priority than the research experience. Thus, the methodological issues of reflexivity and the like are subsumed within, and positioned below, the larger substantive questions addressed by the anthropology of religion. In the end, one seeks the ultimate.

NOTES

1. This essay evolved from a lecture presented at Princeton University in 1990. I thank Albert Rabateau and other members of the Princeton Department of Religious Studies for inviting me. I thank Michael Lambek and Ellen Messer for their comments and for inviting me to help commemorate the life and work of Roy Rappaport.

2. Examples range from extravagantly clinical views like those of Weston LaBarre in *They Shall Take Up Serpents* (1962) to the nuanced analysis, also treating snakes, of Gananath Obeyesekere's *Medusa's Hair* (1981). The focus on symbols as the strategic convergence of the unconscious (thus, outsider to one's

inside) and the objectification of the subjective (thus, again, outsider to one's inside) to which the analysis has a special access (again, outsider to one's inside) expresses a dialectic that deserves elaboration not possible here, where I followed my informants in emphasizing a nonpsychological view.

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Notes for a Cybernetics of the Holy

Thomas J. Csordas

Roy Rappaport's most productive period was in the 1960s and 1970s, when anthropological debate was locked in the throes of a battle between materialism and idealism (or mentalism). Given the tenor of the times, it could hardly be avoided that a proponent of an ecological approach would be cast on the side of materialism, even "vulgar materialism" (Friedman 1974). With the coming of a period, from the 1980s to the present, more open to a theoretical disposition toward collapsing conceptual dualities, Rappaport's work begins to appear ahead of its time. The intellectual influence of Bateson, whose innovative theorizations could hardly be labeled materialist, clearly appears as central to his thinking. His prominent role in religious studies at the University of Michigan bespeaks no compelling drive to reduce sacred realities to material ones. The repertoire of analytic concepts deployed in his writings included a phalanx of ideas distinct to and, it might be argued, irreducible from the study of religious experience: the holy, sacred, sanctity, numinous, mystery, divinity, grace, eternity, and being. He freely cited works from theology and religious studies, including those by scholars such as Martin Buber, Mircea Eliade, Rudolph Otto, Paul Tillich, William James, Hans Küng, and Gershom Scholem.

The notion of materialism is typically associated with reductionism and determinism, and these may be further classified into economic, technological, environmental, and biological varieties. Rappaport's commitment to a cybernetic understanding of feedback between the social and the material in all these senses precludes any strict form of materialism. This is nowhere clearer than in his statements about religion such as the Marxist paraphrase that Maring society was characterized by a "ritual mode of production" (e.g., 1992: 17) and the axiomatic "I take ritual to be the basic social act . . . social contract, morality, the concept of the sacred, the notion of the divine, and even a paradigm of creation are

intrinsic to ritual's structure" (1979: 174). Moreover, although he placed great emphasis on the concept of adaptation drawn from biology, he vigorously opposed the biological determinism of sociobiology and its intellectual offspring such as evolutionary biology, evolutionary psychology, behavioral ecology, and evolutionary ecology. This was evident in his recent exchange with Lee Cronk over the latter's attempt to use evolutionary biology to account for the "paradox of morality" (Cronk 1994a, 1994b; Rappaport 1994d). This paradox, it turns out, is not about the nature of morality but has to do with why morality exists at all among humans, and Cronk attempts to resolve it by arguing that all animal signals are "best seen as attempts to manipulate others rather than to inform them" (1994a: 87). Such a way of formulating a problematic was in essence objectionable to Rappaport, who took note of "evolutionary biology's simpleminded and ugly view of human nature" (1994d: 348). He argued that such an approach goes beyond recognizing humanity's animal nature to claim that this nature is sufficient to account for or understand human phenomena, including morality (1994d: 331). He insisted on the distinctiveness of humanity based on language and the conceptions it makes possible, such as that of the sacred, and rejected a rationalistic emphasis on rationality with its economistic logic focusing on natural selection necessarily conceived in cost-benefit terms.

It is clear as far back as the preface to his 1979 collection of essays on ecology, meaning, and religion that Rappaport was quite comfortable tacking back and forth between the theoretical poles of material and ideal. This aspect of Rappaport's work is evident again in his posthumous book (Rappaport 1999), in which his concerns with ritual, language, and liturgy balance his concerns with ecology and adaptation. Nevertheless, despite the cybernetic nature of his thinking, there remained a dualism in his understanding of the relation between religion and material conditions: there was a cybernetic link between the poles of a dualism but no point of mediation around which the dualism could be collapsed. The dualism of mental and material is perhaps most readily evident in Rappaport's distinction between cognized and operational models (1979). More important for an understanding of his approach to religion are the consequences of his positing the locus of what is distinctly human to be in language and the sacred, which for him necessarily implied one another as products of coevolution. Although he regarded the holy as composed of both the sacred and the numinous, he paid far more attention to the sacred, particularly the linguistically

grounded, ideal realm of "ultimate sacred postulates." I will argue that the persistence of dualism in Rappaport's thinking about religion is a function of privileging the sacred over the numinous and of focusing on liturgy as the privileged form of ritual and that these moves resulted in a theoretical gap or blind spot between the material and the ideal.

Language and the Sacred

In an essay not well known among anthropologists, which was prepared as part of a festschrift for a colleague in religious studies at the University of Michigan, Rappaport acknowledged that his conceptions included a "panegyric of language" (1995a: 607). He suggested that "the sacred is inconceivable in the absence of language," which among all species is unique to humans, but conversely that "language could not have emerged in the absence of religion"—they are coeval (1995a: 602; 1979: 210). For Rappaport, there was a direct connection leading from language to logos, which he understood as a virtually pancultural conception of a cosmic principle of order, and thence to the sacred and sanctity, to ritual, and to the religious foundations of humanity. He refers to the "Epochal significance of language for the world beyond the species in which it appeared. . . . Language has ever more powerfully reached out from the species in which it emerged to reorder and subordinate the natural systems in which populations of that species participate" (1995a: 606–7). This positioning of language in the active mode appears to give it an intentionality that foreshadows its construal in human experience as logos. This logos is not necessarily redemptive, however, but has a distinctly negative side. Rappaport frequently cited Martin Buber in illustrating this aspect of the profound consequentiality for human existence of the development of language. He called attention to Buber's argument that the root of evil is the dual capability of humans to lie and pose alternatives, and he emphasized that these possibilities were constituted by the emergence of language.

Rappaport conceived of the holy as an overarching category composed of the sacred and the numinous. His notion of the numinous drew on Otto's conception of the awe-inspiring Other, Turner's notions of communitas and liminality, Durkheim's notion of collective effervescence, and a tentative invocation of Erikson's observation that its ontogenetic basis may lie in the relation of the preverbal infant and its mother (1979: 211–14). In its emphasis on unison and coherence, the

numinous is collective to the point of evoking the notion of organism. It is nondiscursive, ineffable, emotional, and has physiological elements, but, significantly for the argument I make, this is the closest Rappaport gets to recognizing bodily experience in religion. In short, the numinous is a product of emotion and the sacred a product of language (215).

The linguistic cornerstone of the sacred for Rappaport is the "ultimate sacred postulate." Such postulates are neither verifiable nor falsifiable but bear ultimate meaning for a society, as, for example, the Jewish Shema "The Lord Our God, the Lord Is One." I will briefly elaborate two critical roles they play in Rappaport's theory of religion, one performative and the other paradigmatic and both relevant to my argument here.

The performative role is played by ritual, which sanctifies the material arrangements of life by appealing to the ultimate sacred postulates. For Rappaport, ritual is "the performance of more or less invariant sequences of formal acts and utterances not entirely encoded by the performers" (1995: 613) and sanctity is "the quality of unquestionableness imputed by a congregation to postulates in their nature neither verifiable nor falsifiable" (1979: 208). To summarize in a formula, ultimate sacred postulates certify the truthfulness, reliability, correctness, naturalness, and legitimacy of social arrangements, rendering them unquestionable and thereby allowing for certainty and acceptance, which are enshrined in the performative invariance of ritual (211). The stress on invariance is evident in Rappaport's treatment of *ritual* as virtually synonymous with *liturgy* and as embedded in an overarching liturgical order. Of utmost consequence, "the remarkable thing about liturgy is that as a 'truly saying' it creates or brings into being its own fact" (1995: 619). Ritual creates or "manufactures" sanctity, thereby creating truth of a specific type—the sanctified truth of ritual as distinct from the necessary truth of logic and the empirical truth of experience (1979: 229; 1993b). In the end, however, the sacred is fundamentally a "quality of discourse" and the objects of discourse—although, since its objects themselves are often elements of discourse, sacred discourse and its object may be conflated (1979: 208).

The paradigmatic role of ultimate sacred postulates lies in how they serve as the capstone to a hierarchy of specificity in the ideal or cognitive-linguistic domain of liturgical orders. Ultimate sacred postulates are the most general and abstract feature in that they have nonmaterial significata, are neither verifiable nor falsifiable, and are remote

from social life. What he terms cosmological axioms are somewhat more specific—they are often assumptions drawn in polar terms about paradigmatic relationships in accordance with which the cosmos is constructed, taking into account sensible qualities manifest in social and physical phenomena and hence implicated in social practice. At an even greater level of specificity, rules directly govern the conduct of social relations and indications are conventional signs of current social and material conditions. Finally, classifications of features of social life appear in the form of secular folk taxonomies. I will show how this sequence can be applied in the case of revelatory imagery, but at present I want to emphasize that it can be read in two ways. The first is as Rappaport intended, as representing a continuum of specificity from the abstract ultimately sacred to the concrete evidently mundane. The second, however, recognizes that from an experiential standpoint the ultimate sacred propositions and secular classifications are equally ideal or cognitive-linguistic in form and the fullest engagement of both cognized models and liturgical orders with the materiality of social life occurs at the middle levels of rules and indications. Contemporary practice theory has taught us caution in relying on the notion of rules to understand social conduct (Bourdieu 1990: 37–40, 107–10), however, and I will accordingly suggest that Rappaport's "indications" offer a more fruitful point of entry into the indeterminacy of ritual spontaneity and improvisation, which I suggest marks the joining of material and ideal, adaptation and ritual.

Rappaport's own formulation of the place of the sacred in adaptation rested on the observation that conventions regulating societies are sanctified but not themselves sacred. Ultimate sacred postulates may thus contribute to the flexibility of the adaptive system insofar as, directed only at the goal of persistence, they can sanction any material goals or institutions as well as changes in those goals and institutions. "So, gods may remain unchanged while the conventions they sanctify are transformed through reinterpretation in response to changing conditions" (1979: 232). Oppressive or maladaptive regulatory structures may become divested of their sanctity, not necessarily in a revolutionary way, but with nonstructural corrective responses coming before more radical "sanctified structural changes," such that "sanctity maintains order in adaptive responses" (233–34). The critical point is that Rappaport's arguments at the same time downplay the numinous aspect of the holy and offer a conception of the sacred that emphasizes its discursive nature in

combination with the invariance of ritual. The result is a theoretical lacuna between the ideal (ritual) and material (adaptive process).

To state the issue another way, Rappaport insisted that the concept of adaptation must take account of meaning, and he rejected the radical separation of objective causal explanation inspired by biology and the subjective interpretation of meaning inspired by the humanities (1979: 157–58). Specifically, with respect to the interaction between the material and the ideal, he stated that "The relationship, in fact, between information and meaning on the one hand, and matter and energy on the other, is so intimate and interdependent that it is an error to take either to be ultimate. . . . *Meaningfulness* is *experienced,* and experience has its locus in individuals" (159; emphasis in original). Despite this invocation of experience, however, and despite his attempt to include the numinous in his theorizing, Rappaport never had a real theory of subjectivity. Cognized models are representational forms that can be examined without direct reference to individual or intersubjective experience, and an Austinian illocutionary act achieves its effect in the doing without necessary reference to the intent of the speaker—a promise is a promise whether or not it is a false one and whether or not the one to whom it is made believes it will be kept. I would suggest that this absence of a theory of subjectivity was a significant lacuna in Rappaport's "cybernetics of the holy" (1979)—his phrase, which I have adopted in the title of this essay. Needed to fill this lacuna is a kind of conceptual transducer between the material and ideal. I will try to demonstrate that such a transducer is constituted by a theory of embodiment and lived experience, giving an example at the level of what Rappaport called indications, specifically those constituted ritually as revelatory imagery.

Embodied Imagery

What I will do here is offer an example of how the theoretical lacuna between material and ideal might be filled in a way that emphasizes the simultaneity of the sacred and the numinous (constituents of the holy) and in addition shows the convergence of the holy (ideal) and the environmental (material). I will do this by way of arguing that imagination can be understood as a modality of embodiment, where embodiment is understood as the existential ground of our being in the world (Csordas 1990, 1994, 1997). Along these lines, a construct I have been elaborating is that of embodied imagery (1994), by which I mean that imagination is

a particular kind of bodily or sensory engagement with the world that is differentially elaborated across cultures. I will present some cursory but I think suggestive comparative notes on embodied imagery in the form of revelation experienced by religious healers in two quite distinct cultural settings. I would argue that such revelatory imagery is comparable across settings in that it shares a rationale that can be described in terms of Rappaport's hierarchy of sanctification. That is, it is predicated on the ultimate sacred postulate that "divinity reveals itself to humans" and at the next level of specificity on the the cosmological axiom that "there is a permanent and ongoing struggle between suffering and well-being in which divine power can intervene." Rules for mobilizing, invoking, or directing that divine intervention vary with respect to the social and material arrangements in each setting. Likewise, the indications — in this case the revelatory images themselves — will vary in form and content as well as in the particular problematic human conditions to which they point. At the greatest level of specificity, there may exist classifications of types of images or modes of revelation or such classifications may remain unelaborated.

My first example is that of Catholic Charismatic healers in North America, and the second is of healers in contemporary Navajo society. I have worked with these groups in two successive studies in which my students and I have combined observation of healing ceremonies with ethnographic interviews. These studies have produced narrative accounts of individual patients and healers as well as broader-gauge thematic data on specific topics such as the revelatory imagery I deal with here. For the present, my goal is to examine differences in the engagement of sensory modalities in imaginal processes that might point to the cultural constitution of a cybernetic transducer between ritual form and material condition.

Catholic Charismatic healers in middle-class North America often experience what they call "the word of knowledge," a kind of divine revelation that tells them something they need to know in order to help a patient. The message can be something substantive about the afflicted person's life or problem or it can be a message of empowerment and assurance that the person is being healed. Most substantive messages are visual or include a visual component and are of two types. One includes images comparable to still photographs of people with either no imaginal background or in particular settings and images of people engaged in action that portrays a problematic relationship or situation. The other

includes images of objects associated with everyday life and of individual words, phrases, names, numbers, emotions, or impulses. My interviews with 87 Charismatic healers produced a body of empirical data consisting of 287 examples of revelatory imagery.

Given the frequent observation that Euro-American cultures are largely visual in orientation (Ong 1967; Howes 1991; Jay 1993), it is not surprising that visual imagery predominates among these Catholic Charismatic healers. However, the healers also experience a substantial amount of imagery in other sensory modalities. Specifically, of the eighty-seven healers I interviewed, 54 percent had experienced visual revelatory imagery; 35 percent some type of haptic, kinesthetic, or proprioceptive imagery; 28 percent auditory imagery; and 22 percent olfactory imagery, though none reported gustatory imagery (Csordas 1994: 88). Healers also occasionally reported multisensory imagery, that is, compound images in more than one modality at a time.

The engagement of what Merleau-Ponty (1962) called the "bodily synthesis" is not exhausted, however, by imagery experienced strictly in terms of the five major sensory modalities. Some of the imagery experienced by the Charismatic healers I interviewed could not be classed under specific sensory modalities, although they appeared no less embodied. Again, of the eighty-seven healers, 32 percent reported images of a type I labeled "intuitive," which were constituted by experiencing a "sense" about a person or situation. Another 14 percent reported what I called "affective" images, constituted by experiencing a specific emotion that mirrored or participated in the state of the patient. Finally, 7 percent reported "motor" images, constituted by an impulse to speak or act. Only 6 percent, a relatively small proportion compared to healers in some societies studied by anthropologists, reported dream images relevant to a patient's problem, although a number reported and even cultivated dreams they regarded as relevant to their own psychological and spiritual development.

The body of data I will juxtapose to the Charismatic material comes from interviews with Navajo healers carried out over the past five years by a team of Navajo and non-Navajo researchers under my direction. Using questions about revelatory experience similar to those asked of the Catholic Charismatics, we have worked with people in three forms of religious healing practiced in contemporary Navajo society: traditional healing as carried out by chanters and diagnosticians through a broad range of ceremonies, Native American Church healing as carried

out by road men through the use of sacramental peyote, and Navajo Christian faith healing carried out by ministers and evangelists through the laying on of hands (see Csordas 1999, 2000). The following discussion is based on responses from fourteen traditional, fifteen Native American Church, and twelve Christian healers.

With this array of data, it is possible not only to make comparisons across Navajo and Euro-American cultures but across different cultural styles of healing within Navajo society. Touching first on revelation in dreams, among Navajo Christians only two of twelve acknowledged such an experience, while another two recognized it as possible but without personal experience or as possible but with the strong caveat that dreams could be a means of demonic deception. Two others reported a dream about themselves or a close relative, and another two reported their own bad dreams or dreams of demonic attack. This is only a slightly greater emphasis on revelatory imagery in dreams than among Euro-American Catholic Charismatics, hardly significant given the small and preliminary numbers. However, both traditional and Native American Church healers placed a substantially greater premium on revelatory dreams. Among the traditional, eight of fourteen acknowledged such an experience, with another acknowledging its possibility while not reporting the experience personally. Among Native American Church healers, eight of fifteen acknowledged having had revelatory dreams. This suggests that the relevant contrast is between Christianity and American Indian religions, not between Euro-American and Navajo cultures in general.

The three Navajo healing forms are somewhat more clearly distinguished among themselves when we examine the frequencies of revelatory images in the different sensory modalities. The numbers among the twelve Christian healers who reported images are as follows: visual (three), auditory (one), tactile/kinaesthetic (nine), gustatory (none), olfactory (one), affective (one), intuitive (one). Most of the images in the domain of touch were the common experience of tingling or heat in the hands when praying with the laying on of hands. Aside from this one phenomenon, the fourteen traditional healers reported imagery somewhat more often over a somewhat more even distribution of sensory modalities: visual (six), auditory (three), tactile/kinaesthetic (four), gustatory (one), olfactory (two), affective (none), intuitive (three). Finally, as one would expect in a tradition in which the senses are overtly enhanced by use of the psychoactive medicine peyote, the fifteen Native American Church healers reported a slightly higher proportion of images

across the range of sensory modalities: visual (eight), auditory (six), tactile/kinaesthetic (seven), gustatory (one), olfactory (four), affective (one), intuitive (three).

These differences, preliminary as they are, appear to confirm variation in the cultural elaboration of the sensorium in the domain of imagination across societies and religions. Of somewhat greater interest and consequence, I think, is that even visual images reported by Navajo Native American Church healers appear to exhibit a qualitative difference from the others with immediate relevance to embodiment. This is especially evident in contrast with visual images reported by the Catholic Charismatics. For the latter, images of persons, objects, or deities typically had no determinate perceptual locus—they appeared as if on an imaginal screen somewhere in the mind's eye. I call this a "mimesis of the actual," that is, an imaginal imitation of a person, object, or deity that could have an experiential actuality.

The Navajo Native American Church images do have a determinate perceptual locus, and here are several examples of what I mean. A healer learns something about his patient on the way to the patient's home as he looks at a cloud and sees it folding into the shape of a turtle or a bird, which suggests the need for a particular kind of treatment. The glowing charcoal in the fire during a ceremony turns into a transparent lizard until the healer recognizes that the patient's problem is due in part to the harming of a lizard, whereupon the coals return to their normal appearance. The moon appeared black through the smoke hole of the ceremonial tipi until the healer recognized the patient's problem as related to the moon, whereupon the moon returned to its normal appearance. The shadow of a ceremonial hogan at midnight was transformed into the shadow of a seated man, indicating that the patient would remain emotionally "outside" the healing process until a family argument was resolved. In contrast to the Charismatic images, I call this imaginal process a "transformation of the concrete," that is, an imaginal engagement of the senses while they are concretely deployed in a perceptual act.

Although these examples come from and indeed are most obvious among Native American Church healers, I suggest that they cannot be accounted for simply as effects of peyote but point in the direction of cultural difference in imagination as a modality of embodiment. First, the instance of the imaginal transformation of clouds did not appear to occur under the immediate influence of peyote, although a perceptual habit or "flashback" experience might be invoked. Moreover, there is

some indication of a culturally intermediate form phenomenologically between indeterminate mind's eye imagery and the determinate perceptual locus. In one instance, a Christian healer awoke to see a televisionlike image sequence of a couple he knew, but he located that image on the wall explicitly, as if it were a picture hanging there. I suggest that such instances of imaginal transformation of the concrete can best be placed in context with respect to at least two domains of Navajo culture: perception of the landscape and the nature of omens.

Navajos have identified a variety of culturally meaningful images in features of their craggy environment, which will often be pointed out on a trip across the reservation: a rock formation in the shape of an owl seated atop a mountain or a pair of elephant's feet, a mountain in the form of a bear or a petrified winged monster. One mountain has the profile of a chief lying on his back, with another mountain forming a drum at his feet. To say that these culturally regularized images reflect environmentally conditioned perceptual habits is doubtless in part accurate. Certainly, listening to a Navajo educator talk about the spiritual importance of mountains while gesturing out of his office window toward a particularly imposing example might be compared to what I might talk about while gesturing out of my office window toward another campus building. However, I think it is also necessary to describe this with more of a sense of embodied agency as the collective inhabiting of space by taking up an existential stance within it and as the individual orientation toward the environment that is part of the cultural constitution of self.

The second relevant issue is the interpretation of omens, a topic I found to be interpolated into the Navajo healers' responses to our questions about imagery. Examples of omens are the following. A traditional chanter on her way to perform a ceremony sees an owl perched on a stick and realizes that she must turn around and head for home because the ceremony cannot succeed. Two crows playing with one another appear to follow a man home from an errand, and this indicates his need for a ceremony. When a Native American Church road man goes out of the tipi to pray at midnight, a star begins to run (shooting star), and this conveys a message about his patient. Recognizing that both images and omens could appear in waking states or dreams, I was at first puzzled that image and omen appeared in such close narrative proximity. Despite my pursuit of sensory engagement in the study of embodied imagery, I remained attached to the notion that images are only "imagined" and omens are perceptually "real." Only on reflection did it become

clear that in practice there is little meaningful distinction between hearing a voice of someone not present and hearing the sound of a coyote or a horse outside, between seeing the shape of a deer in the shadows of the tipi or seeing a deer as one steps outside to pray, or between seeing the coals transformed into a lizard and seeing the fire begin to burn in two separate places rather than with one body of flame in the center—an omen that a certain married couple was destined to part. Just as there is a sensory engagement in imagery, there is an imaginal structure in omens. To summarize this much too briefly, image and omen share a common mode of sensory engagement that we have described as the imaginal transformation of the concrete. In imaginal structure, both image and omen "appear" spontaneously and their appearance has "meaning" within the therapeutic process.

The Cybernetics of the Holy

The difference between the mimesis of actuality and the transformation of the concrete identified in my comparison between Navajo and Euro-American revelatory imagery should not be construed as an argument that Navajos confuse or conflate images and omens or the imaginal and real landscape. It will not do to revert to the position that the "primitive mentality" does not distinguish between image and perception or dream and reality. The concrete logic of imagination in "savage thought" is no less abstract and interpretive than the logic of imagination in Euro-American thought. What the present analysis does tentatively suggest, through analysis of revelatory imagery in comparable classes of cultural specialists across cultures, is the possibility of identifying consequentially different cultural modalities of embodiment that constitute culturally distinct mediations of the relation between material and ideal.

To be specific, the analytic locus of this argument is at the midpoint, defined by bodily experience, between discussions among psychological anthropologists of the relation between perception and environment and discussions among ecological anthropologists of the relation between divinatory practice and adaptive process. On the psychological side, it has been argued that susceptibility to optical illusions such as the Muller-Lyer diagram is greater among peoples who live in a "carpentered environment" with greater "experience with two-dimensional reality" (Segall, Campbell, and Herskovits 1966). Again, it has been argued that there are differences across peoples in perceptual field dependence and

independence, which is understood to indicate levels of psychological differentiation with respect to accustomed environment and mode of subsistence (Berry 1976, 1981). On the ecological side, it has been argued that divinatory practices such as shoulder blade augury or scapulamancy (the reading of cracks and spots on animal bones to determine the most propitious direction of travel for a hunting party) have the adaptive advantage of introducing randomness, which protects from overhunting in certain areas (Moore 1957). The first of these perspectives describes sensory difference in relation to environment without much sense of perceptual agency (the perceptual phenomena are passively received effects of the environment); the second hypothesizes the adaptive relevance of randomness in divination without much sense of experiential immediacy (the divinatory practices are mystified manipulations of the environment).

The examples of revelatory imagery discussed above evoke the dimensions of perceptual agency and experiential immediacy in two ways that are consequential for Rappaport's cybernetics of the holy. First, these dimensions introduce, alongside the invariance of ritual grounded in language, the indeterminacy of existence grounded in embodiment. This goes beyond the relatively trivial observation that within any manifestation of the holy the sacred and the numinous do not necessarily correspond. Revelatory imagery is an adaptive structure precisely because it is a sanctified form of numinous experience that directly taps indeterminacy. It is cybernetic insofar as it constitutes a feedback loop among participating individuals (patients and healers) that confirms the intersubjective constitution of the connection between the ideal (cultural) and material (environmental). At a level far more specific than the ultimate sacred postulate, the revelation conveys information with a material referent in the lives of participants; by appeal to and certification from the ultimate sacred postulate, it creates its own truth. There is in addition a second, shorter cybernetic loop, beginning and ending in the sensorium of the healer who experiences revelatory imagery. That is, the image both originates in and is put into therapeutic practice by the healer. This lends particular salience to Rappaport's observation that the immediate subjective experience even of private prayer is one of communication, such that one can speak of autocommunication as well as allocommunication, and that "In fact, the transmitters of ritual messages are often, if not always, their most significant receivers" (1979: 178). Taken as a single structure, this double feedback loop uses the indeterminacy characteristic

of embodiment (Merleau-Ponty 1962; Csordas 1990, 1994) to focus the transpersonal flux of intersubjectivity and interpret the ambiguity of social conditions. The ritual act is thus not only a function of language and the invariance of liturgy but also of embodiment and the indeterminacy of existence (see also Csordas 1997).

The second way in which the agency and immediacy of revelatory imagery is consequential for Rappaport's theory is with respect to temporality. In taking up this theme in his later work, he suggested that in the temporal domain the equivalent to sanctity is eternity. They are in fact like "brother and sister" (1992: 26), guaranteeing that the ultimately sacred foundation of liturgical, and hence social, orders is not only invariant but unchanging. The temporal shapes of liturgical orders are defined by periods and intervals (Eliade's time out of time or Victor Turner's liminal) between periods, and the relationship between liturgical intervals and mundane periods is the relationship of the never changing to the ever changing (15). A high frequency of ritual in a particular social setting regulates daily behavior and corresponds to the degree to which the liturgical order attempts "to penetrate to the motivational bases of that behavior," while infrequent rituals articulate more broadly political configurations of society (18). The occurrence of revelatory imagery within the liturgical order adds another aspect of temporality to Rappaport's concerns with alternation and frequency. It is also semi-independent from duration insofar as it may be independent from the context of particular liturgical events—imagery may occur in a moment of daily life, as a moment in a ritual activity like prayer, or as part of a ceremonial performance. Although the duration of the imaginal experience is variable, its most characteristic temporal aspect is spontaneity. Phenomenologically, rather than having sufficient duration for one to experience "being in" them, they may be incursions of the holy into either everyday or liturgical practice, bearing the kind of urgency identified by Otto as one of the characteristics of the numinous. Insofar as imagery can be included in the class of ritual acts, then, such acts are not only a function of regulated frequency, duration, and alternation but also of spontaneity, simultaneity, and incursion.

Conclusion

In this essay I have tried to build on Rappaport's theory in a way that respects his insistence on the uniqueness of the human and his resistance

against reducing the holy to its material conditions. I have done so by making a move to ground the holy in bodily experience without advocating either a biologistic or economistic account of that experience. Rappaport remained on guard against a stunted conception of rationality shared by these two modes of theorizing, which are currently paired in some forms of evolutionary biology. Rappaport argued that "if reason is not always downright treacherous, it is often narrowly self-serving" (1979: 236). For him, the rational in economics and evolutionary biology has come to refer to calculations pitting people against one another in a way that must in some sense be antisocial. Why, among humans, should the existence of morality be considered to pose a "paradox," while conflict and competition are taken for granted as part of human "nature"? The emphasis on individual actors in these approaches is emphasis on a rationality characteristic of separate metabolic entities or organisms (238), while the epistemology inhering in money dissolves distinctions between qualitatively unlike things (1995a: 626). They fail to take into account the cybernetic systems—the wholes of society, ecosystem, and planetary ecology—that are also "natural, but not in their nature directly perceptible" (1979: 238).

Indeed, even loss of self, or dissolution of self in communitas, is not necessarily a sign of being manipulated by oppressive forces of mystification except from the position that clings to a rationalistically autonomous self. "In sum, liturgical order does not always hide the world from conscious reason behind a veil of supernatural illusions. Rather, it may pierce the veil of illusions behind which unaided reason hides the world from comprehensive human understanding" (1979: 238). Rappaport did not deny that there is a pitfall in "oversanctifying" highly specific directives such as rigid opposition to birth control in Catholicism. He followed the theologian Paul Tillich in regarding such oversanctification as a form of idolatry. Idolatrous postulates are false regardless of their acceptance because they "irrevocably commit the societies accepting them to particular institutions or conventions," which can never attain the unfalsifiable status of the ultimately sacred (239).

Ultimately, for Rappaport, the "Holy is etymologically related to 'whole' and 'health'" (1979: 234). This makes the term apt for referring to the sacred and the numinous, the rational and the affective, together. These conceptions at once subordinate the individual to common interests and allow the operations of society to be tempered by the needs of its members. "Wholeness, holiness, and adaptiveness are closely related

if not, indeed, one and the same" (234). Offering insight into the wellsprings of his ecological anthropology, Rappaport observed that the concept of ecosystem is related to religious conceptions, in particular to the notions of logos and cosmos, in that its truth is not directly demonstrable and it conceives humanity's place in the world in a way that has pervasive moral entailments. Recently, he went so far as to suggest that "ecosystemic conceptions that, in some non-Western societies themselves approach ultimate sacred status, are worthy of high sanctification by religions of the West as well" and can mediate between religious conceptions and statements of modern science (1995a: 629).

Skip Rappaport's anthropology was by no means a reduction to materiality, economics, biology, or environment. On the contrary, it might be said that his was a search for the ultimate sacred unifying principle in cybernetics and ecology/systems theory. Such a notion sheds interesting light on the move toward holism that rejected cultural ecology in favor of a unified interdisciplinary ecology as early as the widely reprinted article coauthored with Andrew Vayda on "Ecology, Cultural and Non-cultural" (1968a). I think it would not be going too far to suggest that from the beginning there was a certain reverence, even piety, in his thinking and that this quality contributed to making him a great leader in the field of anthropology.

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Rappaport on Religion: A Social Anthropological Reading

Michael Lambek

Ritual and Religion in the Making of Humanity (1999), Rappaport's magnificent analysis of religion, was over twenty years in gestation. During that time, public awareness of ecological problems grew, but the visibility of ecological approaches within anthropology was at a low ebb. Indeed, it could be said that Rappaport's earlier work, *Pigs for the Ancestors* (1968), stands as the most outstanding, broadly visible contribution in a subfield that subsequently became overwhelmed by criticism from both Marxist and culturalist directions. Renewals in the form of historical and political ecology notwithstanding (Biersack 1999), it is fair to say that most sociocultural anthropologists, including those whose main interests lie with matters broadly defined as ritual or religion, do not look first to ecological analyses for inspiration. It is to this audience, people who are not interested in the functionalist, behaviorist, or causal premises they identify with an ecological approach, that the present essay is, in the first instance, addressed. In his new book, Rappaport develops an extremely significant argument about the place of religious ritual in social life. He takes on questions long central to social anthropology—as we shall see, there are close parallels with Durkheim—and his discussion articulates with other mainstream anthropological students of ritual, religion, and society.

A large book in every sense, *Ritual and Religion in the Making of Humanity* begins and ends with profound questions concerning the nature of humanity and the future of our existence on earth. Within the evolutionary frame lie Rappaport's formal arguments about ritual, which are powerful and significant on their own. In this essay, I discuss elements of these formal arguments. I do not get into debates about whether or not parts of the work are functionalist or whether attention to function somehow

denies either history or human creativity. Rappaport is able to defend himself on these matters, and in the end this is not the most interesting question. To focus on it is to miss what is genuinely new, strong, and interesting in what he has to say. As with Durkheim, while functionalist readings are possible, they are not the most interesting ones.

The central arguments are formal and have primarily *social* import. They seek to demonstrate: (1) the way ritual instantiates particular moral states and conditions; the relation of morality to behavior, and of acts and words to each other (primarily in chap. 4); (2) the way religion preserves, and indeed provides the basis for, moral order and truth, the relation of a hierarchy of sacred contingency to social durability and flexibility (primarily in chaps. 8 and 9); and (3) the way ritual acts and utterances permeate social life with their moral effects (chap. 10).[1]

Rappaport is centrally concerned with the relationship between order and social change, or, rather, its converse—perdurance: how it is that "all is not lost to time" (1999: 231) and the characteristics of that which remains stable in the long run. He places history within a scheme that considers all kinds of temporal duration and movement, from the eternal to the ephemeral. He returns repeatedly to the *Shema* of the Jews, the postulation "The Lord Our God, the Lord Is One," which has endured for possibly three thousand years (see Gluck, this volume). Rappaport is interested in the properties of such postulates (which, he points out, are unfalsifiable claims largely devoid of material referents) as well as in the hierarchical arrangement among the parts of culture: the way in which the stability of some parts, like the Shema, enables and confirms meaningful changes in others and the way in which these parts are relatively insulated from change.

Rituals perdure relative to other elements of culture, but they are enacted each time anew, with new participants or participants under new circumstances. They therefore serve as a unique means of combining what Rappaport refers to as the invariant and the contingent. The funeral liturgy may stay the same, but each enactment of a funeral relinquishes a different person, surrounded by a unique set of mourners. Rappaport elaborates the immense consequences that he discovers in the relationship between the lasting and even invariant qualities of ritual and the immediate, transient, and variable ones, and he explores the relationship between ritual as a relatively perduring feature of society and all that is more transient in human life—changes at the biophysiological, psychological, social, and environmental (ecosystemic) levels.[2]

How is order possible in the face of continuous change, he asks, and how does the order of ritual help regulate change and continuity? He develops a model of hierarchies of mutability, longevity, specificity, concreteness, and contingency (270; see also Wagner, this volume, and Wolf 1999). Thus, rituals of more specific social content are contingent on those relatively empty of such content, that is, without much reference to an existing social order, as, for example, a coronation is contingent on the Mass. Highest in the hierarchy are what he calls ultimate sacred postulates. These phrases, of which the Shema is one, guarantee legitimacy, morality, and truth; yet they are, as he puts it, characterized by their material and denotative vacuity. They are actually *devoid* of specific social content. They are, paradoxically, both the most certain and unchanging elements of culture and what enable the greatest flexibility to the rest. "Specifying *nothing* they can apparently sanctify *anything*. Bound to no convention they not only can sanctify all conventions but *changes* in all conventions. Continuity can thus be maintained while allowing change to take place, for the association of particular institutions or conventions with Ultimate Sacred Postulates is a matter of interpretation. Interpretations remain forever vulnerable to *re*-interpretation but the *objects* of interpretation—Ultimate Sacred Postulates themselves—are not challenged by reinterpretation" (428, original emphasis).

The question arises as to how specific truths are maintained in the face of historical challenges. Rappaport notes the signal inadequacy of the human form of coding, of symbols or propositions tout court. Truths found in philosophical, political, theological, or even scientific arguments are fragile and open always to lies and refutation, to being discarded in favor of more attractive alternatives. Moreover, and this is typical of Rappaport, he asks an even harder, more abstract, and more fundamental question. How can truthfulness, the condition by means of which specific truths can be established and guaranteed, be created and maintained? *Ritual and Religion in the Making of Humanity* may be seen as an extended answer to that question.

Ritual and Religion in the Making of Humanity is a tour de force. It stands out for its incisive analytic qualities; indeed, it forms virtually a single argument, a chain of syllogisms some five hundred pages long. The reader cannot fail to be impressed by the unique combination of originality, clarity, logic, comprehensive vision, and sheer intelligent thinking. This is no pedantic textbook excursion through the literature; it is wise rather than clever, broad rather than narrow, the culmination of

a lifetime of thought, and finished literally on his deathbed. While I cannot reproduce his profundity here ("I'm not Rappaport"), I want to signal that Rappaport's work is profound.

Despite the exceptional clarity of Rappaport's prose and his earnest attempts to make the argument as accessible as possible, the book has a rather relentless quality and forms a kind of totality that may prove a bit off-putting for the novice to Rappaport's thought. Moreover, it seems to stand alone. With the partial exception of Bateson, antecedents to this unique combination of the logos, the logical, and the eco-logical are not obvious. Like Bateson, Rappaport appears to be characterized more by his originality than his location within a paradigm. Although he is perfectly generous and explicit in acknowledging influences and sources, he is not concerned with positioning himself within a school (nor with producing one). Interesting debates with authors such as Bloch, Geertz, and Leach are engaged along the way, but essentially he attempts to construct the field and his position from the bottom up, from a sheer deductive beginning. My own tactic will be somewhat the reverse. I approach the argument from a number of angles, frequently defined by comparison of Rappaport with other thinkers. At some moments, these will be no more than glancing acknowledgments, but at others I hope to be able to use the method to get at some of Rappaport's assumptions. In brief, one of the aims of the present essay is to situate Rappaport with respect to the social anthropological tradition.

Rappaport, "St. Emile," and Prophet Max

In his splendid foreword to *Ritual and Religion in the Making of Humanity,* Keith Hart compares Rappaport's magnum opus with that of the senior ancestor of social anthropology himself, namely, Durkheim.[3] This comparison is certainly correct. I will argue that what Rappaport attempts to accomplish at the ecological level is virtually a replication, an almost exact parallel, of what Durkheim performs at the sociological level (see Gillison, this volume). Both thinkers are concerned fundamentally with questions of social order and continuity, and both seek to understand religion as a universal and necessary component of human society in that light. If both arguments are ultimately circular, this may say more about the essential and positive nature of ritual than it does about the weakness of their respective theories.

As in Durkheim, there is a sustained seriousness, a strong ethical

imperative, and an argument about moral order being at the root of society. Like *The Elementary Forms of the Religious Life,* Rappaport's book is both philosophically informed and sympathetic to religion. Rappaport's sources of inspiration in philosophy and psychology are as wide as Durkheim's, though necessarily different, including John Austin and William James and theologians Rudolph Otto, Paul Tillich, and Martin Buber. Like Durkheim, Rappaport privileges ritual over belief, form over content, and general, abstract argument over the interpretation of the historically particular. And like Durkheim, and perhaps more directly borrowed from him, albeit strenuously reworked, the concept of the sacred is central. Both attempt to come up with systematic arguments about the place of religion in human life; for both, their strength lies less with history or explaining change than with explaining coherence and continuity. If both thinkers derive religion from the social practice of ritual, Rappaport provides an advance over Durkheim insofar as he sees religion generated not only through the (collective) experiential side of ritual but from its formal qualities and discursive properties as well. It is the development of the formal argument that constitutes Rappaport's major original contribution.

In style, ambition, and mode of argument, no less than in questions, tool kits, conclusions, and ethnographic sources of inspiration,[4] they have more in common than either shares with that other major sociological thinker on religion noted for his seriousness and sensibility, Max Weber. In part, this is surely because the Protestant Reformation is Weber's main point of reference but not Durkheim's nor Rappaport's.

What has the most impact from Judaism upon Rappaport is simple — the incredible historical duration of the Shema. The perdurance of an utterance so short and so lacking in obvious, direct, or referential meaning gives Rappaport pause (and could not be more different from the history of Protestant rebellion against older forms of liturgical order to which Weber addressed himself). In the end, the career of this phrase, which he labels an "ultimate sacred postulate," becomes paradigmatic of what Rappaport sees as central to religion. Yet Rappaport's theory is not necessarily biased toward literate religion. The Maring ritual cycle, famous from his earlier book, provides equally compelling material about the way ritual instantiates moral conditions such as alliance or enmity and provides the basis for temporal experience (see Strathern and Stewart, this volume). In the Maring case, Rappaport argues, the ultimate sacred postulate remains implicit,[5] but it is noteworthy that

Rappaport's evolutionism is not predicated on drawing distinctions between "stages" of religion or on Weberian discussions of modernity.[6]

Defining Religion: The Sacred

Unlike Lévi-Strauss, Geertz, or Douglas, who emphasize aspects of symbolic thought in such a way that in the end it is impossible to distinguish religion from the rest of culture or to establish where a symbolic or structuralist analysis might properly end and give way to something else, Rappaport is explicit about locating the difference. Indeed, he sees religion as something *to offset the deficiencies of language and symbolic culture.* (He does not emphasize any deficiencies of religion that might, in turn, be met by these or any other institutions.)

This is not to say that Rappaport expends much effort on attempting to define religion or that he tries to set it off as a discrete institution. Religion is fundamental to society, the basis for the moral order, norms, and conventions (and conditions for establishing and instantiating conventions) intrinsic to social life. Society itself is constituted in and through ritual acts. As he puts it, "In enunciating, accepting and making conventions moral, ritual contains within itself not simply a symbolic representation of social contract, but tacit social contract itself. As such, ritual, which also establishes, guards, and bridges boundaries between public systems and private processes, is *the* basic social act" (138, original emphasis; see also Levy, this volume).

Both Durkheim and Rappaport locate the heart of religion in what they refer to as the sacred, yet Rappaport is careful to distinguish his argument from Durkheim's. Whereas for Durkheim the sacred is that which is set apart and forbidden, and hence has objective, material properties, for Rappaport the sacred is a property or quality of discourse ("that which is or can be expressed in language" [23]), not of the world.[7] Nor is it a quality of "the objects or Beings that constitute the significata of such discourse" (371). The sacred is "the quality of unquestionableness imputed by congregations [note the Durkheimian word] to postulates in their nature objectively unverifiable and absolutely unfalsifiable" (371). Not merely devoid or virtually devoid of material significata, and thus invulnerable to empirical falsification or objective verification, sacred postulates are not subject to logical attack; indeed, it is often their very violation of logic (their nonrational, counterintuitive or self-contradictory qualities) that invests them with

mystery (281). In sum, sacred postulates are taken by those who hold them to be invariant and unquestionable. (Thus, there is no point attempting to argue with those who accept them.) For Rappaport, *fundamentalism* can be defined in terms of its overspecification of the sacred.

Rappaport suggests that it is "by the presence of . . . sacred postulates, implicit or explicit, that we finally take liturgical orders to be religious" (278). Conversely, he develops an argument to demonstrate that the performance of such orders forms a further critical source of the sacred's unquestionableness. Acceptance and certainty are entailed in performance, and truth (verity rather than veracity) is evaluated according to whether the facts correspond to the utterances rather than, as is usually the case, the inverse (293ff.).

Rappaport is also concerned not to render his account reductive; hence, he is careful to preserve a distinction between the sacred and the "non-discursive, affective, ineffable qualities" of religion that he refers to as the numinous (22). The sacred is constitutive of society and a product of (collective) discourse; the numinous (unlike in Durkheim) is directly connected to individual experience. The numinous and the sacred combine to form the holy. While perhaps of most interest to those with a religious bent, this rather mechanical packaging (borrowed from Otto) is neither the most compelling nor the most interesting part of Rappaport's discussion (indeed, for Csordas [this volume], he does not take experience far enough). Insofar as he attempts to understand religion, it is the formal rather than the substantive properties that take precedence. Moreover, although the chapter on the numinous is rich and insightful, it is noteworthy for the fiercely intellectual way in which Rappaport defends religious experience over and against pure reason. The chapter illustrates his own passions—for holism and order—and implicitly the uneasy relationship that in fact pertains between them, that is to say, between the holism characteristic of lived experience and the qualities of clarity, refined judgment, punctiliousness, and the like that are exemplified in Rappaport's own thought and that he identifies as characteristic of ritual and the sacred.

As Hart points out, whereas for Durkheim the sacred and the profane were understood as distinctly separate, Rappaport "draws no hard line between the sacred and the everyday" (1999: xix). There are degrees of sanctity and sanctification. There is hierarchy in the sense, first, of part to whole and, second, of superordination and subordination.

This is not a matter of power; nor, he says, is it one of logic.[8] In brief, sacred postulates sanctify or certify axioms and various social procedures rather than functioning themselves as the logical ground upon which cultural ideas are premised (265). For example, kingship in Europe was sanctified; coronation was contingent on the sacred postulate asserting the existence of God. As Rappaport points out, this hierarchy of contingency is also related to durability and invariance. Thus, just as "kings could be deposed without challenge to the more highly sanctified institution of kingship, so does the political condition of contemporary western Europe testify that kingship, although in an earlier era 'axiomatic,' could itself be disestablished without challenge to the Ultimate Sacred Postulates of Christianity" (316–17). A critical point is that the highest order postulates are most resistant to tampering by living, presumably self-interested agents (425), a fact that does evoke Durkheim's notion of what is set apart (but compare Wolf 1999).

Morality

Following Durkheim, authors such as Evans-Pritchard have argued that social facts are moral facts, and even Leach, in the course of describing the aesthetic frills on technical acts that he defined as ritual, has famously repeated Wittgenstein's pronouncement that "logically, aesthetics and ethics are identical" (1954: 12). But how is it that the social is moral, that social life is infused with moral concern and evaluation? Rappaport demonstrates the way in which moral states emerge from participation in the sequences of ritual acts and utterances that he refers to as liturgical orders. Participation entails and expresses commitment and obligation. Moreover, it brings into being new moral states such that subsequent acts and events are judged in light of the conventions established during ritual. Once initiated or sworn into office, a person is accountable in new ways. Behavior that was acceptable before is now judged to be wrong (and vice versa). In this respect (and following Austin), Rappaport points out that the relation of ritual utterances to states of affairs is the inverse of what we take the relationship of language to facts normally to be. Our common sense understanding of language is derived from using it to describe or report on the world. If I say the sky is blue and it isn't, then my statement is simply incorrect. The linguistic utterance is judged with reference to the facts. But if I commit to fidelity then it is my subsequent betrayal that is wrong; the facts are

judged with reference to the statement. Indeed, the very concept of betrayal depends upon the establishment of fidelity. Ritual commitment does not determine behavior or persons; it *defines* them.[9] Most acts are understood to be not purely right or wrong in and of themselves but with respect to the commitments that their perpetrators have engaged in and acknowledged.

From this point of view, it is not the fact that society is rule bound that makes it moral. It is neither the presence of rulers per se, nor the degree of adherence to them, that is critical but rather the fact that society entails a series of commitments on the part of its members. Ritual acts provide the means by which conventional states of commitment are brought into being and according to which subsequent practice is understood.

These ideas can be applied to various domains. For example, I have argued that sorcery in Mayotte can be seen as an act in which the sorcerer takes on responsibility for any misfortune that will subsequently befall his victim (Lambek 1993). Sorcery is, from this perspective, a moral transaction or transformation, and its logic lies here, in accepting the consequences of one's acts, rather than in the material realm of cause and effect. The moral consequences lie in the first instance with the practitioner of sorcery rather than with his target, as the former accepts responsibility for any mishap that may subsequently befall the latter. (The practice of sorcery creates sorcerers directly and harms only indirectly and after the fact.) Local understandings in Mayotte come very close to this analysis (although, as Rappaport suggests, they are easily mystified by the way performative utterances come quickly to be taken as descriptive ones), but the relevance of such an argument is probably generalizable to a broad range of practices described as sorcery or magic across many societies (Lambek, 2000).

Much of ritual is like this—producing and accepting conventional states of affairs in which certain criteria of judgment are brought into play. If the ritual is one of transformation of social status, then new expectations for the behavior of the convert, initiate, bride, groom, and so on are brought into effect (and, as Rappaport points out, the main recipients of such information are generally the performers themselves). But in addition, Rappaport argues, certain rituals produce the conventions that make the institution of other conventions possible. Thus, the heart of religion—in the mass, *puja,* sacrifice, and so on—lies in the establishment of sacred utterances, which serve to sanctify procedures

that have more mundane social and political implications—weddings, investitures, legal oaths, and the like.

The Temporality of Ritual: Comparison with Turner

Both Durkheim and Rappaport emphasize the centrality of ritual to religion; both also argue that ritual forms a basis for social order. In twentieth-century anthropology of religion, these have not always been popular positions. Some thinkers begin with ideas or symbols and follow an intellectualist, structuralist, or symbolic trajectory in which, when ritual is not actually dismissed as relatively uninteresting, it is understood as simply a form of representation. This is most clearly stated by Leach (1954), for whom ritual is the communicative dimension of action. In this view, ritual merely expresses by other means what can also be represented in words. Ritual symbols and meanings can be decoded much as myth can (though perhaps less easily, making ritual less interesting).

Among those who do take ritual seriously, Rappaport has been in fundamental sympathy and dialogue with Victor Turner and Maurice Bloch. For each of these thinkers, ritual is understood to have communicative properties, but these properties are not simply referential and they differ from, and in certain ways exceed, what can be communicated by means of words or symbols alone.

Following Van Gennep (1960), Turner (1967, 1969) attempted to explain the effects and transformations produced by ritual in terms of the logic of the temporal form. He managed brilliantly to convey the structural, symbolic, and experiential qualities of ritual as a whole as well as linking specific productions of ritual to the social contexts of their performance. Rappaport shares with Turner a concern with addressing both structure and experience as manifest in or produced by ritual. He is concerned with the temporal properties of ritual, both with the time internal to ritual and with the role ritual plays in the unfolding of external, social time. He examines the way ritual constructs conceptions and experiences of time, not only periodicity, transition, and duration but perdurance and even eternity. Notable is the way he explores the complex ritual cycle of the Maring, which initiates in turn both war and peace. The Maring case is particularly interesting because, unlike in the West (or the Balinese case, to which "the West" is often contrasted), the ritual cycle is not calendrically based. Rappaport

is thus able to expand upon some of Turner's insights regarding the Ndembu, for whom most rituals are similarly not scheduled along a calendrical axis.[10] Rappaport discovers underlying principles of order in these "variable-dependent" rituals and sequences of rituals (197) and connects, yet always distinguishes, the logic and performance of the rituals from the factors that lead up to the decision to perform them in any given instance.

In what is actually a secondary analysis (the challenge to which does not invalidate the way ritual institutes changes in political and moral states or shapes temporal experience), Rappaport argues that the Maring cycle regulates demographic relations and food production. This regulative function (which has a precursor in Malinowski) is comparable to Turner's dramatistic model of social process. As Messer notes in her essay in this volume, Rappaport goes so far as to propose that "the Maring ritual constitutes, or at least codifies, the relations of production of Maring society. . . . Ritual among the Maring is an organizing principle commensurate with capitalism, feudalism or oriental despotism, principles [*sic*] in accordance with which relations of production are organized in other societies" (483, n. 10).

It is noteworthy here that Rappaport does not argue that the ritual cycle serves to control or end war. If anything, in regulating war and peace and distinguishing them from one another, it maintains the possibility *for* warfare, providing the time for each side to regroup and restore confidence in its ability to continue fighting. Ritual signals and distinguishes war and peace, articulating them "into a regulated alternation" (101), but it does not thereby prevent war or bloodshed. Instead it *insulates* war and peace from one another. We will return to this notion of insulation shortly.

Rappaport's account of the temporal qualities of ritual—both what transpires within ritual time and the way ritual articulates social time external to it—has genuinely novel insights to add to the work of Van Gennep and Turner. For example, Rappaport takes from communications theory the distinction between digital and analogic processes and shows how ritual's digital representation of analogic processes summarizes unambiguously a great deal of unstable, uncertain, ambiguous, and complex information (95). But, whereas Turner in his case study method examines the range of such "information" in real situations that lead up to and follow from the enactment of specific rituals, Rappaport's analysis remains at the abstract level of system.

Ritual as Order and Truth: Comparison with Bloch

Turner is particularly attuned to the poetic dimension, and his religious and aesthetic sensibilities are acute, but while he attends to ritual as performance he ignores the concept of performativity central to speech act theory. Maurice Bloch, by contrast, draws on speech act theory to locate what he sees as the coercive property of ritual. Both Rappaport (following also Wallace 1966) and Bloch see ritual less as providing a code (a "forest of symbols") than as constituting an order.[11] Bloch contrasts ritual communication with ordinary speech in order to show the constraining properties of the former (1989a) and presents a penetrating argument about the way in which ritual mystifies the power relationships through which sacred authorities are constituted (1989b).

The basic point, drawn from speech act theory as developed by Austin (1962), is to distinguish performative utterances from ordinary statements. While there are many complex issues to be resolved about this too simple dichotomy, the notion of performative utterances (or illocutionary acts) has been the source of some of Rappaport's most brilliant insights. It is here that the break with ritual as representation is fundamentally made.[12] Rituals do not merely represent the world, nor, in Geertz's important Weberian addition (1973a), do they just provide models for acting in or thinking about the world. Rather, they are fundamentally constitutive of that world which the performers of ritual inhabit and which, through their active participation in it, they reproduce. In ritual, saying and doing are conjoined. Rituals may well establish moods and motivations (Geertz 1973a [1965]), but the point is that they establish states of affairs that remain real and valid irrespective of the appropriate mood and motivation of participants.

Thus, the breakthrough in Bloch and Rappaport is in showing how the worlds that adherents of given religions inhabit are constructed, how the fictional, the made, is realized, rendered *vraisemblable,* natural, and at times even more potent and significant than the world available through mundane everyday perception. The fundamental difference between them is that, whereas Bloch, following Durkheim's dualism, distinguishes and opposes the mystified, ritual, and culturally specific from ordinary cognition (1989c, 1989d), Rappaport proposes a series of levels from more sacred and less referential to less sacred and more referential propositions (Wolf 1999: 20), the former being both fundamental and constituted by means of ritual. For Rappaport, a fully human way of life

without ritual is unthinkable, whereas Bloch argues that there are large chunks of everyday experience, thought, and activity that get by very well without it. In Bloch's view (1986, 1992), the world produced by ritual is constituted by a break from or inversion of the everyday, often by means of violence, symbolic or actual. For Rappaport, the sacred permeates, in varying degrees, the rest of knowledge and action.[13] Rappaport is at pains to distinguish sacred truths, which "stand in opposition to ordinary experience" and are "impervious to disproof by the . . . compelling rigors of daily life. . . . [Yet] their independence from ordinary experience . . . makes it possible for people of widely divergent experience to accept them" (309).

Part of the debate concerns the implications of the formality of ritual language. Both Bloch and Rappaport note that one of the features of liturgical ritual is the way that the past is carried into the present. Rappaport emphasizes that rituals not only contain a self-referential dimension but include messages (referred to as canonical) that were encoded in the past and retransmitted through each ritual performance (52–53). Bloch (1989a) argues that all this constrains both meaning in the present and possible responses to authority, whereas Rappaport emphasizes the propositional force that is enabled. In Bloch's view, ritual order leaves little room for argument. Rappaport takes the same point to emphasize the gain in clarity that ritual provides; in effect, you cannot qualify your commitment or equivocate. One is a negative appraisal, the other a positive one, but the basic understanding of formality is very similar (cf. 29).

Nevertheless, there is a good deal more of interest to be said about the contrast in their assumptions and points of view. Bloch seems to think that in an ideal egalitarian social setting people would make use of common sense and hence, helped along by the universal principles of human cognition, would or could be in general agreement with one another. Rappaport, by contrast, envisions this "state of nature" as one of a flowering of such a multitude of imaginative alternatives produced by language that chaos (Babel, or perhaps some combination of Babel and Sodom) would prevail. "*Societies must establish at least some conventions in a manner which protects them from the erosion with which ordinary usage—daily practice—continuously threatens them*" (323; original emphasis). Religion helps make order out of potential chaos; specifically, through ritual a sacred world is established that protects social order "against the disordering power of the linguistically liberated imagi-

nation" (322). Sanctity offsets the ability of language to produce endless variation; this capacity of language for variation or alternative, he says, "is disciplined by sanctity" (322). For Bloch, on the contrary, religion distorts ordinary thought and language. We may note also how both these positions differ from the Geertz-Weber alternative, for which the absence of religion would be not an overabundance of meaning or noise, nor simple clarity, but an absence of meaning, anomie.[14]

We can add another layer to this debate. On the one hand, Rappaport accepts that performativeness is often mystified. This, indeed, is a main source for the prevalent ideas of autonomous and ontologically distinct deities. He notes how a performative "factive" like the Shema readily comes to be taken as a "constative" report, that is, shifting with surprising ease from a claim about the world to a description of it (279). Indeed, the mystification of performativeness is surely central to the way in which religion works.[15] In a phrase reminiscent of Sahlins (1977) on ideology, Rappaport argues that "the same liturgical orders at one and the same time order nature and morality, moralizing nature and rendering morals natural" (168). Yet Rappaport also sees religion providing an understanding of truth, specifically, a truth about truth. For Rappaport, the very basis of certainty is founded in ritual. Thus, he sees two sides to religion, the mystifying and the enlightening (truth providing), and their complex interrelations.

Like Bateson, Rappaport is skeptical about relying on pure reason, since individual consciousness has a necessarily incomplete grasp of the whole;[16] like William James, he worries that left to its own devices reason becomes a means of serving "private, self-interested, and often selfish ends" (400). Intellectual rationality is virtually equated with means-ends rationality in the economic sense. Ritual provides a means of framing such reason and asserting control over its limitless (and, when limitless, destructive) application. Put another way, in evolutionary terms, the central question for Rappaport is: what is there about or within human culture that might prevent it from going too far against nature? How can pure reason be kept within reason? The answer comes partly through the analysis of liturgical order and partly by means of a distinction between three levels of meaning, ranging from semantic meaning, which works by separation, through higher order meaning, which integrates (largely by metaphor), to totalized meaning (available almost exclusively in ritual experience). "Participation in rituals may enlarge the awareness of those participating in them, providing them

with understandings of perfectly natural aspects of the social and physical world that may elude unaided reason" (402).[17]

Hence, if Rappaport emphasizes the place of order in human social life in comparison with postmodernist, historicist, or Marxist thinkers, it is not to be assumed that this order comes easily. It depends on the fine workings of ritual against a background that would otherwise be characterized by chaos. This perception is bolstered by a religious sympathy, indeed, an infusion of mystical thought, drawn from reflection on materials ranging from those of Heraclitus, Gnosticism, and the Kabbalah through Bateson. Bloch, by contrast, places much more faith in ordinary human cognition, meaning that is, in effect, the "lowest" of Rappaport's levels, and reserves his suspicion for the pathological consequences of the application of meaning at the higher levels.

"In sum," for Rappaport, "ritual in general, and religious experience in particular, do not always hide the world from conscious reason behind a veil of supernatural illusions. Rather, they may pierce the veil of illusions behind which unaided reason hides the world from comprehensive human understanding" (404). But this raises serious methodological questions. How can we rationally take into account the whole while recognizing that reason alone cannot grasp it? After all, Rappaport's entire book is a sustained and powerful exercise in reason. How other than through human reason are we to distinguish one case from the other, decide upon the "not always" and the "may"? Rappaport recognizes this, concluding on a more "reasonable" note: "I do not claim that non-discursive modes of comprehension are superior to conscious reason, or even alternative to it. I have dwelled more upon the inadequacies of reason than upon the inadequacies of non-discursive comprehension because of reason's high status in contemporary thought. Understandings provided by non-discursive experience alone are at least as incomplete" (404).

While Rappaport's critique of capitalist rationality (found in his last chapter) is compelling and appropriate, it is surely not right to equate economistic rationality with human reason per se, nor is it useful to see capitalism as simply the outcome of the exercise of such individualistic and self-interested rationality. Nor is the advocacy of holistic thinking likely to be sufficient to bring down the global economic system, though of course it may be a powerful ideological tool. And, if ritual is a site for overcoming individual self-interest for the collective good, Rappaport recognizes, though he does not elaborate, that it can be politically dangerous as well.

Public and Private, Acceptance and Belief: Comparison with Geertz

To say that Rappaport starts with ritual is to indicate also that he does not start with belief. To show why he regards belief as an inadequate basis on which to build either religion or a theory of it, it is useful to begin with a comparison with Geertz.

If Rappaport is closer to Geertz than to Bloch in the way he sees ritual pervading life and as a privileged locus for discerning cultural meaning, it is because like Geertz he draws on the tradition of American anthropology in which culture is fundamental to the human condition and marks the transition between our species and the rest of nature. As in Geertz's famous essay on evolution (1973b), Rappaport sees culture and humanity as mutually constitutive. But, whereas American writers such as White and Geertz see the symbol as fundamental to, and definitive of, culture, Rappaport adds ritual and the manner in which it constitutes the sacred. The sacred is critical because, in Rappaport's argument, it provides the foundation, not for semantic meaning but for meaningfulness, and not just for meaning but for certainty, truth, and morality. The sacred is not something one believes in but something one accepts as a precondition to belief.

Both Geertz and Rappaport emphasize the distinction between public and private meaning. For Geertz, this is primarily a methodological principle that enables interpretive anthropology to proceed without recourse to subjectivism (1973c), while for Rappaport the separation of public from private is a necessity of social life and one that ritual helps maintain. Whereas in British structural-functionalism, function was about integrating the parts, from a cybernetic perspective too much connection, referred to as hypercoherence, can be a dangerous thing (witness the global effects of economic activity in specific regions). Rappaport argues that ritual provides a buffer between subsystems, thereby constraining the spread of disruption from one part of a system to others. "Ritual helps limit the world's coherence to tolerable levels" (102). Thus, just as we saw ritual articulating Maring states of war and peace and ensuring that they do not intrude on each other, so, too, ritual helps preserve the relative autonomy of the social and the private, respectively, "protect[ing] social processes from infection by inimical psychic processes" (103) and vice versa. Yet at the same time it forms a point of connection between them. All rituals are "self-

informative," contexts in which participants inform themselves of their change in state (104).

For all the reasons that Geertz finds the private an insubstantial basis from which to conduct an interpretive inquiry, so for Rappaport it provides an inadequate basis on which to found a religion. This is evident in his fundamental distinction between (public) acceptance and (private) belief, manifest, for example, in participating in the Mass while thinking inwardly that it is a lot of nonsense. For Rappaport, the participation definitively indicates acceptance and is socially consequential no matter what the belief. Public edifices cannot be built on the vagaries of private beliefs. This is something about which generations of my students have proved skeptical (perhaps because it goes against certain basic North American ideas about the self). There are several ways to respond. First, following Austin on performative acts, it is true that there may be means by which serious reservations or contradictions on the part of the participants may invalidate the performance and hence in effect annul the acceptance.[18] At the same time, such conditions are limited in their scope, enabling ritual to march ahead despite human ambivalence and uncertainty.

Second, despite the discrepancy between acceptance and belief, it is the former that has significant social effects. As Rappaport argues, "the primary function or metafunction of liturgical performances is not to control behavior directly, but rather to establish conventional understandings, rules and norms in accordance with which everyday behavior is *supposed* to proceed. Participation in a ritual in which a prohibition against adultery is enunciated by, among others, himself may not prevent a man from committing adultery, but it does establish for him the prohibition of adultery as a rule that he himself has both enlivened and accepted. *Whether or not he abides by that rule, he has obligated himself to do so*" (123; original italics). It is in this way that morality and the conventions by which it can be judged are instituted and maintained, instituted over and above human ambivalence and maintained in the face of human disregard.

Third, the very fact of acceptance can sometimes influence belief in its direction (Levy, this volume). Rappaport is interested in how outer and inner states may be brought into alignment. Here, like Turner, he goes further than Geertz in addressing the private or subjective side, especially as it concerns religious experience (compare Peacock, this volume). The obligatory may not be rendered desirable (Turner 1967),

or desirable for all concerned, but it is likely to become more than simply an objective set of rules coercing an alienated citizenry if only because, as Rappaport has said, by his very participation in the ritual the potential adulterer has "enlivened" the prohibition against adultery and has defined himself in its terms.

Rappaport does not disregard belief, but he recognizes that it cannot provide the basis for social order or morality if only because it cannot be definitively ascertained; it does not permit of an "indubitable indexical representation" (396). For Rappaport, "public and private processes are (and must be) related, but only loosely related" (122). In the long run, he suggests, formal acceptance will be insufficient to found a social order on the widespread absence of belief. But ritual provides a primary means by which acceptance can be articulated with belief. It may also be noted that this concern with the private and public is but a refraction of his wider questions concerning the partial connections and disconnections between the meaningful and the physical world (Messer, this volume).

We may also link this discussion to the argument that "belief" is central to Christianity, which has its origins in the idea of believing Christ (during his lifetime), that is, placing trust in another person (Ruel 1982). Judaism is based on accepting the law, signaled by conforming to "the ritual observances that pervade all of life" (120). Within Christianity, concepts of order and ritual are intellectually more congenial to Catholics than Protestants (cf. Asad 1993) and within anthropology to those of Catholic or Jewish formation, such as Douglas and Rappaport, respectively. And it is not surprising that charisma is a Weberian concept.

In sum, while Rappaport makes a strong claim for beginning an analysis of religion with ritual rather than belief, this is not on empirical grounds. Rappaport is concerned with the logic of ritual, that is, with the entailments of its form as a unique kind of human action. Conversely, he is cognizant of the insufficiencies of belief with respect to stability, consistency, and definitiveness. Thus, to the extent that he attempts to distinguish or describe religion, it is on formal rather than substantive grounds. Not only is religion not a matter of belief in specific kinds of Being(s), but it is not grounded in belief per se.

From Semiotics to Practice

In distinguishing an approach, like Durkheim's or Rappaport's, that begins with ritual from those that begin with myth or symbol, I do not

mean to imply that the former does not also bring the symbolic into its analysis. The distinction is not between action and thought but whether the latter is essentially or exclusively a matter of representation. For Rappaport and Bloch, it is not; for them, religious action and meaning are fused, such that saying is at once doing and doing is saying. Representing is thus only one of the many things one can do with symbols; conversely, the symbolic accounts for only a portion of signifying practice. Notably, for Rappaport religion's ultimate sacred postulates do not in fact *represent anything.* Instead, they signify what fundamentally *is.* They are thus the antithesis of the key or polyvalent symbols that Turner so brilliantly unpacks. Rappaport, too, performs such symbolic and structural analysis of the Maring repertoire,[19] but this is secondary (cf. Strathern and Stewart, this volume).

At this point, it is past the time to break from the general usage of the word *symbol* and acknowledge the more precise language of Peircean semiotics, which provides another piece of Rappaport's tool kit. Following Peirce, Rappaport is at pains to distinguish icon and index from symbol and to show their intrinsic importance in human culture (without using them to distinguish humans from other animals). If, Rappaport argues, the capacity to symbolize frees us from here and now, ritual can be understood as a reconstitution of indexicality (i.e., of the here and now), an attempt to give symbolic communication the virtues of indexical grounding, most especially the virtue of certainty.

Although Rappaport's application of semiotics parallels theoretical developments at Chicago, most notably those associated with Silverstein (1976), the interests of the latter are closely linked to pragmatics and part of the general trend toward practice theory, whereas for Rappaport what is fundamental about ritual is its relationship to order, to the enduring and rule-bound elements of society.[20] For Rappaport, what is unique about ritual performance is its *conjunction* of order and practice or, as he puts it, the canonical (which is symbolic in Peircean terms) and the indexical. In ritual, celebrants take up messages that are not only previously encoded but have the qualities of order, permanence, and truthfulness. Yet the choice to participate in the ritual and the presence of each celebrant in a particular performance carries indexical messages. In Rappaport's analysis, the two aspects of ritual performance, indexical and canonical, reinforce each other and produce something beyond either of them, something both absolutely unique and fundamental to

social life. By contrast, practice theory emphasizes elements of power, interest, competition, strategy, uncertainty, and calculated risk.

Rather than joining the shift from structure to practice, Rappaport tries to understand how these are related, and related in a hierarchical way, so that practical responses can leave the structural core relatively insulated, and, conversely, how the structural core provides the guarantee, legitimacy, or meaningfulness required for practical operations. Rappaport's account is more hopeful and less cynical than most precisely because, without denying the prevalence of instrumentality, self-interest, and competition, he contextualizes them and argues that society has had the means, namely, liturgical orders, to regulate their presence and effects. In contextualizing instrumental reason, Rappaport may be said to perform by means of ritual a similar task to that which Sahlins (1976) performs by means of structure.[21] Indeed, one might also say that like Sahlins (1985) Rappaport is concerned with the relationship of structure to history, of the stable to the contingent in human affairs. The main difference is that Rappaport sees structure and stability as the product more of ritual action than of mythical thought. It is ritual's establishment of commitments and verities more than the specificities of distinct mythical worlds that interests him.[22]

If one way to marry Rappaport with discourse and practice theory is to look for the effects of practice and history in and on ritual, another is to apply the concern with order evident in Rappaport to practice, supplementing practice theory's obsession with power and interest with attention to the moral. This would entail looking at the way the establishment of moral conditions in explicit performances of ritual spills over into everyday, relatively unselfconscious practice, for example, the way Muslims frame virtually every action with pious utterances or Trobrianders preface all kinds of mundane activities with "magical spells" (Malinowski 1961).[23] It would also examine the way most people attempt, most of the time, to do the right thing under ambiguous circumstances, exercising their judgment with reference to the moral verities established in ritual.[24]

Similarly, one would want to see what kinds of connections could be made between Rappaport's general theory of religion and the diverse forms of religion one finds in practice, hence to marry Rappaport with more Weberian concerns with comparison and history. Rappaport does recognize different kinds of religion. In particular, he notes that in

"complex" societies and universalizing religions the performance of fundamental understandings (e.g., the Mass) may often be segregated from the performance of more contingent understandings, whereas among the Maring the fundamental understandings are largely implicit and often embedded in rituals addressing more contingent issues (271). Moreover, he appears to suggest that Maring ritual condenses many of the functions that in literate religions become increasingly rationalized, institutionally distinguished, or refined by theologians (cf. Levy, this volume).

Rappaport does provide incisive accounts of a number of religions, but he is not really concerned with why people embrace specific religious paths so passionately or convert between them (Peacock, this volume). For Rappaport, ritual helps reduce the problem of choice; he does not acknowledge the common situation of religious pluralism, the fact that in most if not all complex societies religious alternatives appear side by side, often without mutual exclusion.[25] Most people can or must face the choice of which religion, or which version, to follow. Nor does his approach lead us to ask what the larger social forces are that push religious adherence in one direction or another. A very real question in such instances is how to describe the conjunction of diverse religious perspective. Are they one system or many (James 1988; Lambek 1993)? Can they be said to be competing, complementary, contradictory, or incommensurable and, if so, at which levels in Rappaport's hierarchy? While Rappaport emphasizes how liturgical orders disambiguate adherence, many of the historical moments he points to, for example, the Christian conversion of Britain, were far messier. What happens when people must "convert" between liturgical orders or commit to more than one? What happens to the model when we start not with religion in the abstract ("Judaism") but with the practices of a given group (of "Jews") at a specific time and place?

However, a strength of Rappaport is that, in a fashion analogous to the way he addresses change, one could show how a universalizing religion like Islam or Christianity can be fundamental to many different kinds of societies (and hence how there can be many Islams, yet each firmly recognizable as Islam). This is resolved by the notion of hierarchy. Sacred postulates that are themselves devoid of specific social content can be used to ground and sanctify a variety of more specific social and political forms and processes (Wagner, this volume). With respect to an anthropology of Islam, this might entail a shift of emphasis from law to prayer (Lambek, 2000b).

Power and the Ideal Type

Both Rappaport and Durkheim assert that the universality of religion implies that it is not useful to start out by describing religion as false. Both say the question to ask is not whether religion is true but *of what* it is true. As Rappaport puts it, it is necessary "not only to grasp what is true *of* all religions but what is true *in* all religions, that is, the special character of the truths that it is in the nature of all religions to claim" (2).

However, by the same token, Rappaport pays relatively little attention to the relationship between organized religion and earthly power, to the ways in which sanctification often props up ruthless domination or at times compromises itself in competing for power or authority (see also Wolf 1999). Although he is at pains in the last chapters to isolate the ways in which rituals become distorted by power and the exercise of special interests, he refers to this as a *pathology* of religion, as if it were something unusual. In fact, his examples of the oversanctification of specific rules such as the papal encyclical against birth control or Coolidge's statement that "the business of America is business" are quite illuminating. He calls this "idolatry" and notes, following Tillich, how it absolutizes the relative and relativizes the absolute (442–43). Fundamentalism, which he defines as "the literal interpretation of highly specific texts and the granting to them of absolute authority" (as extended ultimate sacred postulates), makes the same error (445). Sanctity subordinated to the interests of the powerful is deceitful and produces false consciousness in those who continue to participate and alienation in those who do not (447). But this in turn raises the questions of whether religion in its pure, "healthy" form is indeed ever found, whether its positive contributions must always be weighed against the abuses, and whether, indeed, the interpretation is not relative to one's historical and political position.

What is needed is not just the deductive argument that sanctity overcomes the problems of lies and interest but rather a demonstration of the playing out of sanctified orders and responses to them (resistance, rebellion, conversion, religious wars, persecution, and pluralism) or "pathologies" (corruption, distortion, deception) over the course of human history. As Rappaport recognizes, it is clearly not the case that sanctity has overcome these problems once and for all, so the question is to see how they offset each other in the course of real events. The move away from idealized models (both his own and his insightful distillations of those of

specific religions) toward history is only begun in the final chapter. It is to be hoped that others will explore the value of Rappaport's model to illuminate specific historical circumstances (see Levy, Wagner, and Wiessner and Tumu, this volume).

In sum, if Rappaport's main point is precisely how religion helps offset humanity's capacity for deception—a broad concept that includes the abuse of power—perhaps he does not pay sufficient attention to the ways in which it has *regularly* been used to support deception or even the ways in which it enables *more powerful* forms of deception and abuse. Similarly, he devotes relatively little attention to religious conflict, to fights over religion (or in religion's name), or to how religion may contribute to conflicts in experience. At the end of the book, he argues that "as power accumulates the relationship between sanctity and authority is likely to be inverted. Whereas in the technologically and socially simple society the authority is contingent upon the maintenance of its sanctity, in the technologically and socially complex society sanctity may well be degraded to the status of authority's instrument" (446). In the latter case, acceptance is coerced through threats of violence and hence the moral entailments developed in Rappaport's earlier arguments no longer hold. But when does this begin? What about the sanctification of gender hierarchy in small-scale societies? And what about coercion by nonviolent means?

The problem is that Rappaport does not recognize that his models have the status of ideal types. Thus, when he suggests a kind of cybernetic ethics whereby "oppression is not only inhumane but maladaptive," he does not recognize how fundamentally this fact of oppression challenges his previous depiction of the "cybernetics of the holy." In fact, it is just a model, one that sets up a system that may never have been actualized. But if distortion is *mal*adaptive, and if distortion is characteristic of most of human history, then is it reasonable to speak of this history as mal*adaptive?* Or does it suggest that we drop the concept of adaptation from the analysis? Moreover, the subordination of the sacred to the deceitful interests of the powerful in the twentieth century suggests that the human linguistic capacity to lie has "in the end" (so far) prevailed over our ability to control lying through sanctity (448–49). Of course, Rappaport's model may be ideal in a second sense, namely, something to strive for.

Perhaps in the end Rappaport's work will be judged less by whether it is seen in evolutionary or historical terms than according to whether

one believes that order or disorder has been more characteristic of human social life.

In Conclusion, the Logos: Order or Incommensurability?

A final word in Rappaport's vocabulary is *logos,* which he takes "to refer to an all-encompassing rational order uniting nature, society, individual humans and divinity into a 'great cosmos' . . . which is eternal, true, moral, and in some sense harmonious" (352–53). The logoi of various religions—"the social, moral, conceptual, and material elements of which worlds are . . . bound together into coherent wholes" (351)—are not dissimilar to what Rappaport himself is after in this book. If the logos is concerned with truth, order, and harmony, so, too, is the model that Rappaport develops. "If harmony is an aspect of an all-encompassing Logos, the Logos cannot be arbitrary, for harmony, must suppose an accommodation of convention to naturally constituted phenomena—laws, process, and things—which convention cannot supervene nor human action alter" (369). The logos is at once both a realistic and ideal understanding of the world.[26]

The logos is "an order of which humans are parts" (473). Not only a conventional, performative product of ritual, it is the actual subject of the book and the order in nature (or, rather, "nature" itself). And, just as the logos may be conceived by the adherents of any given religion to subsume morality and society, so, according to Rappaport's analysis, it does. The parallel to Durkheim—discovering what is true of and in religion—is very close, indeed, and only the scope is expanded. Whereas Durkheim's account sees society and religion as self-constituting and argues for the analysis of society sui generis, Rappaport sees his analysis as justification for contextualizing culture in evolutionary and ecological terms.

We conclude with the basic question to which all this leads, namely, whether Rappaport's theory corresponds to the world as it is, whether it has, in Rappaport's vocabulary, "veracity" (Descartes's *certum*); or whether it provides an ideal and has "verity" (Vico's *verum*) (296) against which the "facts" must be measured and perhaps be found wanting. Does Rappaport's argument construct and constitute an impossibly ideal order, a logos analogous to the one he claims religion itself constructs? He writes, "I am asserting that the correlations I propose are 'in order' or correct, but it is possible for understandings comprising discursive structures to become 'out of order' " (317).[27]

Rappaport himself would say that his is an account of nature, whose "grasp can claim no status more certain than certum, and as such may be off the mark or even dead wrong" (296). He would certainly wish to explicitly deny the claim of *verum* (a fallacy of misplacement he judges destructive). But the suspicion grows as one reads this book that it offers itself as something more than an ordinary scientific investigation.

When Rappaport writes that the "structure [realized in and by means of ritual, as he has elucidated it] is the foundation upon which the human way of life stands" (405), is he describing the way the world is or an ideal? Is he saying that this "ideal" is in some way truer, more "real," than the facts? In the end, discrepancies from the model stand in relation to it somewhat like the acts that run counter to what one has just accepted in ritual. He speaks about pathology and idolatry. His strongest remarks are reserved for the sanctification of money and the way instrumental and self-serving values subordinate more fundamental processes (see Hornborg, this volume). This inversion of the hierarchy of contingency is described as simultaneously immoral and maladaptive. Rappaport calls for a new logos in which the concept of ecosystem is fundamental. Perhaps only through new forms of ritual can ecological comprehension be translated into acceptance and hence commitment. We need, like the Aboriginal Australians, to learn to act "on behalf of the world" and not merely for ourselves. In a phrase that echoes profoundly, if ironically, Lévi-Strauss (for whom "mind" would have the central place that Rappaport gives to ecosystem), he concludes that "humanity is that part of the world through which the world as a whole can think about itself" (461).[28]

In the end, there is a deep respect for both religion and the rationalism that characterizes science, for both the world of natural process and the world of humanly meaningful construction. There is the rational recognition of their incommensurability and also the immensely fertile invitation, yet one that may require a religious leap of commitment to accept, to overcome it.

NOTES

I thank Keith Hart, Bob Levy, and anonymous reviewers for their comments on an earlier draft and especially Ellen Messer for a close and critical reading that saved me from many errors and infelicities. Those that remain are entirely my own.

1. This depiction is of course highly selective. While drawing attention to

various portions of Rappaport's argument, I do not attempt to recapitulate it. To construct a summary of such a precisely argued and totalizing work risks trivializing it. Moreover, parts of the argument already exist in condensed form in Rappaport's own "The Obvious Aspects of Ritual" (1979) and other essays. Nor do I attempt to reckon what here is new or changed from earlier pieces. All citations are to the 1999 work, and the date will not be repeated when page references are given.

2. The perdurance of the Maring ritual order of Papua New Guinea (the locus of Rappaport's ethnographic research) cannot be demonstrated. We simply do not know how many cycles of *rumbim* planting have occurred or when they began. At some places, Rappaport argues that more important than actual time depth is the fact that people accept that a ritual has been carried out "since time immemorial." See Wiessner and Tumu (this volume) and Wiessner and Tumu 1998 for a new vision of Highlands history.

3. "St. Emile," in the heading, is Rappaport's epithet (170).

4. In what may be a tacit response to Durkheim (mediated by Stanner, Yengoyan, and especially Meggitt), Rappaport ends by showing a particular appreciation for Aboriginal Australian religion.

5. It might be phrased as "deceased ancestors persist as sentient beings" (277).

6. It is also noteworthy that Rappaport's cybernetic model, with its emphasis on self-regulation, pays little attention to competition and hence disregards sociobiology.

7. Ellen Messer has suggested (personal communication) that for Durkheim the sacred also refers to order.

8. Rappaport is at pains to distinguish sacred truth from logical truth and ultimate sacred postulates, like the Shema, from logical axioms. This is an interesting discussion best read in the original (287–89, 293ff.).

9. In this respect, Rappaport is rather closer to Foucault or Foucauldian analyses (Hacking 1995) than he supposes. Yang (1994) provides a superb account of what some of the differences between a ritual and a state-based subjectivity might entail.

10. In these societies, one might say, temporal order remains structural in Evans-Pritchard's (Durkheimian) sense or underrationalized in Weber's sense.

11. Tambiah's elegant analyses of magic and other rituals (1985) combine attention to the metaphoric or poetic qualities of ritual and the illocutionary.

12. The emphasis on the nonrepresentational is found again in the centrality of the ultimate sacred postulates, characterized as they are by material and social vacuity.

13. The violence in ritual, as often "real" as it is "symbolic," is addressed by Rappaport in the way it shapes the experience of performers rather than as part of the structural logic of ritual's statements, as in Bloch (1986, 1992), for whom the transcendental is created by doing violence to the everyday.

14. Rappaport's noise would be, in effect, meaningless as well.

15. See, for example, how the mystification of performative statements helps realize the autonomy of spirits in Mayotte (Lambek 1981, 1999).

16. "Purposive rationality" says Bateson (1972: 146, cited by Rappaport, 401), "unaided by such phenomena as art, religion . . . and the like, is necessarily pathogenic and destructive of life; and . . . its virulence springs specifically from the circumstance that life depends upon interlocking circuits of contingency, while consciousness can see only such short arcs of such circuits as human purpose may direct."

17. These arguments concerning reason and rationality might usefully be compared to those of Max Weber (1946).

18. For example, in North America engaging in a new marriage when one is already married to someone else is null and void once the deception is discovered. In fact, this case serves to support Rappaport's point since the sincerity of the parties counts for nothing if the previous marriage does in fact exist. As a counterexample, we may note the way that Jacob's blessing holds good despite the fact that he obtained it by impersonating his brother Esau (Lambek 2000a).

19. See especially chapter 8. Perhaps he does not take this analysis far enough; he does not ask what warfare itself signifies for Maring. It may be noted that Bloch also provides superb symbolic analyses; indeed, Bloch's understanding of the general way in which life must be defeated to produce the transcendental (1986) is not so far from Rappaport's specific conclusion that Maring thought suggests "the subordination of fertility-death to spirituality" (254).

20. There were also disagreements about how to use the Peircean concepts (54–55, 58–68).

21. On Rappaport's relationship with practice theory, see also his identification of deutero-learning (Levy, this volume) with Bourdieu's use of habitus (1999: 304).

22. Perhaps in emphasizing the repetitiveness and formality of ritual and its logical distinction from history (234) Rappaport underestimates the extent to which history, that is, real transformation, is often made during or in the context of ritual itself or at least with respect to ritual order.

23. A central issue here is whether Rappaport's working distinction between ritual and rituals can be maintained or how far it remains useful. Similarly, to what degree do his lower levels of sanctification begin to merge with the habitus?

24. Following Aristotle, I refer to this as phronesis (Lambek 1993, 1996, 2000a).

25. This is true across most of the world. Though exacerbated by the universalizing religions (Bercovitch 1998; Whitehouse 1996), the condition undoubtedly existed in Papua New Guinea prior to European presence (Wiessner and Tumu, this volume).

26. Again, it would appear to be no mere representation but iconically and indexically, no less than symbolically, related to the world.

27. If so, then what is ideal is simultaneously "real," and this is why Rappaport would reject depicting his models in terms of Weber's methodological "ideal type."

28. As Messer (personal communication) points out, Bateson (1972) would in fact combine mind and ecosystem.

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PART III

The Papua New Guinea Context: Following Skip's Ethnographic Footsteps

Rappaport's Maring: The Challenge of Ethnography

Andrew Strathern and Pamela J. Stewart

A striking event in Roy Rappaport's vivid and detailed account of preparations for the *kaiko* pig-killing festival in 1962 among the Tsembaga Maring is the uprooting of the cordylines, or men's souls' *rumbim* (*yu min rumbim*), which signals a major shift in the Maring cosmic cycle: from growth and fertility to the explosion of energy in prestation and warfare. This event is often referred to in passing in evaluations and discussions of Rappaport's work, less, however, as an important motif in its own right than as a component of arguments about the functions of ritual, ecological functionalism, or liturgical authentification. Indeed, in the collective anthropological arena of discourse the Maring—and Rappaport—tend to be associated with these debates and their ethnography is presented only in relation to questions that arise from the debates. Notably, Rappaport himself, in the long 1984 addition to *Pigs for the Ancestors,* engages with his opponents and critics in these theoretical terms, making many interesting and powerful points but also without recourse to his own rich ethnographic corpus. The Maring have also been placed into other analytical "boxes": in terms of the "production" of pigs for festivals in contrast to the "financing" activities of their neighbors, the Melpa (Strathern 1969); and, flowing from this earlier distinction, into the basket of "great man" versus "big man" societies (Godelier 1986). In this essay, we take a different tack. We ask what would happen if instead of attempting to wade through thickets of theory we went back to the corpus of ethnography and thought again about its components as a means of making comparisons: about, for example, red pandanus fruit, marsupials, pigs, red spirits, spirits of rot, the *rumbim,* the Smoke Woman (Kun Kaze Ambra) and her shamans, the fight magic men and their stones hung in a net bag. And what if we allowed similar elements from Melpa ethnography to be

cited as a basis for comparison? This would be a process of making ethnographies speak to each other, creating new arenas of commonality and difference, and permitting a detail from one case to illuminate an aspect of the other, setting up a transgressive conversation. In effect, ethnographers who know the details about related societies often do conduct such conversations in their own minds. Here we do so on paper. Our aim is to show that the ethnography of Rappaport's Maring should not be thrown away with the bathwater of ecological functionalism and that ethnography poses its own challenges to the comparativist outside of any particular theoretical framework (see the introduction to Lambek and Strathern 1998 for a further exposition of this approach and its flexibilities; see also, in the same volume, Strathern and Stewart 1998a for an example of this kind of comparative analysis). Of course, this really means that we as anthropologists fashion our own challenges out of our selections from the ethnography; but that is all right, provided that we remain open to the details in doing so. "Uprooting the *rumbim*" is one such detail.

To illustrate this approach, we take three arenas and think about them in terms of the Melpa and the Maring: (1) group identification, the Melpa *mi* and Maring *rumbim* as performative domains; (2) female spirits, the Melpa Amb Kor and Maring Smoke Woman; and (3) warfare, fertility, and ritual regulation, an exit in pursuit of theory.

Mi and Rumbim

Exact equivalents to the Melpa concept of the *mi* have been hard to find in Highlands New Guinea ethnography. The *mi* is a mystical divination substance associated with the hidden powers of origin of a group, which protects the group members but can also punish them if they break its rules or lie while swearing an oath on it. Strauss and Tischner (1962) have provided a detailed discussion of it, showing its fundamental significance for Melpa social structure, exchange, and morality generally. Their work (essentially that of Hermann Strauss) is not cited by Rappaport (1968), although it provides a useful counterpart to his own stress on ritual as an integrative tool of holistic analysis. The 1960s anthropological stress on the Highlanders as "secular" people, negated independently by Rappaport and Strauss, has been largely abandoned since the 1970s (see, e.g., Strathern 1970, 1979–80; and Stewart and Strathern 1999a, 2000a). Stephen Frankel, writing of the Huli people of the Southern

Highlands Province in Papua New Guinea, commented that the Huli seem to have no such overarching concept of group morality founded in ancestry, although Huli ancestors may punish individuals for impropriety by making them sick (1986: 144).

The Maring also have no equivalent to the *mi.* But their ideas about the cordyline plant, the *rumbim,* especially the red variety, show a considerable overlap with the fundamental notions that inform the Melpa idea of the *mi,* and the two concepts can be seen to operate in the same sorts of performative domains, that is, as the sources of life and the markers of boundaries. In addition, a variety of the cordyline is the *mi* for at least two Melpa groups, the Yamka (Vicedom and Tischner 1943–48 vol. 3, myth no. 39) and the Kawelka (Strathern 1972: 36).

The cordyline is known throughout the Pacific region and elsewhere as a boundary marker precisely because of its own powers of life, which are shown in its longevity and its ability to survive drought. It is not surprising, therefore, to see it pressed into similar symbolic service across a number of Highlands societies. Rappaport's ethnography, however, enables us to move a step or two further. When claims to territories are made among the Maring, "every adult member participates in this ritual by grasping the *rumbim* as it is planted, thus symbolizing both his connection to the land and his membership in the group that claims the land" (Rappaport 1968: 19). LiPuma in his study of the Kauwatyi Maring adds some further depth to this point: "In the ceremonies of the ritual planting of *rumbim* clansmen safeguard the social cycle, their individual *min* co-mingle and are infused into the ground. . . . Moreover the planted *rumbim* insures that men will grow fast and strong and be able to produce many children" (1988: 67). LiPuma's overall argument is that the concept of cosubstance informs all of Maring social organization, and what he has pointed to here is the cosubstance of men's souls and their territorial ground. Rappaport also reports that in rituals performed at a sacred grove on the day before the *rumbim* is uprooted in preparation for the *kaiko* festival two large red pandanus fruits are harvested from low-altitude areas, either planted by persons now dead or from groves in which the remains of dead persons are buried (1968: 176). Some of the oil from this fruit is rubbed on people's legs and buttocks to make them strong and on women's bellies to make them fertile. A cassowary bone is used to feed each person their first mouthful (178).

This detail shows clearly the cosubstance notion later made central

by LiPuma in his ethnography. For our purposes here, we can use it to ask further questions about the uprooting of the *rumbim* itself. It is *dangerous* but *essential,* it seems, to perform this uprooting. Why? Because, we may suggest, it separates men's souls from the earth; it rips them from the earth's "womb" (and the breaking of the roots is like the cutting of the umbilical cord, we might say). This violent act, like that of birth itself, brings with it the assurance of subsequent death during the point in the ritual when the fighters must come to terms with their own mortality as they prepare to face their enemies. This act of ripping, however, has to be seen as timely, not untimely. It shifts the cosmos. The *rumbim* are placed in shallow water, their roots pointing to the clan area, to rot and conduce to fertility, their heads aimed like missiles at enemy land, to wither and send desiccation to the foe in a kind of magical biological warfare. They are like icons of dead men become weapons at their territorial boundaries.

Having decided to tear up their connection with the earth, the Tsembaga men in 1962 ritually reestablished this connection by burying painted stakes near the gate of the ceremonial enclosure: "Now that the *rumbim* was to be uprooted these would protect the *min,* the life stuff of the men, preventing both the spirits of enemies and the corruption that flows from them from entering the house enclosure" (Rappaport 1968: 180–81). This action is comparable to the planting of a type of *rumbim* at the same gateway in order "to keep within the fence the *min* . . . of the local girls" during the time of dancing, since girls might be inclined to elope with visitors (174), and to the planting of two *rumbim* inside the enclosure "to keep the *min* of the men inside the enclosure" and therefore safe from hostile magic when they go out to fight (133). Manipulating the *min* was thus a major part of the sorcery used in warfare, and the backup action of planting protective stakes and cordylines was made necessary by the dangerous primal act of uprooting the communally planted cordylines and letting loose the spirits of war.

Cordyline can thus be seen as a prime holder of life force for the Maring. The same is basically true for the Melpa. Vicedom's myth and folktale collection from the 1930s (Vicedom and Tischner 1943–48: vol. 3) contains a number of references to this effect. In myth 16, the Female Spirit gives her human sister a ritual bundle that includes red cordylines, which the sister's husband plants in a ritual enclosure. The men also wear sprigs from it in their rear coverings when they dance for the spirit. Myth 36 records a visit by female ghosts waving cordyline plants to a

woman's grave. Myth 39 describes how the cordyline came to be the *mi* of the Yamka people, and myths 60 and 71 contain sequences in which a spirit antagonist of a human being is killed by uprooting red cordylines he has planted in a hidden place. In myth 71, a man has tracked down a hostile spirit who has killed his wife and stolen her head. The marsupial cat Watinga advises him, after he has failed to dispatch the spirit with blows from an ax, to pull up the red cordyline plants in the garden and throw them in the fire, and after he does so the spirit dies.

The logic here is clearly exactly the same as among the Maring. The cordyline is connected with life, death, and the boundary between them. Rooted in the earth, it marks attachment and life; uprooted, it implies vulnerability and death. This underscores the point made earlier that its uprooting among the Maring is both an act of extreme danger and an act necessary for the ritual switching from peace to war.

The Melpa concept of the *mi* represents a consolidation and objectification of ideas that for the Maring cluster around the cordyline itself and its connection with *min,* or "life stuff." (It is tempting to think of *mi* and *min* as etymologically related, but we have no evidence that this is so.) The element that links *rumbim* and *mi* together is that of the oath or promise. Planting the *rumbim* is a promise to rear pigs and not engage in fighting until the *kaiko* is next held. Uprooting it means the abrogation of the taboo on fighting and the fulfillment of the promise to kill pigs. Among the Melpa, the *mi* was held in order to swear innocence of wrongdoing or to sacralize also an intention to fight. The *mi* could in turn punish those who lied while holding it or did not keep their promises. Accordingly, it was customary for men to confess in the presence of the *mi* any wrongdoings, acts of betrayal, or grudges against group mates before going out to fight. It became a guardian of group morality and politics, corresponding to Rappaport's general theory of the sanctity of liturgical orders in acephalous societies but supplying an element of transcendence not found in the Maring case, through the notion of punishment. This difference is significant, foregrounded against a great similarity of ideas. We will see a similar pattern in comparing practices directed toward female spirit figures in the two cases.

Amb Kor and *Kun Kaze Ambra:* Icons of Peace and War

Cults directed toward powerful female spirits are not found universally in the Highlands of New Guinea. The Melpa show a considerable stress

on a cult of this kind, in performances that mirrored the cyclicity of generational renewal. It turns out that the Maring also, in a sense, have a 'Female Spirit cult', but its modus operandi is different from that found among the Melpa, as some data will show. Nevertheless, in a broader sense they belong to the same kind of overall ritual cycle (see also Stewart and Strathern 1999a).

In comparing aspects of the Hagen and Maring cosmological notions of cyclicity we can, then, consider ideas about the Melpa Amb Kor (Female Spirit) and the Maring Kun Kaze Ambra (Smoke Woman). In both societies, when men were engaged in activities directed toward one of these female spirits a cessation of sexual activities with human women had to be observed (Rappaport 1968: 29; Strathern and Stewart 1997, 1998b, 1999a). In Hagen, it was prominent male leaders to whom the Female Spirit revealed herself in a dream/vision, at which time she imparted specific knowledge of how to perform her cult rituals. For the Maring, it was the male leaders who became shamans after having been "struck" by the Smoke Woman (Rappaport 1968: 178). It was this privileged relationship that the shaman had with the Smoke Woman that mediated the transfer of knowledge between the Maring men who were preparing to go to war and the ancestors. Through Smoke Woman was mediated the approval/endorsement of the ancestors for the men's actions and an assurance of their protection for the fighters (119–20). Unlike Smoke Woman, the Female Spirit was not involved as a mediator prior to warfare; rather, ancestral support was sought directly through sacrifices and invocations by the men or through ritual experts who fell into trance after possession by the spirit of a fallen prominent warrior (Vicedom and Tischner 1943–48: 2:172).

An interesting convergence between the Maring and Hagen female spirits is found in the sacred stones to which these spirits direct men. In the Maring case, each of the landholding groups within the area possessed a pair of *bamp ku* (fighting stones), which were ritually hung up after the *rumbim* had been uprooted. The stones were hung suspended inside a net bag, which is an object symbolically equated with the womb in many Papua New Guinea cultures (Stewart and Strathern 1997a). These stones were said to have originated at the first home of the Smoke Woman in the upper Jimi Valley (125–27). The power of the Smoke Woman contained within these stones is not unlike that of the Hagen Female Spirit cult stones, which were located by cult members after the Female Spirit told them where to look for them. Her cult stones were

thought to serve as repositories for her powers during the cult performance and afterward, when they were buried in the local ground so as to enhance fertility (Stewart and Strathern 1999b; Stewart 1998). In both the Maring and the Hagen cases, the presence of female powers and symbolism was central to the successful progression of these "male" rituals.

The Female Spirit and Smoke Woman were sought at different moments. The Female Spirit cult performance was held when sickness had befallen the community and the group was weakened through a reduction in the number of men available to act during the challenge of warfare. She was thought to bring fertility to the group (e.g., increasing the number of male children born) and to give relief from bouts of sickness she herself may have inflicted. Smoke Woman was called upon specifically at the time of preparation for war when the fighters needed to be assured that they had the support of their ancestors prior to entering battle.

In both instances, these female spirits merge generally into the wider cycle of fertility. The Female Spirit brings fertility directly so as to increase the health and number of potential warriors in the community while the Smoke Woman allows the Maring men to ask for and receive the protection of their ancestors before entering battle, thereby assuring the death of fewer men. One detail of difference may be significant. The Smoke Woman was thought to "strike" novices with a "rough" form of possession. This occurred after the shaman had inhaled deeply and rapidly the smoke of "bespelled" tobacco cigars, at which time his *nomane* (mind) was said to depart his body through his nose and seek out Smoke Woman, who would "strike" him. Smoke Woman would then be led by the shaman back to his body, where she would enter his head through his nose, at which time he would rise to his feet dancing and chanting (Rappaport 1968: 119). The Hagen Amb Kor gave men dreams and visions in what we might call a more "smooth" encounter. But the Female Spirit could treat male cult members who disobeyed her taboos roughly by killing them. She could also treat females who disobeyed her ritually proscribed taboos in the same rough way. We can suggest that some of the distinctions between the ways the Hageners interacted with the Female Spirit and the ways the Maring interacted with Smoke Woman correlated with their respective "peaceful" and "warlike" associations and more generally with the presence of alliance by exchange among Melpa and its relative absence or underplaying in the Maring

case. But the rough/smooth distinction, as we have seen, holds only in part because both spirits were seen as very powerful figures and their power derived from their positionality as female entities occupying "male" spaces.

Warfare, Fertility, Regulation: An Exit in Pursuit of Theory

One of the strongest arguments Rappaport made in his study of the Tsembaga was that their lives were "ritually regulated." He extended this regulation from their social life to their actual functional adjustment to the physical environment, and it was this extension outward to encompass environmental regulation that occasioned both wide notice and praise for his work and a considerable amount of criticism, which he was at pains to discuss in the 1984 edition of *Pigs for the Ancestors.* We can revisit this theme of regulation, minus the controversy over its ecological aspects, in our comparison here.

A striking effect of reading Rappaport's Maring ethnography is the overwhelming impression that Maring social life really was ritually regulated and that this regulation shows the strongest positive case in the Highlands ethnography for a grand alternation between prestation/warfare on the one hand and production/peace on the other. The clear division between these two phases of the cosmic cycle, marked by the planting and the uprooting of the *rumbim* cordylines, shows also their wider unity and connection. The regular intertwining of the themes of warfare and fertility is shown in many details of ritual activities, but fertility is predictably stressed most at the time of planting the *rumbim,* when another item was also planted specifically for women. This was the *amame* (*Coelus sentellariodes*), referred to as the "pig belly *amame.*" At the time of its planting, the spirits of the low ground were asked to care for it so that the pigs would grow fat, women would be fertile, and gardens would flourish. Rappaport tells us that "The sexual and fertility content of this ritual seems apparent. The spatial placement of the ritual objects associated with male and female may represent the procreative act, which in turn symbolizes fertility in general" (1984: 149). Rappaport suggests that this ritual planting restarts the clock for peacetime activity.

At the time of the uprooting of the *rumbim* also, a day of ritual activities was completed on the *raku,* the ceremonial ground, which included acts aimed at enhancing fertility such as the eating of *marita* (red pandanus) and *ma* (marsupial) meat.

The connection between warfare and fertility is further clearly alluded to by LiPuma (1988): "Maring believe that when a clan abandons its land its clan ancestors are also displaced. Severing the reproductive cycle and thus the flow of substance means the ancestors of the defeated have been severed from the land too. The victorious group . . . may now begin to cultivate the land and initiate its own reproductive cycle" (70).

We should, incidentally, distinguish this argument about the ritual alternation between warfare and fertility from two other arguments about New Guinea societies. One is the observation that in some places warfare is itself seen as a means of enhancing fertility. This idea is exemplified well from the case of the Marind-anim of South New Guinea and some of their neighbors among whom there was "a cosmological cycle of growth and fertility that included the taking and incorporation of life-force, especially through headhunting" (Knauft 1993: 173). This is not what we have been arguing for the Maring. We *have* been arguing that warfare and fertility are linked in a grand cycle, such that fertility is seen as a period of latency, which is then realized in an expenditure of energy in warfare leading to a restatement or reconfiguration of land boundaries. As LiPuma's observations show, warfare can in practice lead to a gain or loss in fertility by a local group through the acquisition or abandonment of productive land. There is therefore a link between the two categories; but this is not to argue that the act of killing is seen as an augmentation of one's own life force other than through the destruction of the life force of enemies.

The second argument that has become commonplace is the idea that there is an eternal oscillation between warfare and exchange in Central Highlands societies, since either can lead into the other. In the Maring case, we have put warfare and prestation together, recognizing in advance that gifts to allies and ancestors are a specific, intended prelude to declaring war on enemies. This again differs from a general proposition that exchange and warfare are interconvertible. It merely recognizes what is also an empirical fact in other cases, that if a group wishes to reengage allies it must first indemnify them for their losses, a proposition that holds for the Melpa and is expressed in their root man/dead man distinction (Strathern 1971).

The Melpa, then, share with the Maring the basic political compulsion that underpins the *kaiko* event: the need to pay allies. We can also tell from the older literature that revenge was something owed to the spirits of the dead killed in warfare (Strauss and Tischner 1962; Vicedom

and Tischner 1943–48: vol. 2). But what of the argument regarding fertility and the grand cycle of ritual regulation? It is here that Rappaport's model has been very challenging. Was Melpa warfare ritually regulated, as Maring warfare was? If not, why not? It is here also that we need to return to some of the theoretical themes we bypassed initially to concentrate on the challenges of ethnographic details, since the details we have selected themselves now point to those themes.

The Melpa do have cultural ideas regarding the *mi* and cordylines that could be inflected into a pattern of ritual regulation of conflict, as we have seen. But they did not have such a clearly collectivized timing of a switch from one phase to the other via the planting/uprooting of cordyline that we find with the Maring. They did, however, stress greatly the need to sacrifice to the dead and the originary forces of the *mi* before deciding to enter into a fight. In that sense, their warfare was indeed ritually regulated. But in other senses we could argue that it was deregulated, entered into through the contingent political designs of leaders known as big men and tied in with competitions over wealth and exchange. This line of discussion, then, leads us back to the finance versus production distinction remarked on earlier. The same is true for the contrast between Female Spirit and Smoke Woman. Smoke Woman picked out and assisted Maring shamans in their communications with the red spirits of warfare: her ritual was tied in with warfare. The Female Spirit cult was relatively delinked from warfare, instigated by big men who used it to emphasize fertility power but also their own power to mobilize resources and distribute pork to a wide set of supporters and visitors during the cult event. The cult thus partially or momentarily uncoupled fertility from warfare, whereas Smoke Woman's cult emphasized their immediate coupling. By way of a more general comparison, in big man/finance systems such as the Melpa developed, there is a tendency to stress leadership through the organization of exchange, whereas in great man/production systems (e.g., the Maring) leadership and influence are diffused through a number of officeholders, although these differences are not hard and fast categories. In both, leaders clearly have connections with ritual sources of power (Strathern 1993), and a system such as the Melpa developed could easily be seen as a historical transformation of the Maring structure, although the evidence does not compel us to do so.

Here, then, we have returned to some aspect of difference. Yet, in their own exchange practices, seen as a replacement for warfare, and not

simply in ineluctable alternation with it, the Melpa reintroduced a coupling with ideas of both warfare and fertility. Exchange came to encompass both. It was competitive, and the idioms of competition encapsulated those of warfare (Stewart and Strathern 1998c). It was also said to "make grease," that is, fertility, and the wealth used in it indeed was at least partly employed in bridewealth payments, which did increase fertility for a group. Thus, for the Melpa, at least at a certain historical time of pacification and the expansion/elaboration of *moka* exchange (Strathern and Stewart 1999b), the alternation of warfare and fertility was swallowed by the encompassing logic of the *moka* exchange system itself.

In more recent times (since the 1980s), exchange has to a great extent been eclipsed by other forces of change, which have reduced the power of traditional big men and altered the patterns of hostility between groups. Elements of the earlier complexes of action associated with warfare and fertility have now begun to reenter community life, although in a changed form.

As was discussed earlier, the uprooting of the *rumbim* ritually marked the mental preparedness of the Maring warriors for battle, as did the holding of the cordyline and confessions of betrayal regarding ill feelings by the Hageners. This kind of practice reenters the contemporary context in Papua New Guinea through witnessing in the churches, thought to mentally steel parishioners for the war against Satan, who it is thought will be shortly at hand (Stewart and Strathern 1997b). Signs of this impending battle between Christians and satanic forces include a lack of fertility. The Duna people of the Southern Highlands Province say that "the ground will finish", that is, there will be an end to the reproductive cycle of the soil (Stewart and Strathern 2000b). The Hageners say that *möi kona paua* (ground place power), that is, the complex of material goods obtained by means of money rather than foodstuffs grown in local gardens, will rise up as a sign of Satan and an indication that the war against him must begin (Stewart and Strathern 1998b, 1998c). (Here the meaning is that *möi kona* refers to "this earth," where mundane, profit-seeking activities are pursued in a modern secular way, as opposed to the sacralized activities of indigenous garden work and particularly the religious worship of God that is thought to give access to heaven.) The connection for the Maring and the Hageners of the cordyline with the *min* (souls) of their people and the symbolic connection of the rooted cordyline in the fertile soil of the group's land are vividly reflected in these millennial beliefs in which

the loss of fertility of the ground is the most definite sign that the war between the faithful and those who are deemed to be the followers of Satan has begun.

Conclusion: Making Ethnographies Speak to Each Other

Roy Rappaport left the world of anthropology a superb set of ethnographic field data as well as a lifetime of thinking further about ritual, functional analysis, ecology, and sanctity, among other matters. As a tribute to him in his capacity as an ethnographer, we have been concerned here to revisit his observations and allow them to speak from his text to the texts of the regional ethnography, specifically those of the Melpa. Our first aim was to bypass theoretical argument by taking a fresh look at "things as they are" (or were in earlier times; the phrase is borrowed from Jackson 1996). In a closing move, however, we have returned to theoretical/comparative issues in more conventional terms, examining the warfare/fertility complex of the Maring as an example of ritual regulation and seeking transformations of this complex among the Melpa. Throughout, we have been concerned not so much to demonstrate a set of firm conclusions as to illustrate the possibilities of our method: of listening to the challenge of ethnography and allowing ethnographies to speak to each other in lively responses to that challenge. We offer our suggestions to the beneficent spirit of a colleague who has now become an ancestor.

NOTE

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Reflections on Pigs for the Ancestors

Gillian Gillison

Pigs for the Ancestors is a work of intellectual daring and beauty. It anticipates E. O. Wilson's *Consilience* by thirty years in its attempt to reunite biology and culture, to preserve "a view of humanity as part of nature" (Rappaport [1968] 1984: 388). The book inspired my first fieldwork in 1973 among Gimi-speaking people of the Eastern Highlands of Papua New Guinea. Dazzled by Rappaport's theory of ritual regulation, I hypothesized that the ritual fixation on menstruation might serve to regulate, or regularly interrupt, the work of women, who performed nearly all the daily tasks of gardening and pig rearing. I had the idea that in the rain forest, where there is little seasonality or other naturally occurring cycles to guide behavior, menstrual taboos might exploit the cycles of women's bodies to organize subsistence behavior.

It took me a while to abandon this hypothesis. In the process, I discovered a great deal about the timing of subsistence among the Gimi. Although women spend much of their days alone in gardens or caring for pigs, their activities are also coordinated by men throughout the year on a lineage or clan basis. The clearing of new lands from forest is always a communal endeavour, which begins with the onset of drier weather in April or May. Some ecologists claim that the Highlands' climate is "everwet" and has no dry season (van Steenis, in Clark 1971: 44–45), raising the question of how the Gimi are able to guage the critical—but extremely subtle—shift to drier weather, which they call *esara fo,* literally "cicada sun," because screeching cicadas arrive inside the settlement. Men name various indicators of the shift, including the position of the sun as it rises, the start of strong northwesterly winds funneled from higher valleys, the ripening of fruits and blossoms on forest trees they have deliberately transplanted to coffee gardens, and the appearance of

honey eaters and Superb Birds of Paradise feeding upon the newly ripened plants (see Gillison 1993: 37). Men say the birds' breeding cycles are synchronized with the ripening of fruits to feed their young.

Big Men are not only astute in assessing the combination of these elusive signs; they also have the authority to be mistaken and to "take the heat" after work parties have been assembled and forced to stop because the rains have not really let up. I heard other men declare in November or January or some other unlikely time that the dry season was now upon us and that hunting parties would soon be going into the forest to shoot marsupials as they left their nests in trees to search for water on the ground. But these observations were generally ignored. It was the responsibility of Big Men to announce the change of season by assessing diverse environmental signs and then to stand behind their collective decision.

In the epilogue to *Pigs,* Rappaport acknowledges that he may not have given "sufficient weight to the role of Big Men in the management of affairs" (1984: 395) or "attended to details of consensus formation" (398). He downplays ethnographic particulars, he says, in favor of "the general issues" (301). I rely on particulars of my own fieldwork among the Gimi to suggest, on the contrary, that the decisions and environmental relations that Rappaport asserts are ritually regulated are actually regulated through discussion, negotiation, and consensus based upon calculations about subsistence that are detailed, specific, and laboriously conscious. By underestimating or even ignoring the role of consciousness in Maring decision making, Rappaport shifted the whole process into the realm of the unconscious so that it became automatic, compulsory, protected from interference by error-prone or short-sighted individual calculations; in short, Rappaport endowed collective decision making with every feature of unconscious thought *except irrationality.* In Rappaport's scheme, the true content of the unconscious is evacuated, or purged of irrationality, while consciousness or "the cognized model" becomes irrelevant or destructive at the organizational level of collective life.

Rappaport compares consensus formation to a switch, an on-off mechanism, that sets the ritual cycle in motion. The threshold is reached when "sufficient pigs" are accumulated to present to allies and ancestors and to uproot the cordyline (1984: 152). The critical number is produced by "natural increase" of the herd (153), and the moment is signaled in two

ways: when the women "who plant and harvest the root crops and do . . . the weeding and . . . the carrying" and who rear the pigs become overburdened and complain to their husbands (157–58) or when the pigs become so numerous that they overrun gardens and cause disputes between pig and garden owners. The number of animals is "sufficient" to trigger the ritual cycle, in other words, when it has reached an intolerable level. Yet Rappaport also reports that the Tsembaga have difficulty in *increasing* their herds because "pregnancies among Tsembaga pigs are infrequent . . . [and] infant mortality among pigs is . . . high" (156), information that seems to contradict his assertion that Tsembaga herds spontaneously grow to unmanageable proportions.

Among the Gimi, there is no question of the pig population expanding by natural increase. The challenge is to produce enough pigs to fulfill obligations that are planned, like marriages and initiations, or unplanned, like illnesses and deaths. The management of Gimi herds is an ongoing enterprise. Men castrate most male shoats about three months after birth. When a sow produces a litter, the man who owns it typically dispatches all but two males and two females. He does this both to make the number of newborns correspond to the supply and quality of female labor at his disposal and to maximize their chances of reaching maturity by reducing sibling rivalry. Women say that a mother pig quickly grows weak and flaccid and fails to produce enough milk for too large a brood. Depending upon the sow's age and reproductive history, Gimi may spare more or less of her litter: the younger the animal, the fewer young she is considered capable of rearing. When a sow is aged or thought to have produced her "lifetime litter quota," she herself may be killed the next time a relative of her owner falls ill or dies.

When a sow bears a litter, the owner carefully reckons the women he can call upon as caretakers. These may include his wife, mother, sisters, and brothers' wives. He takes into account each woman's obligations to him, the number and ages of pigs already in her care, her record of success in bringing her charges to maturity, etc. Gimi men and older women are keen judges of women's prowess as pig herders and their opinions are borne out by a survey I conducted over a two-year period (1973–75). On four occasions, I weighed all the shoats in the village and kept records of other pigs. I found wide discrepancies among the women caretakers that seemed to be based, in large part, upon idiosyncracies like temperament and ambition. To take an extreme example, a lactating mother caring for six pigs had a childless cowife caring for none. Among

130 women between the estimated ages of fifteen and sixty, there were about an equal number of those with no pigs and those whom I termed poor, average or excellent caretakers on the basis of their ages, histories, and the numbers and well-being of pigs currently in their care. This part of my "operational model" corresponded closely to the Gimi "cognized model": according to my survey, Gimi accurately compute inequalities among women's productive capacities and use these assessments on a daily basis to devise strategies to maintain and increase their herds.

Rappaport concedes that he underestimated this kind of data while also insisting that he did so for reasons that go to the heart of his thesis about ritual regulation.

> Individual choices are made with respect to the disposal of pigs: women, I suppose, assess the degrees to which their backs ache against the goals of their husbands; people must be concerned with trade-offs between the work of pig raising and the trouble following garden invasions on the one hand, and the satisfaction of their allies with the pork they are given on the other, and so on. *Whether these and other considerations are weighed rationally is not a matter which need concern us. One of the main points of the analysis . . . was that the Maring ritual regulation is not to be understood as an outcome of the economistic behavior of individuals. . . . Indeed, the Maring ritual cycle stands against or constrains the economic and political goals of individuals and even of corporate groups.* (1984: 306; my emphasis)

Conscious judgments about subsistence, whether reached alone or in consultation with others, have little or no "regulatory" function because they emanate from individuals acting outside a ritual context. Their decisions are unsanctified, in Rappaport's terms, occupying a humble "fifth level of understanding" where "pragmatic expertise is developed: knowledge of gardening, pig husbandry, hunting, gathering, and so on" (1984: 317). Individuals, even when they are Big Men, do not "give orders" that determine environmental relations; only rituals have the power to do that. Rappaport's attitude toward people's mundane activities stems from his disdain for consciousness itself. Men's best-laid plans are bound to hinder their environmental interests, to work against adaptation, because decisions derive from human consciousness, which, by its nature, is fragmentary, error prone, "growing out of the knowledge of the separation from others . . . throw[ing] between logos [i.e., the natural order]

and its comprehension barriers of . . . [d]eception . . . and misrepresentation [that] may generate . . . orders that violate logos, orders that cannot be maintained without damage to the world" (311). Consciousness distorts the world because it separates human beings from one another and from "direct experience of nature's reticulations or circles. Each individual is directly acquainted with no more than . . . an arc on such a circle [*sic*]. Conceptions at once holistic and naturalistic are likely to be lost from general consciousness" (327).

"Disparities" between the natural order and human consciousness, between what is systematic and lawful, on the one hand, and what is piecemeal and distorting, on the other, constitute the main problem of ecological anthropology, a problem Rappaport both sets up and offers to resolve in terms of his own particular construction of "human understanding" (1984: 308ff.). He barely acknowledges the role of culture as adaptation, stating that "it would be hard to imagine the emergence of culture out of a precultural substrate as other than a strongly-selected-for innovation in the adaptive process itself" (385). And then he treats culture mainly as subversive because the consciousness that gives rise to it resides in individuals and grows out of knowledge of separation from others. In the sense that consciousness is partial, it creates the capacity to distort, to cut one off from the lawful and holistic "real world" of surrounding nature.

Rappaport's theory about the role of consciousness in human evolution implicitly dismisses an unmentioned opposite view. If consciousness is "knowledge of separation from others" it is also knowledge of connection. Language enables people to communicate with others with great precision and directness, to identify with others, and thus to transcend the isolation that Rappaport describes. According to a different view, derived mainly from psychoanalysis, it is not consciousness but man's inarticulate, archaic nature still attuned to brute survival that is maladaptive and alienating. Endowed with consciousness and language, human beings come into conflict not only with their surroundings but also with their own inner selves, their "species aspect," which no longer serves them precisely because they are no longer alone, no longer cut off from others by an inability to communicate, but now are aware of a community of interest. Opposed to Rappaport's vision is one that says that it is not our "private understanding," our painful awareness of isolation and mortality, that makes us irrational and self-destructive, incapable of

grasping more than "an arc on the circle," but rather our existence as a "species among species." It is instinctive fears and drives for food and sex that separate us from other people, that make us relentlessly selfish and resistant to communal imperatives, which are the real key to material survival. My field experience suggests that these communal imperatives are a matter of painstaking daily collaborations, worked out in fragile, conflict-ridden, failure-prone processes of social and political negotiation, which may be guided by Big Men or resolved informally by groups of women and men. It also shows that these critical deliberative processes are not disguised in a ritual code but are the unsanctified stuff of everyday life available to direct observation through ordinary methods of fieldwork.

Rappaport acknowledges the critics who accuse him of giving short shrift to the ethnography of decision making, of failing "to realize that overt decision making is part—perhaps the most important part—in feedback processes in human affairs" (Bennett 1976: 206, cited in Rappaport 1984: 321). Sometimes he minimizes the lapse as an oversight or minor difficulty. Responding to Bennett, he says:

> The matter of concern here is the actors' consciousness of the effects of their actions and my failure to take purposeful decision making into account in what seems to be, after all, a very mundane activity. . . . I probably did not emphasize sufficiently the role of conscious, pragmatic decision making in the affairs of the Maring. (321)

Rappaport's underemphasis of conscious decision making is no careless omission, as I have said. It is a cornerstone of his theory, consistent with his attitude toward consciousness in general as an impediment to ecological understanding, a kind of reckoning that "damage[s] the world" (1984: 311) because it is based upon "individual prudence," "the logic of private advantage" (312), "the selfish economizing behavior of individuals or small groups" (324), etc. "To be guided by [practical wisdom]," he says, "is to think and act against the world." Hence, no approach is useful that "focus[es] upon actors and ignore[s] or den[ies] the systematic character of an encompassing nature" (402). Linking it to a Heraclitan idea of *idia phronesis,* Rappaport treats consciousness as a malady for which ritual regulation is the cure in egalitarian societies. Religion is "society's defence against the dissolvant power of human intelligence" (Rappaport, citing Bergson, 324).

The disparity between lawful nature and a self-seeking consciousness means not only that human beings have a problem apprehending their environment but also that the world has a problem reaching consciousness in human beings. "Humanity is the only way the world has to think about itself," Rappaport says, citing Heraclitus again as standard bearer for his ideas (1984: 310). This two-way impasse is resolved by religion, through the dictates of liturgical orders, in which people transcend consciousness "to think and act as part of the world for the sake of the world" (312). Ecological thought, inseparable from religious thought, is achieved collectively yet apart from any deliberative process of communication.

> The general conception [is] of . . . a unified natural order constituted on the one hand by processes—climatic, tectonic, and biotic—over which humanity exercises no control and, on the other, by human thought and action producing social constructions in dynamic, fluctuating . . . harmony with the rest of the cosmos. The holism of this formulation, stripped of its possible mysticism, is also characteristic of what I take to be ecological thought. (310)

Startingly, and with greater originality than any anthropologist of his day, Rappaport proposes the existence of another realm or kind of thought outside ordinary consciousness, one that "claims a man . . . [and] determines his true life and conduct," a concept that he knows is mystical (1984: 310). Rappaport rejects Sahlins' characterization of ritual regulation as "an instrumental mystification of natural reason" (331ff.), yet he also accepts the mystical aspect of his theory in references to Bergson (324, 328). Throughout *Pigs for the Ancestors,* and especially in the epilogue, Rappaport implies the existence of something like a collective unconscious, a kind of reasoning beyond purposeful deliberation that is hyperrational and above all responsive to cues produced in a lawful environment. To understand nature, to be in touch with its fluctuations, people have to be part of nature, the same as it, purged of individuality, acting together "thoughtlessly," as they do carrying out the dictates of ritual in the name of ancestors or God, Salvation, Fatherland, and Honor (435).

Rappaport was criticized for deconstructing culture into nature, for betraying a central tenet of anthropology that says that culture makes human beings unique, gives them a unique capacity consciously to

choose rather than to act unthinkingly like other species. To my mind, *Pigs for the Ancestors* remains faithful to modern anthropological tradition by reviving ideas derived from Emile Durkheim. Indeed, Rappaport may be thought of as having achieved for ecology what Mary Douglas did for the body by expanding into new terrain Durkheim's ideas about the hidden social logic of religion. In developing and enhancing these ideas, Rappaport made explicit the concept of a rational unconscious mind and, paradoxically, exposed its mystical basis and, by extension, the mysticism implicit in classical concepts like the superorganic and even culture. Intentionally or not, Rappaport created a portrait of human understanding that, like much of the anthropology produced in this century, effectively reverses Freud's scheme, driving higher reason and communal interests into the unconscious and making consciousness irrational, self-aggrandizing, unsystematic. For Rappaport as for Durkheim, consciousness, "the cognized model," is nearly uninteresting and epiphenomenal, important mainly for the behavior it may elicit, while the unconscious is the seat of social or ecological reasoning.

Freud was a follower of Darwin, and like Rappaport he saw culture and the capacities for language and symbolic thought as adaptations that alienated human beings from their archaic nature, leaving them bifurcated, part animal and part human (Rappaport 1984: 385). Like Rappaport, Freud saw the unconscious as closer to nature, the repository of our inherited understanding. But for Freud that understanding was attuned not to a coherent natural system but to hunger, sex, and danger, drives that make humans profoundly selfish, unpredictable, disorganized, and antisocial. From this perspective, the work of ritual is to inhibit, channel, and reconstruct our species drives so that they do not damage us and the world we inhabit. "The study of man the culture-bearer cannot be separated from the study of man as a species among species," Rappaport says (242). But when he studies man as a beast he finds no beasts but a population guided by rituals that suppress the discord of private understandings, that supplant the choices symbol use creates, and that put it mystically in sync with the environment.

It has become fashionable to attribute a crisis in anthropology to the misuse of science as a paradigm: evolutionism, functionalism, ecology, Marxism, structuralism, psychoanalysis, etc., are sweeping and ethnocentric intellectual forms of a decrepit Western imperialism that silence the native voice. Anthropological theories are disparaged as "metanarra-

tives" that swallow the particular and morally significant in a universal scheme without relevance to those it describes. Rappaport objected to the excesses of postmodernism, and his own work stands on an eloquent defense of theory building (1984: 396ff.). But by its undervaluation of the role of consciousness and choice in the transition from nature to culture, his theory also reveals a problem of long standing in anthropology. This is the tendency to erase individual consciousness as a "deep structure," to treat individual decision making as chaotic, unsystematic, and outside the universe of discourse. *Pigs for the Ancestors,* and the anthropological tradition it upholds, suggest that the erasure of the individual often goes together with the assumption of a rational unconscious, a "reversal of mind" in which choices are made collectively, without deliberation, through religious observance or "social facts," which take on the compulsory, morally neutral, and efficient qualities of "nature." This construction eliminates not only individual choice and the capacity for guilt but also the unconscious as Freud described it, a repository of irrational, violent, selfish, and self-destructive impulses. Looked at in this way, the problem with anthropology is not bias or grandiosity but, on the contrary, timidity, puritanism, and the inability to understand modern history, to explain wars, ethnic conflicts, or evil done in the name of religion (Gillison 1999a).

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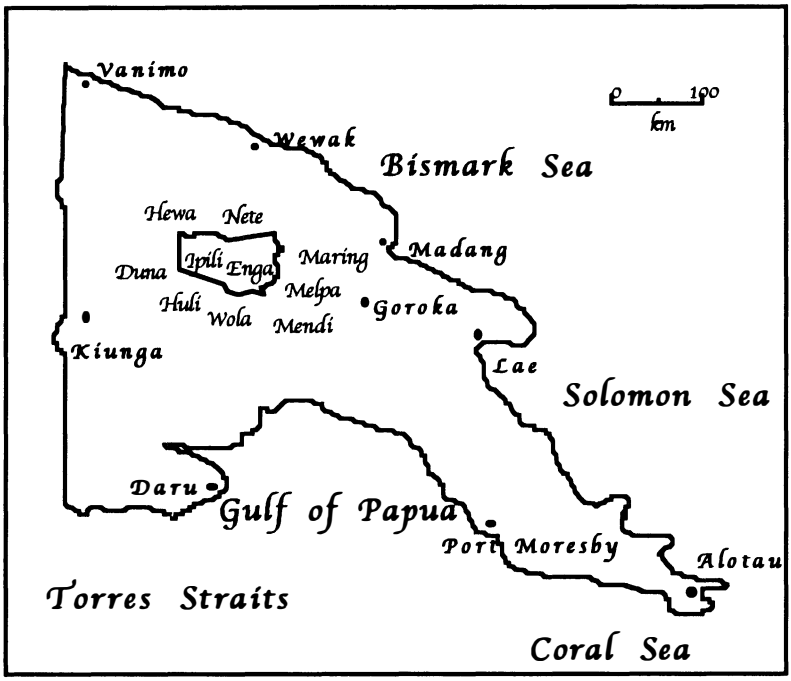
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Averting the Bush Fire Day: Ain's Cult Revisited

Polly Wiessner and Akii Tumu

> Nature is seen by humans through a screen of beliefs, knowledge and purposes, and it is in terms of their images of nature, rather than of the actual structure of nature, that they act. Yet, it is upon nature itself that they do act, and it is nature itself that acts upon them, nurturing or destroying them.
>
> —Roy A. Rappaport, *Ecology, Meaning, and Religion*

Human impact on nature was of concern to people long before stone axes were replaced with steel, digging sticks with bulldozers, and feet with wings and wheels, for human impact is steered by cultural ambitions and cultural design, not tools alone. It was in the area of ritual as human vision and adaptive response that Skip Rappaport made contributions that weathered decades of debate (Bergman 1975; Friedman 1974; Hallpike 1973; Healey 1985; McArthur 1974; Peoples 1982) to become fundamental in anthropology.[1] Here we would like to take two central ideas from Rappaport's work and use them as guidelines for a reanalysis of a millenarian movement that took place among Enga Highland horticulturalists of Papua New Guinea. The first emerges from Rappaport's debate with those who critiqued his earlier Maring work, which concluded that religious ritual has a significant impact on structuring human interpretation of and responses to environmental issues to produce a practical effect on the world. The second, stemming from his later work, concerns the unique ability of humans to act in accordance with the "holy," so that "the ambitions of separate men (humans) may be subordinated to common interest" (Rappaport 1979: 237). During religious rituals, the "numinous" (the intangible emotions that give performance such force), makes it possible to alter the culturally constructed screen



Map 1. Location of Enga Province, the Enga and their neighbors

of beliefs, knowledge, and purposes so that change can be initiated in the cultural system as a whole, Rappaport's chosen unit of analysis.

The millenarian movement discussed, "Ain's cult," or the Mata Katenge, took place in 1943–45 among the western Enga,[2] a population not far removed in distance, basic subsistence strategies, and cultural orientations from the Maring, among whom Rappaport (1968) began his career in anthropology (map 1). The situation and actors are in the past, but the issues are timeless. Leaders in this dramatic movement instructed people to do away with all of the "old ways," placing a ban on warfare, major ancestral cults, bachelors' cults, and female-male pollution taboos, among other things. They urged followers to shift worship from the ancestors to the sun and moon, the original progenitors. By sacrificing the majority of their pigs to the sun, they were to elicit help in dealing with earthly problems, whether these be social, medical, or environmental, and become the recipients of celestial wealth.

Meggitt (1973), in a superb documentation of the cult, attributes its causes exclusively to events that occurred in the early 1940s, even though he admits that the Enga did not see them as an unprecedented spate of disasters. These events included Taylor's patrol in 1939, which briefly introduced many western Enga to Europeans; the severe frost and drought of 1940–41; dysentery in humans; and epidemics of anthrax and respiratory disease in pigs.[3] Meggitt's analysis is based on two central premises that were prominent in anthropological thought at the time. First, although he did not work within the framework of the "new ecology," his publications portray the Enga as a population in homeostasis, with cycles of warfare and exchange regulating the relation of people to land (see Meggitt 1967, 1972, 1974, 1977). Second, and related, he considered the Enga population as basically ahistorical (Wolf 1982), dismissing the rich body of Enga oral tradition as either myth or fabrications concocted to serve current goals.[4]

Here we will first try to situate Ain's cult in its broader historical perspective and propose that it was a response to change brought about by some two centuries of altered human demands on production, which were generated after the introduction of the sweet potato. Following the lead of Rappaport, we will argue that it was the interpretation of post-sweet-potato developments and events of first contact with Europeans within the cosmological axioms of a major cult of western Enga that triggered the cult and structured its prescriptions and proscriptions. Among these was the central concern of averting the end of the world, which was perceived as imminent—the bush fire day. By initiating Ain's cult, the prophets sought to deal with social and environmental problems and thereby stave off the world's end. They strove to do this not by means of local, stop-gap measures, but by calling on the power of the numinous in ritual to alter the beliefs, knowledge, and purposes in the population as a whole, which it was felt were propeling decline. Where this analysis will depart from Rappaport's earlier work is on the issues of adaptation and agency. We will argue that information evaluated through the screen of history, cosmology, and politics can be interpreted to meet a range of interests—conservative, experimental, or progressive. Religious experience manipulated by humans can thus be directed at homeostasis or growth, balance or imbalance, humanity or atrocity. Agency in this process is complex and depends not only on the initiators' goals but on their ability to present their visions as in the "public interest" and elicit a supportive response through the numinous.

The material on which this essay is based comes from published works on Ain's cult and ethnohistorical data. The backbone is provided by Meggitt's excellent work *The Sun and the Shakers* (1973) and supplemented by perceptive analyses of Ain's cult among the Ipili (map 1; Gibbs 1977; Biersack 1998) and Enga to the northeast (Feil 1983). The ethnohistorical material comes from a project carried out by us and other Enga colleagues (Wiessner and Tumu 1998). Between 1985 and 1995, we interviewed elders in over one hundred phratries of Enga to collect historical traditions (*atome pii*), documenting events said to be founded in eyewitness accounts that have been passed down in men's houses for generations (Lacey 1975).[5] Historical traditions, which guide all Enga decisions, contain information on such matters as subsistence, wars, migrations, agriculture, the development of cults and ceremonial exchange networks, leadership, trade, environmental disasters, and innovations in song and dress. Accompanying genealogies place events in a chronological framework. The period covered by Enga historical traditions begins some time prior to the introduction of the sweet potato (250 to 400 years ago) and continues in the present. The sweet potato, which was introduced by means of local trade two to three centuries before first contact with Europeans in the 1930s, released constraints on production, allowed a substantial surplus on the hoof to be produced for the first time, and permitted rapid demographic and economic growth (Watson 1965a, 1965b, 1977).

Prior to the introduction of the sweet potato, conditions were very different than in recent times and interarea differences greater. In the high, rugged valleys of western Enga, dependence on hunting and gathering was heavy and horticulture limited and precarious. In central Enga, people practiced a mixed subsistence strategy of taro horticulture and hunting, and in the lower, fertile valleys of eastern Enga, inhabitants led a more sedentary lifestyle, cultivating taro, yams, bananas, sugarcane, and other crops. Pigs enter only peripherally into the oral record—it is said that most Enga had little interest in the hard work of pig husbandry. The plots of historical traditions from this period revolve around hunting, the salt-ax stone trade, traditional dances, and warfare.

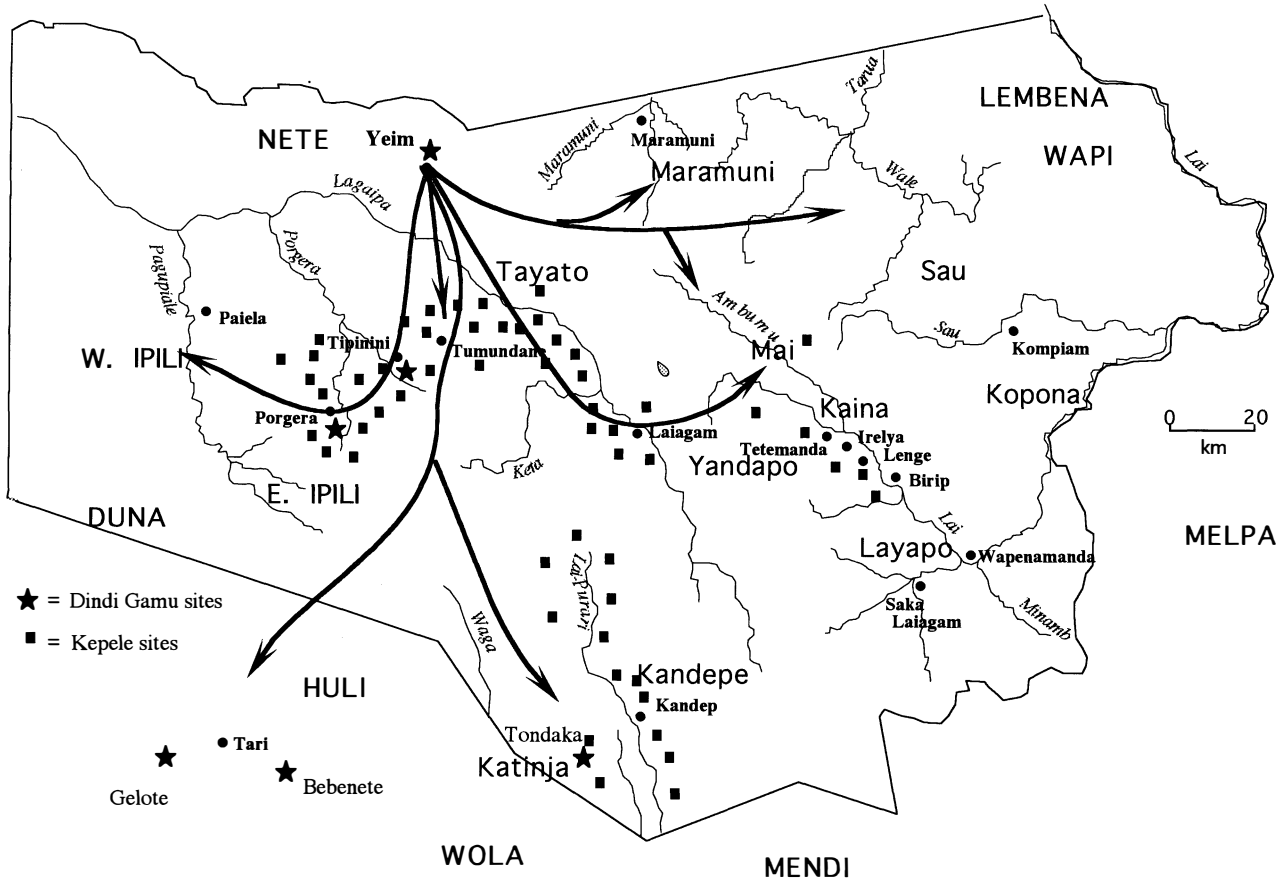
Reactions to the arrival of sweet potato differed by area, though after some generations passed all report substantial shifts in population distribution, population growth, and the expansion of ceremonial exchange and religious ritual in response to mounting social and political complexities. In this context, three large networks arose that can be

counted as systems of ceremonial exchange (Wiessner and Tumu 1998): (1) the Tee ceremonial exchange cycle of the Layapo Enga (map 2), a system of finance crafted by big men to control the trade in eastern Enga; (2) the Great Ceremonial Wars of the Mai, Yandapo, and Kaina Enga, spectacular tournament wars fought for weeks or months between pairs of phratries and their allies to establish a balance of power, to delimit spheres of trade, and for the massive exchange festivals that followed; (3) the Kepele cult of western Enga, held to assemble entire phratries for five days of sacred ritual events, feasting, and exchange with invited visitors (map 2). In addition, as the land filled, war reparations began to be paid to enemies, so that after conflict groups could stay put and make peace. Initially, all of these exchange networks were provisioned by wild game, trade goods, and to a lesser extent by pigs. As they expanded, only pig production could meet the needs of exchange and was intensified accordingly.

During the late nineteenth century, big men straddling the east and center tapped into the wealth of the eastern Tee Cycle in order to finance the Great Wars and to reinvest the large quantities of wealth that flowed out of the Great War exchanges. The Great War exchanges grew with this new influx of wealth and Tee Cycle was transformed from a relatively discreet exchange network to one flooded with wealth. The cost, conflicts, and complexity of organization of the Great Ceremonial war and the Tee Cycle then became formidable. Big men of the east imported cults from outside, including the Kepele cult of western Enga, and restructured them into events to organize exchange cycles, demonstrate prosperity, mediate tensions caused by growing social inequalities, and realign sentiments of tribal members that had been torn by competition. During the decades prior to first contact with Europeans, the Great Ceremonial Wars collapsed under their own weight. Their spheres of exchange were supplanted by the expanding Tee Cycle (Wiessner and Tumu 1998). On the eve of Ain's cult, the Tee Cycle flourished in eastern and central Enga, involving some forty thousand people and the exchanges of tens of thousands of pigs.

The Role of Ritual in Change

Two sets of supernatural beings dominated Enga cosmology. The first, and probably the oldest in Enga religion, was composed of the sun, moon, and their descendants, the immortal sky people (*yalyakali*), who



Map 2. The course of Ain's cult and its relation to Dindi Gamu and other linguistic groups. Other language groups are indicated in large type. Enga dialect groups are in smaller type.

lived in a perfect world.[6] They represented "prosperity past" in the sense that humans were believed to be offspring of the sky people, who had descended from an immortal life in paradise to mortal life on earth.[7] The sky people were believed to act as fate, to control certain natural events, and to be able to assist in divination. They were also the protectors of humans, cooperating in bachelors' cults to transform boys to men. However, should individuals fail to conform to moral codes, they would be abandoned by the sky people and laid open to death. Small feasts supplied with vegetable foods and forest products were held to elicit the aid of sky people in divination.

The second set of influential supernatural beings was composed of the spirits of the ancestors. Essentially, they were the "keepers of prosperity." It was believed that the ancestors would assist their earthly descendants if communication were maintained via ritual. However, the ancestors, like the sky beings, could be angered by certain human failings, for instance, inadequate defense of land or lack of communication via cult feasts. Despite considerable variation in cults for the ancestors, all involved the slaughter of large numbers of pigs, communal feasting, and the feeding and mating of ancestral stones. These rights were believed to elicit the goodwill of the ancestors in promoting the fertility of human populations, pig populations, and the environment.

Within the span of historical traditions, Enga religious ritual underwent considerable growth and development as leaders translated social and environmental information according to these cosmological schemes and steered decisions to hold cult performances, alter them, add new elements, or import entirely new cults from surrounding groups (Wiessner and Tumu 1999). Perceptions of environment that steered the development of cults were primarily positive—that the environment was rich and acceleration of production would please the ancestors and lead to greater prosperity. Moreover, the success of neighbors within Enga and in other linguistic groups was taken as an indication that ever new heights could be reached, if appropriate rituals were adopted and practiced.

Although Enga cult performances were organized in response to temporary environmental fluctuations, a long-term perspective reveals that ritual had a minor role in regulating cyclical human-land relationships, nor did it have an immediate practical impact on the relations of the Enga with their environment.[8] By contrast, the ultimate effects of ritual on economic growth were substantial, for it was through the cults that leaders redesigned ideals, values, and goals to take advantage of the new

productive potential. In summarizing some three hundred years of Enga history, it is easy to portray the sweet potato as the magic ingredient in the formula of change, but in reality considerable ideological groundwork had to be laid before people could take full advantage of the new crop. For instance, pigs were the only form of wealth whose production could be readily intensified to meet the new demands of developing exchange networks, but initially they did not have sufficient value to do the job. Leaders who saw the potential value of pigs encouraged production locally by taking young men and women into their households and teaching them the skills of pig husbandry. Their most concerted efforts, however, were made at a broader level—the social, symbolic, and economic value of pigs was greatly enhanced for the population of entire areas when live pigs and cooked pork were intricately woven into many, if not most, ritual procedures.[9] Demands for pork to supply cults and other feasts did much to see that people did indeed produce. The upshot of the valuation of pigs was intensified production and an altered system of land use—gardens were cleared higher and higher up the valley sides, eliminating forest and with it the importance of hunting. In short, ritual became tied to accelerating growth and cycles of exchange.

Perceptions of social conditions, in contrast to environmental ones, spurred more conservative attempts to reestablish balance and harmony in the face of mounting social and economic inequalities. Cult performances themselves enacted the potential equality of all men (or households) and reestablished the harmony and cooperation so necessary for exchange to flourish. Surplus from intensified production was applied to achieve new forms of social integration (Modjeska 1982) in the contexts of both ritual and exchange. Nonetheless, the temporary achievement of social balance continued to be undermined by rapid economic growth.

Ain's Cult and the Dindi Gamu

It was the above context that Ain's cult unfolded: rapid growth stemming from the release of constraints on production after the arrival of the sweet potato, redefinition of Enga values and ambitions, and unbridled competition between big men. The western Enga were at a disadvantage in this scenario. Soil and climate were unfavorable in comparison with surrounding regions. Western Enga clans participated in the Kepele cult, but they did not have any of the large, economically oriented exchange systems of surrounding areas through which individuals could achieve

substantial financial gain. As a result, ambitious families became drawn into the networks of surrounding areas as suppliers of pigs—for the Great Ceremonial Wars, the Tee Cycle, and the Mena Yae or Mok Ink of the Mendi to the south. The frustration felt by many western Enga at not being able to keep up with standards of exchange set in surrounding regions is expressed in a metaphorical legend attributed to the late nineteenth century called the Yambili: a mythical woman moves with her shells and riches hung in display on the branches of a tree from ceremonial ground to ceremonial ground through western Enga with people scrambling to reach the wealth. The occasional person is able to grasp a shell, but most do not succeed, and she moves on (Wiessner and Tumu 1998).

By the twentieth century, the tensions that had been mounting over previous generations among the Tayato were evident in persistent warfare, regular out-migration (Wohlt 1978), and the prevalence of nutritionally related diseases such as leprosy. Had the western Enga shared the same ritual orientation as those in the center and east, their response might have been quite different and negotiated through standard Enga religious beliefs. As it was, however, western Enga were firmly in the grip of a religious doctrine held by their Huli neighbors and its expression in the influential Dindi Gamu cult.

The Dindi Gamu cult was a pre-sweet-potato cult based on the notion of entropy—that the natural and social world was on a trajectory of decline that could only be corrected by ritual intervention. Although representations differ, one portrayal held by the Huli and Enga is of an unstable earth and cosmos bound together by a fabric composed of the root of the earth entwined by a python. According to Frankel (1986), the root of the earth is conceived of as both a pathway for power and the physical support of the earth. Active points along this pathway, "the knots of the earth," occur where key strands interweave. At these junctures are sacred sites where the root is accessible to ritual intervention. When the root dries and cracks, or when the python is ravenous, this physical support can fragment and the world will end in a fiery apocalypse unless the Dindi Gamu cult is performed to "grease the root of the earth" and "feed the python." If successfully executed, it was believed that the cult could not only stave off disaster but could bring about a recurrence of "the time of darkness" of some three hundred years ago. At this time, a volcanic explosion on Long Island off the coast of Papua New Guinea covered the Highlands in a thick blanket of ash (Blong

1982; Mai 1981), bringing days of fear, suffering, and hardship, which were later followed by enriched soil fertility, prosperity, and perhaps the introduction of new crops like the sweet potato. Ultimately, though, disaster was seen as inevitable: following a Huli prediction formulated after a faulty Dindi Gamu performance in the past (Frankel 1986: 24), it was believed that the end of the world would occur in fire and explosion during the thirteenth generation. The thirteenth generation is now.

Dindi Gamu cult sites are woven into a network that extends from the Papuan Plateau, through the Huli area, and on to the Duna and Enga (Frankel 1986; Goldman 1983; map 1). Major sites are at Bebenete and Gelote, near Tari, and at Tondaka in southwestern Kandep (map 2); at the latter, Huli and Enga of the region cooperate to perform the cult. The Enga branch of the network then continues on to Tipinini and Yeim, where smaller, but nonetheless important, performances were held. Another branch may go into Ipili in the Paiela region. Ritual sites were associated with natural gas outlets that flared up periodically.[10]

Enga request that no details of Dindi Gamu cult procedures be made public, and so the following description is but a brief outline. The cult was supplied by numerous clans of westernmost Enga, who brought pigs, pork, and other foodstuffs, deposited them near the cult site, and departed. A representative from Yeim came to "open the door" with a donation of a dried leg of pork, sugarcane, and taro.[11] Ritual experts and celebrants from western Enga or Huli clans brought the food to the site, which apparently was inside a cave. Some of the food was placed on a stone said to be "jaw of the snake"—this disappeared without a trace. The rest was cooked by mysterious means for senior participants to eat.[12] Ritual experts and other celebrants then went through strenuous journeys of the mind and body. The journeys elicited visions from which predictions were made: if a pig was seen getting up and leaving, it would mean that people would have plenty of pigs; if a woman appeared as an old lady, it meant that girls would be unhealthy; and so on. The ritual experts emerged from the Tondaka without looking back and remained mute for a week, subsequently revealing their predictions to their own people and representatives from other clans of western Enga, who had come to listen. Participants and spectators then dispersed: only the keepers of the site remained year round.

Most Enga regarded the Dindi Gamu and its accompanying lore as powerful and fearful but also somewhat foreign, belonging to the Huli and to a lesser extent the Ipili and Enga clans, which bordered on the

Huli and participated directly in the Dindi Gamu. Nonetheless, as enthusiasts for predictions, most clans of western Enga sent representatives to hear the prophecies of ritual experts when they emerged from the ceremony. For years, they had been told that the world would end in the thirteenth generation, and so they were accustomed to the idea of imminent disaster.

Ain's Cult: the Causes

The initiators of the cult were the sons of Ain, a man who had been a central ritual expert in the Yeim branch of the Dindi Gamu and of the family that was said "to hold the key" for performances at the Tondaka site. His sons were next in line for this role, following western Enga convention that the positions of cult experts were inherited. As believers in the doctrine of entropy, Ain and his sons interpreted events of the 1930s and early 1940s as part of the predicted trajectory of decline. They had long noted a degeneration of conditions in the Tayato area, particularly tension in social and political relations. A close associate of the Ain brothers told us that one of the brothers, Wambilipi, had voiced dismay about the demands to produce ever more pigs for ritual, social, and political occasions, particularly the Kepele cult and war reparations. Such pressures, he claimed, incited conflict over pigs and good garden land and set off a spiral of rampant and destructive warfare that took the lives of many. More pigs were then required to resolve the new conflicts. So severe was the violence that the lives of young men seemed to be worth little more than the lives of pigs.[13]

Further fuel for the fire came from the natural events of the 1940s described by Meggitt: the frost and famine of 1941, dysentery, and epidemics of porcine anthrax and pneumonia. As mentioned earlier, such events were not unique in Enga history. However, when coupled with perceptions of decades of decline stemming from post-sweet-potato developments and rumors of the arrival of foreigners (Taylor 1939), who were light skinned like the ancestors, they were taken as signs that the end of the world was imminent.

Ain's Cult: Proscriptions and Prescriptions

What happened during the initial formulation of the cult is not absolutely clear. Meggitt (1973: 20–21) writes that the ghost of Ain appeared

to his sons and delivered instructions on how to avert the sickness that was striking the Tayato and their pigs. He claimed to have received these instructions from a huge tree-climbing kangaroo that had emerged from a forest pool.[14] This is a "harmless" explanation that avoids any reference to the Dindi Gamu, a highly secretive cult of which Meggitt had no knowledge. The triggering incident that we were given is more sinister. At the Yeim Dindi Gamu site, there is a whirlpool of thermal mud near the sacred area, where only ritual experts dare to tread. It is thought that somebody disturbed the vegetation at the site, and as a result the power of the Dindi Gamu "possessed" the Ain brothers. Afterward, when Wambilipi went out hunting, he came to a beautiful place in the forest where many birds were feeding in a tree. They flocked around him and showed no fear. He noted that there was a pandanus tree that bore a nut cluster. Intrigued, he returned to the same place for three days, and on the third day he saw a strange site—blood was dripping from the bottom of the nut cluster into a dishlike container accompanied by the sound of something crying. Wambilipi went home and told his brothers of what he saw. They conferred, decided that ritual action was required, and then proceeded to cut trees at the sacred Dindi Gamu site to make clubs for killing pigs. When this was done, they set out to launch the cult.[15]

Within this historical and ritual context, the cult prescriptions and prohibitions listed by Meggitt (1973: 21–23) take on new meaning. We have paraphrased these, with Meggitt's numeration in brackets and new interpretations or explications given below.

1. All of the old ways should be given up, particularly ancestral cults such as the Kepele and Kaima, which had been ineffective in counteracting the events of the 1940s, although the Kaima pool rituals could be resumed later. People should turn to the sun and moon (their original progenitors, who were ultimately responsible for the presence of all people and pigs on earth) to aid them in times of crisis [*i and ii*].

Essentially, these prescriptions/prohibitions turned back the clock to former times when rituals for the sky people, sun, and moon appear to have been more prevalent than those for the ancestors. The Kaima cult could be resumed later because it had a strong component of sun worship and required few pigs, while the Kepele, with its lavish usage of pork, was to be discontinued and the ancestral stones discarded.

2. Each local group should build a cult house on its ceremonial grounds with a high platform in front of it. All families should gather, bringing one or two pigs, which would be used by Ain's sons as offerings to the sun. The sons of Ain would mount a platform and stare along the shaft of a spear. In due course, the power of the sun would induce a violent fit of shaking, during which they would call on the support of the sun to protect people and their herds of pigs. The pigs were then killed, while spells were recited, and steamed in communal earth ovens. One side of each pig was given to the sons of Ain together with the entrails and liver and the other distributed for the families of the contributors to eat [*iii*]. *To make up for the meat shortage that would follow the slaughter, cult leaders urged people to take good care of their hunting dogs* [*c*], *for in the absence of pork wild game would be an important source of meat (as it had been in the past).*

Here the emphasis that we received is different from that presented by Meggitt. Our Tayato informants emphatically stated that the cult leaders warned people that pigs were a source of trouble and one of the causes of decline.[16] They added that Ain's sons had an uncanny way of knowing if a man was holding back his pigs. In such cases they would single him out and pressure him to bring more for slaughter. A repertoire of superhuman activities performed by the Ain brothers, for example, the ability to handle and walk on hot coals and to spear a pig in such as way that the spear went clear through him, filled people with fear and helped convert them. In contrast to most Enga cults, in which pigs were slaughtered with great ceremony and respect and every scrap of pork was consumed or employed in rites, in Ain's cult there was no celebration of pork and great wastage. The rough handling and wastage of pork, behavior also noted by Meggitt, ran in blatant contravention to former Enga values. Pigs and pork produced by human labor were thereby devalued.

3. After the feast people should wash themselves thoroughly in a stream every morning for a month, men first and women after, to avoid contracting new sickness. During the first ritual cleansing, the sons of Ain stood on the bank and intoned spells that people would later recite while they washed [*iv*].

Although Meggitt writes that this was to avoid new sickness, these rites of purification were explained to us as marking a change from one state

to another, as they do in Enga bachelors' cults (see also Gibbs 1977). Thus, when people had given up their "old ways"—warfare, ancestral cults, bachelors' cults—they would then be ready to start anew. Informants added that after the purification the followers were given *evodia* leaves to chew in order to symbolize this transition, just as women were given the same after menstruation to mark their transition from polluting/dangerous to clean/safe (Kyakas and Wiessner 1992).

4. *As part of abandoning the "old ways," people should give up pollution prohibitions, discontinue bachelors' cults and copulate frequently to beget many children* [*b*].

This prescription had more political strategy than meets the eye. That its purpose was to beget more children, as informants told Meggitt, is unlikely, for at this time the Enga suffered from child mortality, not infertility, and they were well aware that narrow birth spacing increases child mortality. To wit, pollution beliefs in general and bachelor's cults in particular were means by which older men controlled younger ones and big men kept young men out of the marriage market for years, increasing the number of women available for polygamous marriage (Kyakas and Wiessner 1992). The abolition of pollution taboos and bachelors' cults could thus undermine the authority of big men and the productive potential of their households and thereby curb the social inequalities that were developing in the west, as in other parts of Enga. This is not just speculation—big men of central Enga immediately identified Ain's cult as a movement that could undermine their power and did their best to stop it.

5. *They should give up warfare* [*a*].

Wambilipi dramatized this prescription at Tumundane by collecting spears from the men, making a circular fence with them, burying the guts of a sow in the middle, and on top planting a cordyline shrub. In other clans, according to the information that we collected, cult leaders broke or destroyed weapons. This prescription coincides with the claims of close associates of Wambilipi that rampant warfare was one of the principal manifestations of the decline against which the cult was directed.

6. Numerous food taboos should be followed, including a prohibition against consuming tree pythons [*d*], *even though, as Meggitt notes, these are rarely found in Tayato country.*

We did not investigate the significance of all food taboos, though certainly the taboo concerning tree pythons is linked to the importance of the python in Dindi Gamu lore.

Another noteworthy event not reported by Meggitt, but mentioned by many, deserves consideration. At some point in the course of events, one of the original cult leaders is said to have taken the young son of a clan "sister," killed him, and steamed him in an earth oven. He distributed portions of his corpse like pork, calling out the names of people from all over Enga to come and collect their shares. Few people were in the vicinity, and of course nobody came to receive his or her share. What is interesting about this gruesome performance is that it evokes the sacrifice of young men, which is said to have been part of the Dindi Gamu cult. Perhaps this also indicates the despair that the cult leaders voiced concerning the decline of society to the point where the lives of young men were given in warfare as freely as the lives of pigs were given in war reparations.

In its original conception, Ain's prescriptions would have taken Tayato society back four or five generations to a time when pigs were not as intensively raised and of less social and economic significance than they were in the 1940s. The temporal duration of some of the prescriptions and prohibitions described earlier was limited (Meggitt 1973: 23), although at the very onset of the cult it was not specified when or how things would return to normal, if some of "the old ways" were to be resumed, or whether the cult was to be held periodically. However, the prohibitions critical to the problems just described were to remain: the ban on warfare (and therefore no further need to raise pigs for war reparations), the Kepele cult, pollution taboos, and bachelors' cults.

The Spread of Ain's Cult: New Additions

Ain's sons set out from Yeim with their fellow clansmen to spread the cult throughout the Tayato area, receiving an enthusiastic reception

wherever they went. The popular songs warning of the imminent end of the world that resounded along the way are well remembered:

Paina mende pitamo ongopa Taukopo tato lelya palita,
Nakandapya kukuaka pyu katapu nakandapya?
Nakandapya tataloaka pyu katapu nakandapya?

[On a fine sunny day the Taukopa beech trees will catch fire,
Don't you see us drying up for the day?
Don't you see us preparing for the bush fire day?]

(*Taukopa* in other songs is used to describe a "wind." As far as we could determine, it refers to the natural gas outlets that play a major role in the Dindi Gamu cult.)

That the cult progressed so easily and rapidly is not surprising because the people of western Enga had been prepared for its message by Dindi Gamu predictions and were ritually linked to one another by the Kepele cult network (map 2). The method of active proselytizing, however, was hitherto unknown in Enga, where leaders had traditionally sought out cults judged beneficial for their groups and imported them through purchase of their spells, rites, sacred objects, and the services of a knowledgeable ritual expert. Certainly a good deal of the authority of Ain's brothers to proselytize came from their position in the Dindi Gamu, which had long been the source of ultimate, authoritative predictions for the western Enga.

At Tumundane, the cult took a new direction when one of its ardent converts, Aipa, was shown new pigs of enormous proportions and quantities of pearl shells by the ghost of his father (Meggitt 1973: 25).[17] Converts were to receive these if they carefully followed the prescriptions for washing in the river. This component was not a pure product of Aipa's dreams but also of new information fed into the cult without context—descriptions of the large number of pearl shells introduced into eastern areas by Europeans as well as a cow's tail obtained from a coastal man at the patrol post at Wabag and assumed to be the tail of one of the enormous pigs that would arrive soon. Aipa was instructed by the ghost to dig pits and fill them with bespelled water. Sometime in the future pigs would appear in women's houses, pearl shells would be found in pools, and new crops would sprout in gardens, adding a focus on wealth acquisition to the cult.

This new component was accepted enthusiastically and sped the spread of the cult eastward and southward into areas where clans were peripherally involved in the larger exchange networks of neighboring linguistic groups. People of these areas had long been under pressure to produce pigs for these networks and were envious of the wealth and glory that were distributed in them. These sentiments were enhanced by new wealth introduced via Europeans to nearby clans at the recently established patrol post at Wabag. Ain's cult thus promised to provide without drudgery the riches that they struggled for but had never been able to obtain from their own land.

The permutations of Ain's cult in different areas depended heavily on two factors: (1) proximity to the Tondaka site and the Tipinini Dindi Gamu sites, where Dindi Gamu lore and familiarity with Huli belief was strongest; and (2) degree of involvement in the large exchange networks of neighboring areas. For those within the direct sphere of Dindi Gamu, like the Enga and Ipili of the Porgera Valley, a recurrence of the time of darkness was a major focus of the cult. Large houses were constructed to accommodate communities during the predicted ash fall and keep them safe until cult leaders called on the sun to disperse the darkness. When this was achieved, it was believed that enormous pythons would hang from the sky so that people would make their way to the sky world along paths formed by the bodies of snakes.[18] People would escape disaster on earth by returning to their point of origin as "sky people." Through the power of the sun, the python would be transformed into the link between earth and sky. At Tipinini in the Porgera Valley, the cult took a disastrous turn when a woman named Ipiama led the members of an entire subclan to Lake Tindipa in the mountains, where they drowned in pursuit of the new wealth (see Gibbs 1977 for an excellent discussion of this incident). In an account that we collected, her madness was attributed to the fact that she had cut a branch from the central sacred tree on the Dindi Gamu ritual site at Tipinini. From the Porgera Valley, permutations concerning the time of darkness and the python were carried on to the Katinja Enga (who were the keepers of the Tondaka Dindi Gamu site) and into some clans of the Wage (Meggitt 1973: 34–35).

As the cult moved farther away from clans influenced by the Dindi Gamu and into richer environments, decline and degeneration were no longer primary selling points. Emphasis shifted to the acquisition of wealth and prosperity, the standard fare of most Enga cults. For in-

stance, the Yandapo (central) Enga were told that once the new wealth was mysteriously acquired from the pits filled with water, they would ascend to the sky by means of ropes (not pythons) and live in perpetual wealth and good health (Meggitt 1973).

The Outcome

Ain's cult first encountered serious opposition when it reached the Mai Enga of the upper Lai and Ambum Valleys. In these areas, Enga were prospering from wealth received in the Tee Cycle and the new wealth supplied directly by the Australian administration. There were few reasons why the Mai of these valleys should seek to leave this thriving world. The only truly appealing feature of the cult was the replacement of the old, disease-infested pigs with much larger new animals resistant to plagues.

As Meggitt (1973: 113) observed, perhaps the most critical mistake of the cult leaders in the Mai region was to suggest that so much new wealth would come that each clan would be transformed into a community of wealthy big men. In doing so, they presented the very big men who could persuade others to accept or reject a cult with a doctrine that would undermine their positions. Having competed all their lives for superior status through the Great Ceremonial Wars and the Tee Cycle and guarded their advantage jealously within a small circle of powerful families (Wiessner and Tumu 1998), the idea of a community of big men did not interest them in the least. Here individual interest countered an effort to change group norms, and they solicited the help of administration officers to put an end to the cult. The news of European disapproval, together with the fact that the promised wealth never arrived, brought the cult to its end in all regions. Nonetheless, some of its concepts linger—in 1991 there were rumors that Wambilipi was about to launch a new version. Meggitt (1973: 117–18) writes that Enga of the central areas were too humiliated by their own foolishness to consider serious action against the cult leaders. In western Enga, reactions were quite different. After the initial bitterness over the failure of the cult had subsided, it was given new acclaim as a movement that had prepared the way for Christianity by breaking down "the old ways." Cult leaders still alive in the 1990s were all ardent Christians and proud of their role in Ain's cult. One even suggested that had Wambilipi continued to return to the pandanus nut cluster that dripped blood, rather than hastening to

kill pigs with his brothers, this mysterious force might have given him the mission of spreading the Christian faith.

Concluding Remarks

A reanalysis of Ain's cult within an ethnohistorical framework and models developed in the work of Rappaport suggests that Ain's cult was far more than a spontaneous reaction to the frost and epidemics of the 1940s and brief contact with Europeans. Cult leaders still alive in the 1990s directly voiced their past motivation—to employ ritual to avert what they interpreted as impending environmental disaster brought on by social disharmony. The action that they took conforms closely to Rappaport's proposed scheme—they gathered a wide range of information, including that on social, political and environmental problems that had built up over generations, and interpreted it in the framework of the sacred propositions and axioms of the Dindu Gamu cult. Informed by their own interests, cult predictions, and a historical perspective on these problems furnished by local oral traditions, they took action. Their initial goal was to try to turn back the clock, undo all the developments of recent generations, ban warfare, and devalue the pig, in other words, to address the causes of decline that were leading to the end of the world. A state of balance and harmony would thereby be achieved and people could start anew. The four Ain brothers were apparently content with the idea of a society free of warfare, ancestral cults, pollution fears, and social inequalities and one that would draw help and inspiration from the sun. This was to have been a world where the need for wealth would be reduced and with it the ravages caused by individual competition and rapid inflation. Authority would be vested in ritual rather than economic achievement.

Ain's cult was the first post-sweet-potato cult in Enga in which social and environmental information were received as negative feedback warranting immediate corrective action. No doubt this is attributable in part to the poorer environment of the Tayato region in which growth ran up against environmental constraints sooner than in other areas. Had its initial goals not been altered according to orientations and designs of the recipients as it spread, Ain's cult might indeed have produced a change in social and ecological relations. But as it was the cult moved into areas that were linked to larger ceremonial exchange networks and closer to the source of new wealth introduced by Europeans. Here, with no his-

torical scale on which to weight these novelties, further information concerning cows' tails and pearl shells was processed as positive feedback. New hope was given for continued growth, and the cult was able to take on millenarian aspects. People then found a different solution to the original problem. Rather than abolishing the need for wealth, they would seek to bring about a world in which wealth would be so abundant that its distribution would no longer be the source of conflict. They would do so by turning back the clock to an era in mythic time when humans had not yet descended from paradise to earth.

Whatever expression Ain's cult took in different areas, the cult prophets drew on the unique human ability elucidated in Rappaport's work—to call on the "holy" in order to subordinate the ambitions of individuals to common interests and thereby alter the practical effect of human action on the environment. In doing so, they employed a broad brush, trying to revise not only immediate practice in Enga society but goals, values, and relations between people. Although the cult misfired owing to an influx of information with no historical context as Enga became linked to the broader world economy, in a sense it cleared the slate for things to come. And it did so overnight, sending new waves of orientation throughout the entire cultural system of western Enga in response to action generated by a handful of prophets. In a parallel fashion, Skip Rappaport worked toward an engaged anthropology to alter the Western cultural screen in order to better understand how people in societies throughout the world structure their perceptions and responses to environmental issues. For these contributions and many others, the warmth and inspiration of his presence and the impact of his ideas will continue to be felt, whether New Guinea style, via the spirits of the ancestors, or anthropological style, via the written word.

NOTES

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1. For an excellent discussion, see Biersack 1999.
2. The Enga are well known in the anthropological literature through the

works of Meggitt (1965a, 1965b, 1972, 1974, 1977), Feil (1984), Wohlt (1978), Lacey (1975, 1979), and Waddell (1972) among many others.

3. These were not unfamiliar events to the Enga. Enga oral traditions tell of severe frost and drought in high-altitude areas at least once a generation for the past four generations. Severe human and porcine epidemics are also described in historical traditions from the seventh generation on.

4. Working with history is a privilege for researchers who come later; those who arrive first have the formidable task of describing and analyzing what they find in the present. We were fortunate to have Meggitt's comprehensive ethnography of the Enga and Lacey's (1975) superb work on oral tradition as history as our starting points.

5. Working with oral history from so many phratries made it possible to check for consistency, use converging lines of evidence, and to try to identify broad regional trends in developments that occurred within the span of Enga oral history.

6. See Brennan 1977, Gibbs 1978, and Meggitt 1965b for more thorough discussions of Enga religion.

7. According to myth, a woman breast-fed her child, rather than waiting for a man to bring the sacred water of life to nourish it, and so humans became mortal.

8. The only significant impact was to reduce pig populations for a very short period. Often, however, deteriorating environmental conditions stimulated pig production to provision cults aimed at renewed fertility, putting more pressure on production in hard times rather than reducing it.

9. Excellent examples of the use of cults to value pigs can be found in the Sangai bachelors' cult and Kepele ancestral cult. Within the span of historical traditions, communal bachelors' cults were instituted in Enga to educate young men. In each generation, new lines were added to bachelors' cult poetry, which updated the ideals for men. In earlier generations, these pertained to physical appearance; in later ones, added lines extolled the virtues of men who work diligently to build and fence new gardens, raise pigs, and use them to succeed in exchange. Post-sweet-potato rites added to the Kepele cult integrated pigs and pork into virtually all cult rituals—ritual to express tribal divisions and their essential cooperation, to transform boys to men, to appease the ancestors, to banish ghosts of the dead, and to provide a good party for celebrants and guests (Wiessner and Tumu 1999).

10. Research on the Dindi Gamu posed more problems than any other single topic in Enga history, with discussions curtailed by fears that the world would end should any sacred information be disclosed. The unparalleled sense of secrecy associated with the Tondaka indicated that some natural phenomenon might underlie the cult. During our research, Akii Tumu deduced that the ritual power that emanated from the Papuan Plateau and flowed through the root of the earth, described as smoke, wind, or fire, was related to either volcanic activity or the many natural gas leaks in the region. His first empirical test was to throw a lighted match into the hole near the Tondaka site where the "smoke" from the Bebenete site was said to emerge. The result was explosive—after the initial accumulation of gas was burned away, a small blue flame remained,

hovering in the center of the hole like the eye of the snake. With this knowledge, it was not difficult to get Tondaka participants to discuss the role of the gas outlets. Ballard (1995) has come to similar conclusions for the Huli. That natural gas played a role on the Papuan Plateau is also evident from the work of Schieffelin and Crittenden (1991: 55–56).

11. There are some suggestions, presented in metaphorical speech, that if it were judged that pigs could not suffice humans may have been sacrificed, as they were at some Huli sites.

12. This may have involved "cooking with gas."

13. Unlike in historical narratives concerning politics and economics, political motives are not directly stated or made obvious for Ain's cult. However, Ain's cult would have undermined the power of the big man, which was based on economic achievement, and furthered the influence of ritual experts whose position was inherited. Historically, ritual experts were more powerful in western than eastern Enga.

14. There are other versions as well. For instance, one says that Ain's son, Langane, received the instructions from a white woman, most likely a mythical woman who was believed to have journeyed westward from the Mendi area and disappeared in the cave at the Tondaka site. Different explanations for the origin of the cult need not be seen as correct, incorrect, conflicting, or inconsistent; it is likely that the Ain brothers had several visions during Dindi Gamu performances that were all linked to Ain's cult.

15. Since everything to do with Dindi Gamu is told in symbolic speech, it is not at all clear whether Wambilipi's experience took place in the forest or via a vision during a Tondaka performance. It is certainly typical of hallucinations reported from the Tondaka performances. Though Wambilipi is still alive, it is doubtful that we will ever get further explanation. After the collapse of the cult, participants saw it as a religious movement that prepared the way for Christianity, and its strongest proponents have reinterpreted it in this light.

16. As these informants were not Seventh Day Adventists and pigs are highly valued today, there is no reason to believe that this is an "in retrospect" perspective.

17. Aipa was alive and well, lucid, talkative, and most helpful at the time of our fieldwork.

18. Meggitt (1973: 30) acknowledges that permutations in the Porgera Valley might be associated with greater complexity of religious beliefs. As he did not know of the Dindi Gamu, he could not make this connection and found it surprising that the python was enlisted in an activity that was intended to help men escape disaster.

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Reading Exchange in Melanesia: Theory and Ethnography in the Context of Encompassment

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This essay recounts the history of accounts of exchange in Melanesia — or at least one version of that history. I tell the story of theory as a dialogue with the Maring ethnography, in part because I become nervous when I stray too far from the reasons and relationships of lives in practice and more because the corpus of Maring ethnography is special. Not only have theory and method communicated through the ethnography, but the ethnographers themselves have been friends in communication over a quarter of a century. Many memories ago, as Skip and I rested in the Ann Arbor sun, splayed before us the huge beams that would anchor the house he was building, we talked about ethnography. Skip said that ethnography as practice is a life lived with cultural others that aims to transcend the limits of immediate awareness, theirs and ours. The gestures of totalization that this implicates are a mountain that we can climb but only together through acts of comparison and only if the principles of science rule our actions. Science itself is an exchange — a reciprocity of subject positions, an ability to take up residence in the perspective of an other and to do so in such a systematic way that there is a careful act of triangulation. The ethnographic enterprise is a mutual reflection on the epistemology, desires, and dispositions inscribed in the ethnographer, those embodied in the people with whom he lives, and how this duality appears in the writings of the community of ethnographers. In the epistemological twist of the screw, the only way we knew whether we construed and constructed ourselves and others properly was if we followed the canons of social science. And, he argued, while the West may have discovered science, science was no more Western in its essence or utility than culture itself. That science allows us to raise

the issues of its own genesis, limits, and the mortality of its concepts is in itself evidence that science is a special and universal form of understanding. My friend believed this. In what follows, it will be clear that my sympathies lie in this direction.[1]

Another point he underlined as much with his career as with the words he spoke to me on a later occasion. To be a good ethnographer and a fulfilled person it was necessary to resist being buffeted by all of the trends that sweep, like Highland rain, through the discipline. There was a vast difference between theoretical trendiness couched in unapproachable language and true depth based on a commitment to revealing the textures and experiences of people's lives through theory. Theory and ethnography must dance as partners, at times one leading and at other times the other, but always as partners. I have sought in this essay to put my friend's advice to work. My argument is that there have been two discernible phases in the history of the ethnography of exchange in Melanesia. In the initial phase, which I call functional empiricism, given its emphasis on the functions of material exchange, ethnographers read their relationship to their subjects into the subjects themselves, leading to a conception of exchange that, insofar as it was predicated on rules and contractual-like obligations, reflected our metaphors and ideologies. Against this paradigm has appeared a new Melanesian ethnography (Josephides 1991), which calls for a radical alterity between Melanesians and Westerners as a means of imploding these metaphors and ideologies. This view reads into the ethnographic subject the inverse of ethnographers' relationship to these subjects. Where the first view makes an ethnography of the logic of others unnecessary because everyone shares the same rationality, the second renders ethnography impossible because there is no magic to bring the culturally distant epistemologically near.

So the irony is that Rappaport's writing on exchange (1968) and twenty years later the writings of Marilyn Strathern (1988) are ultimately kindred texts in that they are mirror images. Recognition that the oh so immaterial relations of ethics and spirituality drove exchange led Skip to search for a way to reconcile the ethnographic authority of science with the symbolic production of divinity. That day sitting in the June sun I asked him a question that he had already asked himself. Why to kill a few pigs did the Maring have to shape such an elaborate and explosive ritual, imagined as a cosmology of sentient beings and intricate transactions, coupled with textured practices of material and marriage exchange,

profound in their implications, to so move body and soul that they become engraved on the landscape of collective memory? Why did they imagine and represent ritual as exchange? The only answer was that the Maring were engaged in a world making that fuses ritual and exchange, ethics and economy, and objectification and relationality in a logic of relations that was never the relations of logical enquiry, although there were points of convergence, openings, and schemes of comparative discourse that would allow one to converse with the other. The object of ethnography worthy of its subjects was to discover and cross those thresholds, a story that allows us to hear the voices of others.

Acts of Ethnography

When the Rappaports arrived in Maring country, they sought to settle down among the Tuguma, the eastern neighbors of the Tsembaga. After a long day's journey, they encamped at the rest house at Mondo, hoping in the morning to negotiate a field site with Tuguma elders. But affairs quickly and inexplicably turned sour. Senior clansmen, who on a later understanding would regret their decision, shouted to the Western party (through a translator who was not himself a native speaker of Maring) that they wanted no part of strangers. So they threatened the ethnographers. Whatever the Tuguma believed they knew about the ethnographers and ethnography, it was certainly worlds apart from what the ethnographers believed about their mission. Renouncing their efforts to reside at Mondo, the Rappaports accepted an invitation from the Tsembaga, who, having been bested in recent war, were desperate to turn their fortunes around—to take a chance that the world afar would deliver new magic and vitality to those whom luck had abandoned. In an exchange that neither was (nor could have been) prepared for, the Tsembaga received the goods and gifts of modernity and in return they would celebrate what turned out to be the last traditional *kaiko* that a Maring cluster would ever hold. That ritual sacrifice of pigs for the ancestors would not only become a defining moment in the ascendance of ecological anthropology, but it would inspire Skip to devote himself to contemplating the nature of ritual. The Tuguma would later rue that if only they had known what Skip and Annie were up to the world would be differently colored. The Tuguma, not the Tsembaga, would have worn the halo of a largess and magic that, benighted "bush people" that they were at the time, they did not fathom.

Among other things, like the intricacies of translation, this saga underlines that doing ethnography in Melanesia entails a social and epistemological separation and an effort on the ethnographer's part to transcend the implications of this dual separation. A social separation is unavoidable because ethnographers enter social systems in which they have no identity other than that constructed from their position as outsider. An epistemological break is inescapable because indigenous notions concerning the existence of a knowable reality and the means for knowing that reality are not those of anthropology. More, the forms of desire and the dispositions of agents flow from meanings and values that play little part in the production of the field that produced the ethnographer. The significant issue for any study of others is the implications of these separations for the description and explanation of social practices. Because ethnography unfolds under determinate social and epistemological conditions, it must ground itself in an account of its own structure and possibility. In thus phrasing the problem, I assume in theory what Skip and his buddy Akis, like ethnographers before and since, felt in fieldwork, that grounding many manifolds of difference, on terrain known and to be discovered, is an elemental sameness.

Since Boas and Malinowski advanced the tradition of fieldwork, ethnographers have taken the circumstances of their research into account when evaluating their data and writing ethnography. For most of the history of ethnography, however, this accounting remained implicit, personal, and analytically unsystematic. More than oversight, it was a kind of "collective defense mechanism" that allowed anthropologists to bracket the reality that they were part and product of the encompassment of others by the West (LiPuma 2000). A closer investigation into the circumstances of the field would reveal that ethnographers were part of that primitive band of colonizers made up of missionaries, state functionaries (first colonial and later national), and the like. And these agents had projects and purposes that had less to do with understanding others than with transforming them—and in the process also transforming the conditions for the production of ethnographic knowledge. Impelled by the realities unfolding before them, the stark globalization of modernity in the context of local reproduction, anthropologists have begun to focus on encompassment and its implications. Inspired by the reframing of the ethnographic object, ethnographers, motivated first by studies of practice (Bourdieu 1977) and the pragmatics of speech (Silverstein 1981, 1985) and then by the project of decolonizing the subaltern

voice (Amselle 1997), began an autodefé of the ethnographic enterprise. So anthropologists have rushed to discount the possibility of ethnography based on a newer, more enlightened reading of its content. Like the Fulani "chief" who claimed he was a little bit Muslim and a lot Muslim, and only when necessary, the postmodern view has rejected ethnographic authority even as it relies upon its data. However crowded the stage with contending and contentious positions, what should be clear is that the necessity and advantage of understanding ethnographic practice is nowhere more transparent than in locales, like Melanesia, where the distance between ethnographer and subjects is as wide as can be.

In the context of text production, I examine how the social and epistemological divide has influenced the description and explanation of exchange. Exchange is a particularly informative area of inquiry because the circulation of signs and substances plays a constitutive role in the formation of all social relations, so much so that exchange relations shape the social and epistemological conditions of doing ethnography itself. My argument is that the mutually structuring interplay between the circumstances of ethnography and the construction of knowledge for the scientific field has been a decisive aspect of the understanding of Melanesian exchange systems. This results from a forward linkage between the social conditions of ethnography, the writing/entextualization of field notes, and the production of description and theory. In this perspective, anthropologists can transcend the limits inherent to the outsider only if they construct an analysis of the practice of ethnography as and through exchange. This requires a theory of the relationship between the ethnographer's subjectivity—as culturally constituted and as the experiencing subject of fieldwork—and the structure of rewards and values of the scientific field for which ethnographic knowledge is destined. The critical thrust is to construct a view that transcends the opposition between an objectivism that assumes the supremacy of ethnographic authority and a relativism that assumes the incommensurability of cultures. In a word, it is to relativize relativity.

Focusing on Exchange

Exchanges, material and symbolic, are crucial dimensions in the making of Melanesian societies, and ethnologists have thus directed their attention to the social personae, occasions, and methods of exchange. The understanding is that the category of exchange, in itself and in contrast to

alternative categories, provides a compass for tacking between the meanings and values interior to Melanesian lifeways and those more general and comparative. Exchange is the register of the circulation of goods, words, services, and substances between persons. It is a structuring structure, endowed with generative principles that allow new persons to assume the place of old (Foster 1995), connect each person to others in webs of cooperation and competition (Sillitoe 1979; A. Strathern 1971), serve as material signs of group identity (Thomas 1991), and create the conditions for the enactment of sociality itself (Battaglia 1994). Especially for commentators who imagine exchange as a metasocial practice on a par with Turner's notion of ritual as metasocial—notions that elide in the conception that ritual exchange orchestrates and shapes the finalities of other practices. This view animates Feil's vision of tee ceremonial exchange as the ground of Enga sociability, community, and collectivity (1984: 240) and Rappaport's (1968) contention that ritualized exchange with ancestors and affines regulated Maring warfare and territoriality. The gifts of exchange are thus critical because they satisfy material relations (Healey 1990), are instrumental in the internal contours of local kin groups (Wagner 1968), and reproduce linkages between presupposed groups (Brown 1964; Glasse and Meggitt 1969; Rappaport 1968b), so much so that they are inseparable from the Melanesian imagination and experience of being human (McDowell 1980). Exchange is fundamental in the understanding of the self as agent and subject of social experiences. The history of ethnography reads that once analysts were able to see their way past the concepts of descent imported from Africa they were able to create an ethnographically based, yet encompassing, theory of exchange based on Melanesian realities.

This never-ending interest in exchange seems inevitable because it expresses and makes sense of the lived circumstance of ethnography and ethnographers' experience of Melanesia. Stated simply, the people with whom the ethnographer interacts—informers, friends, and other community members—envision most interpersonal relations as instances of exchange and reciprocity. Ethnography itself is founded on exchange because exchange is the ethnographic source of its possibility. Exchange relations, more than an object of study, are the means by which the ethnographer relates to the community to obtain information. Where it may sometimes be necessary and not unduly cautious to avoid participant observation—as in ritual circumcision and sorcery—all ethnographers must personally engage in exchanges, if for no other reason than

to establish the fact that they are humans with whom others can conduct normal commerce. Ethnography would be impossible without transactions between the ethnographer and the community, gifts ranging from letter writing, medicines, and information to money, camping equipment, and clothing. But, despite the reality that ethnographers must practice exchange in order to study it, and thus nowhere is theory and ethnography less separable, Melanesianists have seldom analyzed *ethnography as a mode of exchange.* The compulsion is to bracket the reality that ethnography is an exchange relation allowed by, and produced in the context of, the encompassment of Melanesia by the West. Focusing on the relationship between ethnography and encompassment is necessary if we are to illuminate the practico-theoretical foundation for entextualization of the words and deeds of practice, the production of *a* field text, and the transformation of that text into an analytical product.

Ethnography and the Transformation of Exchange

From the local perspective, the collector of information stimulates revisions in the concept and practice of exchange. By the end of the 1970s, the Maring had developed concepts of the role of ethnographers and their connection to the circulation of goods, services, and customs. People understood that certain types of information were of special interest to ethnographers and that accordingly they had exchange value. As it was explained to me: "the coming of an ethnographer [whose acts of exchange enrich the community] is like an increase in coffee prices"—an unexpected but welcome event that improves the terms of trade. The objects that materialize also open up new, sometimes unexpected venues and vistas for the construction of value. This is a way of observing that ethnography and ethnographers are inseparable from the Maring encounter with modernity. And critical to *their* project of understanding has been to make a space for the ethnographer in their field of social persons. Explicitly and inevitably, the dimensions of this space have everything to do with how ethnographers relate to the potentialities embodied in things. For Maring, the process was path dependent in that their first encounter with the Rappaports canonized a set of impressions and expectations that would forever shape the evolution of local concepts of ethnography and ethnographers. Skip's persona—a continuously evolving and collectively created objectification—mediated and embodied the Maring

engagement with other Westerners insofar as, based on his reading of these others, Skip introduced himself to the Maring through his engagement with exchange. So the Maring began to fashion an image of the ethnographer as a composite of several known persons—not least the bicultural, bilingual exchange agent who, living on the frontier between two peoples, mediates the relationship between cultures in the interests of trade. Skip not only entered Maring society through the door of exchange, but he established the ethnographer's persona and his relationship to others as grounded in exchange. The body of the ethnographer was one of mediating exchange between the unknowns of modern and local realities. The ethnographer's body, like all objects that contain subjectivities, was drawn into an imaginary that vaulted far beyond the properties of the person in question.

The image of the ethnographer soon traveled a long distance from that early moment at Mondo; in a turn borne from that meeting of unknowns, Skip and Ann, now enshrined as quasi ancestors, played a crucial part in the drama. Skip became a central figure in a narrative of transformation told as a history of enlightenment. The mythos—imagined as history and in this resemblance Western—recounts the story of the coming of the first ethnographers and the changes canonized by their appearance. This myth about exchange across the frontier, spatially and materially realized in the vision of the overflow of goods from America to Maringdom, is also about the transgression of temporal frontiers (such as the relationship between generations) characteristic of modernity. Here is a composite account of several slightly distinct versions.

> When Skip and Ann came and settled on Tsembaga land we assumed that he would behave like a *kiap* [an Australian administrative officer]. But Skip was unlike any *kiap* we ever knew. Where *kiaps* were powerful but stingy, giving nothing away but abuse, Skip offered knives, salt, matches, clothes, tinned meat and fish, rice, kerosene, and much more in great quantities. Plus he gave away large amounts of money. Whenever Akis [Skip's close friend and informant] or other Tsembaga would "story with" Skip about the war, gardening, or pigs, he would shower them with money and meat. He would purchase for vast sums of money the now abandoned tools of war—shields, fight stones, spells, and more. You may think that he gave the Tsembaga thousands of [Australian] dollars. Skip gave them still more. He gave the Tsembaga all this for

> merely talking to him. Before he arrived and taught us, we were uneducated: we did not realize that our customs were money, thinking them only as the ways of the ancestors. Skip created vast changes before he was gone for a long time. But he is getting ready to return. He and Annie feel sorry for us and are gathering valuables from America. When they return they will deliver untold goods and raise us up until we stand above everyone else.

There are as many versions of this "mytho-history" as there are storytellers, though all assume as their generative theme the advent of a new form of wealth creation that replaces customary means. The story is part history, part myth, and an introduction to the Maring conversation with modernity. Skip's myth was part and product of a process by which the Maring on the brink of modernity learned, as perhaps their first and most modern act, to invent a history cleaved into a past inflamed by violence and a future defined by law, a past of pagan ancestor worship and a future of Christian glory, a past of pearl shells and a future of money, a past of subsistence living and a future animated by foreign values and wealth creation. Offering the tonality of a cargo cult, Skip's story and its endless revision were a pragmatic attempt to experiment with the representation and meaning of exchange in the age of encompassment. The Tsembaga would acquire the cornucopia of capitalism through the incorporation of Westerners into a moral cosmology, engendering a conviction as to the capacity of tradition to attract Western goods, with these goods understood metonymically as a door to the totality of Western wealth creation. What should be as evident to anthropologists as it is to Melanesians is that, in their conversation with the modern, ethnographers are a critical persona in the narratives, myths, histories, and tales of transformation.

By the mid-1970s the Maring counted as one of their lessons of modernity that ordinary information has exchange value, as does time. Their experience has been that ethnographers offered gifts in return for commonplace information and sometimes paid them for their time. The Maring knew that certain secret information, such as magic spells, were valuable, but the elevation of mundane wisdoms was an innovation. The process of ethnography (as practiced) objectified culture and then imagined it as an object of value. In discussing our relationship, my most educated informant explained: "For us now, like you, 'Time and stories are gifts.'" What Maring, like other Melanesians, have come to recognize

is that ethnographers — because they live by a novel set of interests — were sources of cultural innovation, especially the extension of exchange to new contexts, purposes, and objects. Ethnographers were also inherently enmeshed in an exchange of information, with the Maring building a comparative discourse of Western otherness through their relationship to, and conversations with, the other in their midst. Ethnography and ethno-ethnography were implicated in the same process of exchange, partners in their pursuit of the terms of comprehension. Simultaneously and critically, engaging in exchange is a source of ethnography, a type of information, a means of transforming the ethnographer into a social person, and a fact of subsistence. The ethnographer, as the mytho-history of Skip's largesse and return reminds us, is a specific kind of exchanging person. Based on physiology (e.g., stature), sociality (e.g., European/white), behavior (e.g., giving and taking), and capacities (e.g., the ability to summon goods), the local community evolved beliefs, desires, and judgments about the identity and participation of the ethnographer in exchange. They synthesized a notion of the Western other, slotting the ethnographer into a cosmology and comparative discourse of otherness. Skip's mythos also illustrates that the original envisioning of the ethnographer was not the final word but gave way to other understandings, which came to attribute an obligation and desire for him to return. The question begged in the ethnography of its own practice is what created the original viewpoint and what inspired its transformation?

Trading Data for Modernity

Sometimes, captured by the currents of life and living, consciousness only comes after reality is established. Only when I was about to leave the Kauwatyi people, after having worked there for nearly two years and having done an earlier stint with the Tuguma, did I realize how much my exchange relations with others had evolved, in part by dint of time and involvement and in part because my linguistic research encouraged me to see exchange in other ways. As integral to my fieldwork, I engaged in several genres of exchange in ways typical of other Maring ethnographers and, I fathom, other Melanesianists. In the most obvious and mundane, I purchased foodstuffs at my door daily, at the market held weekly on the ceremonial dance grounds, and at local trade stores. Though simple in execution, obvious in results, and taken for granted, not one of these transactions breathed prior to modernity, *kina* and *toea*

for taro and tinned fish. The possibility of equivalence turned on the partial collapse of customary spheres of exchange, specifically that Western money displaced the pearl shell, which, classified as a wealth object, could never be exchanged for subsistence foods. The exchange also entailed the assertion of the person as an individual, the transaction pivoting on the separate interests of those involved. Each transaction was, and was taken as, a justification for a new type of exchange, which pushes into the background the relationality of objects, the way they can serve the construction of sociality. Thus, the object, progressively stripped of its potential to reshape social relations, stood more detached and naked with each passing year, with the ascendence of a generation trained at the mission school. The success of the local trade store and the object lesson of the store run by the mission, as well as people dealing with coffee buyers, airline personnel, and others, was that objects were valued exclusively economically and owned by persons who had the sole right of their disposal, with all transactions completely visible in that their immediate functions exhausted their meaning. All that was invisibly foregrounded in local circuits of indigenous exchange loses ground in the new context of the modern. The purchase of tinned fish at the trade store or taro from a local vendor entails an implosion of social space, the absorption of stranger relations that once existed only on the periphery into the heart of the community, this legitimated in part by the elevated status of ethnographers in their unintended role as ambassadors of modernity. The failure of theories that grasp exchange in terms of what objects present to ordinary experience, especially materialist interpretations of the object world, is that they do not see that the local appearance of the object entails a cultural labor of deconstruction (Battaglia 1994), a labor that could not crystalize in the absence of a process of encompassment of which anthropologists have been a part.

A second form of exchange flowed from the reality—already built into Maring expectations of ethnographers' behavior when I arrived—that I would hire members of the junior generation to serve as go-betweens, translators, and the like. They would receive a wage, part of which they would tender to the big man who was "looking after" them. Other parts would go to their parents and to nurture exchange partners. Again, the transaction of wage labor was straightforward even if the politics of who would work for me sometimes had more byzantine and unexpected curves than the Jimi River. Working for an ethnographer, like work on the plantations or at the Anglican mission, served as an

introduction to the capitalist worldview. Installed so deeply in the dispositions of the Western personnel, the view appeared as a compulsion to treat others as objects, with labor mediating social relations such that, in contradistinction to Melanesian wisdom, these relations contain no expectation of engendering other relations because the touchstone of the exchange is to communicate commodities. Or, to reverse the polarity of the cultural change, the Maring have been learning to objectify labor as a commodity because the "gifts" of labor they bestowed on Westerners rarely engendered the sociality they expected. Ethnographers, missionaries, and other Westerners cannot help but confound the local presupposition that gifts act as persons, as when, for example, in all innocence, they demand privacy. The cry for, and retreat into, solitude (because it has no parallel in Maring desire) reduces the persons who work for/exchange with the ethnographer to objects, for the Western understanding is that Melanesian "gifts of labor" (taken as wage/commodities) afford their donor no claim on the ethnographer's social being. The Western world more characteristically conceptualizes and misrecognizes this as others making a claim on our "time"—the term *time* functioning as the epistemological ghost for the social being itself. As Skip pointed out to me as I was leaving for Melanesia, in words more poignant and pointed than perhaps he intended, "privacy with the Maring is a rare commodity." Rare, indeed, because they understood privacy as the negation of the sociality created by exchange. I point this out to underline that ethnography involves a denial of exchange as well as engagement, both of which are part of the encompassment and transformation of the cultural other.

The third form of exchange derived from the nature of ethnographic reality. Interested in events I did not or could not witness, forms of information that held no value to local agents, and generative schemes that, embedded in the habitus of agents, were rarely raised to consciousness, I conducted extensive interviews. In exchange for someone talking with me, I would reciprocate with money and goods. Within the idiom and epistemology of commodity exchange, the Maring appeared here in the person of the shopkeeper, the employee, and the consultant. In addition, there was a narrow variety of persons who wanted as much largesse as they could elicit with, in a very non-Maring way, no intention of reciprocating. The attempt to beggar the other is itself a creative internalization of indigenous, kinshipless trade, where the agents foregrounded the object in relation to the subjects. This reminds us that

because objects are attached to persons in social space, and the space and the position of specific agents within this space are in motion, they have meaningful properties only in enacted contexts. This is especially true in contexts that achieve their simplicity and the purity of the circulation of objects by denying, concealing, devaluing, or misrecognizing this space.

Finally, as an assimilating member of the Kukupogai clan, I would contribute to bridewealth payments and other ceremonial exchanges, which, in turn, legitimized my asking agents about the character of the exchange. As I planted and harvested, accepted and consumed food from Kukupogai lands, as my body, through my giving of labor and the nurturing effects of those foods, entered into an exchange relationship with the land, a land embodying the substance of the ancestors, my obligations toward my adopted clan grew in the special way so that I became a conduit for modernizing the exchange precisely because I was becoming more indigenized. Although ethnographers seek to grasp local exchanges without creating disturbances in the field, there is no way they can participate without leaving their footprints because they are part of the encompassing process. As my housemate, Gou, pointed out to me, the footprints of those who wear shoes are always different.

Exchange and Intentionality

A critical lapse in the theorization of exchange has been a failure to thematize the interrelationship between exchange, intentionality, and the forms of objecthood made possible by the interface of the sensible world, the cultural imaginary, and the metalinguistic capacities of language. Social action—and this is as much a cultural universal as the symbolic capacity of humans—involves the coordination of agents' intentionality. Intentionality is coordinated to the extent that the beliefs, desires, and judgments of one agent correspond to those of another. The effort to coordinate intentions does not determine what is intended culturally or the relative degree of coordination needed to produce meanings and values in context. The necessity and likelihood of coordination depends on the relationship between the agents and the character of the transaction. A critical feature of material commerce—as opposed, for example, to marital negotiations (LiPuma 1994)—is that it can operate with only a minimal coordination of intentionality. Especially exchange across cultural frontiers operates on this minimalism—

as when the Maring trade with those who speak an unrelated language. Where the intentional range of object exchange in marriage transactions was an extraordinarily supple, subtle, and multilayered complex of shared meanings and values, exchange with foreigners (such as a Japanese tourist who, stopping momentarily at the mission airstrip, purchased a clutch of arrows) could whittle the coordination of intentionality down to an improvised dance of iconic gestures. More routinely, the purchase of taro by the Anglican mission did not require either the Western buyers or the Maring sellers to fully understand one another. The status of taro in Maring mythology and ceremonial exchange, the notion that when mixed with water taro is akin to mother's milk, the hierarchy of valuation of taro types, the special ways taro can represent social relations, indigenous notions of taste, and the desires aroused by a meal featuring taro, all of this and more need play no part in the motives for purchase. Similarly, on the sellers' side, those offering the object need only be aware of the willingness of others to meet their demands, however conceptualized. On the margins, working misunderstandings were sufficient to orchestrate material transactions. The "thingness" of objects—that as concrete categories (as opposed to either relational categories such as kinship or imaginary categories such as god) the parties to an exchange may imbue them with unrelated meanings and values—can overshadow the sociointerpersonal functions of the encounter. The extent to which an object of exchange is emergent in practice, reconfigured from parts of what agents already know, may, in instances where the economic dimension is foregrounded, approach zero. Where the sociality of exchange dominates center stage, the attachment of objects to subjects defines that object almost in its entirety.

The problem with functional empirical and new Melanesianist accounts of exchange, and the reason why they can appear as mirror images of each other, is that both presuppose the perfect coordination of intentionality: functional empiricism because everyone shares the same practical logic and the latter because agents perfectly share the same culture. The new Melanesian view advances the claim of shared culture and thus intentionality through the essentializing claim that Melanesian societies were exclusively gift based until the advent of encompassing agents and institutions. The missing pages in both accounts of exchange are agents' struggle to harmonize their intentionality, a struggle that, incidentally and precisely, is the core experience of ethnography insofar as exchange intertwines with other prac-

tices. This implies that exchange is always hidden by its own immediacy and that interpretations of exchange, even those that imagine themselves as practical accounts, are thoroughly theoretical. The paradox is that the more straightforward the transaction, the more obvious the utility of the thing, the more the exchange is hidden from view. Indeed, the progress of an ethnographer in Melanesia (as elsewhere) depends on being able to swim upstream from the working misunderstandings of the initial encounter—upon which the possibility of that encounter's success is predicated—to an appreciation of the coordination of intentionality shaping kin-based transactions.

Social Separation and Exchange Theory

Ethnographers' special participation in exchange is as problematic as it is advantageous, for their social relationship to their subjects of study has the making of an ethnographic distortion insofar as ethnographers are prone to read into their object of investigation their relationship with their subjects of the study. This occurs because ethnography revolves on the continual interpretation of the concepts, desires, and dispositions animating others' actions. This interpretation of intentionality depends on the degree to which ethnographers can transcend the social and epistemological limitations of ethnography—including, critically, their suppositions about exchange. The question of the coordination of intentionality is particularly critical here because its ethnographic transparency grounds the category of exchange itself. Why, we can ask, should there be a category of exchange at all? Why should an enormous and endlessly inventive set of actions and improvisations be so classified? Why should the circulation of such a wide range of cultural objects—from pigs and plumes to spells and forms of sociality—count as exchange? The only ethno*logical* answer is that they are all tokens/examples of the type, exchange. They are typified because ethnographers, based on participant observation with others (which itself calls for and presumes a coordination of intentionality), determine that there is a culturally constructed (though by no means always conscious) regimentation of agents' intentions and purposes across contexts. Exchange as a category for understanding Melanesia therefore presumes the labor of the scientific field, the unending conversation between the community of ethnographers and the circumstances of their lives in Melanesia. Paradoxically, even those theories that deny the cultural reality of such catego-

ries (e.g., M. Strathern 1988) must presuppose them in order to rise above the methodological ooze of the particular (Josephides 1991: 148–49). As Rappaport (1999) argues, for an anthropological account to be persuasive it must generalize and ground its generalizations. So a significant issue for the anthropology of Melanesia is the extent to which the social separation to which ethnography is condemned prevents ethnographers from closing the epistemological distance between themselves and local agents of exchange.

Exchange in Melanesia has both a social and an economic dimension whose relationship is hardly transparent and whose relative weight shifts from one context to another. For the Maring, the most kin-mediated exchanges (between immediate affines from the same cluster) have an economic dimension just as economic trade involves statements about social relatedness (Healey 1984: 43). Social and economic sides of exchange are meaningful even in their absence. Like other Melanesians, the Maring engaged not only in extensive internal trade with neighboring clans but in a lively commerce across cultural frontiers. Healey (1990) has more than demonstrated that there was an intricate net of trading relations linking all of the societies from the Sepik-Wahgi divide to the Bismark Mountains and beyond to the Simbai River and the steplands of the Kalam country. Clansmen pursued trade in stone axes, salt, bird plumes, and pigs with immediate kin, distant persons linked by kin-in-common, and strangers. Although all trade had both an economic and social dimension, there was a continuum. On one side were transactions with affines in which the social dimension so overshadowed the economic that the norms of the exchange invited agents to misrecognize its economic moment. Stereotypic phrases (e.g., "this gift appears without expectation") that were nothing less than a denial of the economic and reciprocal impulse that both agents knew was present marked transactions between kin. On the other side were transactions with strangers in which the economic dimension came to the fore and the "gift" was defined more by its "thingness"—the sheen of bird plumes, the purity of the salt, the size of the pigs—than its production of sociality. Whereas on the frontier exchange instigated sociality, among close kin exchange presupposed a sociality whose existence was independent of any transaction. Between these extremes lay a constellation of positions, a sliding scale of values and meanings so open to ambiguity, negotiation, and improvisation that the social relationship between the agents involved neither exhausted nor predetermined the outcome.

Before encompassment, the organization of social space replicated this continuum of exchange: strangers lived distantly whereas kin members lived close by. The notion that someone could or would desire to reside in a community in which they had no kin was as impossible as it was unfathomable. Thinkable only as an inversion of the world, social relations were as mediated by kinship for the Maring as they are mediated by labor for us. Moreover, the continuum of exchange conformed to forms of the expression of personhood. The economic side of exchange exposed the individual aspect of personhood just as its social side underlined its "dividual" aspect (LiPuma 1998). Transactions with strangers elicited the individual aspects of subjects while transactions with affines elicited dividuality, with numerous gradients lying between these endpoints.

Analytics are often no more than accounts of conversations with informants transformed into a discourse appropriate for circulation within the scientific field. My analysis here is no exception. Toward the end of my fieldwork, my friend Penga, who was intelligent, curious, and miraculously fluent in English, having studied me and absorbed a considerable amount of anthropological thinking, reflected on my stay from the standpoint of others. He fashioned a narrative of the progress of my ethnography told, appropriately, in the idiom of exchange: a narrative that could exist only in the space created by the encounter of cultural others insofar as his account—by virtue of its language, narrative style, abstractness, and entextual intent—made no sense in his culture except with respect to me, just as his narrative would make no sense in mine without our joint act of interpretation.

> When you came here, the only thing we knew about you is that you came from America like Skip [important because place is an index of, and a metaphor for, a kinship relation]. You were not part of any clan, and you had never eaten food from our ground. Because you were wealthy but without kinship, many people asked you for things with no intention of a payback [reciprocating]. Other people explained exactly what they wanted in return because they did not know your behavior [assumptions about the intentions of others being a predicate of their past actions]. But you made a garden on Kukupogai land [and] you worked with people in their garden, helping to build fences [meaning that I gave myself to the production of food, which, embodying the clan substance of that land, produces

> kinship through acts of common consumption]. Now when women brought you food from these gardens they could not sell it to you because it was your food: so they simply left the food for you [the food presupposing the existence of a kinship that the exchange helps to further engender]. Some people asked "Why is he doing this; what are his gifts in return for"? Those who understood your work asked these people to recall if they had spoken to you about customs. [By implicational logic, my gift implies that I have already received a gift from them because gifts are given in return for other gifts or in response to a linguistically veiled desire on the part of the other]. The most important idea for us is "helping," but when you first came you did not see [understand] this. The people who reciprocate when you help them are your friends [the others still see exchanges with you in purely economic terms].

The dual moments of exchange easily invite an ethnographic distortion that is understandable in terms of the ethnographer's position within his or her own scientific culture, which demands that the researcher produce an explanation that transcends his or her own experience, and his or her position within the "other culture," which is that experience. The ethnographer, inescapably a stranger, stands outside the framing of exchange. Especially in the first decades after the opening of the Highlands, anthropologists were socially anomalous creatures because these societies had yet to define a space for this kind of person and behavior. What kind of person resides in the absence of kinship? What species of human behavior is it to plumb the depths of the obvious? Given the epoch and separations, local agents had little reason or relationship to imagine exchange in its social incarnation. One consequence was that the character of their transactions with ethnographers could not but emphasize its economic dimension. And not only did the depth of these epistemological and social separations impede the possibility of a coordination of intentionality, but the paradigms of exchange current in the economic anthropology of the period (e.g., Harris 1966) fixated on data rather than the categories used to discover it.

Early Highland ethnographies unintentionally expose the tenor of this relationship between the ethnographer and local agents. A pioneer among Highland ethnographers, Kenneth Read portrayed his experience of an exchange among the Gahuku. As several women circled his door to sell their foods, he writes that

> I was always tolerant of the tendency to expect that I would take anything offered to me, paying more for some article than it would bring if it had been carried to [town]. But as my [assistant] paid for the goods, I was uncomfortably aware of an *avariciousness* in my self-styled brother-in-law's interest. After the departure of the women, this feeling was confirmed when he . . . told me that the brothers expected me to make a contribution [of the most expensive articles available in the white trade stores] to the bridewealth of Makis's wife. (1965: 75)

Writing in the same year, Newman notes that "on our arrival in the village of Miruma it became apparent that the people were not so much interested in us as in our possessions, and when their interest did turn to us it was initially because we might provide links to the 'red man's world of material goods" (1965: 51). Brown (1978) underlines the same point of the material intent of Melanesians with respect to the carnival of commodities created by the arrival of Westerners. While most early accounts (and many later ones) assume that it is proper to bracket ethnography's interactional foundations, these and a smattering of other comments and footnotes stress the extent to which ethnographers encountered exchange at its most economic moment. From here, it was a short and natural(ized) step to imagine Melanesian exchange in terms of Western tropes, metaphors, and ideologies. Persuaded by their own lived experience and reinforced by the anthropological economics of that era, ethnographers found it difficult not to read their relationship to their subjects of study into their object of analysis.

The unsocialized relationship between ethnographer and local community resembles our ideology of maximization, and not accidently ethnographers attributed this economism to Melanesians. In the first wave of theories of exchange, Melanesian behavior was conceptualized to parallel Western ideology as embodied in the premises of modern economics. The economic viewpoint appeared forcefully in the theory that the inclusion of "nonutilitarian" goods in an exchange network has, as its underlying cause, the stimulation of trade in utilitarian items. Rappaport (1968: 106–9) and other ecologically minded anthropologists supported this thesis to explain why bird plumes, bridal axes, and other objects irrelevant to subsistence should figure prominently in trade. A dialectic had been set up between the expectations of the scientific field and the field experience of ethnographers.

This unabashed materialism aside, other ethnographers of the era sought "to discern the social functions" of the flow of goods (Newman 1965: 52). The understanding was that it was necessary to discover the ways in which exchange not only distributes goods and services but engenders relations constitutive of society. Excluded from the sociality of exchange yet aware that exchange must have an important sociological function, analysts resorted to a quasi-contractual theory. Rarely made explicit as such, the notion that material flows generated the metastructural effect of society making assumed that Melanesians, both with respect to the relationship between individual and community and with respect to that between groups, operated in terms of unstated agreements orchestrated by culture. And, as anthropologists often identified ritual as the other metastructuring practice, what could exemplify the creation of the social through the medium of the material better than the great ceremonial exchanges that punctuated Highland life. The quasi-contractual apparition appears in Godelier's contention that the production of society and the construction of groups are dependent on conditions of exchange that are themselves "external to kinship" (1986: 185). It appears in Sillitoe's (1979) claim that exchange mediates the paradox of how to reconcile individual self-interest with the greater interests of the commonweal and also in accounts that conclude that different structures of exchange engender different types of societies (Rubel and Rosman 1978). It is the underlying theme in accounts that assume that there are no limits to awareness and consequently that people create their society through their self-understanding of their exchange relations (Davis 1992). It appears in Feil's argument that without ceremonial exchange "there is no community" among the Enga (1984: 240). As Feil observed, "The outstanding monographs of Strathern (1971) and Young (1971), and more recently of Sillitoe (1978), have shown ceremonial exchange to be a '*social contract*' between groups and individuals, promoting social control and, on balance, being a positive integrating force in societies lacking formal judicial procedures" (1982: 291; my emphasis). It is one thing to acknowledge that the significance of an exchange depends on the object's attributes, the kinship of donor and receiver, and the context of giving and another thing to grasp the intersection of principles and practices that allow gifts to speak pragmatically about persons. And, though no one spelled it out, a nucleus of critical presuppositions about persons, the coordination of agents' intentionality, and the ontology of a model of social practices grounded the

quasi-contractual view. Feil's tropes and metaphors—the opposition between groups and individuals, the reasoning that ceremonial exchange is to Melanesia what law is to the West, and the idea that societies need integration—embody an entire epistemology.

To begin with, the contractual view assumes that there is a dichotomy between the individual and society: persons pursue forms of self-interest that, while socially constituted, undermine and/or support the social. Once the analytic accepts this opposition, two other assumptions fall into place. On one side of the equation, the theory presumes that individuals may be taken for granted as primordial reference points. Thus, the goal of the anthropology of exchange is to reveal the sociality that orchestrates the relation between the agents, each of which is autonomous, sovereign, and motivated by his or her own interests. On the other side of the equation, the theory assumes the existence of a social structure whose genesis and generative principles flow from certain consecrated cultural grounds. What characterizes Melanesia is the construction of the social through exchange and ritual, what characterizes Africa is the construction of the social through descent and ritual, and what characterizes the West is the construction of the social via the secular commodity form. As the theory winds down this path, it needs another assumption to account for what ethnography knew to be true: that exchange was patterned but imperfectly so. The necessary assumption was that *rules* govern exchange. These range from specific rules (e.g., a proscription for patrilateral second-cross-cousin marriage [see Rappaport 1968b: 125]) to the overarching rule of reciprocity. Recourse to a rule of reciprocity allows the observer/outsider to bridge the gap between the observed behavior of gift giving and indigenous concepts (i.e., balance, equality, and fairness), desires, and judgments whose coordination defines agents' intentionality.

The terms of the original model of exchange, or more precisely the unexamined presuppositions that grounded seemingly autonomous approaches, should now be in focus. The model assumed that exchange and ritual were metastructuring social institutions. They were simultaneously internal to the social and extrinsic so as to impose the invisible hand of structure. Exchange came in two basic forms: persons circulating goods and services to enhance their material lot and engender the sociality required to nurture trading partners and pathways and the structures of ceremonial exchange that organized the production of the social itself. So conceived, the person is always an individual who stands beneath and in

opposition to society, an opposition mediated by the structural power of the metastructuring institutions: exchange, ritual, and most of all ritual exchange. This viewpoint troubles the question of how society coordinates and regiments the behavior of these individuals: the answer provided is that there exist rules of exchange that coordinate agents' actions. The method within the theory is that an ethnographer's exchange relationship to those being studied is a token of the type of individual exchanges routinely carried out for economic purposes.

The New Melanesian Critique

For Melanesia, the challenge to these assumptions originates in the writings of Wagner (1975, 1978). The substance of the critique as advanced by Iteanu (1983, 1990), Marilyn Strathern (1988, 1990), Wagner (1991), and Mosko (1992) is that these assumptions reduced Melanesians to Westerners by virtue of their codependence on our metaphors, tropes, oppositions, and frames of reference. The epistemology of capitalism and Western culture thus regimented the representation of exchange in Melanesian ethnography. These assumptions betrayed a species of ethnocentrism that, to upset and transcend, required a reversal of perspective. If this vision of exchange assumed a commonality between Melanesian and Westerner, then a reversal of thought and method would entail a radical alterity between us and them. It would entail not the presumption of a fundamental sameness but the relativity of absolute difference.

The inversion of perspective begins with the notion that the concept of society is itself irrelevant to understanding exchange. What functional empiricism took as a raison d'être of exchange—social integration—is here only a theoretical distraction, for the notion that society is universal is a part of our ideology, the way in which we naturalize a conventional relationship between persons and the collectivity. Critiquing approaches that posit the existence of metastructuring institutions, Strathern argues:

> This kind of supposition is intimately bound up with those Western explanatory modes that regard one 'area' of life as imposed upon or as an exteriorization of another, and force as applied to something beyond and external to the acting subject.
>
> As I understand Melanesian concepts of sociality, there is no indigenous supposition of a society that lies over or above or is inclusive of individual acts and unique events. There is no domain

> that represents a condensation of social forces controlling elements inferior or in resistance to it. The imagined problems of social existence are not those of an exteriorized set of norms, values, or rules that must be constantly propped up and sustained against realities that constantly appear to subvert them. (1988: 102)

Thus understood, object exchange has nothing to do with the creation or production of society, and the concepts and values dramatized by ritual provide neither maps nor models for other domains of social life. In exchange, agents perform actions on themselves and their relational others by altering the manner in which they attach objects to themselves. Social relationships of one type create, and stand symbolically for, relationships of another type. This reversal of perspective calls forth a concept of the person not as an individual but as a relational person or dividual. Where the original theory saw persons as conceptually distinct from the relations that unite them, the new Melanesian ethnography understands persons as the compound plural site of these relations. Where the original theory grasped collectively as the unification of pluralities (vis-à-vis exchange), the alternative defines collective sociality as an essential unity. Where the original theory assumes that a person's behavior and intentions are a public expression of an inner state, the revised theory assumes that a person's behavior and intentions are the expression of a relationship. Where the original theory held that agents know their internal selves (such as their motives for an exchange), the alternative contends that agents depend on others for knowledge about themselves. As agents, "persons evince and anticipate the knowledge or recognition of their internal composition and capacities in the responses of others" (Mosko 1992: 702). This leads ultimately to the startling claim that "knowledge [about exchange] is recursive and cannot be accumulated" (M. Strathern 1988: 320).

So conceived, the new Melanesian ethnography has not only exposed the tenacity of Western metaphors and models. It has not only shattered the assumptions underpinning the original wave of theories of exchange; it has inverted them. Yet, if the anthropology of myth has taught us anything, it is that opposites ultimately join hands at a deeper, more profound level. Where the original theories read the ethnographer's relationship to the local agents of exchange into the analysis, the revised theory banishes the ethnographer's relationship to these agents from the analysis. But how then to account for a relationship that

the theory has already ruled out? How do we account for the mythos of Skip or the narrative of the progress of the ethnographer? How do we understand the observations of ethnographers like Read and Newman other than by the debasing argument that blinded by Western epistemology they failed to appreciate their own experience?

Where the original theory assumes axiomatically that ethnography is possible because Westerners and Melanesians are driven by similar concerns (e.g., reconciling tensions between individual autonomy and social integration), the revised theory envisions radical separation. The epistemological divide that makes ethnography necessary and problematic now appears as a bridge we cannot cross. There is no promised land of mutual understanding. There is no possibility of tacking between inside and outside to create a context in which the play of voices, our voices and those of Melanesians, permits mutual intelligibility. But how to account for the reality that ethnographers first engage in exchange in which the economic dimension predominates and then, by inserting their person into Melanesians lifeways, progressively socialize the terms of exchange. If people do not accumulate knowledge about the ethnographer, the ethnographic project is doomed because it becomes impossible to transcend the separations to which ethnography is condemned. Where economically centered theories of exchange fought an uphill battle to accommodate its social dimensions, resorting to a "contract" theory that presupposed a form of society that was non-Melanesian at its core, the new Melanesian ethnography has a wonderful answer to the sociality of exchange but must struggle to accommodate its economic dimension. The paradox is that, although the revised view takes deadly seriously the relationship between Melanesians and Westerners and the tropes and metaphors we use to imagine others, it brackets the practice of ethnography, particularly the role of exchange in the creation of the ethnographic persona and thus the existential ground of ethnography itself. For, as I have tried to argue, immanent in the practice of ethnography in Melanesia is the progressive complication of an individuality that revolves around agency, material, and purposiveness with a dividuality that resonates with relationality. Moreover, this transition as a progressive complication is possible because the Western person is already dividual (Boddy 1998: 256)—the socialization of ethnographers eliciting from them what they already embody in another and much more misrecognized state (LiPuma 1998). My progressive absorption into Maring sociality—and thus the transcendence of exchange as

purely economic—can take place because I have already lived the world as a repository of relationships. My intentionality and that of Maring interlocutors can coordinate, meaning can circulate through our bodies, and we can use language about language to clarify ambiguities, because relativity is never absolute.

Inversions, Identities, and Ethnography

I have argued that neither functional empiricism nor the new Melanesian anthropology can articulate an adequate theory of exchange because both ignore the practice of ethnography. In the first instance, a dialectic evolved between ethnographic production for a scientific field that (over)emphasized economism and the social circumstances of ethnography, which emphasized the economic dimension of exchange. So moved, ethnographers read into their ethnographic objects their relationship to these objects and produced theories of Melanesian exchange and personhood that assimilated them to our tropes, metaphors, and ideologies. This paradigm reduced the sociality of exchange to the metastructuring effects of contractlike relations. Glaringly—or so it appears in the rearview mirror—this perspective could not account for the construction of persons, values, or the category of exchange itself. Western categories could enter unexamined because the theory rested on a presumption of sameness between Melanesians and Westerners.

The critique of the new Melanesian ethnography originated from an inversion of this perspective, beginning with a radical alterity between us and them. A new dialectic was set in motion between the production of ethnography for a scientific field that was learning to value relationality and relativity and the effacement of the ethnographer from the social circumstances of ethnography. So moved, ethnographers read out of their subjects of analysis their relationship to them. Rather than mistaking the economic moment of exchange for the totality of the practice, the new theory removes the economic moment altogether. Against this, I have argued that because both of these positions, despite their shortcomings, capture something fundamental about exchange in Melanesia it is necessary to transcend the opposition that they created. The history of accounts of exchange underlines the extent to which ethnography and theory are intrinsically rather than extrinsically connected. So it is not enough to acknowledge this connection, to recognize our biases, or

celebrate the differences between peoples; we must theorize the practice of ethnography.

But the ramifications of the argument go further. The argument implies that for anthropology to grasp the coordinations of intentionality defining indigenous exchange it was necessary for Melanesian societies to first make a social place for the ethnographer. In this respect, anthropology could only understand others in the process of encompassing and thus transforming their worlds. The original notion that Melanesians subscribe to the same social ontology as Westerners is an illusion borne of distance, just as the notion of a radical alterity between their ontology and ours is an illusion that we can create only in the space created by encompassment. Not the least of my friend Skip's accomplishments is that especially in his final words on religion and humanity he taught us that to find the true compass of anthropology we must deconstruct essentialism and relativize relativity.

NOTE

1. Intellectually, Skip had little tolerance for the postmodern conceit that grasps the identity of the ethnographer as a critical ethnographic datum. He once described Obeyesekere's assertion that his experiences as a Sri Lankan imbues him with special insight into the behavior of Hawaiians (1992: 21) as an example of everything with which he disagreed. The logical corollary positions are that the authenticity of an ethnographic account depends on the identity of the ethnographer, and, even worse, since symbolically constituted there is nothing to limit the proliferation of identity criteria (would a female, Tamil-speaking, Hindu Sri Lankan see Hawaiians differently?), ethnography degenerates into an increasing spiral of noncommensurable viewpoints and accounts, each of which is validated ultimately only by the power to enforce that viewpoint and account. For Skip, the only thing on earth that imbued anyone with special insight into the behavior of others was sound ethnographic training and a spiritual respect for them as fellow humans. So we did not broach the question of whether a third-generation Russian Jew or a second-generation Sicilian Catholic had a better chance of understanding Maring practice — though I know on good authority that some Seventh Day Adventists see the Maring as part of the lost tribe of Israel.

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